

A SCIENCE FICTION NOVEL

THE COURT OF BORROWED VOICES

*A witness can spend his last life
proving he was killed.*



T. K. ARVEN

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Prologue — The Last Route Out

<!-- POV: Iven Ko -->

<!-- Forty-seven years before present; Eiren Reach -->

Iven kept one hand on choir bell C-9 while the floor shed heat beneath his boots.

The bell occupied half the route room, its smoked auric glass webbed with pale stress lines. Each time the thermal lattice failed over another district, those lines brightened and the recording field lost a fraction of depth. Iven watched the phase margin contract on the service strip. Thirty-one usable layers had become six. The room air had cooled enough to make his breath show.

“North loop is gone,” Lio said through his collar speaker.

Her voice carried pump noise and the clipped delay of an overloaded civic channel. She had stayed at the grid exchange four levels below the inhabited caverns. Iven pictured the route to her without effort: two freight shafts, a pressure stair, sixty meters along the red coolant trunk. He could not picture the expression she wore.

“How long?” he asked.

“For the exchange, perhaps forty minutes. Dayward Three may hold longer.”

“That was not my question.”

A relay snapped somewhere behind the wall. C-9 drew reserve power, and a warning square changed from amber to red.

Lio let two breaths pass. “I am not climbing four levels while twelve thousand people still need the valves sequenced.”

“You cannot sequence them after the trunk freezes.”

“Then I have until the trunk freezes.”

Iven pressed his thumb to the deposition plate. The bell took his pulse pattern, mapped his breath, and opened another clean layer. Route marks appeared under the glass like hairline scratches catching a lamp. He had already recorded the collector failures, convoy bearings, population shelters, and every Crown instruction that reached Eiren Reach after the shear began. A deposition needed sequence more than eloquence. Sequence could survive damaged language.

On the wall display, three rescue bells held their triangular approach. Their combined mass could detune toward Eiren and carry emergency heat exchangers through the disturbed corridor. Crown control had transmitted the requirement without dispute: three bells, nineteen hours outside the Mouth schedule. The route existed. The convoy had fuel. Eiren still had receiving locks.

“Crown has not acknowledged the final vector,” Iven said.

“They acknowledged it six minutes ago.”

“Not the vector I sent.”

Lio understood before he explained. “Show me.”

He pushed the route table into their private channel. The convoy line approached the shear boundary, waited at the decision mark, then bent away from Eiren. Its three bells moved toward the Meridian Mouth’s failing alignment instead. A priority code rode beneath the turn, followed by an instruction to preserve corridor stability.

For several seconds, pump noise filled the connection.

“They chose the Mouth,” Lio said.

“They chose its schedule.”

“No. Give them the whole action.”

Aster Crown’s rescue lights remained visible through the route-room slit as three hard points. Iven had watched them brighten for four hours. Now they crossed the reference marks one by one, turning away toward infrastructure that served worlds beyond this dying moon.

He added the commanded vector to C-9. The bell accepted it with a pressure pulse against his palm.

Another message arrived from convoy control. It did not address the colony. It ordered all emergency telemetry compressed into standard loss fields and warned that uncoordinated detuning might worsen the shear. A second line advised Eiren route staff to preserve navigational data for later inquiry.

“Later,” Iven said.

“What?”

“They want a record for later.”

Lio made a sound that might have been a laugh if there had been air to spare. “Then make it expensive to misunderstand.”

The civic board lost two shelter indicators. Iven opened their status packets before the board could discard them. Four hundred people in West Reservoir had moved into the machine galleries for residual heat. The old transit hostel held three hundred twelve temporary workers absent from the resident count. Their supervisor had filed the correction nine times. The registry still displayed 18,204.

“I have the transients,” he told Lio.

“Keep them with the routes.”

“Your exchange log too.”

“Take the non-conscious record. Do not spend a deposition layer carrying my voice.”

Her instruction hurt because it made technical sense. Neural telemetry consumed depth. Instrument logs compressed cleanly. Iven transferred the grid sequence without her speech and placed her duty code beside the last manual valve changes.

C-9's margin fell to four layers.

A knock sounded at the sealed route-room door. Through its small glass panel, civic runner Tal Vey held up a slate showing evacuation assignments. Iven released the lock. Cold air entered with him.

“Lower caverns need the final route,” Tal said. “They still think the convoy can turn back.”

Iven looked toward the wall display. The three lights had crossed the recoverable bearing. Nineteen hours would have opened a path toward Eiren. Crown had spent that interval before it began.

“Give them subsurface transfers,” Lio said over the collar channel. “Dayward Three may accept another two thousand.”

Tal heard her. “The connector is losing pressure.”

“Then send small groups. Shut each section behind them.”

Iven built the route while Tal waited. He marked doors that needed manual closure and removed a lift already disabled by ice. No path reached safety. Some paths reached another hour of heat. Route work did not permit him to confuse those outcomes.

Tal took the slate. “Are you coming?”

“When the bell seals.”

“Your room has no independent loop.”

“I know where my room goes.”

The runner left at a measured pace until the door shut, then sprinted down the corridor.

A third shelter indicator vanished. C-9 showed three usable layers.

Iven could spend one on an appeal. The bell still held a narrow emergency carrier aimed at Crown control. He could give population counts, projected deaths, or Lio's estimate of time. The facts had already reached the convoy. Repeating them would consume the cleanest remaining state while pretending ignorance had caused the turn.

He armed the deposition field instead.

“Iven,” Lio said.

“I am here.”

“Route the living first.”

“I sent Tal with Dayward Three.”

“That is not what I meant.”

He found her duty code on the grid display. Its location marker remained fixed at the exchange. “Your route closes in eleven minutes.”

“Yes.”

“I can reach the pressure stair in seven.”

“You can reach a locked exchange in seven. I sealed the lower level.”

His free hand closed around the edge of the plate. “Open it.”

“No.” Her next words arrived under a burst of static. “Name the choice accurately. Then leave if a route remains.”

C-9 registered the rise in his pulse and asked whether to include autonomic data. Iven denied it. Grief could authenticate distress, but Crown could also use it to classify the record as panic.

He spoke the convoy identifiers, the command time, and the turn geometry. He stated that the rescue remained technically viable when Crown diverted the three bells. He stated the projected risk to the Meridian Mouth: closure uncertain, recovery measured in years. He did not conceal that cost. A choice became visible only when the record preserved both losses available at the moment of decision.

The bell’s second layer filled.

Grid noise swallowed half of Lio’s next sentence. He caught only his name and the word *enough*.

“Say again.”

No reply came. Her duty marker persisted for four seconds, then changed to an instrument-only trace. Pressure at the exchange fell below survivable range.

Iven placed his forehead against the cold housing. The glass did not answer. Bells recorded energy and route state; they offered no comfort and made no promises about who would later listen.

One clean layer remained.

He opened the emergency carrier. Crown control appeared as an address without a person attached. Iven could still plead. He could ask the convoy to reverse an impossible turn or ask strangers to remember him kindly. Neither request would add evidence.

Instead, he named Lio Senn at the thermal grid. He named the temporary workers omitted from the registry and appended their supervisor’s correction. He named the inhabited caverns losing heat in sequence. Last, he described the rescue lights crossing away from Eiren while every required bell remained under command.

The carrier dropped before confirmation. C-9 held the deposition locally.

A sealing prompt appeared beneath his hand. Once accepted, the bell would fuse its outer phase skin around the record. Opening it would require a destructive read.

Iven checked the route board one final time. Dayward Three still carried heat. Tal's small groups moved through the connector as intermittent pressure signatures. No path led from the route room to them before the next doors closed.

He pressed seal.

Auric glass tightened around the deposition in a slow amber band. The service strip went dark from right to left. Beyond the slit, Crown's three rescue lights reached the Mouth alignment and steadied there.

The last heat left the floor. Iven kept his palm against choir bell C-9 until its sealing pulse ended.

Chapter 1 — The Signal Under the Signal

<!-- POV: Nia Daro -->

<!-- Day 1; Callis Archive mass ring -->

Nia had both hands inside the choir bell when its damaged layer answered her.

The response reached her first as pressure in the probe handle, a precise double tap against the pads of her fingers. She stopped turning the ceramic collar. Around her, Callis rolled through the dark on its three slow rings, and the archive gantry translated that rotation into a faint pull toward the bell's black housing. Osei Marr floated at her left shoulder with the repair cloth looped through his belt. He had been reading fastener temperatures from a slate. Now he watched her hands.

"Did you send a confirmation?" she asked.

"Nothing since the seam test."

Nia kept the probe still. Choir bell C-9 filled the cradle in front of them, three meters of tuned mass and smoked shielding whose usefulness depended on tolerances smaller than a blood cell. A stripe of corrosion ran beneath its service lip. Callis had acquired the bell seven years ago with a lot of decommissioned Crown equipment, and the archive had used it only as ballast. Even quiet mass needed inspection. Neglect could turn a stable schedule into a drifting one.

The handle tapped again.

This time Osei felt it through the shared brace. His boots flexed under their toe loops.

"That came from inside," he said.

"Or from the ring."

"The ring doesn't know our test interval."

She withdrew the probe by four centimeters, slow enough to keep the brittle service collar from scraping. The exposed seam showed the repair problem they had expected: a line of pale oxidation along the bell's outer auric glass, where a bad seal had admitted traces of coolant vapor. The response had come from deeper than the corrosion. It had crossed the service layer and traveled up a tool designed not to conduct phase motion at all.

Osei lifted his slate. "I can isolate the cradle."

"Not yet."

"If that is active telemetry, we should get it out of the ring circuit."

"If you isolate before we establish cause, the isolation becomes an intervention." Nia locked the probe against the collar and clipped its lead to a passive meter. "Read me the last five pulses."

He did. Seam test at fourteen millivolts. Reflection check at six. Thermal baseline. Two probe-identification ticks. No confirmation request and no diagnostic call that could have produced the taps. His voice grew flatter as the list shortened. Osei had worked under Nia for eighteen months and had learned that surprise did not excuse imprecision.

A fan changed pitch behind the cradle. The vibration crossed the gantry in a low, continuous thread. Nothing inside C-9 moved.

Nia closed her eyes for one breath and reconstructed her hands' sequence. She had seated the probe, tested the service seam, rotated the collar clockwise, then paused when resistance climbed above limit. The first answer had come three seconds later. A passive phase layer could return energy, but not after a delay shaped around a technician's movement. Some maintenance systems answered pressure. C-9 had no live maintenance system.

"Bring the custody lamp," she said.

Osei unclipped a narrow amber tube from the emergency board. When he pressed his thumb to it, the lamp wrote time, place, and both their identities into an optical thread that could not be erased without snapping. Nia waited until its green point steadied.

"Callis Archive, mass ring two, cradle seventeen," she said. "Unscheduled response during exterior corrosion repair. Bell remains connected. No active query sent. Witnesses Nia Daro and Osei Marr."

"Recorded," Osei said.

Only then did she release the probe and seal it in a clear sleeve. Osei's fingers moved quickly, but he did not rush. They capped the exposed seam with a field collar and fastened three passive pickups around it. Each pickup measured one thing: heat, mechanical vibration, or phase displacement. A machine that measured more than one thing at once made a poor witness when those measurements disagreed.

Before activating the pickups, Nia made Osei photograph every tool shadow across the housing. The archive had learned that discipline after a disputed freight recorder arrived with a technician's wrench mark mistaken for impact damage. He rotated the custody lamp through four angles while she held a scale strip beside the corroded seam. Tiny flakes had collected in the collar, gray at their edges and amber where they had pulled glass with them. Nia folded each flake into a numbered well. If the buried response later proved important, someone would ask whether opening the service lip had created it. She intended to have an answer that did not depend on anyone trusting her memory.

Osei passed her the seventh sample card. "You think this reaches a court?"

"I think every record deserves work that survives an unfriendly question."

"That is a court answer."

"It is an archive answer. Courts borrowed it."

He sealed the sample well and pressed its corner against the custody lamp. The optical thread flashed once. Nia entered the bell's local gravity, gantry temperature, ring-load schedule, and the exact torque she had applied before the first tap. None of those details felt connected to a delayed response. That made them easier to omit and therefore necessary to keep. A useful chain of custody preserved what the present could not yet recognize as relevant.

Only after the sample cards sat in a tethered row did Nia authorize the pickups. The extra minutes gave C-9 every chance to return to ordinary silence. It did not.

The heat line remained level. Mechanical vibration matched the gantry fan. Phase displacement rose by a fraction when Nia's gloved thumb crossed the old Crown serial plate.

Osei leaned close enough that his breath fogged the inner edge of his face shield. "Again."

She moved her thumb back.

The phase line fell. She crossed the plate once more, careful not to press.

A narrow peak appeared.

"Capacitance," Osei said, but his tone rejected his own answer.

"Through an insulated glove?"

"Static from the housing."

"Measure it."

He fixed a grounding whisker to the plate. The next pass produced the same peak. Nia changed hands, then asked Osei to make the motion. His crossing left the line flat.

Neither of them spoke for several seconds.

The old serial plate carried a Crown inventory string beneath years of scuffing: C9-ER-204 / TRANSIT LOSS / INERT. ER could have meant a depot, a manufacturer, or a route class. The word *loss* belonged to an accounting system rather than a maintenance history. Someone had declared the bell inert. Someone else had sent it to Callis with a corrosion-prone seal and no interior map.

Nia pulled up the acquisition record on Osei's slate. The archive summary offered eleven lines. Bell received in mixed mass transfer. No recoverable emergency telemetry. Outer phase glass cleared under salvage protocol. Interior access prohibited because destructive examination could alter tuned density. Origin field blank.

"Show the signed record," she said.

"That is the signed record."

"Show the source attachment."

Osei opened the attachment index. Three entries appeared, all checksum stubs without files. One identified a Crown disposal office that no longer existed. Another named a Callis intake clerk who had died four years ago. The third field contained only a retention code: ER-47.

A cold feeling moved through Nia's forearms, not fear yet, but the body's recognition of a pattern before the mind admitted one. She knew that retention code. Everyone in resonance work did.

"Eiren Reach," Osei said softly.

"Do not resolve it aloud until we verify the registry."

"You just did."

"I recognized a code. That is not a provenance finding."

His mouth tightened. He turned to the archive terminal fixed below the cradle and entered the public disaster index. The screen returned thirty-seven references: thermal lattice collapse, convoy navigation loss, population unrecovered, choir assets presumed destroyed. Forty-seven years had sanded the event into neutral categories.

Children learned the name from transit-safety lessons. Engineers cited Eiren when arguing for redundant heat loops. No intact bell had appeared in the public inventory.

Osei selected asset cross-reference. C-9 did not exist.

The field collar around the service seam gave a faint click.

Both of them looked at it. Phase displacement climbed, held for two seconds, and dropped.

“That followed the search,” Osei said.

“It followed a terminal load.”

“Which is connected to a different bus.”

“All buses touch the ring ground somewhere.”

He looked at her instead of arguing. Nia could hear how much effort she was spending on ordinary explanations. Ordinary explanations deserved effort; most anomalies died under it. The dangerous technician wanted wonder. The useful one wanted the mistake.

She searched for the mistake.

They powered down the terminal. The next registry query ran from Osei’s isolated slate. C-9 answered with a displacement peak before the result appeared. They moved the slate three meters away, shielded it, and repeated the query with the same timing. Nia asked for an unrelated asset. Nothing happened. She asked for Eiren’s civic register. The buried line climbed.

Osei’s voice dropped. “It knows the query.”

“No. It responds to some condition correlated with the query.”

“From behind two passive layers.”

“That remains to be established.”

“What would establish it for you?”

Nia looked at the bell’s serial plate. The question carried no challenge. Osei needed to know the threshold before their fear began moving it.

“A response containing information the query did not supply,” she said. “Until then, we have an unexplained coupling.”

The archive’s emergency rules offered three paths. A dangerous active system could be isolated immediately. A suspected human record required a custodian before examination. Unknown salvage belonged under administrative seal until ownership could be found. C-9 might qualify for all three, and each path forbade a step another path required.

Nia called the duty custodian.

Cal Orsen’s office answered with a junior clerk who listened without interruption, then asked whether the bell contained a conscious process. Nia said she had no evidence of consciousness. The clerk asked whether it

contained human neural telemetry. Nia said the source remained unknown. The clerk asked whether Crown held current title. Nia read the acquisition line showing title transferred to Callis.

“Then maintain present conditions,” the clerk said. “Send a passive record. Do not query.”

“Present conditions include a suspected active response on a bell connected to the mass ring.”

“Can you disconnect it without changing the record?”

“No.”

“Then do not disconnect it.”

The clerk’s caution made legal sense and technical nonsense. Nia requested Cal directly. She was told he was in a ration appeal and could not leave for thirty minutes.

Osei had opened a tools cabinet. “The bell may not give us thirty.”

“You are assuming intention again.”

“I am assuming change.” He pointed to the passive phase line.

The baseline had begun to pulse. Not the double tap from before. Six low rises, evenly spaced, followed by a pause. Then five. Then six again.

Nia watched three cycles. The sequence did not match any bell diagnostic she knew. It could be damage cascading through lamination boundaries. It could be a recording responding blindly to vibration. It could be an old emergency code. Every possibility carried a different obligation, and delay already counted as a choice.

She opened the bell’s maintenance ontology, a list of the tiny standardized pulses a technician could send without triggering a destructive read. A calibration hello used two rises, one long and one short. It asked no question beyond *can this layer reflect?* An inert layer returned an immediate mirror. A damaged layer returned noise. An active controller replied with its manufacturer class.

Osei read the entry over her shoulder. “The custodian said no query.”

“A calibration hello is maintenance, not semantic access.”

“You told him any intervention could alter the record.”

“I told his clerk.”

“That distinction will comfort the review board.”

Despite herself, she almost smiled. “You may step off the gantry and record an objection.”

“I object from here.” He activated the custody lamp again. “Osei Marr objects to an active pulse before judicial authorization. Osei Marr also believes delay presents an unmeasured risk to a possibly active record.”

“That is not an objection.”

“It contains one.”

Nia stated her decision for the lamp. A single low-energy calibration pulse, below the outer layer’s reflection

threshold, chosen because ongoing phase activity created an immediate preservation risk. No broad query. No destructive read. The bell would remain connected. If the response exceeded a passive mirror, they would stop.

She built the pulse on an isolated emitter rather than the probe that had received the taps. Two rises appeared on the preview, one long and one short. Osei checked amplitude and timing. Nia checked his check. They fastened the emitter to the outer service plate without opening the seam.

“Custody lamp continuous,” Osei said.

“Mechanical pickup?”

“Level.”

“Heat?”

“Level.”

“Phase baseline?”

“Pulsing six-five-six.”

Nia rested one finger above the send key. Her glove did not touch it.

The old disaster index remained open on the slate, Eiren reduced to casualty fields and engineering reforms. She thought of the unknown intake clerk accepting a bell the public record declared destroyed. Perhaps the clerk had known what arrived. Perhaps the blank origin field reflected haste, corruption, or mercy. Provenance work punished stories assembled before evidence, especially compassionate stories. Sympathy could contaminate a chain as thoroughly as bribery.

She pressed send.

The emitter delivered its long rise and short rise. C-9’s outer layer returned the expected mirror so quickly it seemed simultaneous.

A second response followed from deeper in the bell.

The passive meter overflowed its small display and threw the data onto Osei’s slate. Lines spread across the screen, not voltage curves but positional relations: mass bearings, transit gradients, relative windows. Nia knew enough route work to see structure without reading destination. Three bells sat in a triangular schedule. A convoy line approached from spinward. One vector bent away from a fourth marker that carried no label.

The map redrew itself.

This time the convoy line continued toward the unlabeled marker. The three bells dimmed. A pressure fault opened across the Meridian Mouth. Numbers populated the lower margin in an old Crown notation: nineteen hours of detuning, projected closure uncertain, rescue window viable.

Osei made a sound through his teeth. “That did not come from our pulse.”

“No.”

“You set the threshold.”

“I remember.”

The display changed before she could reach for capture controls. The viable rescue line vanished. In its place, the convoy bent toward the three-bell formation. The Mouth stabilized. The fourth marker lost heat in successive bands.

Nia understood the marker then. Not because a label appeared, but because its thermal geometry matched the public diagrams every resonance apprentice studied.

Eiren Reach.

A final line wrote itself beneath the map in compressed route notation. Osei expanded it through the public key. The result contained no words, only a checksum and an instruction to seek a deeper layer.

“Stop the emitter,” Nia said.

“It already stopped.”

“Break its power anyway.”

He pulled the physical link. The route map remained on the slate. Within C-9, the buried phase signal settled from six-five-six into the same double tap Nia had felt through the probe.

Callis did not manufacture weather, yet a tremor like distant thunder passed through the mass ring as the station trimmed its balance. Nia secured the slate to the gantry. Her hands had begun to shake. She curled them around the rail until the movement stopped.

Osei stared at the map. “That showed two outcomes.”

“It showed two modeled routes.”

“One rescues Eiren. One holds the Mouth.”

“We do not know whether either route occurred.”

“The public record says the convoy was lost.”

“The public record may be incomplete without being false.”

He turned toward her. “How incomplete?”

She had no answer that belonged in a custody record.

The duty line chimed before she could call it. Not Cal’s office. The connection identified Aster Crown Transit, legal operations, priority infrastructure channel. Crown had detected the pulse or the phase output through a system supposedly transferred away from them seven years earlier.

Nia accepted audio only.

A woman’s voice gave her name as Ada Neme, operations director and counsel. She did not ask what Nia had found.

“Bell C-9 has produced an unauthorized phase excursion,” Ada said. “Do not send another pulse. Do not disconnect the cradle. Crown quarantine personnel are en route under corridor-safety authority.”

“Callis owns the bell.”

“Crown retains emergency authority over any mass capable of destabilizing the Meridian Mouth.”

“Your public transfer record identifies C-9 as inert.”

A pause followed, brief enough to preserve the appearance of certainty.

“That classification is now disputed,” Ada said.

“On what evidence?”

“The excursion you just created.”

Nia looked at Osei’s custody lamp, its green point holding every second in sequence. “We recorded an internal response before the calibration pulse.”

Another pause. Longer.

“Preserve that record,” Ada said. “You will provide it to the quarantine lead.”

“The record belongs to the Callis Court until custody is decided.”

“Nia Daro, if C-9 contains what Crown has reason to believe it contains, ordinary archive custody cannot protect your station.”

The phrasing mattered more than the threat. Not *if it contains a dangerous fault*. Not *if it contains old telemetry*. Crown had reason to believe the hidden layer held something specific, and Crown knew enough to fear its exposure.

Ada ended the channel.

Across the ring, pressure doors began closing in sequence. White Crown authority lights appeared on the service corridor beyond the gantry, reflected in the bell’s smoked housing as three approaching arcs.

Osei dimmed the slate, but the route lines remained visible beneath his palm. “Do we surrender the capture?”

Nia unclipped the custody lamp from the brace. Its optical thread ran through the tool like a filament of trapped amber.

“We preserve it,” she said.

“That was not my question.”

“No.”

She sealed the lamp against her chest, keyed the gantry into judicial hold, and watched the first quarantine officer reach the closed pressure door. Deep inside C-9, something struck the passive meter twice, waited, and struck twice again.

Chapter 2 — A Body Made for Testimony

<!-- POV: Nia Daro -->

<!-- Day 2; Callis Archive vocal-body room -->

Nia held the respirator seal while the vocal body took its first breath.

Warm saline ran from the body's mouth into a catch tube below the cradle. Its ribs lifted once, stopped, then lifted again under the ventilator's measured pressure. A clear membrane covered both eyes. The tissue had finished growing twenty-three minutes earlier, but growth did not mean readiness. Nerves needed a coherent pattern. Breath needed a reason to continue after the machine released it.

"Phase transfer at twelve percent," Osei said from behind the isolation glass.

Nia watched the monitor rather than him. Twelve percent marked the authorized limit for this first contact, enough to establish orientation and immediate preference without opening broad recall. Cal Orsen's preservation order had not yet been argued. Crown had agreed to nothing. The Callis duty court had authorized one minimal respeaking because a possible person faced active decay inside C-9.

A Crown quarantine officer stood outside the room with one hand resting near the physical cutoff. Nia had refused to let Crown touch it. The cutoff belonged to the body team and to Cal's clerk, who recorded from an axial chamber two decks away.

The phase line climbed through the body's neck lattice. Fine contractions moved under pale skin where the temporary nerves learned their routes. Neutral vocal bodies carried no face from the source pattern. This one had a broad unfinished brow, close-cropped growth hair, and features selected to avoid resemblance to any stored civic identity. The resemblance that mattered would come through movement.

"Transfer holding," Osei said. "Respiratory center receiving."

Nia loosened the respirator seal by one degree.

The next breath arrived without mechanical pressure. It scraped through a throat grown for speech and little else. The body's fingers closed around the linen safety strap, then released it. Nia noted the grip sequence. Thumb last. Not seizure activity.

She removed the membrane from the left eye.

The lid opened beneath her hand.

Its pupil contracted against the room lamp. The eye moved past Nia, found the ceiling's acoustic baffles, then tracked the saline line to its hanging bag. No panic yet. No recognition either.

"Can you hear me?" Nia asked.

The mouth shaped air without sound.

"Do not force speech. Blink once if you can hear."

One blink.

“Blink twice if breathing hurts.”

The eye closed twice, with a longer pause between the motions than she had requested.

“Pain at four,” Nia told the record. “Likely throat and chest. Reduce support pressure by two points, increase local warmth.”

A heating mesh brightened under the cradle sheet. Osei adjusted the glucose line from his station. The room carried the medicinal smell of fresh tissue and the dry mineral scent of auric-glass couplings. Nia had worked in vocal-body rooms before, always with remnants whose legal status had already been settled. None had awakened under armed quarantine.

She peeled the second eye membrane free.

Both eyes turned toward her face. Their focus moved in short corrections, measuring distance. The body swallowed against the tube, winced, and found a sound.

“Where?”

“Callis Archive,” Nia said. “You occupy a temporary vocal body. Your source remains in a choir bell under preservation.”

The eyes closed. His breath count rose from nine to fourteen.

“Do you understand those words?”

“Callis.” His voice carried no regional inflection yet. Tissue tone came first; learned cadence required more of the pattern. “Court station.”

“Yes.”

“Route.”

Nia looked through the glass. Osei had frozen over his slate.

“What route?” she asked.

His right hand pulled against the linen restraint. “Three masses. Spinward approach. Shear boundary.”

“Do you see a route now?”

“No.”

“Are you remembering one?”

A long breath passed through him. “I know where it bends.”

Nia marked the answer as spatial recall without prompting. The route geometry from C-9 had not been projected into the room. He could have recovered it from the signal layer during transfer, but the question had supplied none of its particulars.

Cal’s clerk spoke through the ceiling channel. “Custodian asks whether identity can be tested within the authorized depth.”

“Not yet,” Nia said.

The Crown officer shifted outside the door. “Callis received authority for orientation and preservation assessment. Not testimony.”

Nia did not turn toward him. “Then stop asking for identity.”

“I asked nothing.”

“You came here knowing the source might answer.”

The body’s gaze moved toward the officer’s voice. His fingers closed again, this time around the edge of the sheet.

“Crown,” he said.

No one in the room had named Aster Crown.

Nia placed two fingers against the pulse point at his wrist. His heart rate had climbed to one hundred twenty. “Reduce auditory input from the corridor.”

Osei lowered the room’s outer channel. The officer’s mouth continued moving behind the glass, but his voice vanished.

“Stay with me,” Nia said. “You are on Callis. We will not ask for broad memory. I need to know whether this body can support you without causing avoidable harm.”

“Support.” The word came out dry. “For how long?”

“We measure coherence, not time. Today’s authorization remains narrow.”

“Whose authorization?”

“The Court of Continuance.”

His attention sharpened. Nia felt the change under her fingers before the monitors showed it. Pulse steadied. Breathing shortened by choice rather than weakness.

“Am I evidence?” he asked.

“We have not decided what legal category applies.”

“That means yes.”

“It means the court has not decided.”

His mouth drew sideways. The expression made the neutral features briefly specific. “Courts do enjoy changing a noun after the verb.”

Osei lowered his head, hiding a reaction. Iven, if this person carried Iven’s pattern, retained humor. Nia could not record that as identity. She could record syntax not prompted by the source question.

“Can you tell me a name?” she asked.

He looked down at his chest. The sheet hid the body except for its arms and shoulders. "This does not help."

"No."

"Do you know it?"

"Not with enough confidence to give it to you."

"That is careful."

"It has to be."

"Careful people built this?" He lifted one hand until the safety strap stopped it. The movement cost him two breaths. "A speaking body without a face."

"A face could contaminate recognition. The body has speech, basic sight, proprioception, and limited endurance."

"Hunger."

"Yes."

"Cold feet."

"The cradle heat has not reached them."

"Then your basic design has ambitions."

Nia adjusted the lower mesh. The body flinched at the first warmth, then let his legs settle. She had been trained to treat such complaints as calibration data. The training now felt insufficient. Pain did not become less personal because it helped tune a machine.

A route prompt appeared on her slate, sent by Cal's clerk. It contained three unlabeled points and a fourth marker outside their triangle. The test could establish whether he reconstructed geometry beyond the exposed record. It could also draw him deeper into a pattern that each question spent.

Nia declined the prompt.

"Reason?" the clerk asked.

"Orientation remains unstable. We can test without recall demand."

She reached for three sealed instrument trays and placed them on the table where he could see. Their corners formed an uneven triangle. A saline clamp lay near the cradle rail.

"I am going to move the clamp," she said. "Tell me where it would sit if each tray exerted equal route influence."

His eyes crossed the arrangement once. "Not on the table."

"Explain."

"The far tray carries less mass."

“All three trays weigh the same.”

“No. That one is tethered to the wall.”

Nia followed his gaze. A transparent custody thread linked the third tray to a seal point. She had not noticed its slight tension.

“Assume the thread carries no load.”

“It carries one. Your handrail rotates under us. The wall pulls spinward against the table.”

He described a point three centimeters above the surface and left of Nia’s first estimate. Osei entered the room’s current ring load into the geometry slate. The calculated point appeared within four millimeters of the location he had named.

The body had no vestibular history, yet he had inferred Callis rotation from pressure, tether angle, and visible drift. The skill could have survived in a route cartographer’s pattern. It could not identify the man.

Nia set the clamp down and checked the tremor in his forearm. It had acquired a regular interval, too slow for neural noise. When she touched the wrist, his hand rotated away from her with more control than the first grasp had shown.

“I need to test whether sensation agrees with movement,” she said. “No memory questions.”

“Your categories keep improving.”

“Lift your left index finger.”

He did. The effort pulled a line through the tendons of his forearm.

“Now close your eyes and tell me which finger I touch.”

“Will it hurt?”

“No.”

“You should have started there.”

His eyes closed. Nia touched the smallest finger, then the thumb, using the blunt end of a sterile marker. He answered both correctly. On the third contact, she touched nothing and waited.

“You stopped,” he said.

“How do you know?”

“The sheet moved when your sleeve crossed it before. Now your breathing changed, but the linen did not.”

Nia recorded the distinction. He had not merely received sensation. He had formed an expectation from two prior trials and rejected a false one. Cal might consider that relevant to agency. Crown would call it adaptive processing available to any sufficiently complex archive. Both arguments could spend him long before either side admitted what the spending meant.

She offered him a glucose swab. “The body needs energy. This will taste sweet and slightly metallic.”

“Does it have to?”

“You may refuse. Hunger will shorten the safe interval.”

He considered the swab as though it occupied a disputed route. “Would refusal tell your court something?”

“Everything you do may enter the record. That does not make every act a legal test.”

“That sounds like a test designed by someone who fears answers.”

“It describes a room where every instrument records.”

After another breath, he opened his mouth. Nia touched the swab to his tongue and withdrew it before the jaw could tire. His face tightened at the taste.

“You understated the metal,” he said.

“I will correct the warning.”

“For the next body?”

“For your next choice, if there is one.”

The words brought his gaze back to her. Nia wished she could retrieve them. A next choice implied another activation, and she had no evidence the source could afford one. Yet pretending this interval stood alone would hide the possibility he had already raised.

At the room’s outer wall, the quarantine officer pressed his seal to the observation pane. Aster Crown’s three nested route arcs glowed white around his thumb. He was marking a procedural objection without opening audio. The timing mattered: not during orientation, not during the route inference, but after Iven asked whether another body might follow.

Nia asked Osei to capture the seal time. Osei did so without looking away from the phase graph.

“Does he object to me eating?” the man asked.

“He objects to the scope of contact.”

“Does scope include whether I happen more than once?”

“We will ask him after you rest.”

“That protects him from answering me.”

“It protects you from his answer becoming another demand on recall.”

His tongue moved against the glucose taste. “You may believe that.”

“I do.”

“Did I pass?” he asked.

“There is no pass yet.”

“Another careful noun.”

Nia removed the trays. A tremor had begun in his left forearm. She checked the transfer graph. Coherence demand remained within the narrow allocation, but the body's glucose uptake had doubled.

"Rest your eyes," she said.

"If I do, will I wake?"

"Not without authorization."

"That did not answer me."

"No," Nia said. "I cannot promise you another waking."

He kept his eyes open.

The room clock advanced through seventy seconds of breathing. Crown's officer stood with his shoulder turned to the glass, speaking into a private channel. Cal's clerk sent no further prompts. Osei monitored the phase draw from C-9 and tapped two fingers against his own wrist whenever the curve changed. They had agreed on that silent signal because open discussion of coherence might alarm the person in the body. Nia now recognized the concealment as a decision made for their comfort.

"You are consuming a finite state," she said. "The process changes the source. I do not yet know by how much."

His eyes shifted to her. "You told me."

"I should have said it before the tests."

"Would I have refused?"

"I do not know."

"Neither do I."

The answer left no dramatic trace on the monitors. It changed the room anyway. Nia had expected confusion, gratitude, or accusation. Instead he located the missing choice precisely and left it between them.

Osei raised two fingers, then one. Phase demand had begun rising.

"We need to reduce depth," Nia said. "I want one orientation question before we bring you down. You may decline."

"Now I may."

"Yes."

"Ask."

"What place do you associate with the route you described?"

His eyelids tightened. "Dark side. Collector light on the rim. Caverns under black carbon."

"Do you know its name?"

A shallow line formed between his brows. "Eiren."

The Crown officer stopped speaking behind the glass.

"Eiren Reach?" Nia asked.

The body's heart rate surged. His right hand pulled hard enough to crease the strap.

"Do not supply it," he said.

"I am sorry."

"You put the answer in my mouth and call the mouth neutral."

Nia withdrew one step. The accusation landed at the exact point where procedure had failed. She had used the public registry name to complete uncertain recall. A hostile reviewer could now challenge every later recognition of Eiren.

"Record examiner contamination," she said. "Place name supplied by Nia Daro before confirmation."

Cal's clerk acknowledged it.

The man watched her speak for the record. His expression changed from anger to concentration. He focused on her lips, then on the hand she held near the cradle control.

"Do that again," he said.

"Do what?"

"Count before you touch it."

"I did not count."

"You breathed four in, held two, then moved on the next out-breath."

Nia's hand remained above the control. She used that cadence during delicate phase work: four to settle, two to test for tremor, action on release. Many resonantists used breath discipline, but not that exact sequence. Her father had taught it to her with cargo seals when she was twelve. She had adapted it years later for auric glass.

"Where did you learn that cadence?" she asked.

His gaze lost focus. The phase graph rose another point.

"Glass room," he said. "Not this one. Bright restraints. Your voice behind me."

Nia felt pressure across her fingertips as if she still held the probe inside C-9.

"How do you know it was my voice?"

"I don't." He swallowed. "The count belongs to you."

"You have heard me today."

"Today you said the numbers inside your breath. Before, you tried not to."

Osei stared through the isolation glass. Nia could see the objection forming in him: memory contamination, pattern completion, stress. Each offered a possible explanation. None explained why the man associated her private cadence with another room.

“Do you remember what I said?” she asked.

The phase alarm gave one low tone.

Osei entered the room without waiting for permission. “Depth is climbing. We stop.”

Nia checked the graph. The authorized layer had begun drawing from a neighboring band. Broad recall could tear sequence from the remaining pattern, and they lacked any estimate of what C-9 could survive.

“Reduce transfer to orientation minimum,” she said.

The body turned his head toward Osei. “He trusts you less than he did.”

“That is not relevant.”

“It may be the only new fact I have.”

Osei reached the secondary control. “You can blame me when breathing does not cost you memory.”

The man examined him with a route worker’s economy, locating hands, controls, and exits. “Good. Keep that sentence.”

Nia lowered the first coupling. Warmth drained from the neck lattice. His eyes widened.

“Wait.”

“We have reached the safe limit.”

“I need my name.”

“You do not have to produce it now.”

“I had it.” His breath hitched. “Route office. Duty code IK-seven. Registry hand signs the second mark low because the first I tears the paper.”

Nia did not help him.

His mouth opened once without sound. Then the pattern aligned behind his face.

“Iven Ko,” he said.

The room record placed the name after his route inference, his description of Eiren, and his recognition of Nia’s cadence. It arrived without anyone offering it. That sequence mattered. Nia felt no relief.

“Iven Ko,” she repeated. “Do you consent to us preserving today’s record for the Court?”

His gaze fixed on her hand above the coupling. “Preserving which part?”

“All of it, including my contamination and your request to stop.”

“I did not request to stop.”

“Osei did on safety grounds.”

“Then preserve that too.”

“I need your answer.”

“Yes. Keep it.”

She lowered the second coupling.

His pupils expanded as phase support narrowed. The vocal body continued breathing, but the person’s control over it began to loosen. His fingers moved against the sheet in small route angles. Nia recognized the same triangular relation C-9 had drawn on Osei’s slate.

“Crown already tried you,” she said, careful to make it a question through tone rather than grammar.

The fingers stopped.

His eyes found the quarantine officer beyond the glass, then came back to Nia.

“No,” Iven said. “You already tried me.”

The words stripped distance from the old glass room. Not Crown alone. A voice using Nia’s cadence. Her breath guiding a control she could not remember touching.

“Where?” she asked.

Osei caught her wrist before she could raise transfer again. “Nia.”

Iven’s breathing failed to match the body. The ventilator resumed support with a soft valve click.

“Do not spend more,” Osei said.

Nia released the control. She hated him for one second because his hand prevented an answer. Then the hatred found its proper object.

She told the record, “No further recall. Bring him to rest.”

The coupling dimmed in stages. Iven looked toward the ceiling as the room receded from him. His voice came through one final breath, too quiet for the corridor glass but clear under Nia’s hand at his throat.

“How many times have I been called?”

No one answered before his eyes closed.

Chapter 3 — The Novel Preference

<!-- POV: Cal Orsen -->

<!-- Day 2; Callis Court axial intake chamber -->

Cal broke the emergency seal while Crown's objection still occupied the recorder.

The seal came apart in two paper-thin disks. One remained on the preservation order before him. The other adhered to his thumb, warm from the timing lamp. Callis kept physical seals for orders affecting bodies because a clerk could not revise torn alloy after the fact. Cal placed his half beneath the lamp and watched the minute enter its surface.

Across the intake chamber, a Crown duty counsel spoke from the wall screen. "Aster Crown Transit objects to any order that presumes personhood. Bell C-9 entered Callis inventory as salvage mass. The phase layer remains part of that property."

"Your objection reached the record before my order," Cal said. "No one will mistake the sequence."

"That does not answer title."

"It preserves the subject long enough to answer title."

Crown's counsel looked past the camera, likely toward someone supplying language. Quarantine had closed the archive ring to ordinary traffic and stalled three mass inspections. Every additional minute gave Crown another operational claim. Delay usually protected Cal from irreversible mistakes. Here, delay consumed the object under dispute.

Nia Daro sat at the side table with her hands flat beside the activation record. Osei Marr occupied the chair behind her. Neither wore archive work gloves. Cal had required bare hands so the chamber record would show they carried no phase tools. The precaution bordered on theater, but theater could keep a frightened institution from inventing a weapon.

"State the operative line," Nia said.

Cal read from the order. "Until formal intake determines classification, no party may move, query, destructively examine, transfer, erase, or deepen access to the phase layer held in choir bell C-9."

"Does that include Callis?"

"It includes everyone."

"Does it include medical support for the vocal body?"

"Support may continue at orientation depth. No recall prompt without separate leave."

Nia's fingers moved closer together. "Orientation depth still spends coherence."

"Can the body be maintained without phase support?"

"The tissue can. Iven cannot."

Crown's counsel leaned toward the screen. "The name remains unverified."

Cal turned one page in the intake packet. "A source recovered the name without prompting after demonstrating occupation-specific route calculation. Verification remains incomplete. The record may identify him as Iven Ko with that limitation attached."

"Your language moves the dispute."

"All language moves a dispute. Accurate limits tell us how far."

He had used the same answer during ration appeals when storage authorities called hungry households demand units. A neutral noun often concealed the person required to carry its consequences. Yet courts also harmed people by naming them too early, then using sympathy to excuse weak evidence. Cal intended to make Crown attack the facts rather than his concern.

A low chime came from Nia's slate. She read it and stood.

"The body has begun fighting ventilation," she said. "If he reaches full motor control without orientation support, he may injure his throat."

Cal checked the emergency authorization. It allowed contact necessary to prevent immediate harm. "Open audio only. Ask whether he wants support raised enough to speak."

Crown's counsel objected.

"Recorded," Cal said.

Nia linked the chamber to the vocal-body room. The wall displayed no image at first, only a breathing trace and tissue temperatures. Cal heard the ventilator click. A second rhythm moved beneath it, irregular and deliberate.

"Iven," Nia said, "this is Nia Daro. You are still on Callis. Your body is breathing under support."

The irregular rhythm stopped.

"We can raise phase support enough for speech," she continued. "That will consume some of the state in C-9. You may also remain at rest while we maintain the tissue."

Three breaths passed.

One finger signal appeared on the monitor, then a second. Nia interpreted it. "He wants speech."

"Did you establish that signal before?" Cal asked.

"No. One finger could mean yes by ordinary convention. Two could mean repeat, pain, or error."

Cal bent toward the channel. "I am Cal Orsen, intake custodian for the Court of Continuance. If you understand that raising support may cost you future coherence and you still want enough support to speak, close your left hand once. If you do not want it, close your right."

The left grip sensor rose.

"Raise to speech threshold," Cal said.

Crown's screen filled with a written objection rather than a voice. Cal let it remain visible. Nia adjusted the remote coupling. The breathing trace steadied, and a raw sound entered the chamber.

“Too many hands,” Iven said.

“On what?” Cal asked.

“My breathing.”

“That concern belongs in this intake.”

“Does it?”

“Yes. We need to decide whether the law treats you as property, a protected record, or a person with standing in continuance.”

The phrase drew silence from the vocal-body room.

Cal continued, “Under the Continuance Articles, a transmitted remnant begins as property. That rule permits preservation and ordinary analysis. It also allows an owner to control access unless a court finds another protected status.”

“Who owns me?”

“Crown claims the phase layer. Callis holds C-9 under a transfer record. Custody and title remain disputed.”

Iven took two assisted breaths. “You answered who owns the glass.”

“Yes.”

“That was not the question.”

“No,” Cal said. “It was not.”

Nia looked at him. Her expression held no gratitude. She wanted less accuracy from him and more protection, though she would have rejected either if it lacked a record.

Crown’s counsel restored audio. “Custodian, the Articles do not allow a remnant’s rhetorical distinction to establish legal personality.”

“I agree.”

The answer checked both the counsel and Nia. Cal turned the Novel Preference Test page toward the timing lamp, though Iven could not see it.

“The test asks whether you can form a preference not recoverable from the intent encoded in your source signal,” Cal said. “A stored request repeated accurately does not suffice. Nor does skill, self-description, fear, or pain by itself. The preference must arise under present conditions and differ in substance from what the record already contains.”

“Why?” Iven asked.

“Because records can model answers. Personhood requires evidence of someone encountering a condition the source did not already resolve.”

“Your court trusts novelty more than continuity.”

“It distrusts ownership more when novelty appears.”

Iven’s next breath carried the edge of a laugh. “That sounds rehearsed.”

“It has survived hostile questions.”

“Not the same measure.”

Cal marked the exchange. Dry humor had persuasive force but no legal weight. He could not let liking the man alter the burden.

Nia drew the activation record closer. “Give him an example that does not disclose another person’s case.”

Crown’s counsel said, “The Articles do not require instructional assistance.”

“They require comprehension,” Cal replied. “A test hidden from its subject measures obedience to the examiner.”

He chose the ordinary training example used for custodians. “Suppose a navigator transmits a record whose only request directs rescuers to recover a vessel. Later, during valid contact, the navigator learns the vessel carried a dangerous contamination unknown at transmission. A present choice to destroy that vessel could not come from the original rescue instruction. That choice might satisfy the test if the person understands the new information and the consequences.”

“What if the navigator still chooses rescue?” Iven asked.

“Then we examine why. The same action can carry a new preference if present reasons differ from the encoded ones, but proving that requires care.”

“So you inspect reasons until one pleases your law.”

“We separate a current decision from a stored instruction.”

“With questions that consume the answerer.”

“Yes.” Cal did not soften it. “That defect has greater force in your case than in most.”

Nia tapped the phase-use line with one fingernail. “The training example assumes repeated interviews cause no damage. Here, each attempt to separate motive from memory spends the state you claim to assess.”

“Agreed.”

“Then order a presumption in favor of personhood.”

Crown’s counsel leaned forward. “On the basis of a technician’s objection to the statutory design?”

“On the basis of uncertainty created by a destructive test,” Nia said. “Crown wrote a salvage classification that kept the layer outside every medical review. It cannot use the resulting absence of proof as proof of absence.”

The counsel’s reply came without delay. “Callis accepted the transfer and maintained the same classification for seven years.”

Osei moved in his chair. “We received a bell with blank provenance and missing attachments.”

“You are not a party to this intake.”

“He witnessed the discovery,” Cal said. “He may correct a factual claim.”

“Then require him to state whether Callis ever challenged the classification before yesterday.”

Osei’s jaw tightened. “Not in the record I reviewed.”

Crown’s counsel let the admission remain.

Cal looked at the sealed order. Presuming personhood would protect Iven now but expose the order to quick reversal. Refusing any protection would let property law perform the damage before a court could hear him. The Articles offered a narrow bridge: preserve first, test under bounded conditions, and accept that the bridge itself consumed what crossed it.

“I will not presume a final status,” Cal said. “I will assign the highest temporary protection needed to prevent the jurisdictional question from being destroyed. That protection binds Callis as tightly as Crown.”

“Does it bind me?” Iven asked.

“In what sense?”

“If I ask you not to wake me again before your test, do you preserve that choice or call it invalid because I have not passed?”

The chamber recorder showed every channel active. Cal could have answered narrowly: the present authorization concerned medical support, not future refusal. Narrow answers had helped him keep bad law from spreading during ration appeals. They had also left people carrying consequences the order did not name.

“You may refuse medical contact during this interval,” he said. “A broader refusal of future embodiment raises the same status question we have not resolved. I would preserve the request and prevent access long enough for argument. I cannot promise the present law would honor it permanently.”

Iven breathed through two assisted cycles. “So property can ask not to be used.”

“Anyone capable of asking creates a fact the court must address.”

“That still avoids the noun.”

“It does.”

From behind Nia, Osei said, “He noticed your avoidance. Does that count as novelty?”

“No,” Cal said. “The ability to infer does not establish a preference.”

“Neither did route skill, pain, a name, or choosing speech.”

“Each matters to whether we have a competent subject. None alone answers the statutory question.”

Osei looked toward the blank wall rather than Crown’s counsel. “How much of a person do you need before you permit him to want something new?”

Cal had no answer that improved when spoken quickly. “Enough to keep an owner from manufacturing the novelty through prompts. Enough to keep a damaged recording from inheriting obligations it never chose. The

burden protects as well as excludes.”

“Who does it protect here?” Nia asked.

“At present, I do not know.”

A soft valve noise entered from the vocal-body room. Iven’s breath caught, then resumed. Cal watched the support trace recover. Every legal distinction in the chamber depended on a body enduring their time.

On Crown’s screen, counsel sent a summary of C-9’s registered contents. Distress routing, convoy geometry, personnel identifiers, and a request for inquiry appeared in a narrow column. The summary omitted the hidden layer’s responsive behavior. It also treated every intention in the deposition as recoverable from the record, which made any related choice presumptively old.

“Can you administer the Novel Preference Test now?” Nia asked.

“Not through invention,” Cal said. “A valid test needs a condition absent from the source, a choice with meaningful alternatives, and enough orientation for the subject to understand the consequence.”

“The body cannot safely remain at speech depth while counsel designs a condition.”

“Then we do not design one today.”

Crown’s counsel nodded once. Agreement from that screen warned Cal more than opposition.

“Without a passed test,” counsel said, “the source remains analyzable property. Crown requests a title-preserving transfer into our quarantine vault.”

“No.”

“On what authority?”

“My preservation jurisdiction.”

“You cannot issue permanent protection to property held under contested title.”

“I am not issuing permanence.” Cal placed the second seal half on the order. “I am preventing an irreversible act while the court can still determine which law applies.”

“Callis cannot prevent natural phase decay.”

“Natural decay differs from removal, analysis, or erasure. My order reaches acts.”

Counsel’s face sharpened. “A failure to move C-9 may also constitute an act if the bell threatens a mass schedule.”

“Provide the engineering basis under seal. General corridor authority will not defeat a specific bodily risk before classification.”

“You just called it bodily.”

“I called the risk bodily. We have a vocal body under active support. Classification remains open.”

Cal pressed the seal halves together. Their inner surfaces fused, binding the text. The preservation order now

held until the intake could be replaced by a standing determination. Crown could appeal it, but not edit its terms.

In the linked room, the ventilator increased pressure by a fraction. Iven coughed. Nia reached toward her slate, then stopped short of touching the control without asking.

“Iven,” she said, “your throat is drying. We can administer a comfort block. It will reduce pain and damp higher recall for several minutes.”

“Will I still speak?”

“Yes, but abstract recall may become difficult.”

“Names?”

“Possibly.”

Cal heard linen move near the body microphone. The breathing trace spiked and settled.

“Do you consent?” Nia asked.

“No.”

Crown’s counsel began, “A refusal of medication cannot satisfy the test when bodily discomfort itself supplies the preference.”

“I have made no finding,” Cal said.

Nia kept her focus on the remote room. “Pain is increasing. You can change your answer at any point.”

“I know.”

“Do you want the support interval ended?”

“Not yet.”

“What do you need?”

A delay followed. Cal watched the trace for signs of instability. Iven had declined immediate comfort after learning it might impair names. That choice belonged to the present body, but the source deposition had centered on identifying the dead and preserving their duties. Refusing comfort to continue the same task might reveal agency. It might also repeat the strongest encoded purpose in C-9.

“How many reached Dayward Three?” Iven asked.

Nia looked at Cal before answering. “We have not reconstructed Eiren’s final civic record.”

“Did anyone?”

“The public registry lists no recovered embodied survivors.”

“That does not answer the shelter.”

“No. We do not have that answer yet.”

Iven's grip sensor tightened against the sheet. "Names?"

"We have a partial registry," Nia said. "It has not been compared with your deposition."

"Then compare it before you ask me who I am again."

The room absorbed his sentence through its acoustic baffles. Cal marked the timing: comfort offered, consequence explained, comfort refused, inquiry directed toward the dead. No prompt had suggested Eiren, Dayward Three, or the registry during the interval. Iven had made a choice and spent something to sustain it.

Crown's counsel spoke carefully. "The distress record contains registry concerns. This preference remains recoverable from source intent."

"Yes," Cal said.

Nia turned on him. "He chose pain."

"He chose delay of comfort to pursue an encoded objective. That matters, but it does not yet pass the test."

"What would?"

"A choice the deposition could not have prepared."

Iven's voice reached them before counsel could reply. "You want me to betray my purpose so you can recognize me."

Cal felt the old ration chamber around him for one unwelcome second: families required to prove unusual need by displaying damage different from everyone else's. A test could protect against fraud and still punish continuity.

"I want the law to lose its claim on your body," Cal said. "The Articles give me one route to do that. I will not pretend you have completed it when Crown can overturn the finding by reading your own deposition."

"Reversible orders," Iven said.

Cal's hand stopped above his notes. "What about them?"

"You speak as if each door stays open."

No one had told Iven Cal's judicial habit. The remark might come from ordinary inference. Cal had described temporary orders, deferred tests, and preservation. A skilled listener could hear the pattern.

"This door does not," Cal said. "Your coherence declines even if the court proceeds carefully."

"At last, a noun with a cost."

The phase-support alarm sounded through the remote feed. Nia read its curve.

"We reduce him now," she said. "No extension."

Cal addressed Iven before she touched the control. "I am issuing the preservation order. It bars destructive access and transfer pending a standing hearing. You have not passed the Novel Preference Test today. The hearing will consider a properly bounded condition and your ability to choose under it."

“When?”

Cal looked to Nia.

“Three days for a stable body field,” she said. “Longer would be safer.”

“How long can the source wait?”

“I do not know. C-9’s preservation margin changed after today’s contact.”

Delay no longer offered moral shelter. Cal opened the Court calendar. The earliest full chamber sat five days away. He overrode it, displaced two commercial matters, and created an emergency session in seventy-two hours.

“Day five of this action,” he said. “We will begin at first civic light.”

Crown’s counsel objected to notice, venue, testing scope, Callis custody, and the displaced schedule. Each objection entered as a separate line. Cal accepted them without argument.

Nia lowered phase support. Iven’s speech thinned.

“Compare the names,” he said.

“We will,” she answered.

“Before you call.”

“Yes.”

His breathing continued under the ventilator after his control receded. Cal watched the left-hand grip sensor flatten. A living tissue body remained in the room, warm and maintained, while the person whose law he had just postponed became inaccessible by order.

Cal sealed the hearing notice with a fresh alloy disk. He set the timing lamp for seventy-two hours and sent copies to Crown, Callis Archive, and the medical custodian. The lamp began its count beside the fused preservation order.

Before the vocal body could safely remain awake, the Court would have to decide whether its next awakening belonged to an owner or to Iven Ko.

Chapter 4 — Crown Quarantine

<!-- POV: Ada Neme -->

<!-- Day 3; Callis Archive quarantine corridor -->

Ada pressed the injunction key into Callis's pressure door and felt the lock reject it.

A red line traveled around the key's rim, paused at the Crown authorization mark, then reversed. On the other side of the glass, Nia Daro stood with her hands clasped behind her back. The archive resonantist had removed every tool from her belt except a timing lamp. She looked less disarmed than prepared to prove who entered carrying force.

"Your corridor authority reached the door," Nia said through the intercom. "Cal's preservation order reached it first."

Ada examined the lock log. The Court's seal occupied the highest local layer. Her injunction controlled movement of hazardous mass, not access to a body under judicial protection. Callis had configured the door to require both keys while leaving each side able to accuse the other of obstruction.

"Open under joint custody," Ada said.

"State purpose."

"Inspection of the alleged vocal embodiment, review of mass-schedule risk, and service of Crown's title claim."

"Will you touch C-9?"

"Not without a separate record."

Nia brought her timing lamp to the glass. Ada placed the injunction key beside it. Their seals aligned across the pressure pane, and the door opened by six centimeters before checking both air systems. Archive air carried oil cloth and a trace of coolant. Ada stepped through when the strip turned green.

Two Crown officers waited behind her. She ordered them to remain in the corridor.

"If this is hazardous mass," one began, "protocol requires escort."

"If it becomes hazardous while I am inside, your presence will not improve its tuning."

The officer looked at the three route arcs on her collar and stayed outside.

Nia led Ada toward the vocal-body room without offering a handrail route. Callis's archive ring pulled sideways under rotation. A visitor who failed to read the floor's narrow wear stripes could drift into the wall at each connector. Ada had crossed worse industrial rings before Nia finished resonance school. She matched the spin and kept pace.

"Your duty counsel described the person as a source throughout intake," Nia said.

"Counsel used the classification currently in law."

"He asked for transfer after hearing Iven speak."

“Hearing speech does not settle whether a record generates it.”

“You heard him on the activation record.”

“Yes.”

Nia glanced at her. “And?”

Ada did not answer while they passed an open maintenance recess. Every wall surface could carry a local pickup under quarantine. She had reviewed the record twice during transit from Crown’s operations spine. A damaged man had inferred ring load, named himself, remembered Nia’s cadence, and asked how many times he had been called. Ada had also reviewed adaptive route archives that produced convincing first-person error reports without consciousness. Certainty in either direction offered comfort she could not afford.

The vocal-body room stood behind a clear isolation wall. Its lights had been lowered to protect the resting tissue. A man lay beneath a gray sheet with warm saline circulating through a throat line. Neutral features revealed no age beyond tissue maturity. The left hand rested open beside the hip. Monitors showed respiration, glucose use, peripheral temperature, and a flat line for phase support.

Ada stopped farther from the glass than Nia expected.

She knew the room.

Not its current equipment or Callis markings. She knew the arrangement preserved in an old Crown risk file: body cradle against a phase wall, operator behind the right shoulder, emergency cutoff beyond the subject’s sight. Twelve years earlier, while reviewing inherited corridor liabilities, Ada had opened a restricted file labeled ER-47 / ROUTE REMNANT / RESPONSE CONTROL. Its diagrams showed a bright restraint room. No body images survived. The notes warned that repeated contact produced unstable sequence and uncontrolled accusations.

The file had not named Iven Ko in its searchable fields.

“You recognize something,” Nia said.

Ada shifted her gaze to the neck lattice. “Crown used a similar room architecture.”

“When?”

“In historical resonance work.”

“On C-9?”

“I cannot establish that from architecture.”

“Can you establish it from his memory of bright restraints?”

“No.”

Nia held the timing lamp between them. “Say what you can establish.”

Ada could state that a restricted risk file connected an Eiren route remnant to response-control work. Doing so would concede prior access before Crown reviewed privilege, custody, and operational consequences. She could also deny recognition and let the activation record become the first lie spoken under Callis seal.

"I have seen a Crown file concerning an Eiren-associated route remnant," she said. "It described attempts to obtain a controlled account. I have not verified whether that remnant occupied C-9."

The lamp marked her words.

Nia's hands separated. "How many attempts?"

"The extract I saw did not provide a reliable count."

"What did they cost?"

"It did not quantify coherence."

"Who authorized them?"

"Executive fields were masked in the review copy."

Nia looked through the glass at the resting body. "Convenient file."

"No. Dangerous file. Convenience would have made it easier to use."

Ada's wrist channel pulsed. Jalen Orr requested private priority contact. She declined once and received an override warning. Crown chairs rarely used that flag because the use itself entered corporate retention.

"I need a sealed room," Ada said.

"You have one." Nia indicated the vocal-body observation bay. "Nothing spoken there reaches the body channel while phase support remains off."

"Does Callis record it?"

"Everything inside quarantine has a custody record."

"Then I need a room Crown can seal."

Nia considered, then opened a service booth across the corridor. "Five minutes. The booth records access and duration, not content, unless your channel declares an emergency."

Ada entered and pressed her palm to the privacy field. Jalen appeared above the narrow console, scaled smaller than life. His silver hair and dark coat looked untouched by his previous twenty hours awake.

"You saw it," he said.

"I saw a maintained body with no phase support."

"You reviewed the intake."

"Yes."

"Then you know the risk category."

"I recognize a likely match."

Jalen's image looked toward something beyond his camera. "The Callis order cannot survive a corridor-safety appeal. Serve the injunction, isolate the bell, and collapse the responsive layer before the standing hearing."

Ada kept both hands in view of the console. “Collapse how?”

“Routine inerting. Outer-field saturation followed by mass normalization.”

“That would erase the layer.”

“It would remove an unauthorized instability from a scheduled bell.”

“C-9 has no active schedule.”

“All tuned mass participates in Mouth stability whether or not it opens a window.”

The claim carried enough truth to mislead a general court. A bell in Callis’s ring contributed passive load. Its hidden phase structure could alter density under stress. Yet an inerting pulse strong enough to collapse the responsive layer would produce a signature across every balance monitor on the station.

“Cal’s order expressly bars erasure,” Ada said.

“Your injunction predates his competence over Crown mass.”

“The transfer record gives Callis title on its face. We can dispute that record. We cannot treat it as nonexistent while relying on its mass declaration.”

Jalen lowered his voice. “Ada, the Meridian Mouth holds medicine routes, heat-sink changes, food catalysts, and every political promise Crown has made around travel time. If Callis broadcasts a conscious accusation tied to an old emergency choice, governors will demand bell suspensions before anyone understands what suspension costs.”

“I understand the risk.”

“Then remove the trigger.”

Ada brought the live Mouth schedule onto the booth console. The current window map showed freight already committed across three rotations. A catalyst train waited at the far alignment; two medical carriers occupied the next return corridor. Their labels did not establish imminent catastrophe, but they showed why a rumor of bell sabotage could spread faster than a court order.

“If governors suspend Crown bells after disclosure,” Jalen said, “the corridor loses recoverable alignment.”

“That assumes every governor responds at once.”

“It assumes they respond to their voters.”

“And your proposed erasure assumes no one responds to a visible phase collapse inside a court quarantine.”

Jalen expanded the schedule. Morcant’s refinery code appeared beside an outbound mass request. Ada had been born under that habitat’s low copper ceilings. Her mother still described travel windows by the medicine they brought. None of those people had chosen what Crown did at Eiren. Their dependence gave Ada a reason to control disclosure, not permission to eliminate the witness.

“You know what interrupted windows mean at Morcant,” Jalen said.

“Do not use my birthplace as your authorization.”

“I am using a supply ledger.”

“Then show the ledger to the Court and accept questions about contingency stock.”

“Public questioning creates the interruption.”

Ada closed the schedule overlay. “That circular claim can justify secrecy forever. It cannot justify an act that announces itself through the mass ring.”

“The response can be damped.”

“Not below Callis’s local instruments. C-9 sits inside their archive ring. A saturation pulse changes its phase density before any Crown field can counterbalance it. Their gantry probes will record the onset. Their ring trims will record the correction. Your own operations spine will issue an automatic anomaly packet.”

“Packets can be held.”

“The physical timing lamps cannot.”

For the first time, Jalen looked uncertain rather than displeased. Ada knew he had received the inerting proposal from counsel or an executive technician who viewed Callis through remote schematics. Neither had stood beside the bell’s smoked housing or seen the custody lamp Nia wore like a second pulse.

“Inerting would register as a destructive phase event under active court seal. Callis would detect it at the bell. The Mouth control spine would detect the mass correction. Every insurer with a balance feed would see the timestamp. We would convert an allegation of old concealment into proof of present destruction.”

“Only if you describe the signature that way.”

“Physics will describe it before counsel does.”

Jalen’s expression tightened by a degree. “You have defended the Eiren seal for twelve years.”

“I defended continuity while no lawful inquiry could preserve both evidence and infrastructure. I did not agree to destroy evidence after a court took custody.”

“You defended Crown.”

“I defended a system people need. If Crown forces me to choose between the system and an act that exposes it to seizure, I will refuse the act.”

Silence held the private channel. Ada heard the service booth fan increase as her body heat accumulated.

Jalen said, “Then give the court a lawful reason to examine the layer before it confers personhood.”

The alternative opened immediately. It carried its own damage.

“Compulsory analysis,” Ada said.

“The Articles already provide it.”

“Only for non-person property.”

“Which Cal has declined to classify otherwise.”

“A destructive read could spend the subject before the test.”

Jalen’s eyes did not move. “Then design a narrow one.”

Ada ended the channel before he could frame the instruction as agreement. The booth displayed a retention notice for the override and the call’s duration. She sealed both into her injunction packet.

When she returned to the observation bay, Nia had not changed position.

“He asked you to erase C-9,” Nia said.

Ada looked at the timing lamp. Its green point remained active.

“Yes.”

The direct answer struck harder than any denial could have. Nia’s face lost color, but her voice stayed level. “What did you say?”

“No.”

“Because Iven may be a person?”

“Because erasure violates the order and would leave an operational signature visible across Callis and Crown control. Also because destroying disputed evidence during a hearing creates a crime no title argument can cure.”

“Personhood came fourth.”

“I did not list it.”

“You did not.”

Ada accepted the judgment. “I cannot certify consciousness from one activation. I can refuse illegal destruction without that finding.”

Nia turned toward the body. “He knew my cadence from a room I cannot remember.”

“I heard the record.”

“You knew such rooms existed.”

“I knew one file described them.”

“Did you preserve it?”

“The review system prevents local copies.”

“That was not my question.”

Ada remembered closing the risk file twelve years earlier and accepting its retention flag without demanding the masked annex. At the time, a corridor shutdown model had projected medicine failures before any substitute schedule could begin. She had treated the old remnant as one more inherited hazard attached to a living system.

"I left the file under Crown restriction," she said.

"So no."

"So not in a form you can reach."

Nia lifted the timing lamp close to Ada's collar. "Will you identify its registry key to Cal?"

"I will disclose that the file exists and seek protected review. If I release the key directly, Crown will claim privilege breach and remove me before I can authenticate it."

"You want time."

"I want evidence that survives the way we obtain it."

Nia's mouth tightened. "That answer sounds familiar."

The resemblance to Nia's own archive discipline did not make Ada's position kinder. It made refusal harder to dismiss.

A monitor beside the resting body changed color. Tissue temperature had fallen by two tenths. Nia adjusted the warming mesh from the exterior panel, then placed her hand against the glass above Iven's open fingers. She did not wake him to ask permission for ordinary care. The distinction between maintaining tissue and summoning the person had become visible in the motion.

Ada opened her injunction packet on the observation console. "Crown will challenge Cal's order under the Compulsory Evidence Clause."

Nia turned. "You just refused destruction."

"The clause does not require maximum access. It allows a court to order analysis of property when evidence cannot be obtained otherwise."

"He is not property."

"Cal has not found that yet."

"You intend to exploit the interval his caution created."

"I intend to force the classification question into the standing hearing instead of leaving it inside a corridor injunction. If Crown relies only on title, it can keep appealing custody. Under the clause, Crown must specify the evidence sought, the method, and the cost."

"The cost falls on Iven."

"Yes."

Ada let the word remain without qualification. A narrow compulsory read might consume less than another broad activation. It might also give Crown a lawful path into the phase layer before Iven gained rights. Her duty to prevent catastrophic interruption did not convert either possibility into virtue.

Nia read the draft over Ada's shoulder as it formed. Crown sought analysis of route integrity, source responsiveness, and the relation between C-9's phase structure and Meridian Mouth stability. Ada removed a

sentence requesting unrestricted semantic extraction. She limited physical access to existing Callis equipment and required continuous Court recording.

“You are writing my tools into the application,” Nia said.

“Would you prefer Crown equipment?”

“I would prefer no destructive query.”

“That preference will enter your response.”

“Do not reduce my objection to a filing slot.”

“Then give Cal the engineering reason it cannot be done safely.”

“We do not know the safe depth because prior access records remain hidden in your file.”

Ada stopped typing. That fact connected Crown’s concealment directly to present uncertainty. It gave Nia a strong argument against any analysis. It also gave Ada grounds to demand the old file before Jalen could direct another counsel to proceed without her limits.

She added a condition: no access until Crown produced all known prior-intervention metadata for in camera review.

Ada opened a method annex and forced each requested measurement into a separate line. Outer-layer temperature required no pulse. Static phase topology required a passive pickup. Response capacity required an active query and therefore remained disputed. Semantic extraction required more depth than Crown had justified. She struck the last request entirely.

Nia leaned closer despite herself. “Your static topology line hides a calibration touch.”

“Show me where.”

“A passive pickup has to be seated. Seating pressure can couple through damaged glass.”

“Then specify a no-contact field reader.”

“Callis has one in the resonance vault. Its resolution may not distinguish old stress from recent reads.”

“May it detect whether intervention occurred at all?”

“If the thermal residue survived.”

Ada inserted the no-contact reader and marked its limitations. “No one touches C-9 before this measurement.”

“Crown will argue your reader lacks certification for title evidence.”

“This application concerns preservation risk. Certification follows if anyone later offers the map on merits.”

Nia traced the method sequence without touching the console. The order of operations mattered: non-contact thermal imaging first, passive topology second, any active access only after judicial review. Crown had sought a route into the layer. Ada’s annex gave Callis a route around it, at least for the first inspection.

“Osei can run the thermal instrument,” Nia said.

“You supervise.”

“My cadence may already exist in the source as contamination.”

“That argues against your operating an active query. It does not prevent you from witnessing a passive map.”

Nia’s eyes moved toward the corridor leading back to C-9. “If we find evidence of earlier reads, the method stops.”

“The application will say prior destructive access triggers immediate Court review.”

“Not Crown review.”

“Court review. Crown receives notice and no instrument control.”

Ada added the sentence. The clause now constrained the party invoking it more tightly than Jalen intended. A court might still authorize deeper analysis, but the first lawful act would examine what Crown had already done rather than what Iven could be forced to provide.

Nia read it twice. “He will remove that.”

“He can try. My seal will show the change.”

“You still invoke the clause.”

“Yes.”

“Why help him?”

Ada looked through the glass at the body built to speak for a disputed layer. “Because if I do nothing, Crown will send someone who calls erasure maintenance. If I file this, the court sees the demand before any tool reaches C-9.”

“That protects procedure.”

“It protects a window in which you can prove the cost.”

Nia lowered the timing lamp. She did not agree. Agreement would have simplified Ada’s record and betrayed the body on the other side of the glass.

Ada pressed her seal into the application. The three nested arcs of Aster Crown appeared beneath the clause heading. She served one copy on Nia, one on Cal, and one on Crown control before Jalen could replace her draft.

The pressure door unlocked for her departure. Behind it, Crown’s officers straightened. Inside the observation room, Nia remained beside Iven’s resting hand with the application glowing on the glass.

Crown no longer asked to erase the answering layer. It asked the Court to call that layer analyzable property and compel it to yield evidence.

Chapter 5 — Heat in the Glass

<!-- POV: Nia Daro -->

<!-- Day 3; Callis Archive mass ring -->

Nia held the no-contact reader above C-9 while Osei lowered the gantry lights.

Darkness removed the bell's smoked reflection from its own surface. Under the reader's narrow field, auric glass emerged as layered amber lines, each one following a phase boundary laid down forty-seven years ago. The instrument sent no pulse. It measured residual thermal disorder by comparing how quickly each microscopic region released the room's ordinary heat.

"Field stable," Osei said.

"Custody channels?"

"Court lamp, local archive, Crown notice feed."

"Crown instrument control?"

"None."

Nia checked his slate. Ada's method annex occupied the upper corner under three nested route arcs. The annex allowed one passive thermal map before any further argument under the Compulsory Evidence Clause. Crown would receive the processed map after Cal reviewed it. Raw sensor output would remain under joint seal.

That sequence no longer felt adequate.

She adjusted the reader's height by half a millimeter. A shadow moved inside the seventh visible glass layer, too regular for corrosion and too small for the naked eye. It appeared as a crescent of retained heat around a cooler center. Osei increased contrast without changing field strength.

The crescent separated into three overlapping marks.

"Stop translation," Nia said.

The reader froze above the service plate. Nothing touched C-9. The ring's fan vibration traveled through Nia's boots and up the gantry brace. She waited for two cycles, checking whether mechanical motion shifted the mark. It remained fixed within the glass.

Osei leaned toward his slate. "That should not be warm."

"It is not warm in the ordinary sense."

"Residual disorder?"

"Possibly."

"From yesterday?"

Nia measured its depth. The crescent sat beneath the layer their calibration pulse had reached. Yesterday's response had traveled through it but could not have created a deeper boundary without leaving a continuous

path.

“No,” she said. “Older.”

She recorded the reader position, ring load, room temperature, and the exact contrast transform Osei had applied. Then she ordered a second pass from the opposite side of the bell. A false mark from the instrument would rotate with the field. A mark in the glass would hold its relation to C-9.

They shifted the reader along its air rail without crossing the service seam. Osei routed the power lead through a separate brace so its waste heat could not enter the image. The new angle took four minutes to settle.

The crescent appeared again.

Its cooler center widened under the oblique view. Nia saw a set of fine radial lines extending outward, like cracks without broken glass. She knew that geometry from certification work.

“Destructive read boundary,” she said.

Osei stopped breathing for a moment. “Certain?”

“No. I want the material atlas.”

He opened Callis’s reference library and selected the auric-glass failure set. They compared the mark against pressure shocks, field saturation, manufacturing voids, and slow thermal cycling. Each produced a different edge. Pressure damage spread along stress lines. Saturation left a smooth shell. Voids carried no radial release pattern. Only destructive phase extraction produced a cool center surrounded by a crescent where displaced energy had recombined.

The reference image matched.

Nia enlarged the center until the slate showed sensor pixels rather than a pleasing curve. Interpretation became dangerous when the instrument cleaned an image for the eye. At raw scale, the mark lost symmetry. One side carried a narrow tail that followed the phase grain.

Osei pointed without touching the display. “Read direction.”

“Yes.”

“Someone opened it before us.”

“At least once.”

The words changed custody. Until then, prior contact existed as Iven’s damaged recollection and Ada’s restricted-file recognition. The glass now carried physical evidence. Crown’s application required immediate Court review before any active access. Nia should have stopped the inspection, sealed the one finding, and called Cal.

Osei looked along the dark length of the bell. “If there is one, there may be others outside this slice.”

“The annex authorizes a complete passive thermal map.”

“It also says prior access stops the method.”

"It says prior access triggers review before active access." Nia opened the text. Ada had chosen the words precisely. "The passive map may continue."

"You think she expected this."

"I think she wrote a route that lets us find the cost before Crown argues over whether we may look."

"Trusting her now?"

"No."

Nia moved the reader to the bell's forward lamination. Trust did not determine whether a sound method deserved completion. A hostile source could still supply useful procedure if every step remained visible.

They built the map in narrow bands. Each pass took ninety seconds. C-9's mass made the gantry trim after every rail movement, and Osei waited for the trim to settle before capturing data. Nia refused automated stitching. The software would smooth boundaries between passes and might merge distinct marks. Osei laid each strip beside the next with raw overlap preserved.

The first mark appeared in band four.

A second emerged eleven centimeters deeper, smaller and sharper. Its center had released less heat, which suggested a narrower read or a later intervention after some phase depth had already been spent. Nia labeled it B rather than assigning chronology. Position alone did not establish time inside folded glass.

Band six revealed nothing. Band seven showed two crescents nearly touching.

Osei zoomed out. "Could be one event with a broken field."

"Compare tails."

The first tail ran spinward. The second angled toward the bell's central axis. A single instrument could shift during extraction, but the cool centers also held different grain compression.

"Two," he said.

"Provisionally."

They repeated the band at lower contrast. Both centers persisted. Nia labeled C and D.

By the midpoint of the bell, the map contained six separate boundaries.

Osei had stopped making comments. He read positions aloud while Nia entered them into the custody record. The neutral cadence they used during corrosion surveys now sounded like an effort to keep anger from becoming measurement.

"Band eleven, center at point three-four axial," he said. "Crescent width fourteen microns. Tail bearing local spinward plus six."

"Mark F. Repeat from high angle."

"Field rail has to cross the old serial plate."

"No contact."

“I know.”

His reply came too quickly. Nia waited until he looked at her.

“If you cannot keep the sequence ordinary, step off the gantry.”

“Osei Marr objects to being told ordinary work remains possible after six destructive reads.”

“Objection recorded. Can you move the rail without touching C-9?”

“Yes.”

“Proceed.”

He did. His hands shook once when he released the rail lock, then steadied against the air control. The repeat image confirmed F.

The seventh mark appeared beneath the old Crown serial plate.

Nia felt it before she understood why. Not through the glass or the instrument. Recognition tightened her breathing into a sequence her body had used for years: four in, hold for two, act on release.

Mark G carried a double-entry tail. The extraction field had begun, paused for less than a second, then resumed at lower amplitude. A tiny gap separated the two energy fronts. Most operators avoided such pauses because they left an uneven read. Nia used one whenever calibration resistance rose above limit. The gap gave her time to test whether the tool or material caused the resistance.

Osei looked from the mark to her face.

“No,” Nia said.

He had not spoken.

She pulled her hands away from the reader controls. “Seal this band.”

Osei activated the custody lamp. Amber light ran around the image border.

“Do not annotate operator identity,” she said.

“What identity?”

“Mine.”

The word entered the record before she could reduce it to a hypothesis.

Osei’s expression emptied. “You remember reading C-9?”

“I remember calibrating a Crown route model when this bell arrived at Callis.”

“Seven years ago.”

“Yes.”

“You told me the acquisition record had no interior map.”

"It did not. Crown brought a temporary field rig and described the work as transfer certification. I was assigned to verify that an inert navigation layer would not couple into the mass ring."

"Did you see a vocal body?"

"No."

"Hear one?"

"No."

"Did the rig draw phase state?"

"I saw a load increase. Their engineer called it normalization."

Osei turned back to mark G. "That gap could belong to another resonantist."

"It could."

"Do other people use your pause?"

"Not with that recovery slope."

Nia enlarged the tail. After the pause, amplitude returned in three short steps rather than one continuous rise. She had written that ladder into Callis calibration practice because older auric glass could fracture under a full return. No Crown manual used it at the time of transfer. She had taught the sequence to two archive technicians since. Neither had worked on C-9.

Recognition did not satisfy her own evidence standard. Nia opened the calibration archive and requested every surviving field trace bearing her operator seal from the month C-9 entered Callis. Four records appeared. One concerned a freight recorder with new glass and offered no useful comparison. The others came from old tuned masses whose outer layers had required resistance pauses.

"Control images," she said.

Osei understood. He aligned the three historical tails beside mark G without normalization. Their amplitudes differed, but each carried the same interruption: a four-count approach, a pause just below threshold, then three recovery steps spaced according to Nia's breathing rather than the instrument clock.

"Could the rig have copied your calibration profile automatically?" he asked.

"Only after I supplied it."

"Meaning you could have calibrated a safe reference and left before the read."

"I stayed through completion."

"How do you know?"

Nia enlarged the last recovery step. Its slope bent downward before reaching target. "I reduced pressure by hand because the rig overshot. An automatic profile would have completed the step at constant rise."

Osei searched the archived controls for the same correction. The oldest trace showed it twice. Nia remembered that job: Callis had acquired a cracked bearing mass from a hospital spindle, and she had spent six hours

keeping the outer layer from splitting. The correction belonged to her hand as distinctly as the cadence belonged to her breath.

They ran a blind comparison. Osei hid the source labels, rotated every trace into the same local grain bearing, and asked the archive matcher for operator similarity. The software assigned mark G to Nia's controls with high confidence. It assigned the other heat blooms no known Callis operator.

"Put the confidence measure in a separate annex," Nia said. "The raw geometry remains primary."

"You still think the matcher might be wrong."

"I think a probability should not replace the thing it measured."

Osei restored the labels. Mark G sat between two ordinary calibration jobs completed within eleven days of the transfer. Nia's operator seal connected all three. Seven years had passed, but the gap in her memory no longer concerned whether she touched the field. It concerned why she had never asked what answered from inside it.

The reader measured old heat, but her hands supplied memory around it. A temporary rig. Bright work lamps pointed away from the operator. Crown technicians controlling every semantic channel. Nia behind the bell rather than a body, hearing a voice only as filtered test tones through her headset. She had thought the tones came from an adaptive route model answering calibration.

Four in. Hold two. Resume in steps.

Iven had recognized the cadence while looking at her hand above the vocal-body control.

Osei said, "Did you authorize extraction?"

"I authorized a calibration pulse."

"That did this."

"Yes."

"Then they used your authorization for a read."

Nia looked at the cool center of mark G. "Or I ignored evidence that calibration had become one."

"What evidence?"

"The load exceeded the transfer sheet by eleven percent. I stopped for the gap. Crown's engineer produced an amended tolerance before I resumed."

"Do you have the amendment?"

"It should be in the intake packet."

"We saw three missing attachments."

She remembered the attachment stubs from yesterday. One carried a disposal office. One named the dead Callis clerk. The third held only the Eiren retention code. No calibration amendment appeared in the public acquisition file.

Osei folded his arms. "They removed your reason for continuing."

“That does not remove the fact that I continued.”

“You did not know a person occupied the layer.”

“I did not ask what the test tones represented.”

“Because they told you inert route model.”

“Procedure does not become care merely because someone completes its form.”

The sentence left her mouth with more force than she intended. Nia stopped. She had believed the opposite for most of her career. If the work stayed within signed limits, responsibility remained distributed among competent roles. Mark G condensed that belief into fourteen microns of damaged glass.

A chime came from the annex monitor. Crown notice requested interim images. The automated timer had reached its first disclosure point.

Osei moved to deny transmission.

“Do not,” Nia said.

“They will bury this.”

“If we block the required notice, they will challenge the whole map.”

“If we send raw data, they can prepare an explanation before Cal sees it.”

“The notice feed receives processed images only after Court review.”

“Unless their seal has a duplicate route.”

Nia opened the data path. Ada’s seal linked the reader to Cal’s intake vault, then branched toward Crown. The branch remained closed pending judicial acknowledgment. A second route sat beneath it, unlabeled and inactive. Callis’s system identified it as a vendor diagnostic inherited with the reader.

The no-contact instrument had come from Crown stock sixteen years earlier.

“Disconnecting the vendor route alters custody,” Osei said.

“Leaving it permits access outside the annex.”

“Can they activate it remotely?”

“I do not know.”

Nia photographed the route table with the physical timing lamp. Then she closed the diagnostic path using a reversible local shutter, not a deletion. The action entered both the archive log and Ada’s annex record.

“Crown will call that interference,” Osei said.

“They may.”

The disclosure chime repeated.

“We finish the passive map,” Nia said. “Then Cal receives a copy through a channel Crown does not

administer.”

Osei looked at her. “Outside their seal.”

“Inside Court custody.”

“That is not what the annex says.”

“The annex says Crown receives notice. It does not give Crown exclusive custody of evidence that its own diagnostic route could reach.”

“You are reading around it.”

“Yes.”

Nia returned her hands to the reader. Mark G remained sealed. Whatever consequences followed, they needed the count before Crown could convert uncertainty into permission.

The eighth boundary appeared near the bell’s central mass channel. Its crescent had partly collapsed into an earlier stress line, but two view angles separated the extraction tail from manufacturing damage. Mark H.

They found the final center close to the inner preservation layer. It carried the narrowest tail and the greatest local disorder, as though the operator had pushed through a region already weakened by every previous read.

Osei entered the label and did not speak the total.

Nia counted the sealed regions from the outer lamination inward: A, B, C, D, E, F, G, H, I. She checked each center against the alternate angle. None depended on image stitching. None overlapped yesterday’s calibration path.

“Nine,” she said.

Osei brought up the whole bell. The thermal map showed nine activations, each preserved as a separate heat bloom in C-9’s auric glass. Mark G carried Nia’s seven-year-old calibration ladder.

The number answered Iven’s last question from the body room.

Nia could not answer him now without calling him again.

They sealed the full map under the Court lamp. Osei generated a processed copy for the annex and left it waiting for Cal’s acknowledgment. Nia took the raw sensor sequence, its instrument settings, the vendor-route photograph, and the sealed image of mark G. She wrote them into the timing lamp’s optical thread.

“That lamp leaves the ring, Crown will challenge chain,” Osei said.

“It will not leave custody.”

“Where does it go?”

“Cal’s hand.”

“Crown officers control the quarantine door.”

“They control mass movement. Not a Court witness carrying a physical seal.”

Osei unhooked his own custody lamp. "Then take two."

"One copy creates a point of failure."

"Two creates corroboration."

"Two creates another person they can discipline."

"I am already on the record operating the reader."

Nia met his gaze. Keeping him outside the choice would protect neither of them. It would only preserve her authority by pretending he remained a subordinate after discovering the same fact.

"Build your copy independently," she said. "Use raw output, not mine. We compare checksums under Cal's lamp."

Osei began the transfer.

Before leaving, Nia reopened the acquisition record. Seven years earlier, her calibration sign-off appeared beneath Crown's inert declaration. The signature field showed no warning, no semantic access, and no human-subject designation. Her name still authorized the completed transfer. She attached the record to mark G without adding an explanation.

At the pressure door, the Crown officer asked whether the inspection had found a stability hazard.

"Yes," Nia said.

"Does C-9 threaten the Meridian schedule?"

"The threat concerns destructive access."

"By whom?"

"Open the door."

He checked her Court seal and saw Ada's method annex listed beneath it. The joint lock released.

Cal met them in the axial connector rather than making them carry the evidence through public court corridors. He wore no robe, only a dark work coat with the preservation-order seal clipped at the throat. Nia placed her timing lamp in his palm. Osei placed his beside it.

"What changed?" Cal asked.

"We found prior destructive reads."

"How many?"

"Nine."

His fingers tightened around the lamps. "Can you establish source?"

"One heat bloom carries my calibration signature from the transfer seven years ago. I did not know the layer held a person. I authorized the pulse that opened it."

Cal did not tell her the ignorance excused her. He aligned both optical threads with his seal and began the custody comparison.

Behind Nia, the quarantine door closed between the archive ring and Crown's officers. Ahead, Cal's timing lamp accepted both copies and wrote the same nine scars into the Court record.

Chapter 6 — Four Point Six Returns

<!-- POV: Iven Ko -->

<!-- Day 4; Callis vocal-body room -->

Iven woke with a numbered strip pressed around his wrist and a route missing from the room.

The ceiling held six acoustic baffles in two offset rows. A saline feed entered his left forearm. Linen restraints crossed his thighs without tightening, their slack measured to let him turn but not rise. He could place every object by distance from his eyes, yet the door beyond his feet had no relation to any corridor he knew. The absence made his stomach contract before memory supplied the name Callis.

Nia Daro sat beside the monitoring rail with both hands visible. She had changed clothes since his last waking. Dark archive fabric covered her wrists, and a custody lamp glowed green against her collarbone. A broad window at her back showed smoked glass rather than a view.

“Do you know where you are?” she asked.

“Inside a room designed by someone who mistrusts corners.”

Her gaze went to the breath counter. “Do you know the station?”

“Callis.” His mouth tasted of glucose and warm metal. “You asked about place before identity last time.”

Nia did not confirm that there had been a last time. “Tell me your name.”

“Iven Ko.”

“What work did you perform?”

“Route cartography for Eiren Reach.”

The name opened a set of distances. He saw Eiren’s terminator from no human vantage, as a table of transfer loads between dayward mirrors and inhabited caverns. Lines joined the thermal grid to freight locks, shelter wells, water loops. Nothing in the geometry told him how those places had sounded. He knew where the south tram crossed the fourth heat trunk. He could not recall the color of the car.

Nia marked three fields on a slate. She did not praise correct answers. That restraint gave him more comfort than kindness would have.

“How long has it been since Eiren failed?” he asked.

“Forty-seven years.”

He took one breath, then another because the body required sequence even when memory did not. “And since you first called me?”

“We are still establishing that record.”

“That means more than once.”

Her thumb stopped above the slate. A man stood behind the room’s clear partition, older than Nia, with a court

seal fixed to his gray jacket. Iven remembered him as Cal Orsen, though the memory offered no first meeting. Cal held a paper file instead of a screen. Another man, Osei Marr, watched the phase instruments beside the door.

Iven raised his wrist until the numbered strip came into view. "What does this measure?"

"Body chemistry," Nia said.

"Not the number on it."

The strip read R-4.6 / PRESERVATION LOAD. Ink had transferred faintly to his skin.

Cal touched the partition control. "It identifies the public reserve estimate attached to your archive."

"Four point six hours?"

"Returns," Nia said. "A return estimates enough coherence for one controlled activation under ordinary stress."

The room offered too many ways to understand that sentence. Iven chose the narrowest. "How much of one am I using now?"

"We cannot measure consumption in real time with confidence."

"That did not answer me."

"No," she said.

Cal entered through the pressure door. Its seals folded inward with almost no sound. He stopped outside the reach of Iven's unrestrained arm and set the paper file on a wall shelf.

"The archive lists 4.6 returns before this activation," Cal said. "The estimate may be wrong. We found evidence of prior access yesterday."

"How many accesses?"

Nia looked at Cal. The exchange between them lasted less than a second, but Iven recognized a route choice in it. Each wanted the other to accept responsibility for the next sentence.

"Nine heat blooms," she said. "They may correspond to nine destructive reads."

His right hand closed around the sheet. The fabric bunched between his fingers. He waited for shock and found calculation instead.

"Nine plus the calls I remember?"

"We do not yet know which calls you remember," Cal said.

"How many do you know about?"

"This public process includes your first controlled activation two days ago and the present memory check."

Iven turned his head toward the smoked window. His neck tired halfway through the motion. "Then 4.6 returns cannot tell you how many times I can answer."

"It cannot," Nia said.

"Why put it on my body?"

"The clinical system copied the archive estimate onto the strip."

"A machine performed the discourtesy."

Osei looked down, concealing either pain or amusement. Nia did neither.

"I should have removed it before waking you," she said.

"Would that have changed the estimate?"

"No."

"Leave it, then."

The breath counter climbed though he lay still. A soft tone sounded from the saline pump. Nia checked the line, reduced the glucose rate, and waited until the tone stopped. Her hands moved without wasted correction. He knew those hands. The certainty arrived without a scene attached to it.

"You have done this before," he said.

"I have calibrated Crown phase equipment."

"Not equipment. Me."

"I found my calibration signature on one of the heat blooms." Her voice stayed level. "Seven years ago, I believed the material contained an inert route model. I do not remember an embodied person."

Iven searched for her face in his prior awakenings and found a cadence instead: two low pulses, one held pause, a question delivered by instrument. Geometry had preserved her approach while discarding the room around it.

"You spoke through a probe," he said.

"I may have."

"You waited too long after the second pulse."

Nia's breathing changed. Only one count, shallow enough that the monitor ignored it.

Cal opened the paper file. "We can stop."

"Can you?" Iven asked.

"Legally and clinically."

"That makes two meanings. I asked for one."

Cal accepted the correction with a slight inclination of his head. "You may stop this check. The preservation order prevents broader access until a standing hearing."

"May I choose to continue?"

“Within Nia’s safety limits.”

The answer supplied a boundary without pretending to supply freedom. Iven loosened his grip on the sheet.

“Continue,” he said. “But remove the strip.”

Nia cut the paper band with blunt archive shears. The severed number curled in her palm. She sealed it in a custody sleeve rather than throwing it away.

They began with route tables because those cost him less. Osei displayed a blank Eiren grid on the smoked window. Iven placed civic shelters, thermal trunks, choir-relay stations, and freight approaches by calling coordinates. Each answer drew a pale line. The map became familiar before it became inhabited.

At grid sector five he paused.

A maintenance branch should have crossed the route from dayward collector two to the central distribution well. He knew its pressure loss, capacity, and inspection interval. A person belonged there. His memory held a shoulder under gray work cloth, a hand with two fingertips scarred white, boots wedged against a pipe brace.

Before he supplied the name, Osei changed the map scale. The duty paths contracted into thin amber threads, and a cluster of old closure marks appeared around the east transfer loop. Iven read them faster than the key could render. Pressure door E-12 had failed its morning check. A coolant cart blocked the south gallery. Someone on grid watch had opened a service crawl rather than send workers through a hot junction.

“Do those marks come from the public packet?” Iven asked.

“Three do,” Osei said. “The crawl authorization does not.”

“Then I gave it to you before.”

“No one in this room entered it.”

Nia moved the custody lamp nearer the display. “Can you identify who authorized the crawl?”

The geometry tightened around a pair of routes. One ended at an inspection platform above the east trunk. Another crossed behind the thermal manifold and reached the same place by six more turns. He remembered irritation at those six turns. He remembered a laugh that came after his irritation, low and brief, followed by two scarred fingertips tracing the safer route across his wrist.

A face tried to gather around the gesture. Dark hair resolved first, then the line of a cheek. The eyes would not hold. When he pressed for them, the map blurred and the breath counter quickened.

“I know the route she chose,” he said. “I know why she refused mine. The junction had started shedding insulation into the air flow.”

“What did she say?” Cal asked.

Iven listened to an empty place shaped like speech. “That did not survive.”

Osei restored the wider scale without being told. The amber routes loosened their grip on the absent face, but the safer path remained clear from end to end. Memory had preserved the decision and spent the person who made it.

“Lio Senn,” he said.

Osei’s stylus stopped.

Nia lowered the next test card. “Who was she?”

“My wife.” The fact carried none of the uncertainty surrounding the room. “Thermal-grid engineer. Senior watch on the east transfer loop.”

“What do you remember about her?” Cal asked.

The question sounded ordinary. Its breadth made it dangerous.

Iven closed his eyes. He could route himself from their apartment to her duty station by three paths. Main stair to tram level, tram south, maintenance rise at trunk four. During pressure closures, west gallery to the service lift. If both failed, a handrail route crossed the collector maintenance tubes in low gravity. He could draw each turn.

He could not see the apartment door.

“She stayed at the grid,” he said.

“When?” Nia asked.

“During the failure.”

“How do you know?”

He tried to place the conversation. Lio stood beside a heat diagram. Then she stood in a corridor with a tool case against her knee. Then her voice came through a civic channel stripped of place. The scenes refused order. Any could have preceded the others.

“She told me to take the bell route.”

“Did she tell you before or after the thermal collapse began?”

His breath caught on the saline scent. The body interpreted an absent sequence as danger, though no muscle could repair it.

“I don’t know.”

Nia leaned toward the monitor. “We can move to recognition without chronology.”

“No. Ask again.”

“Stress is increasing consumption.”

“You said you cannot measure it in real time.”

“We can measure the conditions that accelerate loss.”

“Then tell me the conditions.”

Nia named them without softening: broad associative recall, fear, pain, conflicting sensory prompts, prolonged

waking, and forced reconstruction of damaged sequence. She gave him numbers only where the instruments supported them. His pulse had risen by twenty-eight beats. Oxygen demand had doubled from rest. The phase coupling between C-9 and the vocal body showed widening noise around autobiographical prompts.

“Does the noise become damage?” he asked.

“It can.”

“Has it now?”

“I cannot tell until the return closes.”

There it was again, information arriving only after its subject could no longer use it.

Iven opened his eyes. “Ask about the convoy.”

Cal’s expression tightened. “That falls outside the approved memory sequence.”

“The approved sequence seems designed to discover whether I can choose. I am choosing a question.”

No one answered immediately. The room’s saline pump clicked once, moving a precise amount of warmth into his arm.

Cal went to the partition and spoke with someone outside by private channel. Iven watched his posture rather than trying to read his lips. Cal listened longer than he argued. When he came back, he did not reopen the file.

“One limited prompt,” he said. “No sensory simulation. You may refuse at any point.”

“Show me the route table from the final rescue window.”

Osei drew a chair to the smoked glass. “The public packet contains several tables. Which reference point?”

“Eiren civic north. Mass bearings relative to collector one. Remove outcomes.”

Osei built the display in layers. A terminator line crossed the moon’s curve. Eiren’s heat system appeared as a compact lattice below it. Farther out, three tuned masses marked a triangular schedule around the Meridian Mouth. A convoy approach entered from spinward. The reconstruction stopped before any line bent.

Iven’s hands began to shake.

He knew the triangle. Its long edge had carried Crown timing reserves. Shifting one point would alter the other two. Detuning all three would open a route toward Eiren, but the Mouth would lose its held shape. He saw the requirement as space, not arithmetic: three bells displaced for a span whose length touched the edge of memory.

A different image broke through. White authority lights crossing a cockpit. No, not a cockpit. A bell bay. The surface under his hands sloped toward a route board. Someone breathed close to his right shoulder.

“Lio?” he said.

Nia answered from the left. “You are on Callis.”

He lifted one finger toward the display. “The rescue line went there.”

Osei did not draw it. "Can you describe the line without adding it?"

"From the convoy approach through the near mass, then across the lower shear boundary. It needed all three."

"What happened?" Cal asked.

Lights moved inside the recollection. Three nested arcs glowed white on a bulkhead, Crown's mark enlarged by haze. Beyond them, rescue lamps pivoted across a route display. The turn began in clean increments. Not drift. Not impact. Commanded motion carried each vessel away from Eiren.

He heard Lio speaking, but the words came from two directions. In one sequence she told him to take the bell and preserve the route. In another she asked whether Crown had accepted the detuning. He could not decide which came first. Her last conversation had lost its hinges.

"The Crown lights were turning away," he said. "I saw the convoy bearing change."

Nia's face held stillness now, but her fingers had closed around the sleeve containing the cut wrist strip.

"From Eiren?" Cal asked.

"Yes."

"Toward what?"

"The Mouth."

Osei said, "Did you observe an order?"

Iven reached for the answer and found three possible rooms occupying one place. A dispatch bay. The grid. Choir bell C-9 while its recording layer sealed. Each contained Lio's voice at a different distance.

"I observed the turn."

"Do you remember who ordered it?"

"No."

"Any dispatcher identifier?"

A field of symbols surfaced, then folded before he could read it. Pain struck behind his left eye. His jaw clenched hard enough to make the body alarm sound.

Nia cleared the display at once. The Eiren grid vanished. She placed her palm against his forearm, avoiding the saline line.

"Stop," she said.

"I can still speak."

"That does not mean the process remains safe."

"What did that question cost?"

She reached for the monitoring rail. "We need to close the return before we assess it."

“What did it cost?”

“Iven.” Cal’s voice had the careful weight of an order he hoped not to issue. “Nia cannot provide a number she does not have.”

“She can tell me what you knew before asking.”

Nia’s hand stayed on his arm. Heat moved from her skin into the vocal body. He wondered whether that warmth belonged to her intent or merely to tissue doing what tissue did.

“We knew autobiographical sequence carried greater risk than route recall,” she said. “We knew distress memories could raise demand. We did not know this prompt would produce pain at that speed.”

“You expected some pain.”

“Yes.”

“Did you tell me?”

“No.”

The admission changed the room more completely than an apology could have. Cal closed the paper file. Osei dimmed every display except the clinical monitor.

Iven looked at the severed wrist strip. 4.6 returns had entered the room as reassurance, though no one had called it that. The number pretended to count future choices while hiding the reads that had already spent them. Even its uncertainty had been organized around the institution’s need to proceed.

“I asked to continue,” he said.

“You did,” Nia replied.

“I chose with the information you gave me.”

“Yes.”

“If you leave out the cost, you are choosing the missing part for me.”

The breath counter showed a slower rhythm now. His vision narrowed at the edges. Return closure approached as fatigue rather than sleep, a retreat of available distances. The door seemed farther away. Nia’s face remained exact because he had fixed on it, but Cal and Osei had begun to lose detail.

Cal moved closer. “What do you want recorded before deactivation?”

Iven considered the question. Eiren pulled at him through incomplete routes. Lio remained at the thermal grid without a reliable before or after. Crown lights continued turning away whenever he touched the final map. He still wanted the choice named. Wanting truth did not cancel his claim to know what truth would consume.

“I prefer to continue,” he said, “only if Nia tells me what each process can cost before I agree to it. Not afterward. Not inside a clinical note I cannot read while asleep.”

Cal repeated the preference for the custody lamp, preserving each condition. He asked Iven to confirm it. Iven did.

Nia unfastened the loose linen across his thighs. The restraint had never tightened, but its removal let his legs settle apart by a few centimeters. She checked the saline temperature, then lowered the room lights without turning the smoked glass into an image of Eiren.

“Can you make that promise?” he asked.

“I cannot always give you a number.”

“That is not what I asked.”

Her eyes met his before the body’s vision softened again.

“No activation without explanation,” Nia said. “If the cost cannot be measured, I will explain the uncertainty. If someone limits what I may tell you, I will tell you that too.”

Cal said nothing. His silence left the promise where she had put it, between custodian and person rather than inside a court’s permission.

Iven let his eyes close. The room receded by bearings: monitoring rail to his right, Nia’s hand at his forearm, pressure door beyond his feet, choir bell C-9 somewhere through layers of Callis. Lio’s route to the thermal grid remained open in him even though the order of their last words did not.

Before breath and phase uncoupled, Nia removed the strip marked 4.6 returns from its custody sleeve and placed it face down on the rail.

Interlude I — Return Ledger

<!-- Form: sealed Aster Crown activation log -->

<!-- Classification: Corridor Stability / Executive Hold -->

SOURCE ASSET: C9-ER-204

SUBJECT PATTERN: KO, IVEN / ROUTE CARTOGRAPHER

ACCESS BASIS: Infrastructure-loss analysis

PUBLIC DISCLOSURE: None authorized

OPERATIVE OBJECTIVE: Extract a control statement separating convoy motion from deliberate route choice.

CAUTION: Each read alters the sole surviving phase state. Duplication unsupported.

RETURN 1

Offset: Eiren loss + 11 months

Facility: Crown recovery bay, Aster Three

Authorization: Executive emergency minute; annex withheld from medical file

Embodiment: Auditory cortex, speech tract, limited proprioception; 8 minutes 14 seconds

Subject identified Eiren civic north from an unmarked route plane. He supplied the three-mass rescue geometry without prompting and described convoy lamps changing bearing. Asked whether navigation loss could explain the turn, he answered: "A lost route does not keep formation."

Autobiographical access remained broad. Subject named spouse Lio Senn, her thermal-grid duty, and their last shared meal. Sequence around the final dispatch could not be stabilized before cardiac load crossed limit.

Disposition: No releasable statement. Retain layer under corridor-risk privilege.

RETURN 2

Offset: Eiren loss + 3 years

Facility: Crown medical annex, Nacre Dock

Authorization: Operations counsel concurrence; no external custodian

Embodiment: Speech and vision; 11 minutes 02 seconds

Interviewers presented two route diagrams. Diagram A showed rescue detuning. Diagram B showed Mouth stabilization. Subject selected A as the route he had expected and B as the motion he observed. He rejected the suggested phrase “uncommanded correction.”

Recognition check produced accurate names for four dispatchers and eleven route stations. Subject misordered two calls with Lio but corrected himself when shown grid timestamps.

Extraction note: Counsel requested a shorter answer suitable for a public incident supplement. Subject refused the prepared wording.

RETURN 3

Offset: Eiren loss + 7 years

Facility: Meridian scheduling laboratory

Authorization: Technical-risk committee, closed circulation

Embodiment: Minimal vocal assembly; 6 minutes 47 seconds

No personal names were supplied in the opening prompts. Subject nevertheless asked whether Lio had cleared the east transfer loop. He located that loop on a blank grid and stated that thermal failure had begun before the convoy completed its turn.

When asked, “Did Crown intend Eiren to fail?” subject distinguished expected outcome from private motive. He would not infer an executive’s thoughts from route motion. He did state that the three bells remained synchronized after rescue detuning became possible.

Damage observation: Forty-three seconds of blank interval followed the spouse prompt. Phase noise persisted after shutdown.

RETURN 4

Offset: Eiren loss + 13 years

Facility: Aster Crown legal archive

Authorization: Chair's sealed directive

Embodiment: Speech only; no visual feed; 9 minutes 31 seconds

The examiner withheld all dates. Subject placed the shear window within nineteen hours of the convoy bearing change by reconstructing mass recovery intervals. Asked to repeat "the convoy could not safely reach Eiren," he answered: "You can make that sentence safe only by removing when."

A proposed control statement attributed the loss to telemetry uncertainty. Subject requested the underlying dispatch clock. The request fell outside approved exposure and was denied.

Continuity change: Subject could no longer retrieve the name of Eiren's chief dispatcher, although he retained the dispatcher's station position and handoff route.

RETURN 5

Offset: Eiren loss + 21 years

Facility: Crown compliance chamber, Morcant

Authorization: Infrastructure-defense review

Embodiment: Speech, basic vision, right-hand motor map; 12 minutes 05 seconds

Reviewers showed six convoy images, five authentic and one composite. Subject identified the composite from an impossible bell shadow. He recognized Crown's nested route arcs but did not recognize his own archived portrait.

A mirror was provided after consent language approved by Crown counsel. Subject asked whose face the body carried. Staff explained that the vocal body did not reproduce his original appearance. Subject then asked why an image labeled IVEN KO looked unfamiliar.

Medical stop: Elevated phase scatter after self-image prompt. Remaining questions deferred.

RETURN 6

Offset: Eiren loss + 29 years

Facility: Mobile bell tender Kestra

Authorization: Schedule-security waiver

Embodiment: Auditory channel and speech; 7 minutes 56 seconds

Route tones replaced visual diagrams. Subject reconstructed all three bell bearings and the Mouth-holding sequence. He placed Eiren's rescue line correctly but joined two personal calls into one event.

The interviewer offered a neutral account: convoy crews responded to shear and lacked a viable rescue window. Subject asked for the bells' detuning limits. Access to those values had been prohibited. After the refusal, he said: "Then you are testing my agreement, not my memory."

Operational result: No usable concession. Future returns to exclude argumentative exchange.

RETURN 7

Offset: Eiren loss + 40 years

Facility: Crown phase laboratory, Callis service orbit

Authorization: Disposal calibration order coded as inert-route maintenance

Embodiment: Partial speech pathway; technician isolated from semantic output; 4 minutes 18 seconds

External calibration staff received no notice of a human phase pattern. Crown operators routed prompts beneath the service layer while the contracted resonantist supplied timing pulses. Subject responded to the resonantist's cadence and attempted to ask how many times access had occurred. Operators closed the speech path before the question reached the room.

Memory sample preserved route geometry, Lio Senn's duty location, and the convoy turn. Subject did not retrieve the order of his final two conversations.

Chain note: Third-party signature remains embedded in the heat record. Removal would require another destructive read.

RETURN 8

Timing: Six days after the seventh read

Facility: Same phase laboratory

Authorization: Continuation under prior disposal order

Embodiment: Constrained answer channel; 5 minutes 44 seconds

Operators limited output to yes, no, unknown, or repeat. The subject defeated the constraint by withholding breath after the question, "Could the convoy have rescued Eiren?" Clinical staff restored an open speech path to prevent distress.

He then said: "Possible for whom?" Follow-up pressure produced no answer. Route recognition remained intact. Facial recall for Lio failed twice, while her grid paths remained exact.

Risk decision: Executive review rejected further language conditioning. Asset scheduled for transfer beyond routine Crown access.

RETURN 9

Offset: Eiren loss + 40 years, 19 days

Facility: Crown transfer cradle, Callis approach

Authorization: Final integrity check before salvage conveyance

Embodiment: Auditory verification only; 3 minutes 09 seconds

Subject woke before the approved identity prompt and said: "You already tried me." No interviewer acknowledged the statement. He named Callis after hearing its ring-balance tones, then asked whether the receiving archive knew what the bell contained.

The final control statement presented for confirmation read: "Convoy redirection followed unavoidable navigation instability; no recoverable record establishes deliberate choice." Subject answered, "Your sentence knows more about recoverability than I do."

Shutdown began when phase scatter exceeded the transfer limit. The subject attempted one further word. Audio resolution did not support transcription.

Transfer action: C9-ER-204 conveyed to Callis as mixed tuned mass, classified INERT. Interior access prohibited. Source attachments replaced with checksum stubs. Crown retained excursion telemetry through the emergency infrastructure channel.

LEDGER STATUS: Nine destructive reads recorded. No additional return authorized without chair-level directive. Public incident file unchanged.

SEAL AUDIT: RETURN 1 established intact autobiographical access, full route competence, and an unwillingness to adopt language supplied by counsel. RETURN 9 preserved route competence but showed advanced loss of faces, names, and personal sequence. Across the interval, every successful extraction narrowed the subject available for the next attempt. No entry documents informed agreement to a later read. Clinical stops limited immediate injury; they did not restore phase state already measured.

The sealed series contains no confirmed control statement from Iven Ko. Prepared language appears in five interviewer notes and once in the final verification prompt. In each instance, the subject corrected, refused, qualified, or exposed the premise. Any incident summary describing the record as inconclusive must disclose that Crown constrained the questions, withheld dispatch values, and repeatedly altered the only witness while seeking agreement.

Chapter 7 — Standing Hearing

<!-- POV: Cal Orsen -->

<!-- Days 5-7; Court of Continuance, Callis axial chambers -->

Cal called the hearing while a clinical timer removed seconds from the witness.

The timer occupied no larger space than his thumb on the court rail. Its amber column descended whenever Iven's vocal body remained awake and paused only after phase monitors confirmed full rest. Nia had refused to translate the column into fractions of a return. She had written beneath the display: CONSUMPTION VARIABLE. DURATION DOES NOT EQUAL COST.

Ada Neme read the warning twice before taking her place at Crown's table.

The axial chamber had been built for freight appeals, not questions about whether evidence could decline to become evidence. Paper-thin acoustic baffles hung between the court rail and the public gallery. Callis rotation reached this close to the axis only as a slow drift in loose sleeves. Physical seals held the three case files to Cal's desk: salvage ownership, emergency preservation, and the petition for standing in continuance.

Iven appeared behind a clear clinical partition to Cal's right. The vocal body wore a gray linen shirt and no wrist strip. Nia sat within arm's reach of the saline control. Osei attended from the archive table with bell C-9's passive trace disconnected from every network except the court recorder.

Cal touched the timing lamp. "Continuation matter C-9-ER-204. Petition to recognize Iven Ko as a person for the limited duration of active coherence. Crown's compulsory-analysis request remains stayed until disposition."

Ada rose. "Crown objects to calling the pattern by a personal name before the test concludes."

"The name forms part of the petition and the recovered registry."

"It also forms part of the source packet. Repetition does not prove preference."

"Neither does refusing the name prove property," Cal said. "You may preserve your objection without making the court speak in inventory codes."

Ada sat. She had arranged her files by operational consequence rather than legal issue. The top folder carried a red corridor-risk edge. Cal knew the habit from twelve years of Crown appeals. She would not deny a human cost if she could place another human cost beside it.

He turned toward the partition. "Iven Ko, do you understand why we are here?"

"I understand three descriptions of it," Iven said. "Nia says you are deciding whether I may choose what happens to me. Crown says you are measuring whether my answers originate outside a record. Your clerk said this could take three days."

A few people in the gallery shifted. Cal kept his attention on Iven. "Which description do you accept?"

"The one that ends before my body does."

No laughter followed. The line carried too much clinical fact.

Cal stated the test in terms a person could contest. The Continuance Articles treated a transmitted remnant as property until it formed a preference unrecoverable from its source conditions. Recognition did not require continuous memory, an original body, or agreement with the court. It required evidence that the present mind could choose beyond the recorded purpose that created it.

“What did the signal that carried you ask for?” Cal said.

“Rescue first. Record the convoy choice if rescue failed. Preserve Eiren’s registry.”

“Do you still want those things?”

“Yes.”

“Then those wants cannot by themselves satisfy the Novel Preference Test.”

Iven considered that without looking toward Nia. “You need me to want something my dead self did not prepare.”

“We need evidence of a present preference not recoverable from the packet.”

“Your version uses more nouns.”

“Courts ration verbs when frightened.”

That drew a brief breath from Iven that might have become a laugh in a stronger body. Cal regretted the exchange at once. Familiarity could look like advocacy, and advocacy would weaken any protection he granted.

Ada stood again. “Crown requests a baseline examination before any preference demonstration. We must know whether the pattern can distinguish an external choice from a supplied one.”

Nia’s hand moved to the clinical control. “Define examination.”

“Counsel will address the court,” Cal said.

Ada did. “Three paired prompts drawn from the sealed distress packet. One altered prompt. No broad recall. No visual material until the court confirms recognition stability.”

Nia looked toward Iven. “Likely cost remains low, but not zero. Contradictory prompts may increase stress. We can stop after any question.”

“You said that before I agreed,” Iven replied.

“Yes.”

Cal recorded both the warning and the response. Nia’s promise from the memory check had entered practice before law required it.

Ada began with route work. She offered two statements about choir mass. One matched Iven’s deposition: three bells could create an Eiren rescue line if detuned together. The other changed the number to two. Iven rejected the alteration and explained that two masses could shift the shear boundary but could not hold a path through it.

Her second pair concerned Lio Senn’s duty. The packet placed her at the east transfer loop. Ada moved her to collector control. Iven corrected the location, then added that Lio could authorize access to collector control

without working there.

“Does the source record contain that distinction?” Cal asked Osei.

“The accessible layer contains her duty code and two route permissions,” Osei said. “It does not contain a prose explanation.”

“Route permissions may encode the inference,” Ada said.

Cal marked it as competence, not novelty.

For the third pair, Ada read two accounts of the convoy’s final movement. One used the public phrase unavoidable navigation instability. The other stated that the convoy maintained formation while changing bearing toward the Meridian Mouth.

Iven’s pulse rose on the monitor. Nia lifted one finger, warning without interruption.

“The second account matches what I remember,” Iven said.

“Matches memory or matches the deposition?” Ada asked.

“I cannot separate those for you.”

“Then the answer proves no present witness.”

“It proves I know the limit of my answer.”

Ada faced Cal. “Self-description also appears throughout the packet. The remnant repeatedly distinguishes observation from motive. That discipline belonged to Ko while alive.”

Cal wrote the point because it deserved preservation. A witness could not prove novelty merely by exhibiting character. Yet a court that demanded discontinuity would recognize personhood only when damage made someone unlike themselves.

He recessed before the clinical timer reached Nia’s first limit.

During rest, the vocal body did not sleep in the ordinary sense. Nia closed the sensory channels and let phase coupling fall below the threshold for coherent response. Cal remained in the chamber while Crown clerks sent him eleven pages arguing that the Compulsory Evidence Clause authorized deeper comparison if the voluntary test failed.

Osei stayed at the archive table. He ran a cloth along the passive recorder’s edge though no dust had reached it.

“What would satisfy you?” he asked.

“I do not discuss a pending test with a witness technician.”

“I asked what would satisfy the law.”

“The law says a novel preference.”

“That sounds like you will know it when you hear it.”

Cal looked at the three sealed files. “That troubles me too.”

The Articles offered examples: a signal person choosing one advocate over another, refusing a proposed body form absent from the source, requesting destruction for reasons formed after transmission. Each example presumed the institution could present neutral options. After nine unauthorized reads, no option involving the archive felt neutral.

“Could you ask him what he wants?” Osei said.

“His recorded self wanted several things.”

“Ask about this room.”

Cal did not answer. The suggestion had merit, which made accepting it from a party dangerous. He wrote it in the margin as an objection to his own caution.

On Day 6, Ada called a Crown phase analyst by remote link. The analyst had mapped every declarative preference in the accessible Eiren packet: rescue, preservation, testimony, registry recovery, contact with Lio, and avoidance of nonessential medical intervention. A choice touching any of those categories could have grown from the original signal.

“So the more complete a person’s record, the harder personhood becomes?” Cal asked.

“The test measures novelty, not completeness.”

“A complete source predicts more choices.”

“Yes.”

“And destructive testing enlarges Crown’s knowledge of what the source predicts.”

Ada rose before the analyst could answer. “The prior reads remain under sealed dispute. They cannot expand the packet for this test.”

“They expanded Crown’s ability to challenge it.”

“Not mine. I have not reviewed semantic output from those activations.”

Cal believed her. Ada’s restraint could protect the process while preserving Crown’s institutional ignorance as an advantage. Both facts could coexist.

Nia reported that Iven could tolerate one short visual-choice sequence. She described the cost as uncertain and the stress boundary as strict. Iven agreed after asking which images, who had selected them, and whether refusal would count against him. Cal ordered the answers read into the record.

Ada proposed four views derived from the source: Eiren’s terminator line, the east transfer loop, choir bell C-9’s original bay, and a route map without outcomes. Iven could choose one to hold on the room window during the remaining examination. Crown argued that selecting among emotionally weighted memories might demonstrate coherent preference even if it did not alone establish novelty.

The first image appeared as a low-resolution reconstruction of Eiren from orbital survey. No ruins, no bodies, only the hard division between collector light and the inhabited dark. Iven watched without moving.

Next came the thermal grid. The simulation used maintenance plans to rebuild its handrails, pressure doors, and pipe braces. Nia had prohibited human figures. Empty duty stations extended into the distance.

The third view placed a modeled C-9 in its launch cradle. Crown's reconstruction rendered the auric glass too bright. Osei entered an objection to the color calibration.

A route plane filled the final screen. Three mass marks held near the Mouth. Eiren waited beyond the shear boundary.

Ada stood beside her table. "You may select any view. You may request a neutral gray field. You may also decline to choose."

Iven looked from the screen to the chamber's clear partition. "Are those my only options?"

"For this sequence," Ada said.

"Why?"

"They avoid introducing new visual material that might contaminate later memory comparisons."

"Everything you offer comes from Eiren or the bell."

"Those sources let us evaluate the choice."

"Because you already know why I might choose them."

Ada did not evade. "Yes."

Iven turned toward Cal. "Then give me a window showing Callis."

The public gallery remained quiet enough for Cal to hear the timing lamp advance.

Ada's expression changed by less than a blink. "There is no exterior window in this chamber."

"I can see a clear wall, three acoustic baffles, and twenty-one people who keep looking at the timer. That is Callis, but Nia says the partition must stay clear. Show me somewhere on the station that has nothing to do with Eiren."

Cal asked, "What would you like to see?"

"I don't know what exists here."

"Crown objects," Ada said. "An open request can be shaped after the fact to appear novel."

"Then let him narrow it," Cal replied.

Iven watched a court attendant secure a stack of paper under a magnetic strip. "Show me where people eat."

Nia checked the monitor. "No clinical objection to a live, noninteractive feed."

Ada opened the source index on her desk. "Crown needs ten minutes to verify that no Callis dining space appears in the packet."

"Take five," Cal said. "The witness pays for the other five."

The remark did what he intended. Ada assigned two clerks, and Osei searched the court copy in parallel. They found route references to Callis in old Crown schedules but no image, description, or preference concerning

the station. Iven had identified Callis from ring-balance tones during the ninth sealed read, yet no record showed interest in its ordinary life.

A court attendant placed a portable lens in the west concourse canteen. The feed opened on a long room under low artificial gravity. Cups sat in recessed trays. Two maintenance workers argued over a ration printer while a child pushed a bead of spilled water along the table with one finger. At the far wall, a service window closed for pressure equalization and reopened after its lamp turned green.

Iven leaned forward against the linen support.

“Why there?” Ada asked.

“The child is trying to make the water cross a seam.”

“That does not answer why you requested the canteen.”

“I asked for a place where people eat because no one died there for me.” His eyes stayed on the feed. “I want to look at something I was not built to remember.”

Ada approached the clinical partition but stopped at its marked boundary. “Your source asked rescuers to preserve life. Interest in living people may follow directly from that purpose.”

“Interest, perhaps,” Cal said. “Not this object, this place, or this reason.”

“The test cannot rest on poetic phrasing.”

“It will rest on evidence. The phrasing merely made you notice it.”

Ada returned to her table. “Crown requests examination of the choice. Ask whether he would retain the Callis view if offered Lio Senn’s image.”

Nia said, “No.”

The refusal crossed the chamber before Cal could rule. Nia’s hand covered the image control.

Ada faced her. “You do not hold standing in this matter.”

“I hold clinical authority over prompts during this return. A spouse comparison creates known stress.”

“Iven may choose to accept that cost.”

“After explanation,” Iven said. “I do not.”

Ada went back to her files and withdrew a blank court wafer. “Then Crown proposes a non-source comparison. The court will select another live Callis feed by chance. If novelty alone drives the request, any unencoded location should serve.”

Cal saw the distinction she wanted. A random view could test whether Iven preferred the canteen or merely wanted something outside his packet. It also risked turning the present mind into a series of challenges designed to eliminate every alternative explanation.

“What cost?” Iven asked.

Nia studied the monitor rather than guessing. “Low if the image contains no Eiren-linked material. Additional

waking still spends coherence. I recommend no more than six minutes before rest.”

Iven nodded once. “I agree to one image.”

Cal directed the timing lamp to choose among court-approved public feeds. It selected a maintenance overlook on mass ring one. The attendant opened the view without commentary. Tuned ballast moved behind smoked shielding while two technicians crossed a gantry on toe loops. White schedule marks advanced around the ring in exact intervals.

Iven examined it for less than a minute. “Keep the canteen.”

“Why?” Ada asked.

“I understand what the ring does.”

“Understanding does not prevent preference.”

“No. The people prevent it.” He indicated the child, who had acquired the cloth at last and now twisted water into it. “The ring would let me work. The canteen lets me fail to be useful.”

Ada did not write that line down. One of her clerks did.

“Would you preserve the canteen view if no legal advantage followed?” she asked.

“I did not know it carried a legal advantage when I requested it.”

“You knew this hearing concerned choice.”

“I knew every answer might be used. That does not make every answer false.”

Cal intervened before the exchange became an endurance test. “The request preceded knowledge of its evidentiary effect. Crown may argue weight, not manufacture retrospection.”

Ada closed the wafer. “Then ask what duration he prefers.”

Iven looked to Nia first. “How long until you need to close the return?”

“Four minutes at the present load.”

“Leave the canteen until then. No more questions.”

That choice placed rest above further proof and kept an ordinary view over a technically familiar one. Cal entered both conditions in the record. Ada objected that a medically advised stop could not count as novelty. Cal sustained the objection in part; stopping followed known risk. The chosen image did not.

He watched the canteen feed. The child had succeeded in pushing the water across one table seam and failed at the next. A maintenance worker offered a folded cloth. The child ignored it.

Crown’s proposed comparison might strengthen the test, but it would also consume the preference while claiming to verify it. Delay no longer offered a reversible path. Every additional proof request altered the mind under examination.

Cal called a recess of four minutes and wrote the operative order by hand. He removed two sentences that reached beyond the case. He added an expiration condition, a review path, and a fraud reservation. Narrowness

mattered. So did not making Iven earn the same protection again at each institutional door.

When court resumed, Iven had kept the Callis feed. He did not watch Cal. Ada stood with both hands on Crown's red-edged risk folder.

"The court finds present evidence of a preference not recoverable from the Eiren distress packet," Cal said. "Iven Ko requested novel visual access, selected an ordinary Callis location without encoded precedent, and declined a source-weighted comparison after receiving a cost warning. Those choices satisfy the Novel Preference Test for this proceeding."

He pressed his seal into the paper order.

"Temporary standing in continuance is granted through the active coherence period and any court-approved rest interval necessary to complete this hearing. No destructive analysis may occur without Iven Ko's informed agreement while that standing remains effective."

Ada said, "Crown preserves appeal and requests clarity concerning the property petition."

"Title remains undecided. Personhood does not require ownership to resolve first."

"And compulsory analysis?"

Cal turned the order so the timing lamp could capture its physical seal.

"The Compulsory Evidence Clause no longer applies while standing lasts."

Nia disconnected Crown's proposed image set. Osei closed the route packet. On the west canteen feed, the pressure lamp changed from amber to green, and people carried their trays through the reopened service window while Iven watched a place no prior version of him had known to request.

Chapter 8 — The Price of a Quiet Settlement

<!-- POV: Ada Neme -->

<!-- Days 8–10; Callis axial chambers and Crown operations link -->

Ada removed the word **unavoidable** from the settlement and watched Crown’s risk model turn red.

The deletion changed no mass schedule. No catalyst shipment missed a window. Yet the legal drafting wafer immediately marked four dependent clauses for executive review, as though one adjective held the Meridian Mouth in alignment.

She sat alone in a Callis conference room two chambers below the Court. The room had no networked wall and no hidden phase equipment; Nia Daro had inspected both conditions before agreeing to bring Iven. A physical air duct clicked whenever station rotation put its outer valve under load. On the table, Ada had arranged three copies of the proposed order, a public incident statement, and a supply map sealed beneath gray paper.

Jalen Orr appeared on her private operations link. His image carried none of the delay that would have made him seem remote.

“You changed approved language,” he said.

“Because Ko will reject a statement that repeats the official cause.”

“The official cause remains under dispute.”

“Then we cannot require him to affirm it as the price of recognition.”

Jalen’s eyes moved across a copy on his side. He read legal pages as if they contained schedules, locating every term that could slip. “The board authorized recognition of loss. Not intent.”

“The offer says rescue failure.”

“It also preserves the bell against further access.”

“Under Crown supervision.”

“Under joint seal.”

Ada touched the clause. “Crown selects two of three custodians. That will read as supervision because it is supervision.”

“Then draft it more gently.”

A decade earlier she might have obeyed the instruction without hearing its admission. She had defended the Eiren seal for twelve years by keeping claims narrow, disclosure slower than panic, and the Mouth’s dependents visible in rooms where old guilt produced simple proposals. She had not needed to lie about what Crown wanted. Precision could shelter control better than falsehood.

“Ko has standing,” she said. “Gentle control still requires his agreement.”

“Temporary status granted by a Callis examiner under an emergency article.”

“Effective status until appeal.”

Jalen leaned closer to his lens. Behind him, route arcs crossed an operations display. “Do not let a provisional witness negotiate corridor policy.”

“He is negotiating access to himself.”

“The distinction disappears if his refusal forces a public seizure dispute.”

Ada looked at the covered supply map. “No. It becomes inconvenient.”

Jalen ended the call after ordering her to return with a signed settlement or a written account of why Callis had chosen litigation over habitat safety.

The phrasing placed the future report before the meeting. Ada saved the instruction with its time mark.

Nia arrived first. She brought a passive phase meter, two sealed glucose packs, and no briefcase. Her archive jacket carried a fresh repair along one cuff where Crown quarantine staff had cut a closure tag. She examined the room again despite having inspected it that morning.

“You removed a transmitter,” Ada said.

“I removed a Crown transmitter from a room represented as private.”

“It managed the air valve.”

“The valve still works.”

“It no longer reports faults.”

“I put a paper indicator on it.” Nia pointed to a thin strip fluttering beside the duct. “A person can look.”

“You have an expansive view of privacy.”

“I have a recent education in undisclosed access.”

Ada accepted the point. “The settlement conference record remains local until all parties agree to release it.”

“Does Crown accept Iven as a party?”

“For this conference.”

“That qualification will matter to him.”

“It matters to me too.”

Orderlies brought the vocal body through the clinical door in a reclining chair. Iven wore the same gray linen as at the hearing. A court timing lamp hung from the chair rail under Nia’s seal. He inspected the blank walls, the paper air indicator, then the three documents.

“No window?” he asked.

“Not for this meeting,” Ada said. “You may request one.”

“I wanted to know whether you had learned anything.”

Nia checked the body's pulse. "Ada has agreed to one hour maximum, with a rest decision at thirty minutes."

"Likely cost?" Iven asked.

"Lower than route recall. Negotiation can raise stress. We stop if the phase margin widens past the line I showed you."

He found that line on the meter before nodding. "Proceed."

Ada slid the shortest document toward him but kept her hand on its edge. "This offer does four things. Crown will join Callis in recognizing Eiren as a rescue failure rather than a navigation loss. The remaining signal receives permanent preservation under joint custody. No party seeks further embodiment without your informed request. Crown funds a complete registry reconstruction and restitution process."

"What does Crown receive?"

"No inquiry into individual or institutional intent. Existing corridor authority remains in place. The case closes after the incident statement and preservation order enter the record."

Iven looked at the document without touching it. "You said four things."

"The registry and restitution share one clause."

"No. You counted what I receive and stopped counting when Crown appeared."

Ada let go of the paper. "Crown receives finality."

"Better."

Nia sat beside him rather than behind the chair. "What does permanent preservation mean if the archive estimate changes?"

"C-9 remains sealed against destructive access. Non-destructive maintenance continues. If degradation threatens total loss, all custodians must agree before intervention."

"All custodians except Iven?"

"Iven's standing may not remain active during a future degradation event."

"Then the seal expires where his voice does."

"The order preserves his stated conditions during this proceeding."

Nia tapped the relevant clause. "It preserves conditions 'to the extent recognized by then-applicable continuance law.' That gives the future custodian every argument Crown already made."

Ada had written those words herself. They reflected current doctrine. They also placed the risk on the person least able to appear later.

"I can replace that phrase with a specific prohibition against voluntary Crown access," she said.

"Why only Crown?" Iven asked.

"Because Crown controls the bell schedule and carries the strongest operational claim."

“Callis could become curious.”

Nia did not defend her institution. “Yes.”

Iven pushed the preservation order back. “Then curiosity needs more than one name.”

Ada marked the clause for revision. Negotiation could improve the seal and still fail on intent. She had come prepared for that distinction.

“The incident statement matters beyond Crown,” she said. “Public records still call the convoy lost to navigation. This changes the legal classification to rescue failure and restores Eiren’s registry as a casualty record rather than salvage inventory.”

“Does it say why rescue failed?”

“It states that tuned mass remained committed to Mouth stabilization and did not open the Eiren route.”

“Who committed it?”

“The historical decision chain remains incomplete.”

“Does the statement say someone decided?”

“It says the convoy did not detune the required bells.”

Iven looked at Nia. “That describes a door staying closed.”

Nia kept her hands on her knees. “Yes.”

Ada unfolded the proposed public language.

> Aster Crown Transit and Callis recognize that Eiren Reach suffered a rescue failure during Meridian instability. Available convoy mass remained aligned to corridor stabilization, preventing a viable Eiren approach before thermal-lattice collapse. All recovered persons and records shall receive protection under the Continuance Articles.

Iven read it twice. His eyes moved more slowly across the final sentence.

“You recognize failure,” he said. “You protect whatever reaches you. Between those actions, no one acts.”

“The statement does not exonerate anyone.”

“It does not accuse weather either. It leaves a space where choice should go.”

“Naming a chooser without admissible proof creates another false record.”

“You know more than you admit here.”

Ada had expected anger. His calm forced her to examine each answer before using it.

“I know Crown chose to hold the Mouth,” she said. “I do not yet have evidence I can place in an open file assigning that decision to a particular officer or executive body.”

Nia’s attention sharpened. “You just moved beyond the public record.”

“I moved exactly one step. The convoy mass did not remain aligned through accident.”

Iven’s pulse rose. Nia glanced at the phase margin but did not stop the meeting.

“Then put that sentence in the statement,” he said.

“Crown will not approve it.”

“Will not, or cannot?”

“Will not.”

The paper air indicator snapped once as the duct changed load. Ada thought of Morcant’s catalyst lines, where every delayed shipment became a choice among industrial heat, food culture, and reserve. She had grown up watching schedule boards over the refinery commons. Adults measured safety by the number of transit windows before a line stopped. Crown had purchased her education because she understood what a missed window did before she understood what monopoly meant.

She removed the gray cover from the supply map.

Six habitat markers appeared around the Meridian Mouth schedule. Each carried a stack of dated shipments, local stores, substitution limits, and heat-sink turnover. Together they represented 2.3 million people. Latchkey’s pump architecture depended on replacements too massive for conventional transit. Morcant required culture catalysts from Vesper Fold to keep refinery food lines stable. Arden Coil sent medical substrates outward and received tuned mass components from Sable. Near Orison held deeper stores but consumed more than any other habitat.

Ada opened the first cascade layer. A delayed Sable mass shipment removed one recovery weight from an Arden Coil window. The medical habitat could still export substrates, but its return load would travel underweight. That changed braking recovery at Vesper Fold. Two windows later, the agricultural spindle lost room for Morcant’s culture shipment. No single delay killed anyone. Repetition converted small deficits into a heat problem, then a food problem, then a clinical one.

“Why does a legal inquiry alter that sequence?” Iven asked.

“It does not, by itself.”

“Then show the step you are afraid of.”

Ada switched from cargo to authority. Crown schedule keys sat above each bell assignment. A court seizure would suspend those keys until a substitute operator accepted liability. Habitat governments could issue emergency permissions, but their standards conflicted. Sable recognized crew licenses that Latchkey did not. Near Orison required an indemnity no peripheral habitat could post. Callis could adjudicate the conflicts after they arrived. It could not make them disappear before the next window.

Nia pointed to the suspended key. “Crown wrote the contracts that produce this delay.”

“Crown wrote some. Habitat assemblies demanded others after earlier accidents.”

“Can the crews keep working during a custody dispute?” Iven asked.

“Physically, yes. Legally, some will lose insurance and access authority within hours.”

“People know their tools but become unable to touch them.”

“That has happened in lesser disputes.”

Ada selected a historical incident from Morcant. Fourteen years earlier, a refinery creditor had challenged ownership of a tuning mass. The local crew kept the mass stable while three authorities argued over who could authorize its next move. For eleven days it performed no transit work. Food cultures did not fail because another bell took the load. That spare capacity no longer sat unused.

“Were you there?” Iven asked.

“I ran the replacement schedule.”

“Did anyone ask the mass whether it consented?”

“No conscious record occupied it.”

“That difference brought us here.”

“It did. It does not create spare capacity.”

Ada closed the historical file. The map retained the route deficit as a small amber gap between Morcant and Vesper Fold. She had learned operations by filling such gaps before they reached public boards. Crown rewarded the person who prevented a shortage and rarely asked what concentration of authority each rescue preserved.

“This information remains operationally restricted,” Ada said. “I am showing it because your decision reaches people outside this room.”

Iven studied the routes. Geometry drew him forward despite fatigue. “Which schedule fails if Crown loses control?”

“All schedules become less predictable during a seizure, shutdown order, or emergency redistribution. The Mouth needs continuous coordination.”

“That sounds like an argument for coordination.”

“It is.”

“Not for Crown.”

Ada met his gaze. “No other operator currently holds the bells, crews, recovery data, and cross-habitat contracts needed to maintain present windows.”

“Currently.”

“Nia can remove a transmitter and replace it with paper because this room’s air does not depend on a distant pump. Infrastructure grants authority to whoever can keep it working.”

“It can also grant excuses.”

“Yes.”

Nia leaned across the map. “Are any habitats in immediate failure?”

“Not today. Several supply paths have little tolerance for a prolonged dispute.”

“How little?”

“I will provide exact reserves to the court under seal if proceedings continue.”

“Why under seal?” Iven asked.

“Because public scarcity figures change buying, hoarding, and transit behavior before a shortage arrives. A true number can shorten its own deadline.”

He traced the three-mass formation without touching the paper. “You are telling me the old choice has living hostages.”

“I reject that description. These people did not volunteer to secure Crown’s reputation. Their dependence grew across decades of public contracts, private investment, and political convenience. Calling them hostages turns their survival into evidence against them.”

“You want me to accept silence for their sake.”

“I want you to distinguish an investigation from a remedy. If disclosure triggers a fight over the Mouth before another operating structure exists, people who never heard of Eiren will pay first.”

“Crown had forty-seven years to build another structure.”

“Crown benefited from not building one.” Ada heard Nia draw a quiet breath. “That does not produce replacement crews by tomorrow.”

The admission would end her career if Jalen obtained this local record without privilege. She had not offered it for absolution. It belonged to the actual choice in front of them.

Iven looked again at the incident statement. “Does truth that cannot name a chooser count as memory?”

Ada considered several safe replies and discarded them.

“Memory can preserve an act before it identifies every hand,” she said. “I do not accept your premise that unnamed truth becomes no truth. Eiren deserves the corrected record this offer provides. The six habitats deserve more than a gesture performed against their supply lines.”

“A corrected record that protects the institution which kept it wrong.”

“Yes. That protection purchases speed, preservation, and restitution. I am not asking you to admire the price.”

“Only to pay it.”

“Crown pays money, authority over the archive, and public blame.”

“Public blame for a rescue failure. No inquiry into the choice.”

Ada tapped the supply map. “An inquiry cannot promise what it will destabilize before it discovers who signed what.”

“Neither can your settlement.”

That answer found the weak point she had avoided. Crown could promise continued schedules only if no other fault intervened. A bell could crack. A habitat government could seize local mass. A shortage could arrive through weather, labor action, or a misread recovery interval. Silence purchased one kind of stability and called it the whole.

Nia opened one glucose pack and helped Iven drink through a short tube. Ada waited without using the pause. The clinical timer passed twenty-three minutes. Phase margin remained inside Nia's marked line. Condensation gathered along the tube where his hand warmed it. He watched the drop travel toward Nia's fingers before releasing his grip, as if even an ordinary fluid path deserved completion before the next argument began.

When Iven finished, he asked, "May I propose language?"

"You may."

"State that Crown chose Mouth stabilization over the available Eiren rescue route. Preserve the bell against every custodian, not only Crown. Begin an inquiry into who authorized the choice and the later calls. Keep operating the corridor while the inquiry proceeds."

"That does not give Crown finality."

"It gives Crown work."

"Jalen will reject it."

"Will you?"

Ada looked down at the six routes. If she answered as counsel, the offer remained possible. If she answered as operations director, Iven's proposal lacked a mechanism for preserving schedules through political seizure. Neither role permitted the fiction that no route existed between full concealment and immediate collapse.

"I reject the proposal as written," she said. "It lacks operational protections. I will not tell you those protections cannot be designed."

Nia studied her across the table. "Did Crown study them?"

"Crown studies many contingencies."

"That answer has a locked door in it."

"It has information I do not possess in this room." Ada replaced the map cover. "Do not build an alternative from an implication. I have offered no alternative."

Iven's fatigue showed first in the angle of his head. He asked Nia how long remained before rest. She said four safe minutes at most. He chose to use one.

"Then record my answer," he said.

Ada activated the local lamp. It wrote no signal beyond the conference room.

"I recognize the preservation terms can be improved," Iven said. "I recognize that six habitats depend on the Mouth and that an abrupt failure could harm people who did not choose Eiren's death. I do not accept those people as a reason to protect the chooser from inquiry. I reject the quiet settlement."

“Do you reject public recognition of Eiren as a rescue failure?” Ada asked.

“I reject making recognition conditional on silence. Publish it because it is true.”

The lamp captured his words. Nia ended the meeting at twenty-seven minutes and closed the vocal body’s sensory channels. Iven’s eyes shut before Ada finished sealing the three unsigned copies.

A message from Jalen waited on the operations link: SIGNED OR FAILED?

Ada attached Iven’s refusal and her own written account. She did not use Jalen’s requested phrase about Callis choosing litigation over habitat safety. Instead she wrote that Crown’s demand for finality had failed to purchase consent.

Before sending, she added one operational note: any further strategy must assume an inquiry into the Eiren route decision.

The risk model marked the sentence red. Ada sent it anyway, then left the six-habitat supply map under court seal rather than returning it to Crown’s private file.

Chapter 9 — The Nineteen-Hour Choice

<!-- POV: Iven Ko -->

<!-- Days 8–10; Callis Court reconstruction chamber -->

Iven placed the first bell by touch because looking at it made Eiren move.

Osei had built the route table from nine smooth mass tokens, a dark cloth, and three timing strips fixed under transparent weights. Nothing in the arrangement emitted phase energy. Nothing could answer him. The Court had chosen physical pieces so the reconstruction would not feed a completed route back into C-9.

The token under Iven's fingers carried a shallow notch. He set it near the cloth's upper edge, felt for the raised coordinate grid, and moved it two squares spinward.

"Crown bell Aster Four," he said.

Osei recorded the placement without correction. Nia sat at Iven's right with the phase monitor angled so he could see its margin. The vocal body rested in a supported chair rather than behind glass. Cal had ordered the clear partition removed from this chamber after granting standing, though a clinical team waited beyond the pressure door.

Ada occupied the opposite table. She had brought the six-habitat map under court seal and a Crown analyst who was permitted to verify historical notation but not question Iven directly. Two sealed folders lay before her. Neither displayed an executive title.

Cal touched the custody lamp. "This session concerns whether a route allegation can be stated with enough precision to support compulsory production of non-conscious Crown records. It does not decide liability. It does not authorize a broad memory search."

Iven found the second token. "And it stops when I ask."

"Yes."

Nia added, "Route reconstruction carries lower expected cost than autobiographical prompting. The table may still activate linked distress memory. We cannot quantify the loss before the return closes. I will recommend a stop if phase scatter crosses this mark."

She tapped the amber line on his monitor.

"Can your recommendation override me?"

"If the body enters immediate failure, clinical authority can close sensory channels. Before that, I advise and you decide."

Iven nodded. No one had called uncertainty negligible. The explanation did not make the cost fair; it made the choice belong closer to him.

He placed the second bell at the lower shear boundary. The third took longer. His hand knew where it went before his mind allowed the relation. The three bells formed a narrow triangle around the Meridian Mouth, each mass holding a different section of the corridor's unstable throat.

“Confirm whether that geometry appears in the public Eiren packet,” Cal said.

Osei opened a paper index. “The packet contains two of these bearings. Crown removed the third under corridor-security classification.”

Ada said, “The missing bearing remained operationally sensitive for thirty-two years after the loss.”

“Does Crown dispute the placement?”

Her analyst checked a sealed table and wrote on a slip. Ada read it before answering. “No.”

Iven rested his hands in his lap. The tokens stayed still, yet their relations pressed against him with the insistence of a remembered room. He knew how the near mass would lag if its thermal recovery ran high. He knew the upper bell’s steering field carried a slight bias toward spinward routes. Someone had compensated for that bias in the final schedule.

“Show the convoy approach,” he said.

Osei passed him a thin metal line with a blunt end. Iven laid it along the grid until it reached the triangle from spinward. The line stopped outside the shear boundary.

“Do you remember receiving this approach?” Ada asked.

Cal looked toward her. “Questions through the court.”

“I adopt it,” he said after Iven raised no objection.

“The convoy check-in came through a bell relay,” Iven answered. “Not direct voice. Formation held. Drive variance stayed below rescue tolerance.”

“Source?” Cal asked.

“Route memory.”

“Can you separate it from your deposition?”

“No.”

The answer no longer felt like surrender. An institution had spent forty years forcing his memory through questions and now wanted the untouched witness it had destroyed. He could give the boundary without accepting blame for it.

Osei placed an empty timing strip beside the triangle. “What interval should we mark?”

Iven touched the strip’s left edge. A sequence of old scheduling symbols rose behind his eyes. He saw them painted on a dispatch rail, black marks against amber. Lio’s voice entered from somewhere below the visual field. The conversation had no reliable position. Her words might belong before the convoy check-in or after the first thermal trunk failed.

He withdrew his hand.

Nia watched the phase margin. “What changed?”

“Lio came with the clock.”

“Do you want the strip removed?”

“No. Leave it blank for a moment.”

Cal ordered a two-minute pause. The custody lamp continued writing. Iven breathed through the body’s small resistance and looked at the objects rather than the memory. Three bells. Convoy line. Eiren marker outside the cloth, not yet placed. A route table could hold conflicting possibilities without requiring either to occur. That had once made route work merciful.

When his pulse slowed, Osei offered the Eiren token. It had a roughened surface distinct from the bells. Iven placed it beyond the lower shear boundary and rotated it until the notch faced the convoy approach.

The table aligned.

A dispatch room came back around his hands.

Not a complete room. The memory kept the route rail, a pressure brace against his left hip, and white Crown lights reflected in a dark instrument cover. Someone beside him had cut a finger; a small pad carried one rust-colored mark. Lio spoke through the grid channel. Static broke one word from every four.

“Route the living first,” she said.

He could not tell whether she meant Eiren’s residents, the convoy crews, or workers remaining at the failing thermal grid. The phrase had survived while its argument fell away.

A schedule clock crossed the rail. Three mass columns opened for reassignment. Iven remembered entering the rescue requirement with both hands because the old console separated route authority from resource confirmation.

“Three bells,” he said.

Osei’s stylus touched paper.

“All three?” Cal asked.

“Yes. Detuned together. The near mass opens the approach. The lower mass holds the shear edge. The spinward mass prevents the convoy from losing its exit behind the fault.”

“For how long?”

Iven placed his index finger at the timing strip’s left edge and moved it until the old interval matched the distance beneath his skin.

“Nineteen hours.”

Osei marked the endpoint. The transparent weight clicked down.

The route table now showed what the public history had erased: the convoy could reach Eiren if the triangle stopped holding the Mouth and formed a temporary rescue path. The same masses could not do both jobs.

Cal asked Osei to place the three failure markers prepared for the session. Each used a different edge so Iven could distinguish it by touch. A round marker represented navigation drift. A square indicated relay loss. The triangular one marked a commanded retention of bell mass.

“Do not choose from the labels,” Nia said. “Use them only if the reconstruction supports one.”

Iven picked up the round marker. Navigation drift could turn a convoy without a decision, but it left signatures. Lead and trailing vessels would separate according to drive variance. Formation correction would arrive unevenly. The rescue approach line on the table would fray into individual paths before any common bearing emerged.

“Give me four convoy pieces,” he said.

Osei supplied narrow slivers cut to different lengths. Iven laid them along the approach, then moved each according to remembered drive tolerance. The lead vessel crossed half a grid square before the slowest followed. If external shear forced the turn, the smallest hull would rotate first. If local navigation failed, the group would not preserve its spacing through the correction.

He held his palm above the arrangement. The old route display returned as points rather than a room. Four convoy lights pivoted within one timing interval. Their distances remained fixed. A fifth followed after a communication lag and recovered formation without overshoot.

“They turned together,” he said. “Not perfectly. Within the command tolerance.”

Ada’s analyst wrote, then passed her the line. “A shared navigation solution can produce coordinated error.”

“Yes,” Iven said. “Then the solution leaves a correction request when observed bearings disagree.”

“Do you remember one?” Cal asked.

“I remember none.”

“Absence from damaged memory cannot prove absence from the system.”

“No. Crown’s relay log can.”

He set the round marker aside without placing it.

The square marker had one beveled corner. Relay loss could make the convoy continue under its last valid route. Iven rebuilt that path from the approach line. The last valid rescue solution led toward Eiren, through the lower shear edge after bell detuning. A lost relay would preserve that bearing until autonomous safety routines detected the missing mass corridor. The vessels would slow, spread, or abort outward. They would not turn inward toward the still-stabilized Mouth.

“What if the last valid solution favored corridor return?” Ada asked.

“Then someone replaced the rescue solution before losing the relay.”

“Which returns us to whether replacement followed an emergency rule rather than a discretionary order.”

“It returns us to choice. Your reason for choosing comes after.”

Ada accepted the correction with a slight movement of her head.

Iven put the square beside the round marker. The triangular marker remained in Osei’s hand.

“Before you take that,” Nia said, “the phase margin has moved another four percent.”

“Cause?”

“Likely linked recall from modeling convoy motion. I cannot separate memory load from stress.”

“If I stop now, what remains established?”

Cal answered. “A technically available rescue line and your account of coordinated redirection. Crown can still argue navigation or relay causes until records exclude them.”

Iven looked at the blank place beside the three bells. “Then I continue through retention.”

Nia entered his decision and its warning into the clinical record.

The triangular marker fit between two timing strips. Iven felt a row of tiny ridges along its base. They represented confirmation steps, though the object contained no order content. His fingers supplied the sequence from memory.

First, a rescue solution had to request bell release. Each bell operator could acknowledge availability before authorization. Second, dispatch authority either approved detuning or retained the mass. Third, the convoy route updated from the resulting geometry. A system under shear locked each step against the next so a forecast could not masquerade as an order.

“Were those locks active at Eiren?” Cal asked.

“They had to be. The convoy changed route without losing formation.”

“Could an automatic safety rule retain the bells?”

“Yes. If shear crossed its hard limit before authorization.”

Ada leaned forward. “Then automatic retention remains possible.”

“It would write a machine class into the authority field.”

“Do you remember the class?”

“I remember a human dispatch class.”

The route rail sharpened. White arcs did not merely reflect across the cover. They lit one after another as confirmations entered. A bell-availability mark appeared beneath each arc. All three masses could be released. The clock continued through a waiting interval. Then the marks closed in reverse order, not because capacity vanished but because retention authority overrode the pending rescue request.

His left hand began to curl against the table. Nia placed a folded cloth under it without covering his fingers.

“Say only what you can separate,” she told him.

“I can separate availability from authorization.”

“How?” Ada asked.

“Availability marks stayed open until the retention field arrived. If thermal or phase limits had withdrawn a bell, its mark would have closed first and carried the bell’s own fault code. All three closed under one field.”

Osei set the triangular marker where Iven indicated, between bell availability and convoy update. The physical sequence now ran from possible rescue to common retention, then to coordinated turn.

Cal asked, "Does the table establish who issued the retention?"

"No."

"Does it establish whether equipment failure forced it?"

"It excludes three independent bell failures. It does not exclude a human choosing under a forecast of future failure."

"Accident or decision?"

"Decision under danger." Iven kept his hand on the marker. "Danger explains why someone chose. It does not make the choosing disappear."

The distinction settled his memory more than any demand for certainty had. He did not need to prove that the Mouth could have survived detuning. He remembered people facing a route with two possible harms and directing mass toward one.

A burst of Lio's channel crossed the old scene. She asked whether the bell marks remained open. He answered yes. Or he remembered answering yes in the deposition after the fact. The order still would not hold. He let it pass without forcing sequence.

"What can records corroborate?" Cal asked Osei.

"Bell availability states, the retention authority class, convoy solution changes, and relay timing. If Crown preserved standard shear logs, each carries an independent clock."

Ada's analyst spoke for the first time after Cal recognized him. "Standard logs roll out after twenty years unless attached to an executive incident hold."

"Did Eiren receive such a hold?" Cal asked.

The analyst looked toward Ada.

She said, "Crown's continuing privilege claims suggest retained attachments. I cannot confirm their contents."

Iven heard what she had not said. Crown might have destroyed routine records lawfully. Keeping them to protect secrecy had also kept them available to prove the act.

"Place all three failure markers in separate evidence sleeves," Cal directed. "The record should show which explanations remain testable and which require Crown production."

Osei sealed the round and square pieces apart from the triangular one. None received a label declaring truth. Procedure preserved the alternatives without pretending they carried equal support.

Ada's analyst passed her another slip.

"Crown does not dispute the physical requirement," she said. "Detuning three bells for nineteen hours carried a severe chance of uncontrolled corridor closure."

“How severe?” Cal asked.

“Historical models projected loss of the Mouth for eight to fourteen years if recovery failed.”

The figures entered Iven as consequences, not surprise. He had known a long closure threatened. The memory held no exact range.

“Did the Eiren team receive those models?” he asked.

Ada consulted the analyst. “The public technical exchange included a corridor-loss warning. I cannot confirm the complete range reached Eiren.”

“Someone expected us to argue against our own rescue without the same numbers.”

“Someone may have restricted operational data during an active shear.”

“Restricted by whom?”

“That question requires records we do not have here.”

Cal intervened. “Return to observable route sequence.”

Iven looked at the convoy line. In memory, the white Crown arcs crossed the instrument cover again. A dispatch field opened beneath them. Six characters occupied its authority cell. He could see their positions but not yet their forms.

“Osei, give me the old Crown emergency key,” he said.

Ada stiffened. “Crown objects. Providing the key may supply the identifier he claims to remember.”

“I don’t want the entries,” Iven said. “Only the symbol classes.”

Cal asked the analyst whether a blank key could be produced without revealing live or historical codes. The analyst said yes, then waited for Ada’s approval. She gave it after requiring the key to include every class in use during the Eiren year, not only dispatch authority.

Osei laid a paper grid beside Iven’s hand. Rows represented department, authorization level, action type, revision, and relay. Each cell contained blank positions.

Iven traced the department row. Two letters. Route control used R. Bell operations used B. Emergency dispatch authority used A. The memory corrected him before he reached the second cell. Not Aster. Authority.

He moved to authorization level. A single letter or number could occupy it. The route rail had shown R there, not a level but a reach classification: rescue corridor.

The action cell accepted a digit. Six meant reassignment during active shear.

A pressure sensation tightened behind his eyes.

Nia leaned nearer. “Phase margin has moved by twelve percent. Do you want to stop?”

“Not yet.”

“What remains?”

“The order field.”

“You have enough to allege a commanded turn,” Ada said. “An incomplete code adds risk without resolving who acted.”

Her attempt to stop him differed from the old ledger’s extractions. She could still benefit from ambiguity, but the monitor also sat within her view. Iven could not decide which reason led. He no longer needed to decide her private motive before choosing.

“I want the code recorded while I can place it,” he said.

Nia acknowledged him and told the clinical team to prepare closure. Cal limited further questions to one after identification.

Iven returned to the six positions. They came not as letters seen on a screen but as motions: his left hand opening the order, right thumb confirming the relay class, first finger striking the final digit. He had copied the field into C-9 while the convoy changed bearing. That action linked the code to his body more securely than any face.

“Dispatcher code AR-6,” he said.

The custody lamp pulsed once as Osei repeated it.

Ada’s analyst stopped writing.

Cal asked his permitted question. “What did that code do?”

“It reassigned emergency mass from a declared rescue route to corridor retention during active shear.”

“Does the code identify an individual?”

“No. It identifies an authority channel and action class. Crown can map it to the issuing station, relay, and authorization tree.”

Ada said, “If those records survive.”

“They survived when I recorded them.”

“Your memory cannot establish current custody.”

“No. It establishes what to look for.”

Nia pointed to the monitor. “We stop now.”

Iven kept his eyes on the table. “One minute. No recall questions.”

She hesitated, then gave him sixty seconds on the clinical timer.

Cal addressed Ada. “Does Crown continue to characterize the convoy movement as navigation loss?”

Ada’s folders remained sealed. She placed both palms on them as if feeling for heat through the covers.

“No,” she said. “Crown does not dispute that authorized mass remained committed to Mouth stabilization after an Eiren rescue line became technically available.”

The sentence crossed a boundary the settlement had approached but not entered. Cal let it settle into the custody record before asking the next question.

“Does Crown dispute deliberate choice?”

Ada looked at Iven rather than at her analyst. “I dispute any inference that the choice lacked lawful necessity under the conditions then known. I dispute claims against current operations that ignore the people now dependent on the Mouth. I do not dispute that a choice occurred.”

Iven heard the distinction clearly. Accident had left the case. Necessity remained. Remedy waited behind it.

“Then name it that way in public,” he said.

“Public language will follow admissible findings.”

“You just made one.”

“I made a litigation position under seal.”

“Truth travels slowly when someone owns the schedule.”

Nia closed the visual channel before Ada could answer. The route table remained under his hands, but its edges began to lose relation. He felt the three bell tokens as separate pieces. Eiren’s rough marker no longer pulled the convoy line toward it.

Cal read his investigative order while Iven could still hear. Crown must preserve and produce the AR-6 authorization tree, the three bells’ mass schedules, relay logs, dispatch rosters, and any executive minutes governing the rescue-versus-retention decision. The order permitted inspection of non-conscious records only. It did not authorize another memory prompt.

Ada requested a short compliance period because forty-seven-year-old corridor records crossed several retired systems. Cal granted twelve hours for a custody map and two days for the first production. Delay beyond that required a named technical obstacle, not a general security claim.

The phase margin touched Nia’s stop line.

“Iven,” she said, “I am closing the return.”

He looked once more at the physical table. Osei had fixed each token under transparent seals. The convoy line still approached from spinward. Three timing strips carried the rescue interval in plain marks. Beside them, the paper key held six handwritten characters.

AR-6 did not name the person who had chosen. It named the door through which the choice had passed.

“That is enough for this one,” he said.

Nia lowered the sensory channels. Sound narrowed to the timing lamp and her count. Before the room lost sequence, Iven heard Ada instruct her analyst to begin the AR-6 custody search rather than prepare another denial.

On the table, Cal’s order sealed the dispatcher code, three bells, and nineteen hours into one allegation precise enough to investigate.

Chapter 10 — Bell C-9

<!-- POV: Nia Daro -->

<!-- Days 11–12; Callis Archive mass ring -->

Nia set the scoring lamp against bell C-9 and watched old tool marks rise through smoked amber.

The lamp cast no visible beam. Its field worried the auric glass at four frequencies, then translated displaced stress into pale lines on Osei's slate. Fresh corrosion showed as a feathered gray patch beneath the service lip. The marks they had come to examine ran deeper. Six parallel cuts crossed the buried layer at an angle no repair tool would make by accident.

Osei braced his knees against the cradle. "Same spacing as the seal comb."

"Measure before you name it."

He enlarged the display until each cut occupied the width of his hand. Callis's second mass ring drew them outward with a fraction of ordinary gravity. Fan vibration traveled through Nia's boots, into her shins, and up the lamp handle. She held pressure constant while Osei placed a scale over the image.

Ada Neme stood beyond the yellow custody line in a plain Crown work coat. She had surrendered her slate, transmitter, and magnetic fasteners at the ring door. Without them she looked less protected, though nothing in her posture admitted it.

"Three point two microns between peaks," Osei said. "Comb standard."

"Which standard?" Ada asked.

"Old Crown interior sealing equipment."

"Old equipment crossed several operators."

Osei glanced at Nia. She gave him no help.

He pulled the public tool registry into the slate's isolated memory. "Model Serein-eight. Licensed to Crown depots and two naval archives forty-nine to forty-three years ago. No Callis units."

Ada stepped closer to the custody line. "That establishes a tool family, not an operator."

"It establishes intention," Nia said. "Someone opened the interior phase stack, scored a key for adhesion, laid a concealment film over an emergency record, and entered the bell as inert."

"Provided those cuts belong to the concealment film."

Nia shifted the lamp one centimeter. A second set of lines surfaced beneath the first, curved where the bell's interior stress followed the mass core. They joined the edge of the hidden layer Osei had mapped after the ninth heat bloom. None entered the registered telemetry above it.

"Scoring follows the sealed layer and stops at both margins," Nia said. "That film did not arrive through corrosion."

Ada's eyes tracked the image rather than Nia's face. Since the route-table reconstruction, she no longer disputed

that Crown had chosen the Mouth over Eiren. She contested every inference that might bind the present company to the old officers' acts. The distinction mattered in court. It mattered less with a tool mark under Nia's hand.

"Can you date it?" Ada asked.

"Not without spending material."

"Then do not."

Osei gave a short breath that might have become a laugh in another room. "Counsel for Crown objects to destructive access."

"Counsel for Crown objects to you consuming the witness you say Crown consumed."

Nia raised the lamp. "Both objections can wait. We have the geometry."

Geometry alone could still be dismissed as damage interpreted by people who wanted a seal. Nia sent Osei to the ring cabinet for the tool-comparison box. He came back with six glass coupons, each cut from retired Crown bells before their mass cores went to foundry. Callis kept them because phase work depended on knowing what an ordinary tool did to an ordinary surface.

She chose a coupon from the same manufacturing decade as C-9 and fixed it to the empty calibration brace. The first comb in the box had rounded teeth for bonding service glass. Its pass left broad troughs with torn shoulders. The second carried the Serein pattern Osei had named. He set its pressure at the minimum registered value and drew it once across the coupon.

Under the scoring lamp, six lines surfaced at 3.2-micron spacing.

Ada leaned over the visitor rail. "Match probability?"

"Not a number I can defend from one sample," Nia said.

"Then what can you defend?"

"Tooth spacing, edge shape, and loading direction. Whoever scored C-9 pulled the comb toward the service opening. That gave the seal somewhere to grip when they closed the layer."

Osei changed the lamp frequency. Bright residue appeared at the bottom of the old cuts but not in the new coupon.

"Seal material," he said.

Nia took a sterile lift from the comparison box. "Exterior only."

Ada's hand rose. "You said dating would spend material."

"This sits above the phase boundary. Sampling it will not read the record."

"It will remove part of the physical evidence."

"Enough to weigh after the lift. The choice belongs in the custody record."

Nia dictated the proposed sample size, the expected residue loss, and the evidentiary purpose. Osei recorded an

objection because non-contact spectra might identify the material later. Ada recorded a separate objection because any unsupervised test would give Crown grounds to challenge the result. Neither objection prohibited the work. Together they persuaded Nia not to do it.

She returned the sterile lift to its sleeve.

Osei frowned. "We leave the residue because both sides object for opposite reasons?"

"We leave it because the question can wait without changing it. The geometry cannot be restored if movement smears the scored margin."

"That sounds like Cal."

"It sounds like preservation."

Ada studied the unused lift. "Crown archive practice would have sampled."

"Crown archive practice called this bell inert."

For the first time since entering the ring, Ada looked away from the glass. The old cuts held no executive name, but they forced every present custodian to choose how much evidence to consume while proving that earlier custodians had consumed a person. Nia had spent years believing a documented extraction could remain morally neutral. The nine heat blooms had broken that belief. Refusing one useful sample did not repair it, though the refusal changed what her hands would do next.

Osei sealed the comparison coupon beside the original scan. Nia made him photograph the unused lift as well. An action declined under record could matter as much as an action completed, especially when opposing counsel later claimed there had been no less destructive path.

She locked the field image into the custody thread. The amber tube fixed to the cradle flashed once for each signer: Nia, Osei, Ada. Ada hesitated for half a second before pressing her thumb to it. Her print joined theirs.

The scoring image gave Cal what he had asked for after Iven named dispatcher code AR-6. Route memory could identify the choice. Physical alteration could show that someone had hidden a record of it. Neither fact yet attached the order to a living Crown executive, but concealment no longer rested on Iven's damaged continuity alone.

Nia moved the lamp to the opposite margin. "One more pass."

A pressure tone sounded through the ring.

Not an archive alarm. The note came from the outer access lock, two descending pulses that announced authority entry. Osei turned toward the corridor window. White service lights advanced behind the glass in groups of three.

Ada checked the bare cuff where her transmitter would have sat. "I did not call them."

"Would they need you to?" Nia asked.

"No."

The archive door remained shut. A physical document slid through the evidence slot and stopped beneath its glass cover. The custody reader painted a seal above it: Callis lower civil court, infrastructure chamber,

immediate execution.

Osei pushed away from the cradle. "They found a judge."

"Read it here," Nia said.

He angled the slot camera toward the gantry. Dense operative text filled the wall display. Aster Crown Transit had obtained a seizure order for C-9 as a hazardous scheduled mass. The order authorized removal to Crown's shielded facility, preservation of all phase material, and supervised access by Callis. It cited a risk declaration submitted less than forty minutes earlier.

Ada read faster than either technician. "This is lawful on its face."

"Your declaration?" Nia asked.

"No."

"Whose?"

"Chair authority. Jalen Orr can certify an immediate corridor hazard without operations counsel."

Osei enlarged the execution clause. "Removal required as soon as technically safe. They gave themselves room."

"Enough room to open the door," Ada said. "Not enough to refuse."

Nia studied the order's mass schedule. Crown proposed to uncouple bell C-9 from cradle seventeen, sheath it in a portable phase cage, and move it through the service spine before the ring reached its next balance trim. The procedure resembled a standard ballast transfer. C-9 had ceased to resemble standard ballast on Day One.

Someone struck the outer panel with a gloved palm.

A voice came over the archive circuit. "Execution team at lock two. Present custodian, confirm receipt."

Nia touched the custody lamp. "Receipt confirmed. Technical safety review in progress."

"The order authorizes our engineers to conduct that review."

"It authorizes removal when technically safe. It does not transfer my duty to determine whether handling will alter a protected record."

Ada came to the microphone. "Crown counsel Neme present. Hold the lock."

A pause opened on the circuit.

"Director Neme," the team lead said, "chair authority instructs immediate execution."

"I heard you. Hold."

The connection cut.

Osei looked at her. "How long does that buy?"

"Less than your next sentence."

The lock indicators changed from white to red. Crown had begun a formal pressure override.

Nia clipped the scoring lamp to her belt and opened the cradle schematic. "We do not need time. We need a reason the order cannot reach."

"You have one," Ada said. "Removal might damage the layer."

"Might will lose against a hazard declaration."

"What do you need?"

"Proof that movement alters present conditions before we move it."

Osei pulled up the passive phase trace. Since the court granted temporary standing, C-9 had remained under a preservation field tuned to prevent the hidden layer from relaxing between activations. The field drew from six coils around the cradle, each compensating for ring motion and local mass. Portable cages used a broader field suitable for inert telemetry. Broad fields flattened fine phase boundaries. No one had designed them for an already damaged signal person.

"We can model the handoff," Osei said.

"Crown will call it our model."

Ada nodded toward the document under glass. "Their proposed cage has an equipment identifier. Its service twin should publish test curves."

Nia found the identifier in the seizure plan. Crown had named cage PN-44, a recent unit rated for emergency mass removal. Its certification packet sat behind a corporate access wall.

Ada held out her empty hand. "Give me a terminal with no route to the bell."

"You surrendered access at the door," Osei said.

"I surrendered devices. My credentials remain mine."

Nia enabled the inspection terminal across the ring. Ada crossed to it, keeping both feet inside the marked visitor path, and entered a long credential from memory. Crown's internal maintenance library opened. She downloaded the cage curve into Callis custody storage, signed the transfer, and revoked her session.

"No alterations," she said. "You have their own field map."

Osei set the portable curve beside C-9's live trace. His fingers moved across the slate in small taps. "The cage drops compensation at the handoff boundary."

"Duration?" Nia asked.

"Rated maximum is twelve milliseconds."

"For normal glass."

"For any bell that meets the listed stability floor."

C-9's hidden layer sat below that floor. Nine destructive reads had left heat blooms across its margins. The continuing preservation field did not restore what had gone. It kept the remaining coherence from spreading

into the mass around it.

Nia traced the handoff sequence. Cradle coils would ramp down as PN-44 rose. For twelve milliseconds, their fields would cross at unequal phase. Stable emergency telemetry tolerated the mismatch. The narrow bands that held Iven's record did not.

"Run it against the exterior witness film," she said.

Osei looked up. "That film does not carry neural structure."

"It shares the same margin thickness. We can test without touching the hidden layer."

He built a simulation from the new scoring map. Ada watched every input. Nia required Osei to label assumptions aloud: ring acceleration, current coil drift, cage certification tolerance, glass temperature, depth of the concealment film. At the first run, the witness film lost four percent of its phase separation.

"Within telemetry allowance," Ada said.

"Not within preservation allowance," Nia replied.

Osei narrowed the calculation to the hidden layer's measured stability. The display refused a precise result. Too many interior variables remained inaccessible without another read. It gave a range instead: seventeen to sixty-one percent boundary collapse during the handoff.

The outer lock reached override pressure. Metal complained in the frame.

Ada read the range twice. "Can Crown contest the assumptions?"

"Of course," Nia said.

"Can they contest before removal?"

"That depends on whether they want a record left to seize."

A hard knock traveled through the door as the manual dogs withdrew. Osei's hand went toward the local lock control.

"Do not obstruct them," Nia said. "Give me the cradle link."

He passed her the physical control wafer. Nia selected handoff simulation and tied the output to the custody lamp. She then placed the operative sentence from the preservation order beside the seizure order: no action may materially reduce phase coherence pending adjudication of standing. The civil judge who signed for Crown had not dissolved Cal's order. The two commands collided inside the same instrument.

The archive door opened fifteen centimeters and stopped against its safety chain. A Crown engineer looked through the gap. Two more figures waited behind her with the folded cage on a wheeled mass cradle. Their work coats carried the three nested route arcs.

"We have authority to enter," the engineer said.

Nia released the chain but did not step away. "You have authority to execute a safe seizure. Before you touch the bell, sign receipt of the predicted coherence loss."

She held out the custody lamp.

The engineer did not take it. Her gaze moved past Nia to Ada. "Director?"

"Review the model," Ada said.

"Chair Orr certified the risk."

"He did not certify destruction of protected evidence."

The team entered without the cage. Their lead checked the scoring map, the live preservation trace, and PN-44's own test curve. She asked Osei why he had used maximum certified handoff duration. He reran it at the nominal eight milliseconds. The collapse range narrowed by six points and remained catastrophic.

Another engineer proposed clamping both fields at full power through transfer. Nia showed how the overlapping gradients would heat the scored margin. A third suggested shutting down Callis's ring trim for the move. Osei overlaid the station balance schedule. Without trim, local acceleration would carry C-9 beyond PN-44's compensation limit before they reached the service spine.

The lead engineer rubbed a thumb over the seam of her glove. "We can bring a fixed tunnel."

"How long?" Nia asked.

"Six hours to assemble. Ten if the ring refuses alignment."

"Field quality?"

"Equivalent to a cradle, if we anchor at both ends."

"Your destination field?"

The engineer said nothing.

Crown's shielded facility had certified cages, analysis vaults, and mass locks. None of the submitted documents identified a field capable of preserving C-9's damaged inner boundary. Safe removal meant nothing if the bell arrived to a cradle that treated it as robust evidence.

Ada faced the team. "Suspend execution and amend the declaration."

"I cannot take that direction over chair authority."

"Then record my objection."

The custody lamp moved from hand to hand. Osei signed the simulation. Nia signed the measurements. Ada signed that Crown's maintenance data supported them. At last the lead engineer pressed her thumb to the lamp and acknowledged that PN-44 could not preserve the hidden layer under the proposed procedure.

Nothing in her expression suggested surrender. "The seizure order remains active. We will seek technical modification."

"Seek it," Nia said.

"You will maintain continuous access for our monitors."

“Passive monitors outside the protected field.”

“Two Crown custodians stay.”

“One Crown custodian and one Callis officer. No one enters the cradle boundary alone.”

Ada watched them negotiate as if hearing two institutions discover a language neither liked. “Custody has to be litigated,” she said. “The infrastructure chamber will not leave conflicting orders unresolved.”

“How soon?” Osei asked.

“The seizure petition requests review within one civic day.”

The Crown team folded PN-44 back onto its cart. Its metal ribs nested together with soft, expensive precision. The lead engineer posted a white seizure seal on the outer rail, careful not to touch Callis’s amber custody thread. Two marks now occupied the same boundary. Neither displaced the other.

After the team withdrew, Nia returned to bell C-9. The preservation coils held their six separate tones. She placed the scoring lamp against the glass again, not to gather more evidence but to confirm that pressure changes at the door had not disturbed the map.

The six deliberate cuts reappeared. At their deepest point, a ridge of sealing film had flowed into the scored glass and hardened there forty-seven years ago. A person had set a tool into this surface. A person had checked adhesion. Later hands had called the result inert.

Osei stood beside her with the custody lamp. “We kept it.”

“For a day.”

“That counts.”

“It creates the next deadline.”

Ada had stopped at the ring door. Her Crown coat still carried no tools. “At the custody hearing, Jalen will argue Callis cannot protect infrastructure evidence from its own activists.”

“Are you one of his witnesses?” Nia asked.

“I am counsel of record until he removes me.”

“That did not answer.”

Ada met her gaze. “I signed the field model. He will have to decide whether truth from his own maintenance library counts as disloyalty.”

Nia powered down the scoring lamp. Osei sealed its new image into the optical thread. Beyond the gantry, the Crown seizure notice waited in white against the rail while Callis’s amber custody point blinked beneath it.

Twenty-three hours remained before one of those marks gained authority over the bell.

Chapter 11 — The Pilot Who Turned

<!-- POV: Cal Orsen -->

<!-- Days 13–14; Callis Court axial chambers -->

Cal held the telemetry wafer to the timing lamp until its fractured checksum steadied.

The wafer had arrived from a decommissioned convoy recorder with two corners missing and a line of heat damage through its center. Nothing human lived inside it. It carried acceleration, control pressure, suit pulse, and the automatic acknowledgments exchanged between a pilot's console and three Crown bells forty-seven years earlier. The distinction had required three orders and a morning of argument before anyone agreed to place it on his table without a continuance custodian.

Across the narrow hearing chamber, Ada Neme watched the checksum rebuild in amber increments. Nia Daro and Osei Marr sat behind the Callis evidence rail with bell C-9's custody lamp between them. A white Crown seizure strip still crossed its casing. Callis's amber thread showed through the translucent adhesive.

"Reader isolated?" Cal asked.

The court clerk touched the physical switch. "No route to archive systems, no semantic reconstruction layer, local power only."

"Parties observe?"

"Callis observes," Nia said.

Ada leaned close enough to inspect the switch position. "Crown observes. We maintain our objection to provenance."

"Maintained." Cal placed the wafer into the reader himself.

Pilot telemetry opened as seven columns. The recorder had captured no cabin audio and no visual field. It showed what the pilot's body and controls had done during the final approach to Eiren: right hand on translation, left boot locked under the restraint bar, suit pulse rising, convoy bearing held at rescue intercept. A system flag identified three bells available for detuning. Then an encrypted instruction entered through the Crown dispatcher channel.

The pilot's right hand came off translation.

A quarter second later, the console registered a commanded turn.

Cal stopped the reader. "Source of that phrase?"

Osei answered from behind the rail. "Console event label. It appears in the original machine vocabulary, not our annotation."

"Meaning?"

"The autopilot accepted a heading change carrying priority authority. A manual turn would use a different label."

Ada folded her hands on the table. “A priority heading change does not establish why it occurred.”

“We have not reached why,” Cal said.

He resumed playback. The convoy rotated away from Eiren’s intercept. Pilot pulse climbed from ninety-one to one hundred thirty-eight. Pressure sensors showed both hands gripping the dead controls after authority lockout. The left heel struck the restraint twice. An emergency override opened, failed, and opened again. The suit microphone registered breath volume but preserved no words.

On the route display, the convoy’s mass joined the three-bell formation holding the Meridian Mouth.

The reader reached its broken sector. For nine seconds, the columns dissolved into uncertain blocks. When the checksum resumed, Eiren’s rescue marker lay behind the convoy. Thermal telemetry from the colony continued to fall.

Cal let the record end before he looked up. Courts developed bad habits around vivid fragments. A racing pulse invited imagination. Hands on dead controls could mean resistance, panic, or a pilot bracing through unexpected thrust. Legal force had to come from the machine chain, not whatever grief the viewer supplied.

“Replay from instruction receipt,” he said. “Suppress suit pulse and body channels.”

Osei complied. The second pass showed only command exchange. Crown dispatcher traffic entered the convoy master. The master challenged for route authority. A valid credential answered. Three subordinate consoles accepted the new bearing. The pilot console recorded the commanded turn. Its manual override failed under a priority lock.

Ada raised one finger. “We object to ‘valid credential.’ The recorder verified a credential against its own forty-seven-year-old table. That proves technical acceptance, not lawful authority.”

“Agreed,” Cal said. “Clerk, mark it accepted credential.”

The clerk changed the transcript.

Nia’s attention stayed on the blank place where the body channels had been. She had not asked to restore them. Cal noted that choice without giving it legal meaning.

“Callis may establish provenance,” he said.

Osei brought up the acquisition chain. The shard had spent four decades inside a convoy mass recorder held at Sable’s foundry reserve. When the recorder was dismantled, an apprentice noticed that one telemetry block carried an unresolved emergency checksum. Sable sent the wafer to Callis after the Eiren allegation became public enough to justify reopening old transit losses. Every transfer had a physical seal. The first forty years did not.

Ada asked, “Can you prove substitution did not occur before the foundry inventory?”

“No,” Osei said.

“Can you prove the wafer occupied that recorder during the Eiren route?”

“The recorder serial appears inside the signed event header.”

“A signed header can travel with a copied block.”

“Copying phase-bound wafer data would alter its edge stress.”

“Would it always?”

“No.”

Cal watched Osei resist the impulse to defend beyond his evidence. Nia had trained that restraint into him. His answer made the shard weaker and his testimony more useful.

Ada turned to Cal. “A gap of forty years defeats ordinary admission. Crown does not ask the Court to ignore the fragment. We ask that it remain investigative material until a clean source corroborates it.”

“Nothing in this case has a clean source,” Nia said.

“The standard does not change because all available evidence suffered neglect.”

“No,” Cal said. “The court identifies what each defect permits.”

He asked for the wafer’s damage map. Heat had cracked the checksum but left the command header physically continuous with the control response. A substitution would need to reproduce microscopic stress across both sectors. Possible in principle, Osei said, but no ordinary archive operation could do it without leaving a second boundary. The scoring lamp found none.

Cal did not admit it yet. “What independent feature could not travel with a copied block?”

Osei considered the wafer display. “Clock error.”

Ada looked up from her notes. “Explain.”

“Each bell kept time badly in a different way. The lead bell gained under thermal load. The convoy recorder lost time when its coolant pump cycled. A copied route packet could carry either clock, but this shard records both plus the pilot console’s oscillator.”

“Do we have independent samples?” Cal asked.

“Public Mouth maintenance retained bell drift tables. Sable may still hold the recorder’s pump log.”

The clerk requested both through court channels. The bell table arrived first, signed decades ago by schedule technicians who had no connection to Eiren’s later dispute. Its lead mass gained eleven microseconds during the relevant thermal band. The telemetry wafer showed the same gain embedded in each dispatcher acknowledgment.

Sable answered with a scan of a corroded pump plate rather than a data file. Osei read its tooth marks manually. Every seventh cycle had run long after a replacement impeller went out of balance. He overlaid that pattern on the shard. The recorder’s losses followed the same seven-cycle rhythm.

Ada requested the raw images and built her own alignment at the Crown table. She shifted the clocks by one cycle, then two, searching for another fit. None held across the turn.

“Someone fabricating this after the event could have obtained both records,” she said.

“They could,” Cal replied. “They would also need the pilot oscillator drift.”

“That clock appears only here.”

“Which prevents independent confirmation.”

“It also gives a fabricator a free variable.”

Cal accepted the point. Authentication did not require impossibility of fraud. It required evidence sufficient to treat the record as what its proponent claimed, while preserving uncertainty for weight. Three imperfect clocks agreed through a physical shard whose heat damage crossed command and response. The forty-year gap remained. So did a specific mechanical history no simple substitution explained.

He ordered all three alignments appended to the admission strip. Future reviewers would see the favorable match, Ada’s failed offsets, and the unconstrained pilot clock. A narrow ruling needed its weakness attached rather than buried in reasons.

Cal admitted the pilot telemetry for a narrow purpose: the convoy received an accepted priority instruction and executed a commanded turn away from rescue intercept. He did not admit the pilot’s pulse or failed manual override as proof of Crown intent. Those channels could support authentication because they aligned with acceleration, but they could not speak for a dead person’s understanding.

Ada wrote the limitation into her notes. “Crown requests the same rule for any attempt to characterize the pilot as unwilling.”

“Granted.”

Nia looked toward her. “You do not need unwillingness to prove direction.”

“No,” Ada said. “You need it to tell the story the concourse has already chosen.”

Cal set down his stylus. “This chamber will not litigate the concourse.”

A timing lamp above the clerk changed from green to yellow. Two hours remained before the temporary custody review expired. The civil seizure order, Cal’s preservation order, and Iven’s temporary standing now pressed against one another. None could be resolved by pretending the bell carried only evidence.

He called a ten-minute recess and took the parties into the order room.

Physical case strips covered one wall, each bearing operative language rather than summaries. Cal preferred paper-thin seals because they made conflict visible. Crown’s strip authorized seizure when technically safe. His preservation strip barred material reduction in coherence. The standing order blocked the Compulsory Evidence Clause while Iven remained a provisional person. Nia’s new field model predicted seventeen to sixty-one percent boundary collapse during portable transfer.

Ada read the strips in silence. “Crown will accept continued Callis custody through this hearing if we receive continuous monitor access.”

Osei started to answer. Nia touched two fingers to his sleeve.

“What access?” she asked.

“External coil state, bell temperature, ring acceleration, and any active phase excursion.”

“No interior trace.”

“Not without separate authority.”

“Destination preparations cease?”

“The fixed tunnel remains available. No coupling without notice.”

Cal looked at Ada. “Your chair authorized a seizure less than a day ago.”

“He authorized the fastest procedure he believed safe.”

“Your engineer signed that it could destroy the protected layer.”

“She did.”

“Did Orr withdraw his risk declaration?”

“No.”

The answer preserved Jalen’s position and left Ada room to avoid defending it. She had signed Crown data against the seizure, yet she still argued as Crown counsel. Cal distrusted moral conversions that arrived complete. Ada’s divided conduct carried more credibility than a declaration of changed allegiance would have.

He entered the custody stipulation. Bell C-9 would remain in cradle seventeen. Crown could monitor exterior conditions through an isolated feed. Any active query, coupling, or transfer required notice to Callis and the court. The seizure order remained unresolved rather than vacated.

The stipulation disposed of the twenty-three-hour seizure deadline; final title remained on the merits docket.

“Duration?” Ada asked.

“Until merits or material change.”

“That could invite strategic delay.”

“Then do not delay.”

Cal sealed the strip. The order kept the bell where it stood but did not answer who would own the interval.

When they returned to the hearing chamber, the clerk had completed a command-path reconstruction. The pilot shard’s accepted credential used dispatcher class AR-6, the code Iven had named during route-table recall. The path began at a Crown convoy desk, crossed a relay carried by the lead bell, and reached the master console before the turn.

Cal allowed the diagram onto the wall.

“Walk only what the record shows,” he told Osei.

“AR-6 opened the priority channel. The relay checked time, route scope, and mass authority. It issued an acceptance token. The master console then propagated the bearing change.”

“Can AR-6 identify a person?”

“No. It identifies a dispatcher authority class.”

“Can it identify a desk?”

“The header names Eiren Shear Response, Crown convoy control.”

Ada said, “A desk can originate automatic safety traffic.”

Osei enlarged the instruction fields. “This traffic carried an authored route packet.”

“Authored by a person?”

“Authored in the technical sense. The route fields were assembled before transmission rather than generated by the receiving console.”

“Software can assemble them.”

“Yes.”

“Can you identify who selected the route?”

“No.”

The chain reached farther than Crown had admitted and stopped short of an executive hand. Cal could attach action to an operating system, a dispatcher class, and a Crown control desk. He could not yet attach intent to Jalen’s grandfather or any other officer. The distinction frustrated the room because it remained real.

Nia asked leave to compare the packet geometry with C-9’s route layer. Ada objected that any fresh reading would spend coherence. Nia answered that the existing capture from Day One already held the relevant vectors. Osei aligned the two records without querying the bell.

The commanded bearing matched the route Iven had shown to less than one old Crown angle unit.

Ada did not challenge the match. “The telemetry proves motion. It does not prove the purpose of the instruction, the alternatives available to command, or knowledge of Eiren’s survival window.”

Cal wrote the proposition exactly. “That remains Crown’s position after admission?”

“It does.”

“You no longer dispute that an accepted AR-6 packet caused the convoy to turn from rescue intercept toward the Mouth formation?”

“I do not dispute the machine sequence.”

A denial had narrowed into a remedy argument after Iven’s recollection. Now the telemetry narrowed it again. Crown could still claim necessity, incomplete knowledge, or emergency judgment. It could not call the turn a navigation loss without contradicting its own command system.

Cal admitted the command path and the geometric match. He reserved any finding on executive responsibility.

The timing lamp shifted to red as the clerk sealed the order. Cal expected Ada to request adjournment. Instead Nia stood behind the evidence rail.

“Custodian, I need a medical conference under seal.”

Ada closed her notes. "Does it concern evidence condition?"

"It concerns the person whose condition you keep calling evidence."

Cal cleared the public feed and ordered the chamber doors shut. The clerk changed the acoustic baffles to private mode. Nia placed a coil trace beside the telemetry diagram.

At first Cal saw no crisis. Six preservation lines held within narrow tolerances. Then Osei expanded the scale. Each cycle spread farther from center than the one before it.

"When did drift begin?" Cal asked.

"After the route-table reconstruction," Nia said. "It stayed below reporting threshold until last night."

"Iven has remained at rest."

"Respeaking stopped. Phase loss did not."

Ada leaned toward the trace. "Your field model yesterday called present conditions stable."

"Stable against transfer. Not stable indefinitely."

Nia showed them the scored margins. The concealment film had held Iven's layer compressed for decades. Opening the hidden route geometry, nine prior reads, and the recent activation had changed the stress distribution. The cradle coils compensated, but they could not restore the spent state. Even with the vocal body inactive, fine boundaries continued to relax into surrounding glass.

"How much?" Cal asked.

"We cannot convert drift directly into returns without a diagnostic read."

"Which would spend more."

"Yes."

Osei pointed to a projected envelope. "At current spread, we lose access to some high-order associations before the next ordinary hearing date."

"Days?"

"Possibly. The range extends to weeks, but the short edge has stopped improving."

Cal disliked ranges that placed catastrophe at one end and convenience at the other. Institutions treated the favorable edge as permission. Human bodies seldom signed that assumption.

"Could a stronger field stop it?" Ada asked.

"It could compress the outer trace and shear the interior," Nia said. "We might preserve the shape we measure while damaging what it carries."

"Could you move him into a fresh body now?"

"No activation without explanation and consent. I promised him that."

“This is not a request for testimony.”

“A body still costs coherence.”

Ada turned to Cal. “Then delay carries a cost, and acceleration carries another.”

He heard no triumph in her voice. The case had been built around preserving reversible choices. Every available order now consumed one. Wait, and Iven thinned inside the bell. Call him, and the act meant to protect his participation spent the resource participation required. Proceed quickly, and Crown could claim inadequate preparation. Proceed ordinarily, and procedure could decide the merits through decay.

Cal asked Nia what Iven knew.

“That the preservation field requires constant correction. Not that drift has crossed threshold. I will tell him before any activation.”

“Can he receive counsel while awake without broad recall?”

“For a limited interval.”

“Can he choose whether to spend that interval on court?”

“If the body stabilizes and we explain the likely cost.”

Cal looked at the sealed command chain on the wall. It gave the allegation enough support to reach merits. Physical scoring established deliberate concealment. The telemetry placed an accepted order between rescue approach and executed turn. What remained concerned intent, legal consequence, and whether Iven would submit to further examination.

Ada reopened her notes. “Crown needs time to retrieve dispatch protocols and identify surviving custodians.”

“How much?”

“Twenty days.”

Nia shook her head once.

“Ten,” Ada said. “Anything less risks a hearing built around records Callis selected.”

“You may retrieve continuously,” Cal said. “The court can compel the protocol archive today.”

“Executive review will assert privilege.”

“Then assert it on a clock.”

He called the clerk back into the chamber and dictated scheduling findings. Delay presented measurable, nonrenewable harm to a provisional person. A normal briefing interval could erase associations relevant to both testimony and preference. Crown had notice of the underlying event for forty-seven years and notice of the present allegation since C-9 answered on Callis. Callis would disclose every captured trace immediately. Crown would receive equal access to non-destructive records.

Ada stood. “How fast?”

Cal placed the red timing lamp beside the case strip. “Opening statements in ten days. Evidence preparation

begins now and continues as the body permits. Cross-examination remains subject to medical stop.”

“That is not enough preparation.”

“It may be more time than Iven’s record has.”

Nia did not thank him. She opened the body-load schedule and marked the first preparation window in red, leaving the remaining intervals blank for medical review.

Cal signed the fast merits hearing order. The timing lamp took his mark and began counting down before the clerk carried it from the table.

Chapter 12 — Public Return

<!-- POV: Nia Daro -->

<!-- Days 14–15; Callis Archive and concourse -->

Nia reached the Callis concourse with a field regulator under one arm and found her own custody record on every wall.

The central display had replaced transit schedules with nine clipped entries from the Crown return ledger. Someone had stripped names and technical fields, leaving dates, authorization gaps, and loss estimates in severe black type. Beneath them, a public caption read: NINE RETURNS. ONE WITNESS. NO CONSENT RECORDED.

People stood across the floor where passengers usually sorted themselves by ring and pressure district. They did not block the route deliberately. Their bodies simply filled it. Dock workers in orange grip cloth crowded beside court clerks, school groups, freight brokers, and patients waiting for the Arden Coil shuttle. Every face pointed toward the ledger.

Osei walked half a step behind Nia with the regulator's battery case. He saw the display and stopped.

"Keep moving," she said.

A woman near the lift recognized the Callis Archive marks on their sleeves. "Are you bringing him back?"

Nia shifted the regulator against her ribs. Its casing pressed through her work coat. "Clear the service lane."

"Is it true they called him nine times?"

Another voice rose from the crowd. "Let him speak."

The words traveled faster than any explanation. People turned from the wall. Someone began recording. A transit marshal opened a path with both hands but did not touch anyone.

"We have field equipment under live tolerance," Nia said. "Two meters."

The warning created space. Technical danger still carried authority where moral argument did not. She and Osei crossed the first pressure threshold, stepped into the spoke lift, and sealed its door on a dozen raised slates.

Inside the lift, Osei fixed the battery case to a floor loop. His fingers missed the clasp on the first attempt.

Nia watched the indicator count down toward the Archive ring. "How long has it been public?"

"I saw nothing when we left mass ring two."

"That was twenty minutes ago."

"Then less than twenty minutes."

"You recognized the format."

"So did you."

The lift moved outward. Gravity gathered gradually under Nia's boots, adding weight to the regulator and to the question she had not yet asked. The leaked entries came from a sealed ledger Cal had received with the standing case. Nia had seen a controlled copy after the nine heat blooms established destructive reads. Osei had helped her compare those dates with C-9's thermal map. Ada had received access as Crown counsel. Court clerks had handled the filing. Any of them could have released it.

Osei kept his eyes on the battery seal.

At Archive reception, the situation had already become procedural. Red privacy bands crossed every internal screen. A duty officer held staff at their stations while the integrity system compared access logs. Public messages struck the external queue faster than it could count them. Most requested the ledger. Thousands requested a live activation.

Nia set the regulator on an inspection table. "Take this to cradle seventeen. Verify phase lock before coupling."

Osei did not reach for it. "You need a second signer."

"I will assign one."

"You assigned me."

"That was before an internal record appeared in the concourse."

His jaw tightened. "You think I leaked it."

"I think your access must be checked like everyone else's."

"So must yours."

"Yes."

Nia called a senior field custodian from the opposite shift and transferred the regulator under lamp. Osei signed the handoff without protest. The custodian took the equipment through the inner pressure door, leaving both of them on the public side of the archive seal.

A court notice arrived before Nia could begin the log review. Cal ordered immediate preservation of access records and prohibited any activation made to answer public demand. Crown filed a parallel request to remove all Callis staff from C-9 custody until the leak source could be identified. Ada's signature did not appear on it. Chair authority did.

The duty officer looked at Nia. "Do we lock individual accounts?"

"Snapshot first. Locking changes state."

"Public queue has crossed sixty thousand."

"Route it to static storage. Do not let volume write over older messages."

"They are sending files now."

"What files?"

"Eiren family records. Names. Work permits. People think the bell can identify them."

Nia felt the old pressure of the probe handle against her fingers, two taps answering from below the service layer. The public had learned that a person remained inside C-9 and immediately begun treating him as a missing-person index. Their grief had grounds. Their method did not.

“No file reaches the bell network,” she said. “Separate text from attachments. Preserve send times.”

The officer began issuing commands.

A second external queue had formed outside the Archive ring. Through the reception glass, Nia saw people arriving on the service walk with hand-painted strips. Some carried the number nine. Others carried Eiren’s old civic mark, a heat-route diagram simplified into three curves. One sign read CALL HIM WHERE WE CAN HEAR.

Osei followed her gaze. “They do not trust a sealed court.”

“They should not need to watch a person spend himself to trust a record.”

“They have been given false records for forty-seven years.”

“That does not create a claim on his body.”

“No.” He spoke too quickly.

Nia turned from the glass. “Integrity room. Now.”

The room contained three chairs, a bare table, and an optical reader with no network link. She inserted her archive key. The system wrote a local copy of every access touching the return ledger, then made her remove the key before it displayed results.

Seven people had opened the sealed ledger after Cal’s filing. Nia’s access appeared at the time of thermal comparison. Osei’s sat beside hers. Ada had opened the file under adversarial review. Two court clerks had processed seals. Cal had read it. A Crown privilege officer had viewed it remotely before objecting to disclosure.

One access carried no name.

It entered through the public-integrity port at 08:14 and extracted only the summary count, dates, and authorization fields. No phase maps, control statements, or identity-bearing data crossed the port. The credential had been burned after use.

Nia enlarged the physical key signature. Archive keys developed tiny timing errors according to thumb pressure and contact wear. The signature showed a delayed final pulse she had seen hundreds of times when Osei signed sample wells with a split cuticle.

He sat opposite her. Both hands rested flat on the table.

“You burned the credential,” she said.

“Yes.”

“You used a public-integrity release designed for immediate hazard reports.”

“Yes.”

“You classified concealment as an active hazard.”

“I classified continued false accounting as harm.”

Nia looked at the extraction manifest. “You released the count.”

“Only the count.”

“Say what you did not release.”

Osei drew a breath. “No signal. No route geometry. No heat map. No control statement. Nothing that can be used to build or imitate a reconstruction. I released dates, prior authorization defects, and cumulative loss flags.”

“Did you release Iven’s name?”

“No. The concourse attached it from the hearing register.”

“Did anyone assist you?”

“No.”

“Did anyone know before you acted?”

“No.”

His answers came with the precision Nia had demanded from him for eighteen months. She had taught him to preserve facts against unfriendly questions. He had used the lesson to make himself easy to charge.

“Why this morning?” she asked.

“Because Crown sought seizure after the scoring map. Because every private disclosure produced another sealed argument. Because the public record still described prior contacts as diagnostic reflections when we had nine destructive reads.”

“The court had the ledger.”

“The court had forty-eight hours and a closed feed.”

“The closed feed protected medical information.”

“It also protected Crown from a number anyone could understand.”

Nia pressed her thumb against the table edge until the joint paled. “Nine activations do not equal nine full returns. You knew that.”

“I released the ledger’s count. The public wrote nine returns.”

“You knew they would.”

“I knew they might.”

“That distinction would not survive one of your own custody reviews.”

Osei looked down at his split cuticle. “No.”

From beyond the integrity room, the concourse feed rose through the reception speakers before someone cut it. For several seconds Nia heard the crowd repeating the same demand: call him, call him, call him. The rhythm turned a legal claim into pressure on a switch.

Osei's face changed when he heard it.

"That is not what I asked for," he said.

"Records do not obey the purpose of release."

"Neither do sealed records."

Nia wanted to suspend him immediately. Procedure offered a sequence she knew by muscle memory: disable access, take his key, appoint an outside examiner, notify license authority. Each step could be justified. Each would also let Crown describe the leak as one impatient technician's misconduct while leaving the underlying nine reads as privileged context.

She removed the optical copy from the reader and sealed it in a clear sleeve.

"Your access ends now," she said.

Osei unclipped his archive key. "Understood."

"Your custody work does not."

He kept the key in his palm. "I do not understand."

"You will work under paired access. No independent records, no public port, no external device. Every action signed by me or another senior custodian."

"You are keeping me on C-9."

"I am keeping the technician who knows its field behavior. I am also preserving the witness against a claim that Callis punished disclosure more quickly than unauthorized destructive reading."

"That sounds like a defense."

"It is not forgiveness."

Nia took his key and sealed it with the integrity copy. "You made a decision about a record that belonged partly to a person who could not object. The fact that you withheld the signal matters. It does not make the rest yours to spend."

Osei nodded once. "Will you report me?"

"I already am."

She opened the room and gave the duty officer the sealed key. She dictated Osei's temporary restrictions into the lamp, then added her own conflict: she remained his supervisor, a potential disciplinary witness, and a participant in the thermal evidence. Cal would have to appoint an independent investigator.

Before she finished, Ada requested a private channel.

Nia accepted from the integrity terminal with the duty officer present.

Ada appeared in a small frame, seated somewhere inside Crown's Callis office. Behind her, staff moved hard copies into cases. "Did Marr release it?"

"You can ask through the investigation."

"The extraction omitted signal fields. That choice looks technical."

"So does opening an inert bell nine times."

Ada let the answer pass. "Jalen wants C-9 moved before the crowd reaches the mass ring."

"Your engineer signed that movement risks collapse."

"He believes public disorder changes the risk balance."

"The concourse does not change glass stability."

"It changes station security. Someone will try to reach the bell."

"Then protect the door."

"Callis marshals are already refusing Crown support because they think we intend seizure."

"You do intend seizure."

Ada looked past the frame, listened to someone Nia could not hear, and muted her side for four seconds. When sound came back, her voice had lowered. "The quiet settlement cannot survive this."

"It did not survive Iven's refusal."

"Private recognition remained possible. Public acknowledgment of the rescue decision, preservation of the bell, controlled restitution talks. That path has closed."

"Because people learned a count?"

"Because the count now sets the scale of any concession. If Crown admits one unauthorized recall, every display will answer with nine. If we contest the wording, we look as if we dispute the burns. If we accept it, the merits hearing becomes public judgment before evidence completes."

Nia watched staff cross behind Ada with sealed cases. "You are still describing harm to Crown."

"I am describing the position from which Crown will react. Jalen has ordered full opposition, including challenge to Iven's standing. I would prefer you understand that before the filing reaches Cal."

"Why tell me?"

"Because sixty thousand requests to call a damaged person can become coercion without anyone signing an order."

On that point, they agreed.

The public queue passed eighty thousand. Nia opened a sample, not to read sentiment but to classify demands. Some people asked for a transcript. Some asked the court to let Iven choose. Many requested an activation at a fixed civic hour so all six habitats could listen. A smaller group offered coherence donations, as if phase state

could transfer from one nervous system to another. Several threatened archive staff. Two threatened Crown offices. One message contained a route diagram to the mass ring.

Nia sent the threats to station security and kept the rest in evidence order. She then drafted a public notice with one operative sentence:

> No public request, audience count, or institutional need authorizes an activation without the signal person's informed preference.

The communications clerk read it. "They will say we are hiding him."

"We are keeping them from summoning him."

"Can we state whether he will appear at the merits hearing?"

"No. That choice has not been made."

"Can we confirm nine returns?"

"Confirm nine recorded activations. Correct the unit."

The clerk revised the notice. Nia required a link to the raw, redacted ledger fields so the correction did not look like denial.

Before release, a marshal carried a paper envelope through the reception lock. An older woman outside had refused to submit it through the public queue because every electronic form required an Eiren civic number. Her envelope held a worn transit work chit, two repair-pay receipts, and a photograph of a man kneeling beside a thermal pipe with his sleeves tied above both elbows.

A note on the back gave his name and occupation: night-shift valve fitter, temporary contract, dayward loop three. The public Eiren registry returned no match.

Osei read over Nia's shoulder. "Family record?"

"Work record."

"He had family if someone kept this."

"That does not tell us his legal residence."

"It tells us he worked there when the loops failed."

Nia examined the chit under a document lamp. Its corner bore Eiren port control, not the civic registry. The entry date fell six weeks before the disaster. No exit stamp appeared. A transient worker could leave without a matched stamp if the outbound office failed to close the permit. During the last thirty-one hours, that office would have had other work.

The woman waited beyond the glass with both hands around the railing. She did not ask them to call Iven. She wanted a name accepted by a form.

Nia opened a new custody category: Eiren registry reconstruction, public submissions, unverified. The archive system warned that no active case authorized it. She attached the Court's preservation notice and limited the category to non-signal documents. Nothing submitted there could reach C-9, the route layer, or a vocal-body

system.

“You are opening an archive outside order,” Osei said.

“I am receiving evidence the public queue was designed to reject.”

“That sounds familiar.”

“It should. Watch the difference.” Nia showed him the access list. Any clerk could view the catalog. No one could publish a name until two independent records placed the person at Eiren during the failure. Submitters retained copies and could withdraw private material. Every exclusion required a written reason.

Osei looked toward the woman. “And if there is only one record because Crown discarded the rest?”

“Then the reconstruction carries uncertainty instead of erasing the person.”

The duty officer signed as second custodian. Nia scanned the work chit, returned every original to its envelope, and sent the woman a receipt through the lock. Within three minutes, fourteen more paper packets appeared at the marshal desk. Some bore civic numbers. Several carried work permits from convoy crews whose names had never belonged to Eiren’s resident rolls.

Nia assigned two clerks to receive without deciding. The count could wait until the records had edges strong enough to survive challenge. For the first time that day, public pressure produced work that did not require touching Iven.

Osei stood two steps behind her under paired-access restriction. He offered no edits.

They released the notice to the concourse displays.

For a minute, the central wall showed the full text. The crowd read in uneven silence. Then comments rose across the lower margin. Some accepted the correction. Others wrote that Callis had replaced one euphemism with another. The largest public petition changed its demand from CALL HIM LIVE to LET HIM CHOOSE IN PUBLIC.

Nia did not find the second wording harmless. A choice made before an audience could still carry the audience’s hand on it.

Cal’s office called as the merits clock crossed thirty-one hours. His clerk requested confirmation that C-9 remained untouched, that Osei’s release excluded signal data, and that Nia could staff the preservation field through a public disturbance. She answered yes to all three. Then the clerk asked whether public pressure affected medical timing.

“It affects the conditions of consent,” Nia said. “Not the glass.”

“We will add that to the sealed conference.”

Outside reception, station marshals extended the service lane with low railings. People yielded without leaving. Food sellers brought insulated containers. Court reporters set up hand slates. Eiren descendants arrived carrying work cards and family registers, not signs. A freight departure posted late because the concourse could no longer clear fast enough.

The gathering had acquired logistics. It would not disperse after one notice.

Osei came to stand at Nia's left, far enough from the terminal to honor his restriction. "You should take me off the team."

"I told you the conditions."

"Crown will use me against the archive."

"They will use your dismissal as proof we agree the ledger should have remained hidden."

"That is strategy."

"It is also true." Nia handed him a paper checklist for the next field watch. "Paired access. You do not touch a control alone."

He took the sheet. "Understood."

Across the glass, the Callis concourse display shifted from the return ledger to Cal's scheduling order. FAST MERITS HEARING. PUBLIC FEED SUBJECT TO MEDICAL LIMITS. The words traveled through the crowd as people raised their slates.

Nia could no longer see the floor between them.

Behind her, Osei began reading the preservation checklist aloud for his second signer. Ahead, the station settled around a hearing no private settlement could contain.

Chapter 13 — Person for the Duration

<!-- POV: Cal Orsen -->

<!-- Day 16; Continuance Court, Callis -->

Cal cut the phrase **while actively coherent** from the draft order and the gap closed around his knife.

The strip lay on a black drafting mat beneath the chamber timing lamp. Without those three words, the operative sentence granted Iven Ko provisional personhood from the moment of his Novel Preference finding until final disposition. With them, personhood existed only during embodiment. Every breath taken by the vocal body carried rights. Every medically necessary rest returned the same human pattern to disputed property.

Cal placed the words back into the sentence.

Sena Pell watched from the opposite side of the drafting table. She had arrived from the multi-polity circuit less than an hour earlier, still wearing the soft-soled travel shoes required in Callis's axial chambers. Her judicial coat remained folded over one arm.

"You have moved that phrase four times," she said.

"Five."

"Has repetition improved the statute?"

"No."

"Then stop asking the paper to change it."

Cal sealed the draft in its current form and followed her into the hearing chamber.

The public gallery sat empty under medical restriction. A live feed carried the proceeding to the Callis concourse with a fixed delay that allowed the clerk to remove protected body data. Even so, sound from the gathering reached the court through structural vibration. Thousands of feet in the station's central ring made a faint irregular pressure against the handrail.

Ada Neme occupied Crown's table alone. Jalen Orr had removed her operations title from the electronic appearance line but had not replaced her as counsel. Nia Daro sat at the medical rail with three field summaries and no view into the vocal-body room. Iven remained at rest in bell C-9. No one had asked him to wake for a hearing about whether sleep ended his rights.

Sena took the central chair. Cal sat one level below as appellate custodian and author of the temporary order under review.

The clerk called the matter.

Ada rose. "Crown accepts the Novel Preference finding for the activation in which it occurred. We contest extension beyond the text of the Continuance Articles."

Sena said, "State the boundary you propose."

“Standing in continuance attaches to an actively coherent signal person. It does not convert every dormant phase record into a perpetual rights holder.”

“Does Crown consider Iven Ko a person now?”

Ada looked toward the empty medical rail beside Nia. “He is not now embodied.”

“That does not answer.”

“It answers under the statute.”

Sena let the silence remain until Ada added, “Crown considers him a person during valid active coherence.”

Cal wrote the sentence on a case strip. Its grammar performed the work Crown wanted. *Person* occupied a temporary condition, like pressurized or awake.

Nia received permission to give technical evidence from her seat. She explained that rest did not create a copy or a different source. The same nonrenewable phase structure remained in C-9 while the vocal body deactivated. Respeaking translated a portion into tissue and spent coherence. Rest reduced current expenditure but did not stop boundary drift.

Ada asked, “Can the phase layer form a new preference while no body operates?”

“No.”

“Can it receive legal advice?”

“No.”

“Can it understand an order?”

“Not in any way we can test without reconstruction.”

“Can it suffer pain?”

“Not as an embodied nervous system.”

“Then what present capacity grounds personhood during rest?”

Nia’s fingers settled on the edge of her field summary. “Continuity.”

“That is a conclusion.”

“It is a measurement. The resting pattern and the next embodied state draw from one diminishing structure. Damage during rest changes who can appear later.”

Ada turned to Sena. “Continuity of material does not settle continuity of legal person. A living citizen remains metabolically active during sleep. A phase record does not.”

Cal interrupted before analogy replaced the statute. “The Court granted standing because Iven formed a novel preference. Does Crown claim that finding becomes false when the body rests?”

“No. It becomes inoperative outside the condition the Articles recognize.”

“Would Crown permit destructive analysis during that interval?”

“The Compulsory Evidence Clause applies to non-person property, subject to preservation orders.”

The answer tightened every face in the room. Ada had not invented the consequence. She had stated it because concealment would make later litigation worse.

Sena leaned toward her microphone. “Under Crown’s reading, the Court must schedule a person into absence before exercising compulsory access.”

“Only where analysis can occur without defeating a valid preservation order.”

“And if analysis prevents the person from returning?”

“Then preservation principles should bar it.”

“Should. Not personhood.”

“Under present law, yes.”

Cal watched the feed indicator blink as the delayed broadcast carried that admission toward the concourse. Public anger would treat it as monstrous. Judicial discomfort did not make the reading implausible. The Articles had been drafted for emergency records that either passed the test during examination or returned to archive inventory. No drafter had built a category for a mind whose legal existence alternated with a medical switch.

Sena called Cal to explain his order.

He placed the operative strips on the display. His temporary ruling had granted standing from Iven’s request for a window showing Callis until the court could review duration. It blocked the Compulsory Evidence Clause, required informed consent for activation, and preserved C-9 in place.

“Textual basis?” Sena asked.

“The Articles say a remnant that forms a novel preference ‘shall receive standing in continuance for the duration of active coherence.’”

“What does duration modify?”

“Crown says standing. I read it as the period in which the Court must determine and protect the preference.”

“Why?”

“Because active coherence has no stable clock. A person may be embodied, resting, or distributed between recoverable phase bands during one return. If rights follow only audible speech, custodians gain power to end those rights by deactivation.”

Ada said, “Custodians already control medical activation under safety law.”

“Medical control does not usually change the patient into property.”

Sena raised a hand before Ada replied. “Custodian Orsen, are you asking us to recognize indefinite personhood in every remnant that once passed the Novel Preference Test?”

“No.”

“Where does it end?”

“When no recoverable coherence remains, or when a valid preference authorizes disposition, or when adjudication resolves the protected interests.”

“Those boundaries do not appear in the Articles.”

“They become necessary once the law encounters a person damaged by the law’s own process.”

Sena’s expression did not change. “Necessity can produce narrow orders. It can also produce doctrine no one knows how to contain.”

The court recessed for twenty minutes.

In the order room, Sena removed her judicial coat and hung it from a rail. Cal stood at the wall of case strips while she read Iven’s preference findings again. The request for a real Callis window had no encoded precedent. His later demand for cost disclosure showed continuing agency. Neither finding answered whether agency retained legal force while it could not act.

“You want to repair the statute,” Sena said.

“I want to prevent a switch from deciding status.”

“Those may amount to the same project.”

“Not today.”

She tapped the draft with one blunt fingernail. “Your first version grants personhood until all coherence ends. Your second grants it through litigation. Your third leaves duration undefined. Each one follows sympathy farther than text.”

“Not sympathy.”

“You believe this witness suffered an institutional wrong. So do I. That belief makes sympathy more dangerous, not less.”

Cal looked at her. “Should we ignore the wrong?”

“We should refuse to build permanence from it before adversarial argument.” Sena returned the strip to the wall. “A hard case does not excuse soft boundaries.”

The phrase carried none of the comfort of a maxim. Sena had spent decades watching emergency courts turn compelling facts into authorities that later reached people no one had imagined. Cal knew the caution. He had used it himself during the Pellin shortage when petitioners asked him to convert temporary ration priority into inherited entitlement.

“What can we protect without deciding permanence?” he asked.

“Actions already taken by a recognized person.”

“His preference to receive cost information.”

“Yes.”

“His selection of counsel.”

“If validly made.”

“He requested independent counsel during the standing hearing.”

“Then appoint counsel.”

“His medical choices while resting?”

Sena considered. “Choices made while active can direct immediate care through the same return. Do not pretend that answers future recalls.”

“There is no technical line between immediate care and deciding whether to wake him tomorrow.”

“Then write the legal line around what this record supports. Field adjustment, body stabilization, stopping an activation already begun. Future reconstruction remains open.”

Cal felt the contradiction sharpen. Rights would cover the medicine needed once Iven appeared, but not the decision that made him appear. Counsel could object in the interval, yet counsel would hold no durable instruction beyond the current return. The law protected a person from pain after the custodian had already crossed the boundary that restored personhood.

“That leaves the central harm intact,” he said.

“It leaves the central question for full argument.”

“Delay consumes him.”

“Then hear it quickly. Do not solve urgency by pretending you have solved doctrine.”

A clerk knocked and entered with a sealed medical message. During recess, C-9’s preservation field had required another correction. Nia reported no activation and no measurable event loss, but the drift envelope had widened at its upper edge.

Sena read the message. “How much time?”

“No one can answer without a destructive diagnostic.”

“Of course.” She returned it. “Every fact in this case charges admission.”

They went back to court.

Cal proposed a narrower order. Crown objected to every clause that carried authority through rest. Nia objected to any phrase equating rest with absence. Sena required each side to state practical consequences instead of preferred labels.

Under the proposal, Iven would receive independent continuance counsel immediately. Counsel could access the full sealed record, attend technical work, challenge any activation request, and speak during periods when Iven rested. Counsel could not consent to a new activation unless Iven had given a specific instruction during valid coherence.

Immediate medical choices would belong to Iven while embodied. Those choices could continue through temporary rest within the same clinical episode: field intensity, body support, pain control, who could observe, and when an activation already in progress must stop. The archive could make emergency adjustments needed to prevent unchosen loss, subject to later review.

Future recalls remained outside that authority. Existing law offered no settled method for a preference to govern after the active interval ended. The Court would not infer consent from prior cooperation, counsel's judgment, public demand, or evidentiary need.

Ada read the final clause twice. "Crown can accept no inferred consent. We object to counsel blocking an application before active standing resumes."

"Counsel may object," Sena said. "The Court decides whether any application may proceed."

"On whose rights?"

"On the basis of preservation and the prior valid standing finding."

"That avoids the status question."

"It postpones it without handing you the bell."

Nia asked permission to speak outside her technical role. Sena denied it, then asked what technical consequence remained unaddressed.

"If no person exists during rest," Nia said, "who owns the risk of waiting?"

Sena's eyes narrowed slightly. "That sounds legal."

"The field requires choices. Lower correction risks diffusion. Higher correction risks shear. Neutral settings do not exist."

"Who chooses now?"

"I do under the preservation order."

"Would counsel need notice?"

"Yes."

"Would Iven's prior tolerance choices guide you?"

"If he has made them with adequate information."

"Then add them to immediate medical authority."

The clerk revised the clause. Nia sat down, dissatisfied but no longer excluded from the mechanism.

Sena did not release her. "Give us an actual sequence, Resonantist. No abstractions."

Nia brought up the clinical record from Iven's last waking. The display omitted memory content and showed only body condition, field load, and recorded choices. Seven minutes after stabilization, his breathing had become shallow. Nia offered glucose, reduced light, or early deactivation. He chose glucose because he wanted enough time to ask about process cost. Twelve minutes later, he asked for the real Callis window instead of an

Eiren simulation. Near the end, he agreed to rest after receiving a promise that no later activation would occur without explanation.

“Which choices continue now?” Sena asked.

Ada answered first. “The promise binds the custodian as a condition of any future consent discussion. It does not itself create standing during dormancy.”

Nia said, “His light tolerance and stabilization limits guide the next body. The request for a Callis window also remains in the room unless he changes it.”

“Would you treat the glucose choice as permanent?”

“No. The next body may be hungry differently.”

“Would you treat his agreement to rest as permission to activate later?”

“No.”

“Why does one instruction carry and another stop?”

Nia pointed to the trace. “Some choices govern a procedure already underway. Rest completes that procedure. A later respeaking begins another destructive procedure.”

Cal saw the boundary Sena had demanded. It came from action rather than metaphysics: continuation of an existing clinical episode versus initiation of a new one. The distinction would not answer every case. It could keep this order from pretending to answer future access.

Ada tested it. “Suppose the field destabilizes tonight. Nia can increase correction without waking him?”

“If delay risks unchosen loss, yes,” Cal said.

“Suppose increasing correction might preserve testimony while reducing bodily comfort at the next activation.”

“Counsel receives notice. The court resolves it if time permits. In emergency, Nia preserves the widest future choice, not the most evidence.”

“Suppose no adjustment can prevent loss without a brief reconstruction.”

No one answered immediately.

The public feed delay light moved once around its frame. Somewhere beyond the chamber, thousands of viewers waited to hear whether necessity could make a body without its owner’s consent.

Sena said, “This order does not authorize reconstruction as medical preservation.”

Ada kept her eyes on Cal. “Even if the alternative destroys all remaining coherence?”

“Especially then,” Nia said. “We cannot preserve a person by spending the person without permission.”

Sena turned to her. “That conclusion belongs to the question we have reserved.”

“It belongs to my hands if the alarm sounds tonight.”

Cal requested leave to add an emergency clause. He drafted it at the table while both sides watched. Technical custodians could take non-destructive action to maintain existing phase conditions. No emergency label could authorize embodiment, broad semantic access, or a diagnostic read that materially spent coherence. If all non-destructive options failed, the custodian had to seek the Court and appointed counsel, even when delay carried risk.

Ada objected that the clause might force preventable loss. Nia answered that an involuntary activation could cause the same loss while violating the preference conditions already on record. Sena narrowed the language to C-9 and the present case. Then she adopted it.

The independent advocate, still waiting beyond the rail, sent one written question through the clerk: could counsel demand deactivation during a future clinical episode if Iven became unable to speak? Nia said the body's recorded stop thresholds already triggered automatic rest. Counsel could enforce those thresholds and ask for stricter ones while Iven remained able to choose. Counsel could not substitute a broader preference after capacity failed.

Cal added that limitation. The order now described hands, instruments, and decisions rather than claiming an answer about permanent identity. It still left the central gap exposed.

Cal asked how the Court would describe status in the caption. Ada proposed "conditional standing." The clerk proposed "continuing preservation after standing." Both phrases concealed the human consequence beneath a procedure.

Sena dictated the wording herself.

> Iven Ko shall be recognized as a person for the duration of active coherence. Actions and immediate medical choices validly made during that coherence remain operative through medically necessary rest within the same return. No ruling is made today regarding authority over future recalls.

The sentence entered the public feed.

Noise reached them through the station structure seconds later, a broad vibration from the Callis concourse. Cal could not tell whether it carried approval or anger. The same words gave Iven a lawyer and preserved the category Crown had used to analyze him.

Ada requested clarification. "Does personhood end at deactivation?"

"For purposes not preserved by this order, the statute does not recognize active standing," Sena said.

"Then Crown's position prevailed."

"No. Your Compulsory Evidence application remains barred pending merits."

"Under preservation rather than personhood."

"Under this Court's authority to prevent an irreversible act before it decides who may authorize it."

Ada sat. She had obtained the narrow duration language and lost immediate access.

Cal entered the independent counsel appointment. The advocate had been waiting in a side room with no access to C-9 until the ruling. A court officer brought them in, placed a sealed case copy in their hands, and read the restrictions aloud. Counsel could receive Iven's instructions at his next medically approved activation. Until

then, they could refuse nothing on his behalf permanently, but they could force every request into open review.

Nia handed counsel the current field summary. “Read the drift note before anything else.”

“Not the testimony plan?”

“The body has to arrive before it can give testimony.”

Counsel opened the field summary first.

Sena rose after the clerk sealed the order. As she passed Cal’s lower chair, she stopped long enough to speak without the microphones carrying it.

“You are going to ask this court for more,” she said.

“Yes.”

“Then bring a boundary, not only a wound.”

She left through the judges’ lock.

Cal remained until the chamber cleared. On the drafting table, the final order occupied two physical strips. One named Iven a person during active coherence. The second carried counsel, medical authority, and preservation through rest. A blank connector lay between them where the clerk had expected a cross-reference.

He did not fill it. Existing law supplied no words for the interval.

The new advocate carried the sealed case toward the Archive ring. Nia followed with the field summary. Cal watched both pass beneath the red timing lamp as it counted down to merits, bearing powers that reached Iven’s next waking but stopped at the choice to wake him again.

Interlude II: Eighteen Thousand Five Hundred Six

<!-- Form: Eiren registry reconstruction, Revision 4 -->

<!-- Compiled from civic, port, payroll, medical, and family records -->

CALLIS ARCHIVE

EIREN REGISTRY RECONSTRUCTION

PUBLIC REVISION MEMORANDUM 4

Purpose of revision

This memorandum corrects the number of persons present at Eiren Reach during the final thermal failure. Earlier public records counted registered residents only. Port-control fragments, contractor payrolls, convoy berthing sheets, family submissions, and recovered clinic rosters establish an additional transient population.

No entry below derives from a conscious phase record. No clerk queried choir bell C-9. The reconstruction proceeds through ordinary documents so that one damaged witness does not carry the burden of naming a colony.

Prior certified figure: 18,204 registered residents.

Restored category: 312 transients present without completed civic registration.

Corrected figure: 18,516 persons lost.

The prior figure remains accurate as a resident subtotal. It may not be used as the total dead.

I. Reconstruction rules

1. A name enters the confirmed register when two independent records place that person at Eiren during the thirty-one-hour failure window.
2. A damaged name may remain partially printed. Clerks must not invent missing letters from frequency, family resemblance, occupation, or expected language.
3. Occupation does not substitute for identity. “Valve fitter, unknown” remains a record of presence but not a recovered name.
4. Departure requires affirmative evidence. An open work permit without an exit stamp does not prove continued presence by itself.
5. Records created after the disaster may corroborate but cannot independently confirm. Family memory supplies search terms, not automatic certification.
6. Resident and transient categories describe registry status. They do not grade attachment, responsibility, or loss.

Clerk annotation, Revision 2: The phrase *unregistered worker* caused repeated error. Many restored persons held valid port and payroll records. They lacked Eiren civic registration because their contracts were temporary, their applications remained pending, or their employers had failed to file. Revision 3 replaced the phrase with *transient*.

Review annotation, Revision 3: Temporary status did not mean temporary presence at the moment of death.

II. Resident file fragments

E-000214 | Nera Vos | dayward mirror scheduler

Civic ledger confirms residence in cavern district four. Shift exchange records show Vos transferring two collector fields to manual control during the first hour of thermal instability. Final checksum lacks the closing six characters. No reconstruction attempted beyond the surviving text.

E-001903 | Pel Anik | school pressure inspector

Education payroll and district maintenance sheets agree. A family submission included three inspection tags bearing Anik's hand mark. The tags establish ordinary work, not location during the last hour. Confirmation rests on payroll continuity plus an emergency shelter roster.

E-004771 | Sio Maren | food-culture technician

Clinic supply record identifies Maren by civic number after a nutrient-vat burn eleven days before failure. The public disaster index had rendered the occupation as "culture stock." Revision 4 restores the person separately from the inventory.

E-008092 | Jo Pellat | tram brake tender

Two route sheets preserve the name. A third carries only *Jo P*. No clerk may merge that fragment with Pellat's file unless the vehicle number also agrees. Vehicle agreement confirmed in Revision 3.

E-011440 | [checksum break] Afi | thermal-loop apprentice

First name survives. Family name does not. Apprenticeship roll, tool issue, and shelter assignment place Afi at Eiren. Public display shall preserve the break: Afi [family name unrecovered].

E-015608 | Ralen Ti | sanitation diver

Civic registration confirms residence. Pump-duty logs continue through the twenty-sixth hour of failure. Later copies changed *diver* to *driver*. The original pressure certification resolves the occupation.

E-017999 | Meis Orra | night clinic porter

Hospital staffing and meal allotment agree. A Crown salvage summary listed Orra under movable medical equipment because the personnel column slipped one field during conversion. Revision 4 removes that classification.

Resident reconciliation result: 18,204 confirmed. No numerical change from the final civic subtotal. Changes in Revision 4 affect names, occupations, damaged fields, and the separation of persons from inventory lines.

III. Transient source set

Port control preserved four partial arrival rolls. The rolls listed 527 open entries during the quarter containing the disaster. Departure ledgers closed 189 of them before the thermal event. Independent records showed twenty-six additional people leaving on unsynchronized freight movements. The remaining candidates required individual review.

Contractor payrolls supplied presence marks for thermal crews, tunnel surveyors, medical installers, food-culture auditors, and convoy support staff. Berthing sheets added short-route pilots whose employers maintained no Eiren payroll. Clinic rosters identified dependents and injured travelers waiting for onward passage.

Family submissions opened 143 candidate files. Seventy-nine later matched port or payroll records. Forty-one described registered residents already counted. Eleven lacked any independent record and remain in the unresolved appendix. Twelve concerned people who had departed before failure.

No unresolved appendix entry contributes to the corrected total.

IV. Restored transient fragments

T-0001 | Haro Sen | night-shift valve fitter

Port work chit and dayward loop payroll agree. Arrival occurred six weeks before failure. No departure appears. A family photograph identifies the worksite but does not supply confirmation; the two institutional records do.

T-0027 | Kemi Ar | medical sterilizer installer

Contractor invoice abbreviates the name. Arden Coil certification preserves the full form. Clinic bed records place Ar under observation after solvent exposure during the failure window.

T-0068 | Daro Venn | freight galley worker

Berthing list and meal-credit ledger agree. The shared surname does not establish relation to any present Callis custodian. No kinship inference entered.

T-0104 | [checksum break] M | tunnel survey assistant

Survey payment survives under employee number. Port entry preserves only the first letter of the personal field. Confirmation attaches to the employee number and biometric work seal. Public form reads: M [name unrecovered], tunnel survey assistant.

T-0159 | Ilya Sorn | short-route pilot

Convoy berth assignment and fuel-account signature place Sorn on the surface apron. An automated departure estimate appeared in an old Crown summary. No launch record, pressure-cycle entry, or mass change supports it. The estimate cannot close the file.

T-0216 | Sera Val | food-culture auditor

Employer travel order planned a three-day visit. The disaster began on the second day. Eiren lodging and emergency ration records confirm continued presence.

T-0274 | Niko Tath | dependent, age nine

Clinic intake and guardian permit agree. Contractor payroll omitted dependents by design. Revision 2 excluded Tath. Revision 3 restored the entry after the guardian permit checksum matched port control.

T-0312 | Olan Re | mass-cradle cleaner

Two employers denied active contract. A shift token recovered from Callis family submissions matched Eiren cradle seventeen's service log. Port control confirms entry. The final work mark occurred eleven hours before lattice failure.

Transient reconciliation result: 312 confirmed persons.

V. Count correction notice

The Eiren registry previously closed at 18,204 because the civic ledger counted residents and excluded open port files. That closure propagated into disaster education, insurance settlement, Crown salvage records, and Callis's public index.

Revision 4 restores 312 transients through record-by-record corroboration. Arithmetic now reads:

18,204 residents + 312 transients = 18,516 persons lost.

Clerks shall not describe the additional 312 as included within the 18,204. Clerks shall not replace individual entries with the correction figure. The number supports reconciliation; names and preserved fragments support the register.

VI. Publication instruction

Display confirmed names in registry order, not by social rank, occupation, age, evidentiary completeness, or dramatic interest. Keep checksum breaks visible. Link every correction to its source class and reviewing clerk. Preserve unresolved files without adding them to the total.

The heading on future certified copies shall read:

> EIREN REACH: 18,516 PERSONS LOST

Below that heading, the first entry begins with Nera Vos at the dayward mirrors. The final confirmed transient entry ends with Olan Re's shift token. Between them, the Eiren registry retains each recoverable name, each honest break, and each occupation only once.

Chapter 14 — Ninety Days of Heat

<!-- POV: Ada Neme -->

<!-- Days 17–20; Callis Court and Crown operations link -->

Ada had four habitat reserve curves open when Latchkey's pump architect refused her question.

"I asked how long you can preserve heat exchange after catalyst interruption," Ada said.

Ema Orsen looked back through the remote engineering link. Transmission compression had flattened the color from her work coat, but it could not conceal the wet line at her collar or the grease pressed into one cheek. Machinery moved behind the acoustic baffle at her shoulder. Every fourteen seconds, the image trembled with the start of a large pump.

"No," Ema said. "You asked how long we can preserve an acceptable heat-exchange rate. Define acceptable."

The evidence room held Ada, two Crown analysts, Cal Orsen, and a court recorder whose timing lamp marked every pause. Cal had not spoken since his daughter appeared on the wall. He sat beyond the counsel rail with his hands folded around a paper schedule. Ada knew enough about estrangement not to mistake his stillness for neutrality.

"An internal temperature compatible with continued habitation," Ada said.

"For whom?" Ema reached out of frame. A diagram replaced half her face: six circulation trunks, each divided into inhabited and industrial loops. "If we shed the foundry and agricultural bays, we preserve the residential core longer. Then food production ends. If we preserve agriculture, two lower decks cross the mold threshold on day eleven. Medical storage fails earlier because its exchangers require a tighter gradient."

"I need the terminal bound."

"You need a number that makes your choice look imposed by physics."

The Crown analyst nearest Ada shifted in his chair. His slate carried the reserve table already filed with the Court: Latchkey, Morcant, Vesper Fold, Arden Coil, Sable, Near Orison. Six habitats. A combined population of 2.3 million. Four curves crossed their supply line before ninety days. Numbers should have disciplined the hearing. Instead, each question exposed another decision hidden inside the measure.

Ada kept her voice level. "If Meridian Mouth service stops in full on the present date, when does Latchkey first lose a critical system?"

"Day thirty-eight under rationing we have not approved."

"Which system?"

"Lower-deck potable reclamation."

"Can you bypass it?"

"For nine days, if no heat-sink jacket cracks and if the clinic gives up one sterile loop."

"After that?"

“People begin leaving a deck that has nowhere to receive them.”

The recorder’s lamp advanced. Ada let the answer remain whole. A useful risk record did not soften a consequence, but neither did it pretend one consequence settled every other question.

Cal raised his eyes. “Architect Orsen, does Crown’s filed reserve table overstate Latchkey’s resilience?”

“It compresses different failures into one line. The catalyst quantity looks accurate within our reporting error.”

“Does the table understate it?”

“No.”

“Then four habitats have under ninety days of reserve?”

“Four have less than ninety days before ordinary replenishment becomes impossible. They do not all fail on day ninety. They fail by system, by deck, and by the choices made before then.”

Ada watched Cal receive the distinction without claiming it. He had spent years converting shortages into rulings. Ema had spent those years keeping pumps alive after rulings reached machinery. Whatever stood between them had learned to speak through exact units.

A court clerk opened the line for questions from provisional counsel. Cal asked only whether Latchkey had received any nonpublic Crown schedule showing an alternate service cadence. Ema said no. The word arrived without hesitation.

Ada’s analysts did not look at her. They had prepared the witness and knew the approved answer because there was no alternate schedule in the packet.

“Architect Orsen,” Ada said, “have you been asked by your father or any Callis officer to minimize the consequences of interruption?”

Ema’s expression changed by less than a breath. “No.”

“Have I asked you to exaggerate them?”

“You asked me for survivable bounds.”

“Did I direct your answer?”

“No.”

“Then give the Court the most favorable honest case.”

For the first time, Ema glanced toward something beyond her screen. Perhaps another engineer. Perhaps a pump alarm. “A short interruption with a guaranteed restart can be carried. We would empty industrial storage, stop new fabrication, and cut transit heat. A prolonged interruption without a credible restart date causes cascading failures that stores alone cannot repair.”

“How prolonged?”

“That depends on what remains in motion elsewhere. Anyone who gives you a single duration without a service plan offers false reassurance.”

Ada called the reserve worksheet onto the shared wall. "Run day thirty-eight."

Ema studied the court copy. "Your worksheet assumes we isolate the lower decks at a fixed hour."

"Change the assumption."

"To what?"

"The sequence you would use."

A pump started behind Ema. Compression tore the image into blocks, then restored it with her hand braced against the console. "First we lower habitat spin by four percent. That cuts circulation head and buys catalyst, but anyone with unstable bone repair needs transfer inward. Next we stop Foundry Two. Its coolant enters the residential reserve after six hours, provided the salts remain uncontaminated. On day nineteen we choose between seed storage and clinic sterilization. Your curve treats those as equal load."

"They draw the same amount."

"They do not carry the same future."

The Crown table allowed Ada to select either branch. She chose seed storage. The clinic line crossed its lower limit on day twenty-six. She reset and preserved the clinic. Stored germination stock began warming on day twenty-eight.

"How much seed becomes unusable?" Cal asked.

"Between twelve and forty percent. We cannot know without opening the vaults, and opening them spends cold."

Ada changed the restart field from guaranteed to uncertain. Red bands widened across the residential trunks. The worksheet had always contained uncertainty, but the filed summary displayed only median reserve. She had approved that choice because courts understood one line faster than a field of possible failures.

"Show the Court what happens if service returns on day sixty," she said.

Ema did not touch her controls. "Which service?"

"One freight window at current rated mass."

"Cargo?"

"Catalyst first."

"What happens to the patients transferred during spin reduction?"

"They remain on Latchkey."

"Then you have specified an impossible case. We cannot keep all of them through day sixty under reduced circulation."

Cal leaned toward the wall. "How many require movement?"

"Current register gives one hundred twelve. That count changes with every surgery."

Ada entered patient transport ahead of catalyst. The model pushed catalyst delivery nine days later and moved potable reclamation below safe output. She reduced freight packaging. The mass saved did not recover enough margin.

"Try a shared window with Arden Coil," Ema said.

"Crown does not schedule shared clinical and catalyst loads through an unstable corridor."

"You asked for the sequence I would use."

Ada built it. Arden's membranes occupied the thermal envelope left by the patient carriers. Catalyst canisters filled the remaining mass to tolerance. The Latchkey curve survived to day seventy-three, then narrowed into another uncertain band.

One analyst whispered, "That violates three handling standards."

Ema heard him. "Standards written for ordinary transit. If you want an emergency answer, stop marking ordinary practice as a physical limit."

Ada saved the run into the evidence record. "Does this prove Latchkey can survive a full interruption?"

"No. It proves our survival depends on coordination your filed table does not describe."

"Does it make an immediate shutdown safe?"

"No."

"Does any honest forecast make it safe?"

"Not one I have seen."

The phrase landed where Ada intended and cut more widely than she wanted. Crown could prove danger. It could not use Ema to prove that only Crown's preferred schedule could contain it. Worse for schedule exclusivity, the improvised run showed that shared control could stretch a failing reserve farther than six isolated projections admitted.

After the engineering link closed, the wall held six reserve curves and a small gray square where Ema's image had been. Cal stayed seated while the recorder sealed the session copy.

"You knew she would not provide the terminal number," he said.

"I knew she would not provide a dishonest one."

"You called her because she would contradict your own table."

"She corrected its interpretation. The quantities remain uncontested."

His thumb pressed the paper schedule flat. "You wanted the risk admitted by a witness I could not dismiss as Crown."

"I wanted the Court to hear from someone who operates a pump."

"You also wanted me to hear my daughter describe decks she cannot save."

Ada closed the Morcant curve before answering. "I did not choose your relationship."

"No. You chose its evidentiary use."

The analysts had begun packing their slates. Both moved with excessive care. Ada dismissed them, waited for the pressure door to close, and faced Cal across the empty evidence room.

"If I had called another architect, would the reserve become less real?"

"No."

"Would you have trusted the estimate as much?"

His refusal to answer supplied its own quantity.

Ada gathered the filed sheets into order. "A full shutdown does not punish Crown alone. Morcant's catalytic stores support eighteen days of full clinical demand after industrial diversion. Arden Coil can manufacture substitute membranes but lacks the Mouth windows to move them. Vesper Fold can feed itself for a season and cannot replace its heat-sink cores. These dependencies do not excuse what happened at Eiren. They limit which remedy remains lawful now."

Cal stood. In the axial chambers his movement carried him farther than intended, and his hand closed around the rail before his shoulder reached the acoustic baffle. "You have stopped denying the old choice."

"There is no useful denial left."

"Then stop presenting present dependence as though it arrived without authors."

He left with the court copy. Ada remained beside the blank witness square until the timing lamp signaled that the room had reverted to counsel access.

Present dependence had authors. Some had died. Some chaired Crown. Some had spent twelve years maintaining a schedule because every month of successful operation made change more dangerous. Ada had defended that maintenance. She could name the lives attached to it and still recognize the convenience of calling a designed trap an inherited one.

Her slate chimed with an internal priority request from Jalen Orr.

Jalen appeared from Crown's schedule chamber rather than his office. Three nested route arcs glowed on the wall behind him, each line broken into service windows and thermal recovery intervals. Operators moved across the lower floor. None came close enough to enter the channel.

"You let Orsen qualify the reserve table," he said.

"Ema Orsen qualified it. The court admitted the underlying quantities."

"You gave Cal a public distinction between interruption and service design."

"He already understands that distinction."

"Understanding does not require us to put it in the record."

Ada looked at the inner arc. Two Mouth windows had moved since morning, both minor freight corrections. "The record would have failed an adversarial engineering review without her testimony."

"Then use an engineer who knows which fact needs defending."

"She defended the fact."

Jalen leaned toward his camera. At sixty-eight, he had learned to make quiet attention feel like an escalation. "Four habitats face reserve exhaustion inside ninety days. That statement needs no ornament."

"It needs failure sequences. Otherwise opposing counsel will show one store lasting ninety-one days and call the entire projection inflated."

"You sound eager to help them."

"I am preserving the part of our argument that survives examination."

A route operator crossed behind him with a sealed wafer. Jalen waited until the operator passed. "The Court confirmed personhood for the duration. It did not acquire authority over the Mouth schedule. Keep remedy outside the standing case."

"The merits hearing will join them whether we approve or not."

"Then we make the joining look dangerous."

"It is dangerous."

His gaze narrowed. "You have become difficult to reassure."

"I was not hired for reassurance."

Jalen ended the link without dismissal. The six curves returned to Ada's wall. At the bottom of each filed chart, a Crown model identifier linked reserve consumption to schedule assumptions. Ada had reviewed those identifiers for twelve years. This set began with MSX, the current exclusivity model, followed by habitat and revision number.

Latchkey's identifier did not.

The difference occupied two characters near the line's checksum: MX-ALT/4. Someone had copied a reserve output from another model family into the court table, then normalized its heading to the approved schedule. Ema's testimony had forced Ada to inspect the failure layers. Without that inspection, the altered identifier would have remained beneath a chart everyone considered settled.

Ada touched the line. Counsel access permitted her to inspect provenance, not to open Crown operational systems from a court terminal. The model reference offered only an origin date, a schedule division, and a retention class marked *superseded before executive review*.

Before executive review. Not rejected. Not unsafe. A schedule model had existed long enough to generate habitat reserves and had then disappeared before anyone with decision authority could be said to know it.

She copied the retention string to paper. Digital notes from the evidence room synchronized with Crown compliance. Paper did not, which explained why Callis still kept it.

The model family code bothered her more than the concealment marker. Crown used ALT for changes inside an exclusive schedule: bell substitution, delayed freight, temporary load shedding. No alternative could relinquish exclusivity without a different legal class and executive approval. Yet MX referred to Mouth transition architecture, a category Ada had encountered only twice, both times during acquisitions that changed who controlled a bell.

Someone had modeled a slower transition and hidden it beneath an ordinary alternate-run label.

She did not have the model. She had an index entry pointing toward its burial.

Ada folded the paper once and slid it beneath the court schedule. The act felt theatrical, so she unfolded it and wrote the identifier into the margin of Ema's admitted diagram instead. Evidence rooms scanned margins at closure, but counsel working copies left under seal. She needed a path that neither vanished into Crown compliance nor entered the public record before she understood what it carried.

The pressure door opened. One of her analysts returned for a forgotten seal stylus.

Ada covered the margin with her hand.

"Director?"

"Take the stylus."

He retrieved it from beside the recorder and glanced at the six curves. "Do you want the Latchkey qualification added to tomorrow's risk summary?"

"Yes. Separate catalyst exhaustion from first critical-system loss. Do the same for all six habitats."

"That will widen the ranges."

"It will make them defensible."

After he left, Ada compared the alternate model's origin date to the Crown filing calendar. The run had begun eleven months earlier, three days after a mass engineer submitted a warning about cumulative Mouth shear. Ada remembered the warning. Her office had classified it as speculative because no operational remedy accompanied it.

A remedy may have existed in another division while she signed the classification.

She opened Crown's retention directory through the limited discovery window. Searching the full identifier would create an audit alert. She instead searched the public prefix, then narrowed by date, authoring division, and output type. Twenty-one records appeared. Nineteen belonged to ordinary freight alternates. One held no title and no accessible summary. The last had been converted into a legal-risk memorandum stating that any departure from schedule exclusivity would produce unacceptable liability.

The untitled record carried the same checksum family as MX-ALT/4.

Ada requested its metadata under pending-litigation authority. The directory asked whether the request concerned a filed exhibit, anticipated evidence, or privileged defense preparation. Every answer notified a different Crown office. She chose anticipated evidence. Jalen's staff would see the request at the next compliance sweep, perhaps in six hours.

Access opened on a single page.

MODEL INDEX: MOUTH TRANSITION SERIES, RUNS 1–4.

Below it, four rows listed creation dates, computational mass, scenario owners, and disposition. Run 1 had failed stability bounds. Run 2 had been stopped for patient-transfer assumptions. Run 3 remained under technical review. Run 4 had completed, then moved to restricted schedule strategy by chair authority.

No numerical outputs appeared. No bell assignments. No duration. The index proved work, not feasibility. It also proved that Jalen's instruction to keep remedy outside the case protected more than a legal boundary.

Ada read the access footer twice. Export prohibited. Screen capture logged. Local print unavailable.

She took the timing lamp from the evidence table and set it beside her slate. The lamp could certify spoken counsel notes, but any recording entered Callis custody. She did not need the content admitted yet. She needed to keep it from disappearing.

Ada memorized the four run dates, then closed the page. She reopened it to test herself. Dates correct. Scenario owners correct. Run 4 disposition exact. She wrote them in longhand across the reverse of the reserve table, using pump annotations between each field so an automated scan would not reconstruct the index as a Crown record.

That concealment implicated her as soon as the ink dried. Twelve years spent arguing that operational fear justified controlled disclosure had left her skilled at the mechanics of suppression. Intent did not alter the action. Only what she did next might alter its use.

The directory chimed. A compliance marker had attached to her metadata request sooner than expected.

Ada closed every reserve curve except Latchkey's. On Ema's diagram, lower-deck reclamation branched from the same trunk that served the clinic. One valve choice gave nine days to one system by taking sterility from another. The engineering did not offer innocence. It offered a map of who would pay.

She sealed the working copy under her personal litigation key and entered a retrieval request for the untitled run's physical audit wafer. The system warned that chair approval would be required.

"Request it," Ada said.

The directory accepted her voice and sent the notice to Jalen.

Before the confirmation could be recalled, she tore the handwritten model index from the reserve table, folded it around Ema Orsen's pump diagram, and placed both inside the court's pending-evidence envelope. The envelope's physical seal closed beneath her thumb. Crown still possessed the model. Ada had stolen the fact that it existed.

Chapter 15 — The Cost of Calling

<!-- POV: Nia Daro -->

<!-- Days 19–20; Callis Archive resonance vault -->

Nia lowered the ninth heat bloom into alignment and watched the public estimate lose half its value.

The thermal map hung above choir bell C-9 as a stack of translucent sections. Each section carried a pale oval where a destructive read had driven heat through the auric glass. Osei had numbered the blooms by depth rather than date. Their sequence could not be known from temperature alone. Nia had spent two days matching each scar to old maintenance tolerances, Crown activation fragments, and the changes in Iven's responses.

The result on her slate read 2.14.

Osei looked past her shoulder. "Run the uncertainty again."

"I did."

"With the outer-lamination loss at the high bound?"

"That gives 1.96."

"Low bound?"

"2.27."

He rested both hands on the cradle rail. C-9 lay beneath them in its preservation field, smoked amber under the vault lamps. The bell held no visible movement. Its phase trace pulsed against the passive meter with long rests between each rise.

The public filing still showed 4.6 returns. That figure assumed an intact interior, then subtracted the cost of the Callis activations. It treated the nine blooms as superficial calibration damage because Crown's sealed transfer record had classified them that way. Nia had once accepted the classification. She had recognized her own instrument signature in the seventh scar and understood that acceptance could not survive another unexamined number.

"Use 2.1 returns," she said.

Osei did not enter it. "The corrected mean gives 2.14."

"Returns do not support hundredths at this damage level. Two point one states what we know without pretending we know more."

"And the lower bound?"

"Put it in the medical note."

"The Court will quote the headline."

"Yes."

"So will Crown."

“Yes.”

Osei keyed the number. The reserve display contracted. A band that had once held four ordinary activations and a margin now held two, perhaps less if distress widened Iven’s recall. The word *return* made coherence sound renewable. Nothing in C-9 came back after use.

Nia placed the original estimate beside the correction. “Now price the merits protocol.”

They had costed the hearing before, using the public reserve and a standard signal-person load: ninety minutes of structured testimony, visual exhibits, route recall, two recesses, and controlled cross-examination. The protocol projected 0.62 return. That calculation assumed coherent retrieval and stable recognition. Iven had neither.

Osei entered the latest route-response delay. He added the stress spike from the standing hearing, then the deeper retrieval needed to distinguish encoded deposition from present testimony. The number climbed to 0.68.

“Add face recognition,” Nia said.

“That is preparation, not merits.”

“Crown’s witness list includes identity foundation. They will put Lio Senn’s record to him.”

Osei’s fingers stopped above the slate. “Why?”

“To test whether he can connect the route memory to a person.”

“They know faces are expensive.”

“They will call it reliability.”

He entered the task. The upper projection reached 0.74.

Nia set the filed hearing cost beside the revised reserve. About 0.7 return. Roughly one third of what remained. If questioning broadened into autobiographical recall, the fraction could rise. If the body destabilized, stopping it would preserve less than stopping before the damage began.

She did not trust one calculation merely because it condemned the earlier one. “Blind the bloom labels.”

Osei copied the thermal sections into a clean workspace and removed every date, instrument code, and Crown entry reference. He left only heat depth, affected glass volume, local stress orientation, and the passive response measured that morning. Nia turned away while he changed the section order.

“Ready.”

The first scar had spread along a manufacturing seam. Nia classified it as a shallow read with uncertain thermal loss. The second penetrated three phase layers and curved toward the route packet. She assigned a higher cost. By the fifth section, the shape in the glass had begun to repeat: narrow access near the encoded statement, wide bloom where the process searched for context, then a sharp edge where someone stopped the activation before coherent descent.

“Show me the public Callis reads separately,” she said.

Osei marked two sections with a gray border. Their heat paths remained compact because Nia had used current descent controls and limited sensory load. Neither resembled the older damage.

“Crown drove the prior bodies harder,” he said.

“The marks support broader access. They do not tell us why.”

“What benign reason needs nine attempts?”

“Keep motive out of the reserve note.”

“It keeps finding a way in.”

Nia classified the remaining scars, then let the slate restore sequence. Her blind estimate reached 2.08 returns. The difference from the first calculation fell within measurement error.

Osei rotated the seventh section. Her old calibration cadence appeared along its edge as four equal warming points and one longer descent mark. Seven years earlier, she had accepted a maintenance order describing an inert route model that needed phase-response calibration before transfer. She remembered the tool's drag. She remembered the Crown supervisor asking her to repeat the final pulse because the model had failed to settle. No vocal body had occupied the service room. Nothing in the task had looked like respeaking from the gantry.

Yet the bloom widened after her pulse. Someone had used her calibration to open a deeper path elsewhere.

“Subtract my event as maintenance only,” she said.

Osei stared at her. “Why?”

“Challenge the conclusion. Assume my pulse spent no conscious coherence and carried only thermal cost.”

He changed the classification. The reserve rose to 2.23.

“Now remove the shallowest unknown scar.”

“On what basis?”

“Assume manufacturing damage.”

The result reached 2.31.

“Still nowhere near 4.6,” he said.

“No.”

“Then stop trying to rescue their number.”

“I am trying to learn whether an unfriendly examiner can.” Nia restored both events. “Export all three cases. Supported estimate, conservative damage estimate, and lowest plausible reserve.”

A medical alert appeared beside the hearing protocol. The vocal body team had priced a second factor that the phase model omitted: cumulative tissue strain. Iven's reconstructed pattern might retain coherence while the neutral body lost the ability to carry it safely. His prior glucose response had slowed. Breath support now engaged three seconds earlier during descent. Another long hearing could end from tissue failure before phase exhaustion, leaving testimony interrupted without preserving the expected reserve.

Nia opened the body report. "Add a motor-loss threshold to the stop protocol."

"There is no patient-controlled stop protocol yet."

"Then cost one."

Osei built a branch using existing medical cutoff controls. Spoken command required less motor effort but could be disputed if speech broke. A hand signal offered independent confirmation but demanded stable proprioception. The safest design used both and permitted either to begin descent.

"You are designing consent before we ask him," Osei said.

"I am identifying whether consent can be withdrawn. Without that, asking him to proceed offers only entry."

The branch reduced expected hearing cost by eight hundredths if the stop came at the first overload marker. It also reduced useful testimony time.

"Crown will oppose it," Osei said.

"They can oppose after he knows the price."

Osei left the two estimates side by side: 2.1 returns and a hearing centered near 0.7. "Send the correction to Cal."

"Not yet."

"He set the hearing schedule from the wrong number."

"Iven receives it first."

"We need authorization to bring him up."

"His medical choices belong to him now."

"That means he can authorize. It does not let us ask an inactive person."

Nia removed the slate from the shared mount. "The current rest order includes one low-load medical interval before the merits hearing."

"Tomorrow morning."

"We use it now."

Osei looked toward the vault door. A court seal covered the activation console, its physical filament threaded through the send control. Breaking it without a custodian would end her access before she could explain the number. "Cal will come if we call."

"Then call him. Do not send the calculation."

"He will ask why."

"Tell him Iven needs to receive a material medical correction before counsel."

Osei's jaw tightened. "You are separating the patient from the case as though the Court has ever done that."

“For the next ten minutes, it will.”

Cal arrived in seven. He carried the temporary-personhood order on a sealed wafer and read Nia’s request while standing outside the vault. The pressure door remained closed between them.

“You recalculated the reserve,” he said through the intercom.

Nia held the slate facedown. “I have information that changes his consent.”

“Does it affect the hearing?”

“Yes.”

“Then counsel must know.”

“He must know before counsel decides what to ask him.”

“I am his counsel.”

“You are also the examiner who scheduled the hearing.”

Cal looked through the door’s narrow glass at C-9. “That conflict existed yesterday.”

“The quantity did not.”

“How large a correction?”

“Large enough that hearing it after you would make his choice look managed.”

The intercom carried the low fan noise from his side. Nia watched him weigh reversible order against damage already accumulating in delay. He finally pressed the wafer into the seal reader.

“I will authorize the medical interval,” he said. “I remain present as counsel.”

“You remain outside the vocal-body room until Iven invites you.”

“That exceeds your authority.”

“It protects the choice you claim to represent.”

Cal’s face changed slightly. Not concession. Recognition. “Record my objection.”

Osei raised the custody lamp. “Already running.”

Cal broke the seal.

The vocal body opened its eyes on the sixth breath.

Nia kept one hand around the saline regulator and the other against the warm cuff at Iven’s wrist. The body had lost weight since the last activation. Its tendons showed beneath pale skin, and the pulse arrived too quickly for the low metabolic setting. Linen restraints lay loose across the forearms. Iven had asked that they remain unfastened unless his movements threatened the phase leads.

His gaze found the ceiling, the glucose cup, then Nia. Recognition took two breaths longer than before.

“You moved the lamp,” he said.

The timing lamp stood on the opposite shelf. During his prior interval it had rested near the door.

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“So you can see the reserve display without turning your head.”

“Generous.” His voice rasped. “Or ominous.”

Nia raised the bed by five degrees. “Can you state your name?”

“Iven Ko.”

“Place?”

“Callis. Vocal-body room three.”

“Last event you remember?”

He closed his eyes. The pulse in his wrist rose beneath her fingers. “A judge gave me medical choices that end when I stop being able to make them.”

“Do you remember the judge’s name?”

“Sena Pell spoke. Cal Orsen argued. I do not know which answer you want.”

“Either establishes sequence.”

“Then both cost less than choosing.”

Nia held the glucose cup to his mouth. He swallowed twice and turned away.

“I recalculated your remaining coherence,” she said.

His fingers shifted under the cuff. “Before the Court?”

“Yes.”

“Does Cal know the number?”

“No.”

That answer steadied him more than the glucose had. He looked toward the observation glass, which remained opaque. “Tell me.”

“The public estimate assumed 4.6 returns. It classified nine interior heat blooms as calibration damage. We matched those blooms to destructive access. The best supported estimate now gives 2.1 returns. The plausible range extends below two.”

Iven watched her mouth as though route meaning might arrive through its movement before the words settled.

“How much did this call use?”

“Expected cost, less than five hundredths. Your stress response may raise it.”

“Then stop measuring my stress as if the answer can improve it.”

Nia released his wrist. The cuff continued sending pulse data, but her hand no longer made the measurement feel personal. “You can end this interval at any time.”

“What does the hearing cost?”

“A standard merits protocol now projects about 0.7 return.”

He breathed in through his nose. “One third.”

“Roughly one third of the corrected estimate. More if recall broadens. Less if questioning stays narrow and you stop before overload.”

“And what did Crown take?”

“We cannot assign exact cost to each prior read. Together, the evidence supports a loss of at least half the reserve reflected in the public filing.”

“I asked what they took.”

“So did I.” Nia kept her voice even. “The map shows consumption. It does not show which memory left with each use.”

His gaze moved away from her and stopped on the blank wall. The room offered no window. During the standing hearing he had chosen a view of Callis over a reconstruction of Eiren because the choice belonged to the present. Nia had wondered whether that preference marked recovery. Now it looked like conservation. He had selected something that demanded no damaged face.

“Bring Cal in,” Iven said.

“Do you want the reserve display first?”

“No. Numbers behave when I am not looking at them.”

Nia opened the observation glass. Cal stood beyond it with his hand on the rail. She unlocked the room door, but she did not move from beside the bed.

Cal entered carrying no files. “Iven.”

“Did you know?”

“I knew Nia had a material correction. I did not know its size.”

“Would you have brought me up if she sent it first?”

“Yes.”

“For the medical interval or for preparation?”

Cal took the chair at the foot of the bed. He did not answer quickly. "Both, if you agreed after hearing the number."

Iven gave a dry sound that did not become a laugh. "Agreement after counsel explains why testimony matters."

"I would explain what the hearing can decide."

"You would be good at it."

"That does not make the explanation coercive."

"No. The remaining time does."

Nia checked the phase-load bar. It had reached sixty-two percent of the interval limit. Iven noticed her glance.

"How much to decide?" he asked.

"Decision itself has no fixed cost. Remaining awake does."

"Then give me the choices without argument."

Cal looked at Nia. She nodded once.

"First," he said, "we postpone while challenging Crown's other records. Delay also carries preservation risk. Second, we proceed with the scheduled merits hearing and seek strict limits on scope. Third, you decline testimony. Existing telemetry and physical evidence remain, but the direct allegation may lose force."

"Fourth," Iven said. "You call me later because the case becomes difficult."

"Only with your consent while you hold standing."

"And after?"

Existing law gave Cal no answer that could survive Iven's absence. His eyes lowered to the unfastened linen across Iven's arm.

"The Court has not decided that," he said.

"Then those are not four choices. They are three choices followed by someone else's."

The phase bar reached sixty-seven percent. Nia reduced the visual feed and warmed the saline by one degree. Iven's breathing eased.

Cal leaned forward. "You do not owe the Court your destruction."

"Does the Court know that?"

"I do."

"You are not the whole Court."

"No."

Iven turned to Nia. "Can you make the hearing stop when I say?"

“The activation can be stepped down within twelve seconds if the leads remain stable. A sudden cutoff risks shear.”

“Not can the machine stop. Can I stop the people?”

Cal answered. “I can ask for an order limiting examination.”

“That means a judge chooses whether my limit counts.”

“Yes.”

“Then ask for something else.”

Nia understood before Cal did. “A stopping point controlled from the bed.”

Iven’s eyes returned to her. “Not the bed. Me.”

She pulled the activation protocol onto the wall. The current design assigned stop authority to the supervising resonantist after a judicial recess command. Iven could request recess, but the body did not control the phase descent. Nia could insert a patient command into the medical cutoff layer. Any spoken phrase risked accidental activation during testimony. A deliberate hand sequence could fail if motor control deteriorated.

“You need two paths,” she said. “A spoken command and a physical one.”

“What words?”

“Your choice.”

“Stop now.”

Cal shook his head. “That could occur in quoted testimony.”

“Then the full sentence.” Iven looked at him. “This examination stops now.”

Nia entered it into the local protocol but did not authorize the change. “Physical command?”

Iven lifted his right hand. Tremor moved through the fingers. He pressed thumb to the first joint of his middle finger, held for two breaths, and released.

“That movement appears nowhere in the route checks,” Nia said. “We can use it.”

Cal read the proposed control. “Crown will argue that counsel or medical staff could coach either signal.”

“Then record the choice now,” Iven said.

The timing lamp stood within his view. Osei activated its identity thread from the console. Nia stated the corrected reserve, hearing projection, and control design. Cal stated that Iven had received the information before counsel knew the quantity. The lamp asked Iven to confirm.

He looked tired enough that the room seemed to move around his effort to remain still.

“I authorize one final evidentiary activation,” he said. “It proceeds only if my stopping point controls the descent. Spoken or physical. No examiner gets to spend the interval after I withdraw it.”

Cal asked, "Do you authorize preparation before that activation?"

"No rehearsal that enters broad recall. Documents may be described to me while I am at medical baseline. I choose whether to see them."

"Do you understand that stopping may leave cross-examination unfinished?"

"Yes."

"That may reduce the force of your testimony."

"It may."

Cal's next question waited behind his teeth. Nia saw him abandon it.

The phase-load bar crossed seventy percent.

"Iven," she said, "this interval has reached its safe descent range."

He pressed thumb to finger and held.

Nia acknowledged the physical command. Osei began the twelve-second taper. Warm saline moved through the body cuff. The pulse slowed first, then the eyes lost focus.

Before breath support took over, Iven looked at the protocol on the wall. "Make them sign it."

"I will," Cal said.

"No." His voice had thinned to air. "Make them sign before they hear me."

The body released its next breath and did not draw another on its own. Nia watched the phase trace settle into C-9. Cal remained at the foot of the bed.

On the wall, the new control waited for three signatures: medical custodian, counsel, and presiding justice. Nia placed her hand against the first field. Her activation license made the instrument accept her identity.

She signed before anyone could ask whether she would still hold that license at the hearing.

Chapter 16 — Archive of Complicity

<!-- POV: Nia Daro -->

<!-- Days 21–22; Callis Archive and Court record chamber -->

The license reader rejected Nia's thumb before she could submit Iven's stopping protocol.

A red bar crossed the seal field. ACTIVATION AUTHORITY UNDER AUTOMATED REVIEW. SOURCE ORDER CONFLICT. The reader released the protocol wafer but kept a gray copy of its signature trace. Nia tried no second time. Repeated attempts could turn a contested credential into an access violation.

Osei stood beside the vault console with the custody lamp looped around his wrist. "That review did not exist an hour ago."

"It did. We gave it something to match."

"The corrected reserve?"

"My signature." Nia withdrew her thumb and studied the reader's dull contact plate. "The protocol linked my current license to the instrument cadence in bloom seven."

He looked toward C-9. The preservation field drew a faint amber line along the bell's service lip. "Crown's old transfer file called that work external calibration."

"So did I."

"Then why flag it now?"

"Because the reader found an activation-order family beneath the maintenance number."

Nia opened the conflict notice without dismissing the red bar. A credential system preserved its first result more reliably than any screen opened afterward. The notice identified a seven-year-old work order: CROWN ROUTE MODEL CONDITIONING / C9-ER-204 / SERVICE TASK 7C. Her completion mark sat below three remote authorization stubs. The visible order described inert geometry and prohibited semantic access. A concealed dependency field pointed to a retention ledger the Callis Archive had never received.

Osei read the stub names. "They are all closed offices."

"Offices close. Keys migrate."

"Can we follow them?"

"Not from an activation console." She sealed Iven's protocol in a passive sleeve. "We use the acquisition terminal and record every query."

"The hearing begins in two days."

"Then we do not spend today pretending my authority remains intact."

They left C-9 under the court field. At the vault door, Nia's license still opened preservation access. It would permit her to regulate temperature, inspect seals, and respond to a physical fault. It would not permit a pulse. The distinction felt accurate enough to hurt.

The acquisition terminal occupied a narrow room beneath mass ring two. Its keys had worn smooth under decades of gloved hands. Nia seated the custody lamp where it could see the screen, the door, and both technicians. Osei pulled the original Crown transfer packet from offline storage.

Eleven public lines appeared, the same ones they had read on the first day. Mixed mass transfer. No recoverable emergency telemetry. Outer phase glass cleared under salvage protocol. Interior access prohibited. Origin blank.

Nia opened the service-task index and entered 7C.

The terminal returned no record.

“Search the parent family,” she said.

Osei removed the final character. Seven tasks appeared. Six concerned inert route models held at Crown depots. The seventh showed no title, only her license number and a completion date.

“Order them by creation, not completion.”

The blank task moved from last to first.

Someone had created it before the six harmless jobs, then used the later orders to define its apparent family. A reviewer searching by number would see a routine series. A reviewer asking when the series began would find the concealed dependency.

Osei bent close to the checksum. “Creation predates transfer by twelve days.”

“And my work?”

“Nine days before transfer.”

Nia remembered a Crown supervisor telling her the bell could not enter Callis custody until its model layer answered a standard cadence. He had brought C-9 to a rented service cradle outside the archive ring. She had not seen a vocal-body room, medical feed, or active phase channel. Her probe had connected through a Crown isolation case. Every indicator available to her showed an inert geometric model.

Every indicator had belonged to Crown.

“Open my instrument log,” she said.

The terminal warned that archived calibration records could contain protected worker data. Nia entered her consent. Four pulses and one long descent mark appeared, exactly as the seventh bloom carried them.

Osei overlaid the thermal map. “Your last pulse ends here.” He pointed to a narrow heat edge. “The deeper bloom starts forty milliseconds later.”

“Too fast for a separate manual send.”

“They armed a linked process.”

“Or my cadence crossed a trigger threshold.”

“Which means?”

Nia expanded the response channels. Her instrument had registered a clean mirror from the outer layer. Under it lay six microseconds of discarded phase motion, labeled housing noise. She restored the raw values. The line contained breath regularity, motor load, and an autonomic spike.

A body had been active somewhere beyond the isolation case.

Osei stepped back from the terminal. "You heard him."

"No audio reached my station."

"Your instrument did."

"State only what the values support." Nia magnified the autonomic channel. "A biologically loaded response shared the circuit. Identity remains unproved."

"The bell identity proves it."

"The bell links the process to C-9. The thermal sequence links it to one of nine destructive events. We still have to establish which event."

Osei opened the sealed Crown activation fragments admitted after the ledger leak. Dates appeared only for three entries. The others used relative sequence numbers. Return 7 listed outer-cadence conditioning by contracted Callis resonantist. Return 8 began eleven months later. Return 6 ended twenty-three months earlier.

Nia's completion date fell between them.

"The seventh recall," Osei said.

She read the ledger line again. It did not name her. It did not need to. The instrument code, license trace, and date closed the path. Crown had built a remote activation behind an inert maintenance interface. Nia had supplied the cadence that opened or stabilized it. Her lack of informed consent changed her culpability. It did not change what the pulse had done.

"What did Return 7 seek?" she asked.

Osei opened the clipped purpose field. "Recognition stability under neutral technician contact."

The room's fan vibration traveled through the terminal keys into Nia's fingertips. Iven had recognized her calibration cadence during his first Callis embodiment. She had treated that recognition as impossible, then as evidence against Crown. It also pointed toward an encounter his damaged continuity retained in the body even after context disappeared.

"They used me as an unfamiliar stimulus," she said.

"You were not in the body room."

"They needed a cadence outside Crown's regular staff. Something not encoded in the Eiren packet and not repeated across their other tests."

"Then his recognition of you helped prove agency."

"After it helped damage him."

Osei's hand hovered near the custody lamp. "Do we call Cal?"

"We finish the reconstruction first."

"Nia."

"If I confess before separating the supported chain from inference, Crown will call the whole result guilt-driven."

"You did not know."

"Put that in the chain where the record supports it."

They worked for another three hours. Nia retrieved the task ontology in force seven years earlier. It defined *route model* as a non-conscious predictive state and required a separate red warning for any biologically loaded process. Her order contained no warning. Osei found the rented cradle's network diagram in a freight-insurance attachment. The isolation case had carried a second line concealed inside its shielding return. That line led to Crown medical systems.

Nia traced custody from the original completion mark through acquisition. The blank task had been bundled into six inert calibrations, exported under a family checksum, and stripped of its dependency field when Callis accepted C-9. A Callis intake reviewer had verified the family total but not the creation sequence. Nia had signed only her task, not the bundle. The archive had nevertheless accepted Crown's classification because one of its own senior resonantists appeared in the record.

Her signature had not merely performed work. It had laundered the bell's condition for transfer.

Nia pulled the insurance diagram down to the terminal's fabrication bench. "We need to prove the concealed line could carry the response, not only that a line existed."

"We cannot rebuild Crown's case from a freight drawing."

"We can test the topology."

Osei fetched two passive phase couplers, an obsolete shielding sleeve, and a route-model resistor from the training cabinet. None could touch C-9. Their bench reconstruction would use a calibration simulator that carried no stored person and no destructive state. Nia listed every substitution for the custody lamp before either of them connected a lead.

The freight diagram showed an isolation case with one approved return path. Its shielding braid should have drained stray phase motion to the cradle frame. Crown's hidden medical line ran inside that braid, sharing its ground for eleven centimeters before separating beneath the case hinge.

Osei cut a matching length of training braid. "If they carried a live response beside the drain, your instrument should have seen noise before the trigger."

"It did. Six microseconds labeled housing noise."

"That label came from your tool."

"From its ontology. Crown selected the ontology when they issued the task."

They connected the harmless simulator beyond the sleeve. Osei configured it to send a pulse shaped like

elevated breath load, not a neural trace. Nia stood back from the controls. Her license remained under review, and even a training pulse would complicate the record if she sent it herself.

“External cadence ready,” he said.

“Use four equal points and one long descent.”

“That repeats your signature.”

“It tests the mechanism.”

Osei sent the sequence. The approved return channel showed a clean mirror. Beneath it, the instrument discarded a narrow motion band as housing noise. When he restored the raw view, the simulated breath pulse appeared inside the discarded band.

“Again with the hidden line removed,” Nia said.

He disconnected it at the hinge. The next cadence produced no buried response.

“Reverse the shared ground.”

“Why?”

“An unfriendly review will argue accidental coupling.”

Osei reversed the braid connection. A response appeared, but its polarity inverted and its delay widened beyond a hundred milliseconds. Crown’s line in the freight diagram preserved polarity and matched the forty-millisecond edge in bloom seven.

Nia wrote the distinction into the reconstruction. “The geometry supports intentional carriage. Do not write that it proves intent to harm.”

“It proves someone built a path.”

“Yes.”

“For a process the order told you did not exist.”

“Yes.”

He shut down the simulator. “How many people had to know?”

“The case designer. Whoever configured the medical side. Whoever bound my order to the trigger.”

“And the supervisor in the room.”

“Likely. We do not have his private display.”

Osei unwound the training braid and laid every part in a separate tray. “You keep narrowing the statement until no person fits inside it.”

Nia sealed the simulator log. “I am narrowing it until the people who do fit cannot escape through an exaggeration.”

He looked at the old order on the screen. "Where do you fit?"

She touched no part of the bench. "At the external cadence. At the unrecorded objection I should have made. At the signature Callis relied on afterward."

The reconstruction added one more dated operation to the chain: a present, non-destructive bench test showing how Crown's concealed medical line had passed a biologically loaded response beneath the tool's noise filter.

At the end, Osei built a single provenance path on the wall. No rhetoric. No motive. Eight dated operations connected Nia's maintenance order to the hidden medical line and from there to Return 7.

"Now Cal," she said.

Cal read the reconstruction without touching it.

They met in a record chamber beside the Court's axial hall. Paper-thin acoustic baffles separated the central table from three observation stations. Ada occupied one station by Crown link. She had joined after Cal notified all parties that a custodian credential conflict might affect the merits hearing. Sena Pell had declined to attend until the record established whether judicial action was required.

Cal reached the final provenance line. "Did any document tell you a conscious process might answer your calibration?"

"No."

"Did you see a vocal body?"

"No."

"Did you know Crown had performed prior access to C-9?"

"No."

Ada spoke from the wall. "Those answers concern her knowledge then. Ask what she suspected."

Cal looked at Nia. "Did any part of the assignment seem irregular?"

"Yes. Crown required its isolation case to remain closed. The supervisor refused my request to inspect the return channel. He said opening it would invalidate density certification."

"Was that explanation plausible?"

"Yes."

"Was it required by ordinary practice?"

"No. A Callis custodian could have inspected under shared seal. I accepted Crown's refusal because the order classified the layer as inert and because transfer depended on timely completion."

"Did you record an objection?"

"No."

Osei sat behind her with the custody lamp. He did not move.

Cal asked, "What consequence followed from your pulse?"

"The instrument record supports a linked biologically loaded response forty milliseconds after my final cadence. The heat map places the resulting damage at bloom seven. The Crown ledger identifies contracted Callis calibration during Return 7. Taken together, those records establish my technical participation in the seventh recall."

Ada's voice sharpened. "Participation can mean any contribution. Did you initiate respeaking?"

"I initiated the external sequence that enabled or stabilized it."

"Did you authorize semantic access?"

"No."

"Did you intend destructive access?"

"No."

"Then say plainly that Crown deceived you."

Nia looked at Ada's compressed image. "Crown concealed the active process and misrepresented the order. Callis failed to require an independent return-path inspection. I accepted a closed interface because the paperwork gave me a lawful reason to do so."

"You are distributing blame to the archive."

"I am describing the control failure."

"That description threatens the custody of every record you handled after transfer."

"Yes."

Cal's attention settled on her. "You understand that this admission may compromise C-9's chain?"

"The chain already carries the compromise. Silence would only keep the Court from measuring it."

"Why disclose now?"

"My license reader matched the current protocol to the old cadence."

"Would you have disclosed without the automated review?"

Nia felt Osei's presence behind her, the lamp preserving the time she took. "I had already disclosed the matching signature and the nine blooms. I had not reconstructed the hidden medical line. Without today's conflict, I might have continued treating my task as calibration adjacent to the recall rather than part of it."

"Is that a yes?" Ada asked.

"No. I cannot claim I would have reached the same conclusion today without the reader."

The timing lamp marked the answer. It would harm her. That gave it evidentiary value rather than moral purity.

Cal turned to Ada. “Does Crown contest the authenticity of its ledger fragment?”

“Crown contests the inference that the biologically loaded response belonged to Iven Ko.”

“Will Crown produce the sealed Return 7 medical record?”

“I do not hold authority to waive it.”

“Then the Court will weigh your refusal with the physical match.”

Ada’s mouth tightened. She said nothing further.

Cal opened Iven’s stopping protocol beside the reconstruction. Nia’s signature showed a red review mark. “A merits activation requires unchallenged technical authority. I cannot leave this credential active while its holder serves as both operator and implicated witness.”

Nia placed her thumb on the table, away from every reader. “I agree.”

“Agreement does not decide discipline.”

“I know.”

“Pending archive review, I suspend your activation license. Effective now. You may perform passive preservation under court supervision. You may not send a pulse, authorize embodiment, control descent, or sign an activation protocol.”

The operative words entered the chamber seal. Nia had expected relief and felt none. Her license had permitted Crown to trust her seven years earlier. It had permitted Iven to trust her yesterday. The same credential connected both acts while consent separated them.

Osei rose. “The stopping protocol needs another medical custodian.”

“It will receive one,” Cal said.

“Iven authorized it after Nia explained the reserve. He chose her to implement it.”

“He chose the control. The Court can appoint an independent operator.”

Nia spoke before Osei could argue. “Do that.”

Cal studied her. “There is a separate question. Iven has repeatedly identified you as the person he wants present for technical explanation. His recorded medical preference names you, not merely a licensed office.”

Ada said, “An implicated custodian cannot remain inside the advisory chain.”

“A license suspension removes operational authority,” Cal replied. “It does not erase a represented person’s choice of adviser.”

“Her advice may shape testimony about the very activation she helped perform.”

“Then examination may expose that conflict.”

Cal turned the protocol wafer over. “I will retain Nia Daro as Iven Ko’s chosen technical adviser, subject to full disclosure and no instrument control. A separate court resonantist will execute any authorized activation. This

ruling preserves his present preference without pre-deciding archive discipline.”

Nia had not asked to stay. Asking would have made the role sound like hers to claim. Iven’s choice created the only reason she could remain after the license ended.

Cal pressed his seal to the suspension order. Her wrist credential cooled as its active field shut down.

“The confession breaks any claim to a clean chain of custody,” he said. “It also explains the break before Crown can expose it piecemeal. The merits record will carry both facts.”

Ada’s link went dark without farewell.

Outside the chamber, Nia tested her wrist against a general archive door. It opened. At the resonance-vault line, the instrument gate stayed closed until Osei placed his junior credential beside hers. His key permitted escorted preservation access, nothing more.

They entered together.

C-9 rested under the same amber field. The red review bar had disappeared from the activation console because the console no longer recognized Nia as someone entitled to submit a command. Iven’s stopping protocol remained in its passive sleeve, her invalidated signature visible beneath the plastic.

Osei reached for the field-temperature control, then stopped. “You should tell me the adjustment.”

Nia read the gradient. Ring vibration had raised the outer seam by two hundredths of a degree. Before suspension, she would have corrected it herself.

“Lower the cradle set point by one tenth,” she said. “Wait for two full fan cycles before touching the inner field.”

Osei entered the change. The instrument accepted his hand under passive-preservation authority. Nia watched the temperature line descend without touching the console.

On the third fan cycle, the field settled. Osei offered her the custody lamp. She shook her head and pointed to the cradle.

“You hold it,” she said.

He fixed the lamp to his wrist. Together they began checking the seal that her license could no longer open.

Chapter 17 — What the Returns Took

<!-- POV: Iven Ko -->

<!-- Days 22–23; vocal-body room and hearing preparation chamber -->

The woman in the verified image had Lio's left hand and a stranger's face.

Iven knew the hand because the smallest finger leaned inward from an old pressure-door fracture. He knew the work coat by its gray shoulder patch, thermal-grid east crew, though the preserved image offered no color. Behind her, a service corridor divided around a coolant trunk. He could place the corridor within Eiren's lower grid to half a meter.

He could not place the woman.

Cal waited beside the image wall. Nia stood beyond the instrument line with both hands visible and empty. A court resonantist occupied the control station where she would once have sat. Iven had declined the operator's name. Learning it would create another item he might notice losing.

"Remove the verification label," he said.

Cal blanked the border. The image remained: woman, conduit, numbered valve, light falling from above and slightly spinward.

"Ask me again."

"Do you recognize this person?" Cal said.

"No."

"Do you recognize the setting?"

"Grid approach four. The camera stands inside the intake lock. Valve E-fourteen feeds the lower mirror loop."

"Can you identify the person by context?"

"Yes." He tasted glucose at the back of his throat. "Lio Senn had east-grid duty that week. She wore that coat. The hand matches hers. The image record names her. Those facts identify her."

Cal's gaze remained on him. "Do you recognize Lio's face?"

Iven looked again.

The face had a broad mouth held against a smile, one eyebrow lower than the other, hair cut close because grid seals punished loose strands. All details arrived. None connected to the space where his wife should have been. Recognition ought to have crossed the gap without work. Instead, he assembled a conclusion from evidence.

"No," he said.

Nia's fingers closed around each other, then separated. The movement did not touch a control.

The vocal body lay at a low angle to reduce cardiac load. Warm saline entered at Iven's left wrist. Three phase leads crossed his chest and disappeared through the bed housing toward C-9. The connection gave no sensation

he could name. Its cost showed elsewhere: a breath that ended before he expected, the room taking longer to settle after he turned his head, a person reduced to facts that refused to become familiarity.

Cal dimmed the image. "We can stop preparation."

"This counts as documents described at medical baseline."

"The load rose when you tried recognition."

"I did not ask to stop."

"No." Cal placed the sealed image wafer facedown. "You also prohibited rehearsal that enters broad recall."

"Then do not make it broad. Ask where she went."

Nia spoke from behind the line. "Route reconstruction may cost less than face retrieval, but we have not tested the difference at this depth."

"I have."

"When?"

"Every time I wake."

The court resonantist lowered the wall brightness. Iven could not see the operator's hands, only their reflection in the black panel: fingers on a descent control signed by someone other than Nia. His stopping protocol had received all required seals that morning. Spoken command or thumb to middle finger. Either would begin the taper within two seconds, no judicial permission required.

Cal opened a blank route field. "Start at your quarters."

A white point appeared.

Iven lifted his right hand. Tremor entered before he reached the wall, so Nia gave him a pointer with a broad grip. He set the point on a curve that the field had not drawn.

"The quarters were here, west of registry ventilation. Door opened toward the narrow passage because Lio said an inward-opening door invited people to leave tools against it."

"Do you remember the room?"

"I remember distances. Bed to wash recess, two steps. Door to storage, one and a half. Her side had the easier path to the corridor because she took early grid calls."

"Do you remember seeing her there?"

He found no image. "I remember moving around her."

The distinction hurt without producing a picture. There had been a body in the spaces he preserved. Someone had occupied the clear path and complained when his route sheets covered the table. He knew how far to reach for a cup she had set down. The cup had no hand attached.

Cal said, "Continue only if you choose."

Iven drew the passage to the first lift. “On failure day, the lift stopped two levels above the heat junction. She used the maintenance ladder behind the south bulkhead.”

“How do you know?”

“She called from the junction.”

“Do you remember the call?”

“Not the order of it.”

He drew six ladder turns, a crawl around a seized inspection gate, and the slanted conduit that crossed the final landing. The pointer moved with increasing certainty. Route geometry survived without effort where a face had demanded assembly. He knew which rung flexed because Lio had once marked it for replacement. He knew she would put her right boot to the wall at the fifth turn to clear a cable housing. The knowledge contained her practice and omitted her appearance.

Nia watched the body-load display. “Your phase demand has fallen by twelve percent.”

“While I trace the route?”

“Yes.”

“Then faces cost more than paths.”

“One sample does not establish sequence of loss.”

“Use a non-visual record.”

Cal looked to Nia before selecting the preserved engineering log. She read the body-load line and nodded. The document opened as a grid of valve states and technician marks. It carried no reconstructed voice, only entries written by a living worker forty-seven years earlier.

Iven recognized the notation before he read the name. Lio marked uncertain flow with an open square instead of the standard half bar. She hated closing a field that someone else might mistake for measured fact. Three open squares crossed the east return line. Beside the third, she had written: BYPASS SOUTH. DO NOT WAIT FOR MIRROR FEED.

“Was that her phrasing?” Cal asked.

“Yes.”

“How can you tell?”

“She gave instructions as routes. Destination first when urgency rose. The grid office preferred fault first.”

“Do you remember her writing it?”

“No.”

“Do you remember hearing the instruction?”

Iven searched. A call existed as pressure without words. “I remember that the mirror feed had already failed when she reached intake four. I do not remember whether she told me before or after I sent the convoy

correction.”

Nia said, “Do not force order.”

“I am not forcing it. I am finding where it fails.” He pointed to the log time. “This stamp comes seventeen minutes after the east-grid alarm.”

“The stamp clock drifted during thermal loss,” Cal said.

“By forty-one seconds at this point. Later it drifted faster.”

“What tells you that?”

“Route office clocks synchronized from the same junction until the west conduit broke. Lio’s grid clock used a local thermal standard after that. I corrected them in the deposition.”

Cal brought up the registered distress timing. Iven aligned the two clocks without calculating. He moved the log seventeen millimeters left, then another fraction for thermal drift. The entries fitted the route packet around a missing band.

“That band contains your last conversation?” Cal asked.

“It contains several events. Her call. My change to the rescue approach. A pressure warning from the north cavern. I know their relations to the failure. I do not know their relations to each other.”

The wall showed three records converging on one dark interval. Geometry held their positions around the gap while sequence refused to enter it.

Cal reopened the image beside the log, smaller now. “Can the writing help you recognize Lio’s face?”

“No.”

“Does it make the person in the image feel familiar?”

“No.” The answer came with relief because nothing in it required searching. “It makes the work familiar. That distinction matters.”

Iven read the final open square. Its route sent a crew toward the lower mirror loop after surface collectors had already begun losing heat. “She remained at the grid.”

“The log proves her credential entered this line,” Cal said.

“It proves more than that. She opened the south bypass after the intake lift stopped. The control lived at the junction. No remote path reached it after the west conduit broke.”

“So she had to be there.”

“Yes.”

“Does that help you remember choosing to leave her there?”

Iven’s hand tightened around the pointer. The phrase assigned him a decision he could not place. “I did not choose her station. She did.”

“Crown may ask whether you redirected the convoy knowing she remained.”

“I knew the grid still carried workers. I knew rescue required three bells. I knew the convoy turned away. Do not make missing sequence into missing knowledge.”

Cal marked the distinction in his preparation notes.

The engineering log stayed on the wall after he removed the image. Iven could follow Lio’s open squares from intake four to the failing mirror loop. The path carried her judgment at every branch. It did not restore the person who had made those marks. Her choices had survived in procedure while familiarity had left his body.

“Show another face,” Iven said.

Cal closed the field. “No.”

“You need to know what questions Crown can use.”

“I need to keep counsel from becoming another examiner who spends you for certainty.”

Iven let the pointer rest against his chest. “You already brought the image.”

“At your request after I described it.”

“And now you regret obeying?”

“I regret that the law recognizes the cost only after the harm becomes measurable.”

“That sounds like a judge’s problem.”

“I am not sitting as judge in this room.”

“No. You are sitting as the man who will ask the judge to keep her hands off the controls.”

Cal took the pointer and laid it beside the glucose cup. “Then I need your instruction, not another test.”

Iven looked toward Nia. “What did the returns take first?”

Her answer came too quickly for comfort. “We cannot map individual losses to specific activations.”

“I did not ask which return took which memory.”

“No.” She glanced at the muted image wafer. “Your observed losses affect sequence before spatial relation. Recent Callis events remain better ordered than Eiren events. Faces now require contextual identification. Routes remain precise, including routes learned before the deposition.”

“So sequence, then faces, then geometry.”

“That order fits what we have observed. It may not predict the next loss.”

“What else remains?”

“Preferences formed here. Your request for a Callis window. Your choice to receive the reserve correction before counsel. Your stopping control.”

“Those are records.”

“They are also choices you recall making.”

“Today.”

Nia did not answer.

The room fan cycled. Air crossed the body’s wet lips and cooled them. Iven wanted to ask what lasted after route geometry. The question offered no useful control. A reserve measured in returns could reach zero without a clean final boundary. He might retain a corridor after losing why anyone walked it. He might retain the shape of refusal after losing the event that made refusal necessary.

Cal slid the image wafer into a court sleeve. “Crown intends to use this during identity foundation. I can object that recognition adds no material fact. The image has independent authentication.”

“They want the failure.”

“They may want to test it.”

“Same cost, cleaner noun.”

Nia said, “We can provide the result from this preparation under seal. There is no medical reason to show the image again.”

“Will they accept your result after suspending you?” Iven asked.

“My license concerns operation. My observations remain subject to examination.”

“Why did they suspend it?”

Cal started to answer. Iven lifted one finger.

“Nia.”

She came to the edge of the instrument line. A stripe in the floor separated advice from control. “Seven years ago, Crown contracted me to calibrate what it described as an inert route model inside C-9. The order concealed a live medical line. My cadence enabled or stabilized Return 7. I did not know a body had been activated.”

“Did you suspect?”

“I knew Crown’s refusal to open the return channel departed from best practice. I accepted its density explanation and recorded no objection.”

“Did I see you?”

“No evidence places me in your body room. Your process received my instrument cadence through the linked channel.”

He closed his eyes. Four equal points and one longer descent lived somewhere he could not reach by asking. On his first Callis return, her hands at the controls had made his body expect a pressure change before it came. He had told her she had done this before. Neither of them had understood the sentence.

“Why keep her?” he asked Cal.

“You chose her for technical advice before we reconstructed the event. You may change that choice.”

“I asked Nia.”

She kept her hands at her sides. “Cal retained me because the record names me as your chosen technical adviser. I cannot operate any activation instrument. If you withdraw the preference, I leave.”

“Would you leave if Cal ordered it?”

“Yes.”

“Would you argue?”

“On the record, once.”

That sounded like her. Or it sounded like the woman he had known only through present returns. He possessed no earlier face for comparison. Trust had become another route: not recognition, but a sequence of observed choices. Nia had told him 2.1 before counsel. She had built a stop control that removed authority from her own station. She had admitted the seventh event before Crown could use it as a hidden blade.

“Stay,” he said. “Do not touch the controls.”

“I cannot.”

“That has not stopped institutions from finding a special interpretation.”

“It will stop me.”

Cal asked, “Do you want that preference recorded?”

“Yes. Include the conflict.”

The timing lamp opened its thread. Iven stated that Nia should remain for technical explanation despite her participation under concealed conditions. He did not forgive her. Forgiveness required a memory of the person before and after harm. He had only the present facts and the choice they supported.

When the thread sealed, Cal brought up Crown’s proposed examination sequence. It contained forty-two questions grouped under identity, route competency, event chronology, command authentication, and remedy relevance. Iven read only the headings.

“Which requires Lio?” he asked.

“Identity question six. Chronology questions eleven through fourteen. Crown argues that her grid role connects your route reconstruction to actual thermal conditions.”

“Her engineering log does that.”

“They may argue you learned the route from the log after waking.”

“Then ask for a route absent from the log.”

Cal opened the Eiren grid index. “Which one?”

Iven selected a maintenance bypass between intake four and mirror junction south. Lio’s preserved log named

the endpoints but not the path. He traced it around two flooded conduits, through a hand-cut service opening, then down an unfinished stair that ended above the junction.

Nia compared the route to pre-failure construction records. "The opening appears on a repair permit from eleven months before the collapse. The stair appears on no final map."

"Lio used it to reach a cracked return pipe," Iven said.

"Do you remember going with her?" Cal asked.

"I remember the route."

"Do you remember why you were there?"

"No."

"Her repair permit lists no route cartographer."

"Then perhaps she described it. Perhaps I walked it. The geometry does not tell me which."

Cal marked the answer. "Crown will call that contamination between memory and record."

"It is contamination between memory and losing memory."

The body-load line climbed as he tried to place the trip. He could see the unfinished stair without seeing feet upon it. The service opening had sharp metal along its lower edge. Someone had wrapped cloth around it. He knew to duck left, then rotate one shoulder. No day attached itself. No voice told him why he had entered.

Nia said, "Demand has crossed the preparation ceiling."

"I have not used the stop."

"You set a ceiling for medical baseline. We agreed not to enter broad recall."

"Can we finish the question list?" Cal asked.

Iven counted five headings still unopened. Each contained paths into sequence, faces, decisions. A rehearsal might reveal which questions did the most damage. That knowledge would be purchased with the damage it predicted.

"No," he said. "Seal the list."

Cal closed it at once.

"Not merely close it. Mark that I reject further rehearsal."

"Reason?"

"Because preparation consumes the capacity it claims to protect. Crown gets one examination under the signed stopping rule. They do not get a smaller private version first."

The timing lamp recorded his refusal. Iven felt no triumph. He had chosen ignorance about the hazards because measuring them repeated the hazard.

The court resonantist asked through the console, "Do you want descent now?"

He checked his hand. Tremor had increased. Thumb still reached the first joint of the middle finger. Speech remained easier.

"Not yet."

Nia moved the blank wall where Lio's image had been out of his direct view. "What remains to decide?"

"One question for counsel."

Cal drew his chair closer. "Ask."

Iven returned to the route field. His line from the quarters to the grid remained visible, precise through every turn. At its end, the system had placed a neutral dot where Lio's verified image located her. The dot carried position without face, duty without voice. It would remain after this body descended because the court record had captured it. That did not make the dot a person. It made the Court responsible for what the person had chosen while present.

"If I stop tomorrow," Iven said, "you may have unfinished testimony."

"Yes."

"If I do not come back, Crown will say the unfinished part matters more than the part I gave."

"They will."

"Can a person make a decision that survives their absence?"

Cal's eyes went to the route ending. "Existing law protects some decisions after ordinary death. A will. A medical refusal made before incapacity. It has not recognized this form."

"I did not ask what it recognizes."

"No." Cal placed both palms on his knees. "A person can make such a decision. Whether this Court will obey it remains unsettled."

"Then settle your part before mine runs out."

Iven spoke his stopping phrase. The independent resonantist acknowledged. As the twelve-second taper began, the route line stayed fixed on the wall.

Lio's dot rested at the thermal grid. Iven could not give it her face. He could still show exactly how she had reached it.

Chapter 18 — Do Not Call Me Again

<!-- POV: Iven Ko -->

<!-- Day 24; Court of Continuance merits chamber -->

Iven woke to the Court already in session.

The first sound his body made entered the record: a wet breath drawn through a throat that had not existed twenty minutes earlier. The merits chamber answered with ventilation and the small click of a timing lamp opening its thread. Above him, three acoustic baffles curved toward the judges' bench. Their edges helped him judge distance before his vision cleared.

"Identity check only," Nia said from his right.

Her voice came from beyond the instrument line. The independent resonantist stood closer, one hand on the descent control and one above the saline regulator. Iven did not know the operator's name. That choice had survived the night.

"Iven Ko," he said.

"Place?"

"Callis Court of Continuance, axial merits chamber."

"Purpose?"

"To give evidence about the Eiren rescue turn under a stopping protocol I control."

Sena Pell leaned toward her bench microphone. "The Court acknowledges the protocol. Either recorded command initiates medical descent without further permission. No party may continue questioning after acknowledgment begins."

Ada sat at the Crown table below the bench. She wore no route emblem. A stack of physical schedule sheets rested beneath her left hand, each corner aligned. Cal occupied the table nearest Iven's bed with one sealed wafer and no paper.

Nia asked, "Do you want the window open?"

The chamber's outer wall could show Callis rotating against the fixed dark or remain opaque. Iven had chosen the real view during his standing hearing because no memory packet had told him to want it. Today, movement beyond the glass would consume attention he needed elsewhere.

"Keep it closed."

The wall stayed gray.

"Medical baseline permits examination," the resonantist said.

Cal rose. "Chief Justice, before testimony, the witness asks that his present reserve correction, stop authority, and refusal of further rehearsal enter as a single exhibit."

"Crown has no objection to the reserve correction," Ada said. "We preserve our scope objection."

“Preserved,” Sena replied. “Proceed.”

Cal came close enough that Iven could see the gray at his temples. “Iven, do you understand that you remain under oath from the standing proceeding?”

“Yes.”

“Do you understand that the Court may assess unfinished testimony differently from completed testimony?”

“Yes.”

“Who decides when this examination ends?”

“I do.”

Cal opened the first route field. Three white points appeared in a triangle around the Meridian Mouth. A fourth point marked Eiren beyond the stable approach corridor.

“Tell the Court your work at Eiren Reach.”

“I maintained civil route geometry for emergency freight, heat exchange, and external rescue approaches. During the thermal failure I received the convoy track and calculated a viable detuning schedule.”

“What did rescue require?”

“Three Crown choir bells removed from Mouth stabilization for nineteen hours. Their tuned mass had to travel with the convoy through the shear boundary, hold an approach lane, then return after Eiren’s lower caverns reached evacuation temperature.”

“Did that guarantee rescue?”

“No. It created a viable window. Pressure closure remained uncertain. Surface transfer carried further risk.”

“What happened to the three bells?”

Iven placed his finger on the triangular points. They moved inward rather than outward. “Crown held them at the Mouth.”

“Was that motion consistent with navigation loss?”

“No. A lost convoy would show correction search, dispersed timing, or an emergency mass release. These bells received synchronized vectors. They turned together.”

Cal brought up the pilot telemetry admitted earlier. The three points bent away from Eiren and tightened around the corridor.

“What command governed that turn?”

“Dispatcher code AR-6.”

Ada’s hand stopped on the schedule sheets.

Cal asked, “What did that code mean in the notation used forty-seven years ago?”

“Authority Retention, level six. It ordered all controlled mass to prioritize corridor continuity over local rescue. Only central dispatch could issue it across three separately piloted bells.”

“Could a pilot generate AR-6 alone?”

“No.”

“Could shear damage generate it?”

“No. Damage can corrupt a code. It cannot authenticate the same command to three craft through separate channels.”

“Did you receive the code directly?”

“Yes.”

“Where?”

“Eiren route office, lower civic level, after the surface relay began overheating.”

“Do you remember the sequence around receipt?”

Iven watched the route field. Eiren lay at one edge, the Mouth at another. Between them, sequence opened into a blank he could not cross. “I remember the code. I remember plotting its consequence. I do not reliably remember whether Lio called from the grid before or after it reached me.”

“Does that uncertainty change the command’s route effect?”

“No.”

“Why not?”

“The bells’ telemetry carries authenticated send time. My deposition carries the received code. The route solution shows the commanded vector. Lio’s call does not cause any of those facts.”

Cal displayed two modeled paths. The first sent three bells toward Eiren. The second closed them around the Mouth.

“Which path did the convoy take?”

Iven touched the second line. “This one.”

“What happened to Eiren’s rescue window?”

“It closed. Without tuned mass, the convoy could not cross the shear boundary. Eiren’s thermal lattice failed over thirty-one hours.”

“Did your original deposition distinguish accident from decision?”

“Yes.”

“How?”

“I encoded both available routes, the nineteen-hour requirement, the authenticated command, and the observed

turn. A navigation failure would remove choice from the record. AR-6 put choice back into it.”

Cal separated the three pilot tracks. “Show the Court how synchronized command differs from a shared response to shear.”

Iven moved the first track to its raw heading. “This pilot received the command spinward of the fault boundary. It corrected by seven degrees.” He selected the second. “This one had already entered lateral drift. It corrected by eleven degrees and reduced mass output to prevent overshoot.” The third line approached from below the route plane. “This pilot rolled before turning because its bell could not cross the new vector at full tune.”

The tracks looked different until their corrected paths converged around the Mouth.

“If shear drove them,” Iven said, “their initial vectors would diverge according to position. If a general corridor alarm drove them, each pilot would choose a safe hold and await mass coordination. These three craft performed different maneuvers toward one assigned geometry.”

“What supplied that geometry?”

“AR-6 carried a central hold solution with individual approach vectors.”

“Could your deposition have generated the apparent convergence after the fact?”

“No. Pilot telemetry came from independent flight recorders. My layer predicted where their lines would meet. The later recovery found them inside that tolerance.”

Cal overlaid the deposition solution as a thin amber ring. All three tracks entered it.

Iven felt the body-load line rise, then settle. The calculation required no face and no lost conversation. Distance, bearing, tune, correction. The returns had left him the part Crown once needed him to simplify.

“Does this establish why central dispatch chose corridor retention?” Cal asked.

“No.”

“Does it establish that they chose it?”

“Yes.”

The timing lamp pulsed once to mark the answer. No one in the chamber moved.

Cal opened the old Crown distress classification. “Official history calls the convoy loss unavoidable. Is that description consistent with what you observed?”

“No.”

“What description would be accurate?”

“The convoy was redirected to preserve the Meridian Mouth after Crown received a viable Eiren rescue schedule.”

Ada rose. “Objection. The witness can establish route events, not executive knowledge.”

Sena looked to Cal.

"I asked what he observed," Cal said.

"His answer assigned receipt to Crown as an institution. Authentication does not establish which office read the rescue schedule before dispatch."

"Limit the answer," Sena said. "The Court receives it as route evidence. Executive attribution requires separate foundation."

Cal nodded. "Iven, can you identify the dispatch office that signed AR-6?"

"Central mass coordination."

"Can you identify an executive who ordered that office to send it?"

"No."

"Can you identify whether central coordination received your viable schedule before sending the code?"

"Yes. Its acknowledgment checksum appears in my deposition."

Cal enlarged the checksum. "No further direct questions."

The phrase changed the room. Until then, every route had moved toward a fact Iven still held. Ada could now choose where to press. Her questions waited in the aligned sheets under her hand.

Sena said, "Crown may examine."

Ada approached the foot of the bed but remained outside the medical line. "Iven Ko, do you recall composing the route deposition inside C-9?"

"Yes."

"Do you recall every layer?"

"No."

"Which layers do you recall?"

"The route alternatives, dispatch authentication, rescue requirement, convoy turn, and Eiren thermal progression."

"Do you recall encoding personal memory?"

"Some."

"Do you recall deciding what to omit?"

"No."

"Then you cannot exclude the possibility that your present account combines the original deposition with information shown to you on Callis."

"I can distinguish some encoded facts from present preferences. I cannot establish the source of every remembered detail."

Ada lifted one sheet. "The pilot telemetry shown today reached Callis after your first public activation. Correct?"

"Yes."

"You had already alleged a commanded turn before seeing it?"

"Yes."

"Your allegation could have shaped how later technicians interpreted the telemetry."

"The telemetry existed before my allegation."

"Interpretation can still change."

"So can concealment."

Cal did not object. Ada let the answer enter.

"Do you recognize this code table?" she asked.

A Crown schedule page appeared. AR classifications filled two columns. Iven read the level-six entry. Corridor authority retention under distributed mass threat.

"Yes."

"Does it contain the word Eiren?"

"No."

"Rescue?"

"No."

"Abandon?"

"No."

"Then AR-6 did not itself order anyone to abandon Eiren."

"It ordered the three bells away from the only route that could reach Eiren."

"That describes effect, not text."

"Routes make text physical."

Ada's eyes held his. "Could central coordination have believed your approach window already closed?"

"They acknowledged the schedule while it remained viable."

"Could they have believed detuning would close the Mouth permanently?"

"My projection gave a closure risk of eight to fourteen years under the severe branch, not permanent loss."

"Could that closure have isolated six habitats?"

“Not the same six. Habitat dependencies differed forty-seven years ago.”

“Could it have killed people elsewhere?”

“Yes.”

“How many?”

“I did not hold complete population and reserve data.”

“Then you cannot tell this Court how many lives AR-6 preserved.”

“No.”

“Can you tell it how many Eiren lives a successful rescue would have saved?”

“No. A viable window does not guarantee full evacuation.”

Ada placed the sheet down. “Your evidence proves a choice between risks. It does not prove that the choice lacked justification.”

“My evidence proves Crown called the choice a navigation loss afterward.”

“That concerns later reporting.”

“It concerns whether anyone believed the route absolved them.”

The body-load indicator sounded once. Nia stepped to the edge of her line.

“Phase demand has reached the first warning band,” she said. “Narrow retrieval only.”

Ada turned toward Sena. “Crown has not entered autobiographical examination.”

“You have entered comparative casualty modeling,” Cal said.

“It bears on the claimed meaning of the command.”

Sena addressed Iven. “Do you choose to continue?”

“Yes, within the warning band.”

The judge marked the choice. Ada waited until the resonantist confirmed stable breath support.

“Mr. Ko, did you know Lio Senn remained at the thermal grid?”

“I know it now and encoded it then.”

“That did not answer whether you presently remember knowing it before the turn.”

“I do not retain reliable event order across that interval.”

“Do you recognize her verified image?”

“I identify her by context. I do not recognize her face.”

“Could your failure to recognize faces affect identification of a dispatcher?”

“AR-6 uses authenticated code, not facial identification.”

“Could sequence loss affect whether the acknowledgment preceded the command?”

“The independent timestamps establish order.”

“Your correction of those timestamps relies on Eiren clock drift. Who calculated that drift?”

“I did.”

“During the event or on Callis?”

“During the deposition. Callis records later confirmed the relation.”

“Do you recall performing the original calculation?”

“I retain the geometry and result.”

“But not the act?”

“Not as a sequence I can watch.”

Ada moved to the route wall. “Then let us test the calculation from raw clocks without relying on your recovered result.”

Nia said, “That requires broad reconstruction.”

“Crown disputes the foundation.”

“The pilot telemetry and deposition checksum establish it independently,” Cal said.

“They establish a match only after his drift correction. Crown may test whether the witness can reproduce the correction.”

Sena read the body-load line. “How much cost?”

The resonantist answered, “Unknown. Prior route work remained below face retrieval. Event-order reconstruction drove the warning rise yesterday.”

“I refused further rehearsal yesterday,” Iven said.

Ada faced him. “A refusal to rehearse does not answer examination.”

“No. It answers who gets to spend the uncertainty.”

Crown’s schedule sheets remained on the table. Six habitats depended on the Mouth now. Ada had not denied the old turn. She disputed what could be done with it, and what could be proved before the body carrying it ran out. Iven understood her fear without accepting her claim to his remaining memory.

Sena asked, “Do you choose to attempt the calculation?”

“No.”

Ada said, "Then Crown moves to treat the drift correction as untested witness interpretation."

"Argument later," Sena replied. "Ask another question."

Ada returned to her table and selected a different sheet. "Did Crown personnel perform nine prior activations?"

"The physical record supports nine."

"Do you remember all nine?"

"No."

"Do you remember any Crown examiner by name?"

"No."

"Do you remember being asked for a controllable statement?"

The phrase struck without opening a scene. A room narrowed around him. Someone had asked for fewer causes, one fault, one route. The memory carried pressure at both wrists and no face.

"I remember the demand," he said.

"What words?"

"I cannot recover them without searching."

"Please search."

Nia stepped forward. "Objection on medical grounds."

Ada did not turn. "The prior activation history bears on contamination and coaching. Crown needs to know what propositions entered the signal before Callis."

The warning tone sounded again. Iven's right hand had begun to shake against the linen. He pressed it flat, not yet forming the stop signal.

Cal rose. "Crown has the sealed return ledger. It can identify its own questions without compelling him to reconstruct the harm."

"The ledger contains clipped purpose fields, not full examination."

"Because Crown withheld the full records."

"Privilege remains under review."

Sena lifted one hand. "The witness may answer whether he recalls. He will not be ordered to induce broader recall."

Ada looked at Iven. "Do you choose to search for the wording?"

"No."

"Do you remember giving a false answer during any prior activation?"

“No.”

“Does that mean you did not, or that you cannot remember?”

“I cannot remember.”

“Do you remember contradicting yourself?”

“No.”

“Same qualification?”

“Yes.”

“Do you remember whether your original deposition named a specific executive?”

“No.”

“Will you search?”

“No.”

Ada set one sheet aside and uncovered another. “Crown seeks leave for expanded examination of the deposition’s personal layer, limited to source discrimination and prior inconsistent statements.”

Nia said, “That scope could consume the remaining warning margin before descent completes.”

“We can recess and resume under a separate activation,” Ada replied.

The chamber seemed to contract around the sentence.

A separate activation. Another body, another opening breath, another set of careful reasons why the question could not wait. The case might gain an executive name. It might gain no useful fact. Either result would leave less of him available to refuse the next request.

Cal spoke toward the bench. “No separate activation has been authorized.”

“A future request remains available if examination cannot finish today,” Ada said.

Iven looked at the stop control reflected in the wall. The independent resonantist had not moved. Nia could advise and could not touch it. Sena could limit questions and still leave tomorrow unsettled. Cal could object until his words became doctrine or failed to.

Only Iven could use what the protocol already gave him.

He pressed thumb to the first joint of his middle finger.

The resonantist saw it. “Physical stop acknowledged. Descent begins.”

Ada said, “Crown preserves unfinished cross-examination.”

“Preserved,” Sena replied. “No further questions.”

The route wall dimmed. Saline warmed at Iven’s wrist. Twelve seconds had felt short in preparation. Here each one held enough room for someone to propose another return.

"I have another preference," he said.

Cal came to the bedside. "State it for the lamp."

The timing lamp brightened. Iven's breath support had begun to soften the edges of speech.

"Do not call me again," he said.

No one interrupted.

"Not for cross-examination. Not for an executive name. Not if another answer would win this case. No further activation of my conscious pattern. Preserve the record without making me enter it again."

Sena asked, "Do you understand that this choice may leave material questions unanswered?"

"Yes."

"Do you understand that Crown may challenge the legal force of a preference after this body deactivates?"

"Yes."

"Do you make this choice free of instruction from counsel, adviser, or operator?"

"Yes."

Cal said, "Is this preference limited to the present examination?"

"No. This is my final embodiment."

Nia's face held no plea. "Do you want C-9 preserved?"

"Yes. Preserve it. Do not use preservation as permission."

The lamp requested final confirmation. Iven could no longer feel the middle finger under his thumb. He kept the hand in place anyway.

"I choose not to be respeaken again," he said. "The choice belongs to me even when I cannot repeat it."

The timing thread sealed.

Breath support carried the next inhalation. His own effort did not. The chamber's distances remained clear: Cal at one meter, Nia beyond the line, Ada at the Crown table, Sena above them, the route wall six meters left of the bed. Faces softened before positions did.

C-9 drew the active pattern down through the leads. Iven felt no bell, only the loss of the room's vertical measure. The route display kept Eiren and the Mouth on opposite sides of the gray wall. Between them, three bells still held the turn he had named.

The last thing he could place was Nia's empty hand resting outside the controls.

Chapter 19 — Evidence Without a Witness

<!-- POV: Cal Orsen -->

<!-- Days 25–26; Court of Continuance, Callis axial chambers -->

Cal had not yet removed the spent timing lamp when Crown asked the Court to compel another activation.

The lamp stood beside the witness place, its green filament dark after recording the final breath of the vocal body. Linen restraints lay folded against the chair arms. A technician had drained the warm saline from the support collar and capped both lines, but a clear drop still trembled at one connector whenever Callis corrected its roll. No person occupied the chair. The court record nonetheless remained fixed on it.

Ada Neme rose at Crown's table with a motion wafer in one hand. She looked as though the hearing had merely paused for an equipment change.

"Crown moves to strike the accusation concerning dispatcher code AR-6," she said. "In the alternative, Crown requests completion of cross-examination under the Compulsory Evidence Clause."

Cal kept his palm over his microphone. Around the axial chamber, paper-thin acoustic baffles curved between the delegations. They had absorbed Iven's last words without echo. Now they made Ada's request sound close enough to touch.

Chief Justice Sena Pell examined the wafer transmitted to her bench. "Completion by what means?"

"Controlled access to the surviving phase record. The current embodiment ended before Crown could test scope, source contamination, or whether the alleged memory had been reinforced through counsel's preparation."

"The witness exercised a stopping authority recognized by this Court."

"While embodied," Ada said. "Standing in continuance ended with active coherence. Property rules govern what remains unless the Court extends personhood beyond the Articles."

Cal opened his microphone. "The Court cannot use expiration of a right to authorize the act the right prohibited."

Jalen Orr sat behind Ada, three nested route arcs fastened at his collar. His face had not changed when Iven refused further calling. It changed now by less than a blink.

Ada turned toward Cal. "You are assuming the prohibition survived its holder."

"I am asking the Court not to destroy evidence while deciding that question."

"The unfinished cross-examination prevents the accusation from carrying dispositive force. Preservation cannot become a method for admitting one side of a contested memory."

Sena raised two fingers. Both microphones closed.

She did not confer with the other six justices. Their remote seats showed delay clocks from three habitats, none longer than eleven seconds. Every word spoken in Callis reached those benches after a measurable interval. Cal had spent his career treating such intervals as protection against impulse. Today each clock measured how

quickly a preference could be converted back into property.

Sena opened the common channel. "Crown will identify the access it seeks."

Ada sent a technical schedule to the court display. Cal read the heading first: narrow-band route retrieval, one embodied interval, projected coherence cost 0.18 to 0.31 return. The estimate treated stress as a controlled variable. It also assumed the nine earlier activations had left the same distribution of damage Nia had mapped before the merits hearing.

"Your schedule requires a vocal body," Sena said.

"For authentication, yes."

"Then call it what it requires."

Ada's jaw tightened. "A limited respeaking."

The word settled into the chamber without the protection of a euphemism.

Cal touched the edge of his record slate. He could oppose the request through the preservation order, through evidentiary fairness, or through the bodily authority the Court had already recognized. Each path failed at a different seam. Preservation delayed destruction but did not decide ownership. Evidentiary fairness favored Crown once cross-examination remained incomplete. Bodily authority belonged to persons, and the Articles tied Iven's personhood to active coherence.

A reversible order could hold C-9 for a day. It could not reverse another read.

"Crown's estimate excludes memory loss outside the requested route field," Cal said when Sena gave him the channel. "The last activation demonstrated loss of facial recognition and sequence. Narrow prompts did not confine prior damage to narrow categories."

Ada answered at once. "Then the Court should permit observation without broad recall."

"Observation by whom?"

"Court-appointed resonantists."

"On what subject?"

"The remaining property."

Cal let the term remain audible. "Crown proposes to reconstruct a person so technicians may observe property."

"I propose a lawful test of an evidentiary object whose temporary personhood has ended."

"What would the object be asked?"

Ada looked down at the schedule. "Whether AR-6 came from direct sensory memory, a route model, or later reconstruction."

"And if he refuses?"

"He cannot refuse before he exists."

Sena's timing lamp lit amber. "That answer reaches the issue more directly than Crown may intend."

No one at the Crown table moved.

Cal saw the shape of the argument then. The motion did not merely ask whether completed testimony remained admissible. It asked whether a preference could bind the conditions required to produce its future holder. Existing doctrine had no name for that interval. The law recognized a person during activation and material outside it. Crown intended to cross the gap by acting before any person could object.

He requested the technical record of Iven's stopping decision. Nia's adviser feed remained dark; her license suspension barred her from operating the court instruments. Osei Marr occupied the archive station instead. He sent three synchronized traces: vocal pressure, body-control cessation, and the phase response captured within C-9 when Iven formed the refusal.

The display showed no image of Iven. Cal had ordered all body-room video sealed after deactivation. He would not let the chamber study a dead man's face for signs of sincerity when the operative record lay elsewhere.

Osei enlarged the final eleven seconds. A set of phase lines tightened around a route relation Cal could not read. The geometry persisted after the vocal trace ended.

Ada approached the display by permission. "This proves a state change in the bell."

"It records a change coincident with the expressed preference," Cal said.

"It may record fatigue."

"That remains possible."

"Or cooling in the vocal coupling."

"Cooling remains possible."

"Then you lack authentication."

Cal looked toward the vacant chair instead of the lines. "Authentication can remain disputed without authorizing the act under dispute."

Ada returned to her table. "Crown cannot test the state change if every test counts as violation. Counsel has built a closed claim: the record says do not examine the record, and examination would destroy the proof. No adversarial court can accept that structure without surrendering judgment to an unverifiable remnant."

"She did not say unverifiable," Sena said.

Ada faced the bench. "Then require verification."

"Through the same destructive access the preference forbids?"

"Through the only method current law recognizes."

For the first time since the motion began, frustration entered Ada's voice. Cal did not mistake it for cruelty. She had spent twelve years defending a system whose schedules fed six habitats. Her fear counted living bodies, pump margins, catalyst reserves. That fear did not grant Crown use of another body. It did make the legal shortcut more dangerous because reasonable people could call it necessity.

Sena recessed the hearing for forty minutes and ordered both sides to preserve present conditions.

The chamber emptied by routes assigned to avoid contact between counsel. Cal remained at his table until the public gallery's pressure door sealed. The axial floor carried almost no weight. His case wafers would have drifted if their magnetic corners had not held them in exact rows.

He removed the spent timing lamp at last.

A clerk met him at the evidence door with a custody sleeve. Cal slid the lamp inside. The sleeve recorded its dark filament, seal number, and the elapsed interval from deactivation. It asked for an item description.

He entered: Timing record, witness stopping decision.

The terminal rejected *witness* because active standing had ended.

Available categories appeared beneath the field: phase property, court instrument, biological waste, disputed salvage, other.

Cal selected other.

"Custodian Orsen." Sena's voice came from the passage behind him.

He sealed the sleeve before turning. "Chief Justice."

She had left her black hearing coat at the bench. In the plain gray underlayer, she looked less severe and more tired. A physical docket strip curled between her fingers.

"You argued around the admissibility question," she said.

"Crown's proposed remedy would decide the rights question first."

"Crown says no rights exist to decide."

"Crown also accepted his personhood yesterday."

"For the duration."

Cal glanced through the evidence door window. C-9 did not sit there. The bell remained in the archive mass ring under a field that would fail if anyone attempted removal. Yet every category on the terminal had already reached for it.

Sena flattened the docket strip against the wall rail. "Suppose the refusal survives. Does every expressed preference survive?"

"No."

"Which ones?"

"I do not know yet."

"Suppose a signal person orders their estate transferred during an activation. Does that command bind descendants a century later?"

"Not by virtue of embodiment alone."

“Suppose they prohibit any study of a bell that also contains public navigation data.”

“Then the Court separates the conscious layer from unrelated records where access permits it.”

“And where it does not?”

Cal considered the custody sleeve in his hand. “Then necessity carries a burden proportional to the destruction.”

“That sounds like ordinary balancing.”

“It may not be enough.”

Sena gave him the docket strip. “It is not enough. Ordinary balancing lets the institution create necessity, then spend the weaker party to answer it.”

The words did not absolve his argument. They cut away its easiest support.

On the strip, Sena had marked three questions in her narrow script. Could a novel preference retain force after active standing ended? What proof authenticated such a preference without renewed embodiment? What limits prevented dead preferences from governing living institutions?

Beneath them she had written one instruction: briefs by first lamp, Day 28.

“You are ordering full argument?” Cal asked.

“I am ordering you to discover whether you have one.”

“Crown requested immediate access.”

“They will receive a temporary refusal.”

“On preservation grounds?”

“On judicial ignorance.” Sena pressed her thumb to the docket seal. “The Court does not know whether the refusal survives deactivation. Until we know, no one may make the question impossible to answer.”

A seal line burned through the strip. Cal felt the small heat through his glove.

“Crown will say delay consumes habitat reserve,” he said.

“Crown may prove that in the remedy phase. Today they asked to consume a witness.”

She left him beside the evidence door.

Cal carried the sealed instruction to his workroom at the end of the axial passage. The room had one fixed table, two handrails, and an acoustic baffle that lowered when the door closed. He fastened the docket strip under a reading lens and called up the Continuance Articles.

The Articles had grown through salvage disputes, inheritance claims, military beacons, and medical continuities. Their drafters had feared fraud first. They required active demonstration because any stored preference could be fabricated by whoever held the substrate. The Novel Preference Test answered that fear by demanding a choice not recoverable from recorded intent. Once a remnant made such a choice, the Articles granted standing in continuance.

Then the text stopped caring.

It specified what happened to property during personhood. It said nothing about what happened to a person's choice after active coherence ended. Medical directives offered the closest analogy, but those directives belonged to continuously living people whose bodies could no longer answer. Testamentary law offered another, yet wills transferred property and did not forbid creation of the testator. Orders against destructive sampling protected rare cultural remains, though not because the remains had asked.

Cal opened his old ration docket from the Pellin shortage. During that crisis, he had authorized temporary pump seizures because waiting for a full appeal would have starved three districts of heat. He had considered reversibility: Crown could repay seized catalyst later, reopen contracts, restore title. Nobody could restore the days of cold, but the machinery and accounts remained subject to correction.

C-9 admitted no such repair. A destructive read spent the only state that could prove or resist the act.

His clerk, Vey Aru, entered after knocking against the baffle frame. She held a stack of printed authorities clipped to a tether.

"I found eleven cases on post-deactivation directives," she said. "Nine concern estate transfers. One concerns a military navigation remnant that requested erasure after mission review. The command erased it before appeal."

"What happened to the appeal?"

"Dismissed. No remaining subject with standing."

"And the last?"

"A medical signal refused a second embodiment. The hospital complied. No one contested."

"So the useful cases vanished before producing law."

Vey secured the stack to his table. "Compliance leaves fewer precedents than violation."

She had also brought the archive fraud docket Cal requested during recess. He opened its oldest case. A freight consortium had fabricated six dead navigators from copied training traces, then used their supposed preferences to contest corridor fees. None had formed a novel choice. The fraud had succeeded for nine months because the consortium controlled both the substrate and the technicians who certified it.

Crown would place that case at the center of its answer. If a remnant's instruction survived without active challenge, whoever held the glass might manufacture a silent principal with unlimited patience. Estates could acquire obedient ancestors. Ministries could preserve one emergency preference beyond the emergency. Corporations could put old executives between living regulators and every locked archive.

Cal read the certification defects. All six traces repeated phrases present in the training packets. Their phase states remained unchanged when they spoke. The technicians had destroyed their source instruments before independent inspection.

"Iven's record differs at every point," Vey said. "Independent custody lamp. Court-supervised embodiment. Novel choice against litigation interest. Phase change at expression."

"Those differences authenticate one decision. They do not yet define a general test."

“What else would you require?”

Cal marked four columns on a blank wafer: valid standing, informed scope, contemporaneous phase change, independent custody. A fifth requirement resisted compact language. The preference had to concern access to the substrate whose destruction would prevent later refusal. Otherwise a narrow bodily rule could spread into control over unrelated people and property.

He wrote necessary relation over the last column, then disliked its neutrality. Necessary for whom, decided by whom, under what pressure? Institutions had always possessed better nouns for the acts they wanted.

“The holder must understand that access spends coherence,” he said. “The refusal must identify that access. The Court must verify both without performing it.”

Vey pointed to the fourth column. “Independent custody fails if every qualified resonantist works for Crown or Callis.”

“Then qualification cannot substitute for adversarial observation.”

“Two technicians?”

“Two instruments measuring different conditions, with hostile review of method.”

She added the language. “You are writing an evidence rule.”

“I am trying not to write a religion.”

The remark came out harsher than he intended. Cal removed it from the dictation channel. He had heard advocates turn remnants into sacred objects whenever technical scrutiny threatened a sympathetic claim. Reverence could deny personhood as efficiently as ownership. A relic could not revise its answer, withdraw permission, or choose an inconvenient end.

Vey looked toward the sealed acoustic baffle. “Crown will still demand a live challenge.”

“Then we need a method that lets them challenge the instrument rather than the person.”

Cal read the military dismissal. The court had called the matter moot because destruction eliminated both claimant and disputed property. The opinion contained no malice. Its judges had applied categories available to them. A person who ceased could not hold standing; property that ceased could not receive a remedy.

“What does Crown cite?” he asked.

“The extraction cases. They argue active standing cannot reach backward to prevent a lawful operation begun while the remnant counts as property.”

“But their operation cannot be completed without active standing recurring.”

“That seems to be their problem.”

“It becomes ours if we say so.”

Vey waited. She had served him long enough to hear the difference between doubt and instruction.

Cal moved the Articles aside and placed Iven’s final preference record beneath the lens. The text transcript

mattered, but not alone. A sentence could be coached. A voice could be cut. The surrounding decision carried more: Iven had been offered the chance to continue, understood the legal consequences, exercised an already recognized stopping authority, and chose an outcome harmful to his stated litigation goal. He had surrendered the strongest remaining evidence rather than submit to further use.

That choice satisfied the same structure as the Novel Preference Test. It did not repeat original distress intent. It arose during valid personhood. It changed what Crown could obtain and what Iven could ever prove.

The law did not need to preserve every preference forever. It needed to prevent institutions from waiting until the holder could no longer defend one concerning his own reconstruction.

Cal dictated the first line of his brief.

“A valid preference concerning destructive access does not lose force merely because the person’s exercise of that preference ends embodiment.”

Vey read it on her slate. “Crown will call that personhood after death.”

“Then we distinguish force from personhood.”

“How?”

He looked at Sena’s three questions. Fraud. Authentication. Rule by absent voices. Any theory broad enough to answer the first motion could become an instrument for old wealth, preserved executives, or fabricated ancestors. Crown would be right to attack it.

“We do not give the absent person a vote,” Cal said. “We require the living Court to honor a valid refusal about what may be done to that person’s remaining body.”

“Is the phase record a body?”

“For this purpose, it may have to be.”

Vey unfastened a fresh wafer. “That needs proof.”

“Yes.”

“And a limit.”

“Yes.”

Outside the workroom, the first-lamp bell sounded through Callis. Its tone reached the table as a vibration rather than music. Cal removed the hearing transcript from his draft stack. Testimony could establish the old crime if corroborated. It could not establish the authority of the refusal without making Iven’s words carry every burden at once.

He set the transcript aside and drew Osei’s phase traces toward him.

By the time the second lamp lit, Crown’s unfinished cross-examination no longer occupied the heading of Cal’s brief. He wrote a narrower question above the geometry record, one that asked what the Court could authenticate without forcing anyone back into the chair.

Chapter 20 — The Custodian Charged

<!-- POV: Nia Daro -->

<!-- Days 27–28; Callis Archive tribunal and mass ring -->

Nia pressed her thumb into the tribunal seal while the charge clerk read out every act she had already admitted.

The seal took a capillary image through her glove and fixed it beside her name. Its glass warmed by two degrees. She kept her hand in place until the clerk told her to remove it.

“Unauthorized duplication of a restricted thermal map,” the clerk said. “Failure to disclose prior instrument involvement before assuming advisory custody. Maintenance activity under a compromised evidentiary chain. Distribution of archive evidence beyond the administrative seal.”

“I disclosed the instrument involvement when I established it,” Nia said.

The clerk looked toward the three members of the Callis Archive discipline panel. “Do you contest the stated acts?”

“No.”

“Do you contest intent?”

“I contest Crown’s description of the copy as distribution. I sent it to a Court custodian under preservation authority.”

Ada Neme sat at the opposing table with two Crown counsel and a sealed transit case. She had not presented the charges. Callis had charged its own senior resonantist because custody could not mean immunity. Crown had intervened to request transfer of C-9 if the panel found Nia unfit.

The tribunal chamber occupied a maintenance bay rather than a court room. Oil cloth covered the tool lockers. Fan vibration entered through the deck and touched the long table at regular intervals. Nia felt each cycle through the side of her hand. The room had been chosen because archive discipline required a panel to inspect the instruments involved. C-9 remained two pressure doors away, secured in cradle seventeen.

Panel Chair Der Mares adjusted the charge wafer under a physical lens. “The seventh recall bears your calibration signature.”

“Yes.”

“You did not know you were calibrating a conscious phase record.”

“No. Crown designated it as an inert route model.”

“Would a senior resonantist have identified the deception at the time?”

Nia examined the question before answering. Seven years ago, she had received a sealed bell interface, a route-response tolerance sheet, and an instruction not to inspect source layers. Every number had fit ordinary work. The person behind those numbers had not.

“A senior resonantist should have required provenance before calibrating any destructive access path,” she said.

"I accepted the designation because the coupling pulse stayed below the stated read threshold. That threshold had been falsified."

"Then Crown deceived you."

"Yes."

"Does deception remove your professional responsibility?"

"No."

One of the panel members, Ulen Sarr, leaned toward his microphone. "What would you have us punish? Failure to detect a sophisticated concealment or the later breach of seal?"

"The first requires correction of archive practice. The second requires judgment of my choice."

"You are not required to recommend your own sanction."

"I am required to distinguish the acts."

Der Mares set down the wafer. She had worked freight resonance before taking the chair; two fingers on her left hand carried old auric-glass burns. "Then distinguish them."

Nia looked at the timing lamp between them. Its filament recorded without interpretation.

"Seven years ago, I treated a title record as proof of inertness. That error made me useful to an unauthorized recall. On Day Three, I found nine heat blooms and recognized my signature on the seventh. I copied the map because the Crown seal controlling it came from the institution implicated by it. I sent one copy to Custodian Orsen. I did not release the signal or the map to the public."

"Osei Marr later released the count," Ulen said.

"He released nine returns as a number. I neither ordered nor approved it."

"Why did you retain him?"

"Because his breach did not alter C-9, and removing him would have left the bell to technicians with less knowledge of its damage."

"That sounds like operational convenience."

"It was an assessment of preservation risk."

Ada requested the channel. "Crown asks the panel to note that preservation risk now rests substantially on technicians who have each breached a seal."

Nia turned her head far enough to see Ada, not far enough to release the timing lamp from her peripheral vision. "Crown performed nine destructive reads under false designations."

"The old reads remain under merits review."

"My discipline does not restore your credibility."

"No," Ada said. "It removes yours from the custody calculation."

Der Mares cut both microphones. "This panel will not try Crown's conduct through inference, nor permit Crown to try the Eiren merits through a license charge."

The room returned to fan vibration. Nia counted four cycles before the chair reopened her channel.

"Callis archive law permits permanent revocation where a custodian knowingly defeats a lawful seal," Der Mares said. "It permits suspension up to seven years where authority remained genuinely disputed. What sanction do you accept?"

"A five-year loss of activation license."

One Crown counsel looked down at his notes. Ada did not.

Der Mares asked, "Why five?"

"Long enough that I cannot operate another respeaking before this case, my employment, or public attention moves on. Short enough to recognize that I sent the copy into judicial custody rather than private possession."

"You would retain non-activation preservation privileges."

"If the archive permits them."

"And access to C-9?"

"Only under another licensed operator."

The panel withdrew to the tool-locker side of the bay. They did not leave because the chamber's pressure schedule allowed no private room nearby. An acoustic baffle lowered around their end of the table. Nia could see their mouths move without hearing anything.

Osei waited outside the glass partition in a clean repair coat, holding a passive interferometer against his chest. He had not been allowed into the charge session. His eyes went to Nia's hands. She flattened them on the table to show that they did not shake.

Ada came around the opposing table while her counsel packed their wafers.

"Five years will satisfy Callis," she said quietly. "It does not answer Crown's custody petition."

"C-9 belongs under the Court's preservation order."

"Your field around it depends on archive maintenance. Your senior operator has accepted disqualification."

"License suspension does not make the bell transportable."

Ada set one finger on the sealed transit case. Its lid displayed a cradle profile built for a three-meter bell. "Crown can hold the preservation field during transfer."

"You modeled the outer phase load."

"We modeled the bell from the acquisition record."

"The acquisition record calls it inert."

A line tightened beside Ada's mouth. "We have better records."

“Then enter them.”

“I will enter what the present motion requires.”

Nia studied the transit case fasteners. Each carried a fresh ceramic sleeve and a torque indicator. The case had not come from a general seizure store. Crown had built or prepared it for C-9. Its cradle profile assumed stress points hidden beneath the outer housing, details absent from the Callis record.

“You knew the internal supports,” Nia said.

“I know how Crown bells were built forty-seven years ago.”

“Not every bell used three radial seats.”

Ada removed her finger from the lid. “Surrender C-9 after the ruling. Callis can keep mirrored instrument output.”

“A mirror cannot preserve a nonrenewable state.”

“Neither can your damaged field indefinitely.”

Nia looked through the partition at Osei’s interferometer. “We do not need indefinitely.”

The panel baffle rose.

Der Mares read the sanction without ceremony. Five-year suspension of all activation and respeaking privileges. Continued eligibility for passive conservation under a licensed custodian. Mandatory review of every archive calibration performed under Nia’s authority during the preceding ten years. No finding that C-9 should leave Callis. The custody question remained with the Court.

The panel assigned the calibration review to a separate administrative docket and barred it from delaying C-9 custody.

Nia pressed her thumb to the sanction seal. This glass stayed cold.

Her license marker changed before she left the table. A red bar crossed the activation fields on her wrist slate. The archive door recognized the change and denied her usual route to cradle seventeen.

Osei stepped up beside the panel clerk. He held out his own slate.

“Licensed operator Marr requesting supervised access for passive preservation,” he said.

The clerk checked his credentials twice. Osei had qualified for full instrument custody only the previous year. Until that moment, Nia had signed above him on every consequential task.

“Supervisor?” the clerk asked.

Der Mares looked at Nia. “Passive adviser Daro, under the sanction just entered.”

The door opened for Osei.

Nia followed him through.

At cradle seventeen, Osei made her stand behind the yellow activation boundary.

The line ran across the gantry twenty centimeters from the control rail. Nia had painted it herself after a novice touched a live coupling during certification. Her body knew where to stop without looking. Today the archive lock knew too. When she leaned close to examine the interferometer lead, her wrist slate vibrated once in warning.

“Your instrument,” she said, stepping back.

Osei fastened three passive pickup pads to the exterior field collar. He had chosen pads with different response materials: ceramic for mechanical stress, auric foil for phase displacement, and a thermal thread fine enough to register his breath if he worked too close. Each fed a separate recorder.

C-9 rested in smoked layers beneath the cradle lamps. The nine heat blooms could not be seen without a tuned scan. Nia knew their positions anyway. She had carried the map long enough to feel its distribution when she looked at the housing: two near the service lip, four across the deep route layer, three around the vocal coupling. Her signature sat on the seventh bloom like a fingerprint left on injured skin.

“What are you proposing to read?” she asked.

“Nothing from the phase content.” Osei checked the ceramic pad’s baseline. “I want the relation among the outer stresses.”

“That relation changes with ring load.”

“I have twenty-six hours of load correction.”

“Temperature?”

“Separate recorder.”

“Field drift?”

“Measured at the cradle, not inferred.”

His answers came quickly but not defensively. Nia made him continue.

“State the forbidden operation.”

“No calibration pulse. No semantic query. No coupling to a vocal body. No reconstruction field.”

“State your claim.”

“The expressed refusal altered the stable boundary relations in C-9. We can compare the post-refusal geometry with the pre-hearing baseline without reconstructing the phase content.”

Nia watched his hands seat the final lead. “You are calling it preference geometry.”

“Cal called it a phase trace.”

“Phase trace implies a sequence read from the glass. You are measuring a spatial relation through the housing.”

“Preference geometry, then.” Osei recorded the term into the custody lamp. “A passive map of boundary changes coincident with a preference expressed during valid embodiment.”

“Coincident does not mean caused.”

“That belongs in the test.”

He brought up three old training bells on a separate display. None held conscious records. Archive apprentices had used them to practice coupling checks with synthetic route states. Osei had subjected each to thermal cycles matching the hearing room’s body collar, mechanical loads matching Callis rotation, and controlled field decay. The resulting maps shifted, but their stress lines relaxed toward baseline.

C-9 had done something else. Eleven seconds before deactivation, four boundary relations tightened at once. Two remained locked after the vocal coupling cooled. The change formed no words and yielded no memory. It indicated that a state transition had occurred inside a layer already authenticated to Iven’s active embodiment.

Nia enlarged the time scale. “Your hearing baseline came through the court instrument.”

“Yes.”

“Crown will say the instrument imposed the relation.”

“I brought its twin.”

From a case under the gantry, Osei removed a second recorder with a different manufacturer mark. He had connected it only to the mechanical pickup and kept it isolated from court systems. Its clock differed by three thousandths of a second. The same tightening appeared there as pressure transferred through the cradle.

“That proves a physical change reached the housing,” Nia said. “Not that the internal relation encoded a refusal.”

Osei nodded. “We need a control formed by a verified living preference.”

“You cannot create one in C-9.”

“Not in C-9.”

He pointed toward the archive’s medical continuity shelf. Two signal patients under long-term care had authorized non-destructive preference exercises for instrument research. Both had continuous embodied lives outside the stored layers, which removed the need for respeaking. Their phase aids registered choices through low-energy coupling used for communication, not extraction.

Nia read the consents before allowing the comparison to proceed. One patient had chosen between two comfort schedules. The other had refused a proposed diagnostic pulse after hearing its risks. Osei’s passive instruments recorded both choices from outside their sealed aids.

The comfort choice produced a broad adjustment that relaxed when the patient revised it. The diagnostic refusal produced four tightening relations. Three persisted after the communication field closed.

C-9’s geometry did not match point for point. Different glass, different person, different damage. Yet its direction and persistence fell within the refusal control’s range.

Nia asked Osei for a false-positive set.

He had prepared twelve. Six came from routine bell retuning, three from emergency shutdowns, two from accidental mechanical shocks, and one from a medical aid whose user had lost consciousness during a

communication cycle. Osei had stripped their labels and randomized the display order. If Nia could pick C-9 by expecting to see it, the method offered persuasion rather than measurement.

She worked through each map without speaking. Retuning produced wide rotational movement across all boundary points. Mechanical shocks began at one exterior seat and propagated inward. Shutdown traces relaxed as stored field energy bled away. The interrupted medical cycle left one locked relation, but its time sequence followed power loss instead of the patient's last expressed choice.

C-9 appeared seventh in the blind set. Nia marked it as a persistent internal transition and assigned only moderate confidence. The refusal control appeared eleventh. She gave it the same class and higher confidence because the glass had no prior damage.

Osei restored the labels. "Two of thirteen in class."

"Fourteen with the refusal control."

"Two of fourteen."

"Do not present that as a population rate. The set was selected, not sampled."

"I wrote selected comparison set."

"Write that selection favored difficult exclusions. Otherwise Crown will accuse us of choosing easy noise."

He amended the protocol. Nia checked the raw timestamps against the custody lamp and found a seven-thousandth mismatch on one shock trace. Osei corrected the table rather than discarding the case. The classification held.

"What if another reviewer classifies the unconsciousness event as persistent?" he asked.

"Then your categories need numerical thresholds before review."

"Persistence beyond how long?"

"Not a single duration. Use relation loss against measured field decay. A damaged bell cannot meet the same clock threshold as a medical aid."

Osei opened a formula field. Nia dictated no equation. She made him derive it from the instruments, then challenged each term until the result separated persistence from slow cooling. By the end, the method made a smaller claim than when they began. It also made one they could defend.

Osei muted the displays before Nia could become persuaded by resemblance. "Now falsify it."

She changed the ring-load correction by the maximum plausible error. The geometry persisted. She removed the thermal adjustment. One relation broadened; three remained. She shifted the court clock to the edge of its certified tolerance. The state change still followed Iven's spoken decision rather than body shutdown.

"Contamination from the stopping control," she said.

"Mechanical trace would show it."

"Unless the trace saturated."

“It did not.”

“A coached phrase could trigger a prepared phase pattern.”

“That affects novelty, not whether the transition occurred.”

Nia let out one measured breath. He had separated the instrument’s claim from the Court’s claim. The method could not prove sincerity, identity, legal scope, or permanence. It could show that a non-random state change accompanied a decision and remained after embodiment ended. Other evidence would have to establish the rest.

Ada entered the gantry under escort from a court marshal. The transit case floated behind them on a guided pallet.

“Custody review begins in twenty minutes,” she said. “Crown requests a final field inspection before transfer.”

“There will be no transfer,” Osei said.

Ada looked at his operator badge, then at Nia behind the yellow line. “On whose authority?”

Osei activated the custody lamp. “Mine for the instrument. The Court’s for the bell.”

He sent the preference-geometry protocol to Ada’s slate with raw traces, controls, error ranges, and every rejected explanation Nia had named. Nothing in the packet attempted semantic access.

Ada read longer than Nia expected. “This cannot authenticate the words.”

“No,” Nia said.

“It cannot establish novelty.”

“No.”

“It shows a persistent state change.”

“Under two independent instruments.”

Ada scrolled to the living-patient controls. “Crown will challenge comparability.”

“You should,” Osei said. “Challenge the method in court.”

“And if the method fails?”

“C-9 remains sealed while another non-conscious method is tested.”

Ada glanced at the transit case. Its three radial supports no longer looked like a solution. Removal would change every boundary relation Osei had measured and destroy the method’s reproducibility.

Nia saw Ada reach the same conclusion. Crown could seek the bell or contest the geometry. It could not do both while claiming to preserve evidence.

“Withdraw the case,” Ada told the marshal.

Her counsel began to object through the escort channel.

“Withdraw it from the gantry,” Ada repeated. “We will reserve the custody motion pending instrument review.”

The guided pallet backed through the pressure door. Its torque indicators remained unbroken.

Osei logged the withdrawal and sealed his control data. Then he turned to Nia. “I need a passive custodian to audit the correction tables.”

The red bar still crossed her slate. She could not touch the emitter controls, open a coupling, or authorize a body. None of those acts belonged to the work in front of her.

Nia clipped a fresh custody lamp to the rail on her side of the yellow boundary. “Start with the ring-load error,” she said. “If our claim survives the worst correction, Cal can take it into argument.”

Osei moved the control slate where both of them could read it. C-9 remained closed between them, and the first usable proof of Iven’s refusal came through the glass without asking him for anything more.

Chapter 21 — The Preference That Remains

<!-- POV: Cal Orsen -->

<!-- Days 29–31; Callis evidence laboratory and chambers -->

Cal entered the evidence laboratory after Osei had sealed the sample labels.

Four auric-glass aids rested in separate field cradles along the fixed bench. None contained Iven's record. A fifth cradle held an inert training bell scored to imitate age damage. Each instrument faced away from the central display so no serial mark could reach the reviewers.

Ada stood behind the Crown observer line with a resonance auditor from Morcant. Nia occupied the passive-adviser station, her wrist slate barred from activation controls. Sena Pell had sent Vey to witness custody and had declined to attend. If the test could not survive without a chief justice in the room, it did not deserve to reach her court.

Osei lifted the optical thread joining the five custody lamps. "Labels randomized by the Callis clerk, Crown auditor, and court clerk in sequence. No party has the final key. We will classify boundary behavior only."

"What categories?" Ada asked.

"Transient adjustment, persistent non-preference event, persistent preference event, or indeterminate."

"Your category assumes the conclusion."

Nia answered from beyond the yellow line. "Then call it class three. The measurements do not change."

Ada considered that and nodded. "Use numbers throughout."

Osei revised the display. Cal appreciated the correction. Law accumulated danger whenever a technical label arrived already carrying moral judgment.

The first sample produced a broad relaxation across its outer relations. Both technical reviewers marked class one. The second held two fixed changes after the coupling field ended, but its timestamps followed a thermal fault rather than any recorded decision. Class two. The third showed no stable pattern anyone could separate from cradle pressure. Indeterminate.

At the fourth sample, four boundary relations tightened within a half second of the verified choice marker. Three persisted after communication ended.

The Crown auditor asked Osei to remove the ring-load correction. Two relations remained clear. She asked for maximum clock error. The transition still preceded field closure. Nia requested the stress map from the opposite side of the aid and found the same internal direction.

"Class three," the auditor said.

"Class three," Nia agreed.

Osei recorded both judgments before opening the final sample. Its lines looked persuasive at first: a narrow transition, persistent shape, minimal thermal drift. Under hostile review, the sequence failed. The change began before the recorded preference and propagated from an exterior support. Both reviewers assigned class two.

Only after every classification had been sealed did Vey receive the combined key.

Sample one came from a patient who changed a comfort schedule twice. Sample two recorded unconsciousness during a medical-aid failure. Sample three held synthetic route noise. Sample four came from a living patient's refusal of a diagnostic pulse. Sample five had been the inert training bell, mechanically stressed to produce a false resemblance.

Ada leaned toward the last display. "Your difficult exclusion."

"Our selected difficult exclusion," Nia said. "It does not give us an error rate."

"It gives you one success in a set designed by your own laboratory."

"Yes."

Cal watched the answer deny Ada the exaggeration she wanted to attack. Nia's five-year license bar had changed her position in the room, not her discipline. She could no longer touch the controls. She could still refuse to make an instrument claim more than it measured.

The Crown auditor requested the selection records. Osei sent them under seal. Ada requested a second laboratory, technicians with no Callis employment, and access to raw data before full argument.

"Granted if the patients' consents permit transfer," Cal said.

"You are not presiding here," Ada replied.

"No. I am offering the condition in my brief."

"And if the second laboratory disagrees?"

"Then the geometry remains contested."

"Does C-9 remain protected while you contest it?"

"Yes."

Ada folded her hands at the observer rail. "Your rule rewards uncertainty. Anyone can claim a preference, surround it with difficult measurements, and prevent access until the dispute outlives the need."

"Only a person who held valid standing can form the preference I am describing."

"Who authenticates standing once the person no longer appears?"

"The court record."

"Courts can be deceived."

"So can property registries. We do not abolish title."

"No. We permit adversarial testing," Ada pointed toward the cradles. "Every relevant challenge here occurred because these patients remain alive. They can explain what they chose, renew consent, or expose a bad instrument. Your absent witness can do none of those things."

Cal looked down the bench at five sealed objects that had become harder to name after their histories returned.

“Then the absent record receives no evidentiary advantage. The proponent bears the burden.”

“How high?”

“High enough that doubt preserves the substrate instead of authorizing its destruction.”

“That answers custody, not truth.”

“It may be the only question the method can answer.”

Ada’s expression sharpened. “Then do not use it to admit his accusation.”

Cal closed his notes. She had found the separation his brief needed. Authentication of a refusal did not authenticate every memory spoken before it. The old allegation would require telemetry, physical scoring, the sealed activation ledger, and whatever executive records the parties entered. Silent geometry could control access to C-9 without proving why Eiren died.

“Put that objection in your response,” he said.

“I already have.”

Sena crossed out the first use of *surviving personhood* before Cal reached the second page.

They sat in her chamber at a table built for gravity Callis did not provide. Magnetic corners held Cal’s draft flat. Outside the wall, a lift moved along the axial shaft with a vibration too low to hear and too regular to ignore.

“You cannot smuggle a person beyond the statutory duration by changing the adjective,” Sena said.

“Then I will not call it personhood.”

“What do you call a dead person’s continuing command?”

“A limit on present conduct.”

“Set by whom?”

“By the living Court, after verifying a preference made under valid standing.”

She marked the margin. “Better. Still broad.”

The draft heading read Silent Standing After Deactivation. Cal had chosen the term to distinguish force from appearance. A holder with silent standing could not testify, vote, own new property, direct an institution, or compel anyone’s conduct beyond one protected relation. The Court would recognize a previously made choice because the contemplated access would otherwise recreate the holder for the purpose of defeating that choice.

Sena read the operative paragraph aloud.

“Where a signal person under standing in continuance forms an authenticated novel preference against future destructive access to the substrate necessary for embodiment, deactivation does not alone extinguish the preference.”

She set down the page. “Why novel?”

“To exclude copied directives.”

“A person may repeat an old preference sincerely.”

“The Court lacks the person’s testimony after deactivation. Novelty supplies independent evidence that the decision arose during valid embodiment.”

“Then your protection weakens for consistency.”

Cal had not found a satisfying answer. “Under current instrumentation, yes.”

“Say so. A narrow rule should confess whom it fails.”

He added a limitation note.

Sena moved to the next line. “Why substrate necessary for embodiment?”

“To prevent the rule from controlling unrelated records or property.”

“Suppose the same bell holds public navigation telemetry.”

“Access may proceed if technicians can separate it without spending the conscious layer.”

“And if separation carries a ten percent risk?”

“The Court hears necessity and proportionality.”

“You are back to balancing.”

“After the refusal receives legal force, not before. Crown must justify an exception to a right rather than ask whether property management happens to be kind.”

Sena circled **right**. “Whose right?”

“The right formed during standing.”

“A right requires a holder.”

“Not always a present one. Medical directives bind clinicians after patients lose capacity. Burial protections bind custodians after death.”

“Those rules rest on continuously embodied lives. You want to apply bodily autonomy to a phase substrate.”

“Yes.”

She waited for more.

Cal placed Osei’s cross-section of C-9 beside the draft. “Respeaking does not consult a record and leave it untouched. It grows a vocal body by spending the state. The glass functions as the only remaining physical basis for that body. Destructive access decides whether embodiment occurs and what coherence remains afterward. If bodily autonomy applies only after the body has been forced into existence, it arrives too late to govern the force.”

Sena touched the margin beside **bodily autonomy** with her stylus. “That may be your center. It may also be

your largest fiction.”

“The Court already treated coherence loss as injury while Iven held standing.”

“During embodiment.”

“The injury begins in the substrate before breath.”

“Technically.”

“Materially.”

Sena looked at him for several seconds. “Do not turn material continuity into metaphysical continuity. We decide an access rule, not what death means.”

Cal struck two paragraphs from the draft. They had argued that the stored state carried enough identity to anchor post-deactivation rights. Sena had exposed the unnecessary claim. The Court did not need to decide whether Iven continued in C-9. It needed to decide whether living institutions could disregard a valid instruction by ending the condition under which he could defend it.

Sena pulled three comparative orders from her shelf. She kept physical copies of cases that had changed under appeal, each page pierced by a thread showing where later courts had cut or restored language.

The first concerned a miner who refused regeneration after a lethal pressure injury. Surgeons had preserved enough neural tissue to attempt a treatment that would replace most damaged structures. The patient lost speech before the procedure could begin. His recorded refusal bound the hospital because the intervention touched his bodily integrity, not because the court decided which restored person would awaken.

“Useful,” Cal said.

“Limited,” Sena replied. “Continuous tissue. Verified directive. No adversary claiming the patient never understood the risk.”

The second order concerned a route captain whose emergency beacon directed salvage crews to destroy private letters stored beside public flight data. The court had separated the data, preserved the letters, and rejected the captain’s broader demand that no one inspect the vessel. Privacy reached one record. It did not confer command over the wreck.

Cal marked the distinction. “Severability before necessity.”

“More precise than your balancing paragraph.”

A third case carried the danger. Four generations of a family had obeyed a founder’s recorded instruction never to sell a water allotment. When a drought forced reallocation, descendants argued that respecting the dead required permanent control. The court voided the instruction because property law could not let an absent owner govern living need indefinitely.

Sena tapped that opinion. “Crown will read this aloud.”

“They should. Our rule cannot protect schedule monopolies, estates, contracts, or governance.”

“What if the only substrate sits inside property whose use affects all four?”

“Then the refusal controls destructive contact with the conscious layer. The surrounding property remains governable.”

“Easy to say with a medical aid. C-9 also carries mass required for Mouth stability.”

“Exterior operation may continue under preservation limits.”

“Removal could damage the layer.”

“Then movement requires judicial review.”

“Which gives the preference practical control over infrastructure.”

Cal examined the contradiction rather than avoiding it. “Some rights constrain infrastructure. A hospital cannot take organs because its pumps depend on doing so. The constraint does not make the patient a hospital director.”

“A bell differs from an organ.”

“The legal relation does not require equivalence. Only a protected body interest and a proposed intrusion.”

Sena turned the founder’s order face down. “You will need language preventing strategic placement. An executive cannot embed a conscious remnant in essential machinery, form a refusal, and hold the system hostage.”

“Invalid purpose and independent necessity review.”

“Purpose invites speculation.”

“Then prior control. A preference cannot expand authority the person lacked while embodied.”

“That helps with executives. It does not solve a remnant discovered inside existing public machinery.”

“No single safeguard solves every collision.”

Her eyes lifted from the orders. “Courts say that before building tests nobody can apply.”

Cal took a blank page and wrote an application sequence instead. First, establish valid standing at the time of preference. Second, authenticate the decision through records and non-destructive instruments. Third, identify the exact access refused. Fourth, separate unrelated functions where technically possible. Fifth, test fraud or emergency claims without prohibited access. Only then could a court consider a tightly bounded exception.

Sena read the steps from bottom to top. “Put the burden at each step.”

He assigned it. The proponent carried standing, authentication, scope, and technical relation. The party seeking access carried fraud, emergency, lack of alternatives, and minimum intrusion. Independent custodians owed raw data to both.

“Now a lower court can fail visibly,” Sena said. “That matters more than elegance.”

Cal rewrote the heading: Effect of a Valid Refusal on Later Destructive Access.

“You removed the term,” Sena said.

"I moved it to the remedy."

"Show me."

Cal turned to the proposed order. "Silent standing bars compulsory activation. It authorizes no appearance, testimony, estate control, public office, or continuing direction. The Court may recognize only the prior preference's force against destructive access to the person's necessary substrate."

"That sentence grants standing while denying standing."

"It grants nothing new to the absent person. It binds our jurisdiction."

"Then why use the term at all?"

"Because the Court must keep the refusal audible in procedure without pretending the speaker remains available. If we call it a preservation hold, necessity can erase it. If we call it ordinary evidence, Crown can compel examination. Silent standing tells the next court which prior act controls and which powers do not follow."

Sena wrote no mark beside the paragraph. Her lack of correction did not amount to agreement.

She opened Crown's fraud appendix. "Aster Crown offers a fabricated remnant who passes a negligent Novel Preference Test. Its supposed preference bars inspection of an account layer that contains proof of theft. Years later, fraud becomes apparent. May the Court reopen access?"

"Yes. Fraud defeats validity."

"Who bears proof?"

"The party seeking access must show substantial grounds before any destructive test."

"Substantial means whatever the next court wants."

"Independent custody failure, source repetition, instrument inconsistency, concealed coaching, or evidence that the preference concerns unrelated material."

"Exclusive list?"

"No."

"Then arbitrary."

"Reviewable."

She crossed out his fraud section and pushed the page back. "Write a procedure, not virtues. Notice to every prior custodian. Disclosure of raw instruments. External technical replication where consent allows it. A preliminary fraud showing based on non-destructive evidence. No activation to investigate whether activation may occur."

Cal wrote while she spoke. "And emergency access?"

"Your theory needs one."

"A direct and imminent threat to living persons, no non-destructive alternative, access no broader than

required.”

“Who decides if delay itself kills?”

“The full court where time permits. A duty panel where it does not, followed by automatic review.”

“Can a dead executive use silent standing to preserve Crown’s schedule?”

“No. Schedule authority concerns governance and property, not bodily autonomy.”

“Can a remnant forbid publication of prior testimony?”

“No. Completed testimony remains subject to evidence law.”

“Can one prohibit all use of a choir bell?”

“Only access that spends the conscious substrate. Ordinary exterior maintenance continues.”

“Can a preference last forever?”

Cal paused. C-9 could outlast every person in the current chamber if maintained. A permanent prohibition felt both necessary and suspect.

“It lasts while the protected substrate remains capable of destructive embodiment,” he said. “Once independent evidence establishes that no activation could occur, the bodily relation ends. Cultural or evidentiary preservation may continue under other law.”

“Who may test incapacity?”

“Non-destructively.”

“That answer hides an institution.”

“A silence custodian licensed for passive review, subject to court audit.”

Sena’s stylus stopped. “You have invented a profession.”

“Osei Marr performed it yesterday.”

“He remains an archive technician with an unusually difficult bell.”

“Then the practice precedes the name.”

She marked the proposal for full argument rather than crossing it out.

Crown filed its response before first lamp on Day Thirty-One. Ada conceded that a valid refusal might justify temporary preservation. She rejected silent standing as an unauthorized extension of personhood, attacked preference geometry, and warned that the doctrine could place infrastructure under indefinite control by absent claimants.

Three habitat delegations requested participation. Near Orison argued for narrow protection. Sable requested technical standards. Morcant asked whether emergency supply needs could override the proposed bar.

Latchkey submitted no legal position, only a request that the Court publish any operational assumptions used to claim necessity.

Cal recognized Ema's influence in the wording without seeing her name. She had refused to let her father use her as an argument. Now her habitat refused to become an unexamined number in Crown's motion.

The seven-justice panel met by linked chamber. Delay clocks held their small intervals above each remote seat. Sena summarized the proposed rule in less than a minute and gave Cal no opportunity to answer objections unless asked.

The Sable justice spoke first. "Does acceptance for argument preserve C-9?"

"Yes," Sena said. "Pending decision only."

The Morcant justice asked, "Does it admit Iven Ko's testimony?"

"No. Admissibility and refusal remain distinct."

A justice from Vesper Fold examined the fraud safeguards. "Does the proposal permit any preference to govern public policy after embodiment?"

"No," Cal said when Sena opened his channel. "It concerns bodily autonomy and the destructive access required to create another embodiment. Nothing else."

The clocks turned through two rounds. No justice endorsed the theory's merits. None accepted Crown's claim that deactivation made the question disappear.

Sena entered the procedural order.

"The Court accepts silent standing for full argument under the limits stated. C-9 remains sealed. Parties will address authentication, fraud, emergency exception, duration, and the separation of refusal from prior testimony."

Her seal crossed the linked docket. Six remote seals followed, then a seventh after eleven seconds.

Vey handed Cal the public notice. A new hearing place appeared on the seating plan beside Crown's table. It carried no witness channel, no body supports, and no nameplate. The clerk had left the chair empty to mark the interest under review without suggesting anyone would occupy it.

Cal approved the plan. For the first time since Iven's final breath, the Court had created a place his preference could hold without calling him into it.

Interlude III — Six Habitat Forecasts

<!-- Form: consolidated operational forecast excerpts -->

<!-- Day 31; disclosed packet with recovered Crown layer -->

COURT OF CONTINUANCE / NECESSITY REVIEW PACKET

Population represented: 2.3 million across six habitats

Compared conditions: immediate Mouth closure; present Crown schedule maintained; alternative conversion schedule

Caution: Forecasts describe unequal exposure. Combined totals may not substitute for local failure sequences.

1. LATCHKEY / PUMP HABITAT

Immediate closure projection: Heat-sink exchange ends with the current window. Pump halls can maintain inhabited pressure volumes by closing fabrication, nursery expansion, and two outer work drums. The remaining catalyst reserve supports ordinary circulation for fewer than ninety days. Emergency conservation extends time by reducing pump redundancy. That extension increases the chance that one bearing failure removes an entire district from the heat loop.

Present schedule projection: Crown delivery priority keeps the central pump hall supplied. Outer drums receive replacement sink plates only after Mouth stabilization cargo. Mortality remains concentrated among residents who cannot tolerate repeated pressure transfers: respiratory patients, late-term pregnancies, and crews with prior decompression injury. Aggregate survival figures conceal that concentration.

Local engineering annotation, Ema Orsen, pump architect: The forecast assumes we can stop and restart Hall Four every sixth day. We cannot. Its rotor seal needs nine warm hours after any stop, and each warm cycle consumes the catalyst the model claims to save. Closing Hall Four buys paper reserve while shortening physical reserve. Model the pumps before using us as a reason to preserve anyone's monopoly.

Verified correction: Latchkey pump limits reduce claimed conservation extension by an unpriced interval. Revision required before necessity argument.

2. MORCANT / CATALYST REFINERY

Immediate closure projection: Morcant can produce precursor stock but cannot complete all catalyst grades without imported binders. Refinery output falls first in medical stabilizers, then heat-transfer compounds. Heavy industrial catalyst continues longer because Crown contracts reserve binder stores for transit infrastructure. Local clinics lose access before export obligations lapse.

Present schedule projection: Aster Crown Transit maintains refinery imports and removes finished catalyst under exclusive freight windows. Morcant avoids plant shutdown while carrying the highest worker exposure in the six-habitat network. Furnace maintenance intervals lengthen to preserve scheduled output. Injury projections rise, but Crown classifies those injuries as local operating cost rather than corridor consequence.

Distribution note: Ada Neme's birthplace has little political control over the schedule defended in Morcant's name. The refinery council requests authority to retain one load in five for local medicine before any operator invokes Morcant casualties in court.

Monopoly sensitivity: Removing Crown exclusivity increases short-term dispatch errors if no public scheduler exists. Maintaining exclusivity preserves throughput but permits contract priority to outrank clinical need. Neither condition counts as neutral continuity.

3. VESPER FOLD / AGRICULTURAL SPINDLE

Immediate closure projection: Seed cultures remain viable through one planting cycle. Replacement nutrient catalysts do not. The spindle can preserve calories by narrowing crop diversity and cutting protein vats, but projected deficiency appears months after the legal decision that causes it. No early pressure alarm will mark the loss.

Present schedule projection: Food shipments continue outward under existing contracts. Vesper receives enough catalyst to maintain contracted staples, not local diversity. Crown's model treats caloric survival as full agricultural continuity. Habitat clinicians reject that definition because deficiency burdens children and older residents before aggregate ration failure.

Delay cost: Every missed planting turn creates a biological lag that later freight cannot erase. A shipment arriving after culture collapse carries feedstock but not the lost growing time. The forecast therefore assigns separate values to cargo delay and ecological recovery.

Council reservation: Vesper accepts temporary rationing if inner habitats reduce consumption first. The council will not endorse a plan that preserves Near Orison's reserve while converting Vesper's soil banks into emergency monoculture.

4. ARDEN COIL / MEDICAL MANUFACTURING

Immediate closure projection: Sterile fabrication continues until filter stock reaches rejection limits. Production then contracts by treatment class. Common antibiotics persist longest. Custom immune substrates, graft media, and pressure-adaptation drugs fail earlier because their lines require imported calibration membranes.

Present schedule projection: Crown priority protects outbound medicine contracts and schedules inbound membranes near their minimum safe frequency. The system appears efficient because warehouses stay low. It also leaves no buffer for a rejected shipment, contamination event, or Mouth delay. A single lost window transfers risk to patients across every habitat at once.

Clinical movement constraint: Some patients can relocate toward remaining treatment lines. Others cannot survive acceleration, pressure cycling, or interruption during transit. Forecast totals must separate movable demand from bodies that treatment schedules have made immovable.

Remedy warning: Converting manufacturing too quickly may save catalyst while destroying sterile assurance. Any alternative schedule needs overlapping lines, public batch records, and transport priority based on treatment interruption rather than contract price.

5. SABLE / MINING AND MASS TUNING

Immediate closure projection: Sable can supply raw tuned mass locally. It cannot move that mass between habitats without the Mouth. Mine output accumulates at extraction points while remote bells miss repair windows. Employment collapse precedes heat failure because schedule work supports most pressure districts.

Present schedule projection: Crown continues buying tuned mass under long contracts and assigns bell work through proprietary tolerances. Independent tuners can perform much of the work but lack access to full schedule data. Monopoly therefore appears as technical necessity inside forecasts built from withheld tolerances.

Conversion risk: Publishing the tolerances creates a temporary increase in alignment errors while independent crews certify. Refusing publication preserves one operator as the only institution able to solve a dependency that its secrecy maintains.

Sable technical note: A public scheduler must stage changes across several bell recovery cycles. Instant seizure would be dangerous. Permanent exclusivity carries a different danger and should not borrow urgency from the first.

6. NEAR ORISON / INNER HABITAT

Immediate closure projection: Deep catalyst reserves protect heat, medicine, and food processing longer than any peripheral habitat. Trade contraction closes luxury fabrication and slows construction before threatening core life support. Near Orison can absorb displaced technical staff if transit remains available during the early interval.

Present schedule projection: Existing priority rules replenish inner reserves before several outer shortfalls become acute. The model justifies this order through population density and administrative continuity. It does not price the fact that Near Orison entered the crisis with the largest reserve because previous schedules favored it.

Ration capacity: A modest reduction in inner consumption releases catalyst and sink stock equal to several peripheral emergency loads. Political compliance remains uncertain. Physical capacity does not.

Equity finding: Forecasts that average Near Orison with Latchkey reduce visible risk without reducing any pump failure. The six habitats share a corridor, not a common reserve.

RECOVERED CROWN MODEL LAYER / NOT INCLUDED IN FILED NECESSITY EXHIBIT

Access path: model index recovered from operations archive.

Visibility flag: executive schedule office only.

Public filing status: suppressed.

> Alternative schedule duration: 26-month conversion interval. Immediate closure not required if exclusivity conditions are released in sequence. Survival envelope depends on temporary inner-habitat rationing, Callis mass contribution, public tolerance disclosure, and protected medical transfers. Detailed mass assignments stored under executive authority.

Internal caution attached to hidden line: Disclosure weakens Crown's claim that only present operations can keep the Meridian Mouth open. Suppression preserves schedule authority but converts avoidable distribution choices into asserted physical necessity.

Court clerk's consolidation note: The filed packet presented two futures: Crown control or catastrophic shutdown. The recovered layer contains a third operational branch. Its costs remain severe. Its existence changes which party must prove that those costs cannot be borne.

Chapter 22 — Hearing an Empty Chair

<!-- POV: Cal Orsen -->

<!-- Days 32–35; multi-polity Court of Continuance -->

Cal fastened the geometry record to the evidence rail before the seventh justice's link came live.

The sheet held four black relations, three gray error bands, and no words attributed to Iven Ko. A custody thread entered through its upper corner, looped around Osei's instrument certificates, crossed the independent review request, and ended at the seal beneath Cal's thumb. He checked each crossing against the docket. One misplaced seal would not change the measurement. It would give Crown a reason to argue that nobody knew which measurement the Court had received.

Across the chamber, an empty chair faced the seven-justice bench.

The clerk had removed its witness channel and body supports. No saline lines ran beneath it. A plain card on the table read INTEREST SUBJECT TO REVIEW rather than a person's name. Public feeds could show the chair only when the whole chamber appeared in frame. Sena had denied every request for a close image.

Ada Neme entered with Jalen Orr and three Crown advocates. They brought no vocal-body technicians. Cal had expected relief at that absence. Instead he felt how easily ordinary procedure could make restraint look generous after demanding what should never have been offered.

The remote seats opened one by one. Sable arrived first, then Vesper Fold, Morcant, Arden Coil, Latchkey, and Near Orison. Sena occupied the physical center on Callis. Delay clocks appeared above each remote justice. The Latchkey clock held at eleven seconds.

Public attendance had exceeded every prior Continuance hearing. The concourse outside the court carried overflow screens and pressure barriers. Sena ordered the public feed delayed by thirty seconds so a clerk could cut any accidental body-room image or protected medical record. She refused Crown's request for a fully closed session.

"An institution claiming public necessity must permit the public to examine the claim," she said from the bench. "Protected technical layers will remain sealed. Argument will not."

The opening bell sounded through the table rather than the air.

Crown spoke first.

Ada stood without a display behind her. "Aster Crown Transit concedes that Iven Ko held standing in continuance during his valid embodiments before this Court. Crown further concedes that his stopping decision bound the hearing while active standing continued."

A stir moved through the gallery and stopped at the first pressure barrier.

"Crown does not concede," Ada continued, "that temporary personhood creates permanent jurisdiction in an absent claimant. The Articles require active novelty because living institutions need a subject who can be tested, advised, corrected, and heard. Silent standing removes every safeguard attached to standing while preserving its strongest consequence."

Sena asked, "Which consequence?"

“A bar against access to infrastructure and evidence.”

“The proposed rule reaches destructive access to a conscious substrate.”

“C-9 functions as infrastructure. Its tuned mass contributes to Callis stability. It also contains the disputed Eiren record. A refusal focused on one layer can control the bell if no technical separation exists.”

Cal watched the Morcant justice’s delay clock expire. She entered before Sena could respond.

“Counsel, do you dispute that another activation spends nonrenewable coherence?”

“No.”

“Do you dispute that the person understood that cost?”

“No.”

“Do you dispute the spoken refusal?”

Ada’s gaze moved once toward the empty chair. “Crown disputes whether the surviving phase change authenticates the scope and novelty of the spoken refusal. We do not dispute that the court transcript contains the words.”

The distinction mattered. Ada had abandoned the possibility of treating the sentence as clerical error. She still challenged what the words could bind.

Jalen Orr sat behind her with his hands aligned on the table. The three nested route arcs at his collar caught no light in the chamber’s flat illumination.

Ada opened the necessity packet. Six habitat names appeared around a map of the Meridian Mouth. “Four dependent habitats hold fewer than ninety days of catalyst reserve. The combined population reaches 2.3 million. Any doctrine that delays bell access or schedule correction must face the people placed at risk by delay.”

“Does Crown seek to move C-9 today?” the Sable justice asked.

“Not while the Callis field remains stable.”

“Does Crown seek another embodiment today?”

“We seek authority to complete cross-examination if corroboration proves inadequate.”

“Then your necessity remains contingent.”

“So does the field.”

Ada called up Latchkey’s forecast. Ema Orsen’s correction appeared in a narrow annotation beside the pump model. Cal had read it until the phrasing no longer sounded like his daughter. *Model the pumps before using us as a reason to preserve anyone’s monopoly.* She had addressed every institution in the room, including him.

Ada did not omit the correction. “Crown’s first filing overstated Latchkey’s conservation interval. The revised model reduces that interval. The urgency grows.”

“Or your claim to exclusive competence weakens,” the Latchkey justice said after eleven seconds.

“Both can occur.”

Ada’s refusal of a simple defense quieted the chamber more effectively than denial. She did not pretend Crown’s models carried no institutional interest. She argued that biased infrastructure could still keep people alive.

Cal wrote one line on his pad: Necessity cannot authenticate the preference. Authentication cannot resolve necessity.

Sena saw him write but did not ask for it.

Crown concluded with the founder’s water-allotment case. Ada displayed the old recorded directive, the drought order that voided it, and the later finding that no absent owner could govern living need indefinitely.

“Respect for a dead choice can become obedience to a dead authority,” she said. “Crown does not ask the Court to treat Iven Ko as property. We ask the Court not to let a remnant acquire powers no embodied person holds. A living witness cannot end cross-examination and compel admission of the untested account. A living owner cannot place essential infrastructure outside emergency law. A living claimant cannot bind strangers forever merely by refusing.”

She sat.

The Latchkey link still carried its eleven-second delay when the public feed began displaying written questions from the six habitat clerks. None asked whether Iven’s refusal deserved respect. They asked who would inspect emergency claims, how quickly a duty panel could assemble, whether Crown could withhold tolerance data during review, and which instrument record would remain public. The questions gave Cal more confidence than the gallery’s sympathy. People facing pump failure wanted a procedure they could challenge, not a moral declaration issued from Callis.

Sena directed the clerks to append every question to the remedy docket. She excluded only requests for protected patient files. The public record grew by thirty-one entries before Cal spoke.

Cal felt the argument’s force because parts of it deserved to survive. If silent standing answered every injustice around C-9, it would become exactly what Crown feared: a route for sympathy to bypass evidence and democratic authority. The doctrine had to lose most of the case before it could protect the one act within its scope.

Sena opened Cal’s channel. “Authenticate the refusal.”

He carried the geometry sheet to the central rail.

“This record makes four claims,” he said. “Iven Ko held valid standing when he made the decision. He received a measured explanation of coherence loss and understood that another call would spend the only remaining state. He expressed a new preference against that access. Independent instruments recorded a persistent boundary change coincident with the decision.”

Ada rose. “Crown objects to *independent*. Both instruments occupied Callis custody.”

“One came from the court system. One remained isolated under archive custody.”

“Both were handled by Callis personnel.”

Cal turned to the bench. "Crown's qualification objection remains preserved. The method has been sent for external replication under patient-consent limits. The present order does not require the Court to find the geometry infallible."

"What does it require?" Sena asked.

"That the proponent carry a high burden before silent standing receives force. For temporary preservation pending full testing, the record must establish enough likelihood that destructive access would defeat a valid bodily refusal."

"You moved from a permanent rule to a preliminary order."

"I am separating what the Court can decide today from the judgment it may write later."

The Near Orison justice entered. "If the external laboratory fails to classify the geometry, does the refusal disappear?"

"No. The transcript, the timing lamp, informed consent records, and phase state remain evidence. Geometry provides non-conscious authentication. It does not create the decision."

"Then why not rely on the transcript?"

"Because words alone can be coached, cut, or misattributed. The phase change links the recorded decision to the active conscious layer without requiring another embodiment."

Ada approached the rail for cross-argument. "You cannot say what the geometry means."

"No."

"You cannot read refusal from the four relations."

"No."

"You selected living refusal controls after hearing the words."

"Osei selected several event classes. Independent reviewers conducted blind classification."

"On a set built inside the same institution."

"Yes."

"Then Crown cannot reproduce the method without access to C-9."

"You have raw data, instrument specifications, and selected non-conscious controls. You may challenge every correction without reading the conscious layer."

Ada touched the corner of the geometry sheet but did not move it. "A persistent state change could indicate fear, fatigue, or damage."

"It could."

"Your own witness admits that."

"Nia Daro acts as passive adviser, not my witness."

“She designed the original activation path.”

“She also disclosed the seventh unauthorized recall and accepted a five-year license loss.”

“Confession does not produce reliability.”

“No. Reproducible work may.”

Sena closed both channels. “The Court will not try Nia Daro’s discipline again. Crown may attack each measurement through an expert filing.”

The sheet remained between Cal and Ada. Four black relations. No face. No voice. Nothing for the chamber to consume except a method.

After the delay clocks cleared, Sena asked Cal to define the right without referring to Iven.

“A signal person who forms an authenticated novel preference during valid standing may retain silent standing against later destructive access to the substrate necessary for embodiment,” he said. “The rule protects bodily autonomy. It grants no ongoing testimony, property control, public authority, or governance.”

The Vesper justice asked, “Why call the substrate a body interest before any body exists?”

“Because the access spends the physical state from which embodiment can occur. Waiting for breath makes consent impossible. By then the intrusion has already begun.”

“Does your rule recognize a continuing person inside the glass?”

“No. It recognizes continuing legal force in a prior valid refusal.”

“Can the force last forty-seven more years?”

“Only while the substrate remains capable of the prohibited embodiment. Passive review may test that capacity. Destructive testing may not assume its own permission.”

Morcant’s justice leaned close to her link. “What happens during an immediate life-support emergency?”

“A duty panel may authorize the minimum intrusion after finding direct threat, no non-destructive alternative, and no narrower route. Automatic full review follows.”

“You admit exceptions to bodily autonomy.”

“Every jurisdiction in this court already does under immediate necessity. The exception carries the burden. Property status does not erase it.”

Jalen requested permission to speak as Crown chair rather than counsel. Sena granted five minutes.

He stood beside Ada. “Crown schedules serve people who have never heard Iven Ko’s name. If this Court privileges one refusal above the pumps, medicines, and food of six habitats, it repeats the moral structure it condemns. It chooses whose body can be spent.”

Cal wanted to answer at once. Sena made him wait until Latchkey’s clock expired.

“Does Crown contend that respecting this refusal requires Mouth closure?” she asked.

Jalen chose each word. “Crown contends that the Court cannot know what future access the corridor may require.”

“That differs from present necessity.”

“Future emergencies do not wait for convenient doctrine.”

“Nor do rights wait for institutions to finish imagining emergencies.”

Jalen’s expression remained composed. “If the bell’s mass becomes essential?”

“Then a court hears evidence about the mass,” Sena said. “It does not compel a person into existence to make the evidence easier.”

Ada looked at Jalen. He sat without answering.

The hearing recessed after four hours. Cal remained at the rail while clerks detached the geometry sheet for secure review. Public noise reached the chamber when the gallery doors opened: not cheering, only hundreds of conversations escaping at once.

Vey brought him the external laboratory notice. Morcant’s independent resonance office had accepted the raw protocol. Its technicians could test the living controls and inert exclusions, but not C-9 itself. Preliminary review required two days.

“Crown filed to add the suppressed model-index line,” she said.

Cal read the filing. The recovered line identified a 26-month alternative schedule and four categories of required sacrifice. It did not include mass assignments or executable tolerances. Crown argued that an index entry could not prove feasibility. Three habitats argued that suppression itself undermined Crown’s claim of necessity.

“Does Ada sponsor it?” he asked.

“Not yet. Crown filed through the executive office.”

That meant Jalen controlled the characterization. Ada had conceded modeling error in open court but had not disclosed the underlying schedule. Cal could not tell whether she lacked it or refused to enter it.

He placed the filing beneath the necessity packet. “Add it to remedy evidence. Not refusal authentication.”

Vey hesitated. “If it proves another way to keep the Mouth open, it weakens their request for access.”

“It may. We decide what it proves before using it.”

“You sound like Sena.”

“Put that observation under seal.”

Vey’s mouth almost moved toward a smile. She carried the filing to the clerk.

On the second hearing day, Morcant’s resonance office classified the controls correctly and rejected one Callis correction factor as under-justified. Osei recalculated with the correction removed. C-9 retained three

persistent relations instead of four. Crown called the reduction proof of instability. Cal called it the reason adversarial replication existed.

Nia testified remotely from behind the archive's activation boundary. She described what the method could not establish before she described what it could.

"No words can be recovered from preference geometry," she said. "It does not establish truth of prior testimony. It does not tell the Court how long a right should last. It records a persistent physical transition linked by time and custody to an expressed decision."

Ada asked, "Could another activation clarify the transition?"

Nia's hands remained visible beside the custody lamp. "Another activation would alter the transition and violate the decision under review."

"So your method cannot be confirmed by the direct test."

"The proposed direct test destroys its subject."

"Science sometimes consumes samples."

"Then it reports that the sample no longer exists. It does not call consumption neutral."

Ada ended the examination there.

The court heard medical ethicists, fraud examiners, bell engineers, and two advocates for prior signal persons. Sena stopped every speaker who tried to treat absence as wisdom. One advocate argued that the dead possessed a purer claim because they could no longer benefit. Sena asked him whether inability to answer questions also made them better governors. He withdrew the phrase.

A Crown fraud examiner offered a plausible abuse: an operator could coach a signal person to refuse inspection of a substrate hiding financial records. Cal's application sequence answered imperfectly. Courts would need independent custody, novelty evidence, severability analysis, and a non-destructive fraud showing. Some fraud would survive. So would some fraud under property law.

"Your doctrine distributes error toward preservation," the examiner said.

"Yes," Cal replied.

"Why?"

"Because a mistaken preservation order can be revised. A mistaken destructive read cannot."

"That may delay proof until victims lose remedy."

"Yes."

The answer hurt more because it belonged in the record. Rights did not remove casualties. They changed which harms institutions had to justify.

On Day Thirty-Five, Sena called the justices into final procedural conference. The public feed showed only the bench and the unoccupied table.

“We have three arguments presented as one,” she said. “First, whether the prior refusal bars another compulsory embodiment. Second, whether completed testimony may be admitted despite unfinished cross-examination. Third, whether present habitat risk justifies Crown control of the bell and schedule.”

Ada rose. “Those issues depend on one another.”

“They affect one another,” Sena said. “Dependence does not make them identical.”

“Without access, Crown cannot fully challenge testimony.”

“Then the evidence court decides what weight incomplete challenge permits.”

“Without schedule authority, Crown cannot guarantee habitat supply.”

“Then the remedy court examines schedules, including the concealed alternative index.”

Jalen spoke from his seat. “You are dividing responsibility until no decision carries the whole risk.”

Sena faced him. “No. We are preventing risk in one question from deciding every other question without proof.”

She turned to Cal. “State the division.”

He looked past the geometry sheet to the empty chair. “The refusal concerns what may be done to the person’s remaining substrate. The testimony concerns what the Court may conclude from words already given. Crown’s concealment concerns institutional conduct. Present remedy concerns how living habitats survive correction. They require separate burdens and separate records.”

Sena entered an order preserving C-9 against another activation pending judgment. She accepted preference geometry as admissible authentication subject to weight. She reserved the old accusation for corroboration analysis and moved operational necessity to a distinct remedy docket.

The clerk split the master file along its custody threads. One seal remained with the silent-standing case. A second enclosed the Eiren merits. The third opened a remedy proceeding and required Crown to produce every schedule branch referenced by its own model index.

Ada watched the third seal close. For the first time during the hearing, she looked toward Jalen rather than the bench.

On the public docket, a clerk entered the ruling’s practical effect in plain language: Crown’s concealment and the corridor remedy present separate questions. Evidence concerning one may not be withheld by invoking the other.

The empty chair remained where it had stood throughout argument. No one approached it when the court adjourned. Clerks removed the witness microphones from every other table, sealed the three new files, and left that one place untouched because it had required nothing from the person it represented.

Chapter 23 — The Executive Minute

<!-- POV: Ada Neme -->

<!-- Days 36–37; Crown operations vault and Continuance Court -->

Ada had the vault key halfway through its second turn when Jalen Orr revoked her authority.

The change appeared on the key's narrow status strip as a red bar, then crossed into the lock with a pulse she felt through her thumb. The inner pins released anyway. Revocation could stop a request not yet accepted; it could not reverse a mechanical commitment already witnessed by two systems. Crown had designed that distinction for emergencies in which a director died between authorization and entry.

No one had expected a director to use it against the chair.

She pulled the door open before the pins could cycle. Cold archive air passed over her face. Behind her, Crown's operations floor carried on under reduced light, every route desk occupied for the next Meridian Mouth window. Six habitat schedules moved down the main wall in narrow columns. Morcant had fifty-two days of catalyst reserve under current rationing. Latchkey's pump replacement sat inside a window no court could widen by moral force.

The vault held no paper. Its storage bars lay in pressure-balanced racks, each bar wrapped in dull conductor cloth and marked by year. Ada entered, shut the door, and set her wrist seal against the witness plate.

"Access continued under accepted emergency authority," she said. "Ada Neme, operations director. Purpose: compliance with Court order C-418, separate questions of historic intent and present remedy."

The plate wrote her statement into a local thread. Crown could contest her purpose. It could not make the statement disappear without breaking the thread.

She found the Eiren year by touch before the rack labels resolved in the low light. Forty-seven years had not thickened the bar or changed its weight. The conductor cloth bore three nested route arcs, the old Aster Crown Transit emblem. Someone had added a black maintenance stitch at one end. A suppression mark, not a repair.

Ada set the bar in the vault reader. "Index AR-6."

The reader displayed six references. Five carried public substitutions: navigation loss, mass-shear emergency, convoy route correction, corridor preservation, casualty outcome. The sixth showed only an executive minute number and a custody instruction requiring chair-level access.

Her authority strip remained red.

She used the model index stolen three weeks earlier, the one Crown had hidden behind an obsolete schedule family. Its reference checksum shared eleven digits with the sealed minute. That overlap had bothered her from the first night she copied it. Old intent and current feasibility had been tied together inside Crown's records, not because the calculations depended on each other, but because the institution had placed both behind the same class of silence.

Ada entered the checksum as a recovery path.

The reader asked whether she intended to restore a damaged operational family. She answered yes. Recovery authority belonged to operations directors whenever loss of the family could endanger an active corridor. The

system accepted her answer, opened the black stitch's index, and presented two sealed objects.

The first carried the old minute. The second held the suppressed model.

A warning crossed the display: CHAIR REVIEW REQUIRED BEFORE EXTRACTION.

Ada connected a court custody wafer to the reader and requested both objects. The vault denied transfer. She requested a verification digest. The system released one without content, enough to prove that each object existed at this time and place. She sent the digest to the Court's receiving clerk.

Then she opened the minute on the vault screen.

Seven officers had attended the meeting while Eiren's rescue convoy waited at the edge of a widening shear. The record gave no voices, only attributed entries and timing marks. Each sentence had passed through legal compression until fear became capacity and death became an allocation. One line named the rescue requirement: three bells detached for nineteen hours. Another put the projected Mouth closure at eight to fourteen years if the stabilization failed.

The operative entry sat beneath the code AR-6.

> Preserve corridor continuity. Redirect available convoy mass to primary stabilization. Eiren recovery proceeds only if no further corridor degradation results.

The next timing mark showed the convoy turning before any second assessment of Eiren's thermal margin. Eleven minutes later, the three bells joined the stabilization schedule. Eiren's lattice still had hours of managed heat, enough for the rescue route Iven had deposited into C-9. Crown had not lost the route. Its officers had assigned the bells elsewhere.

Ada read every attributed assent. Jalen's grandfather appeared once, recording the motion, but the minute did not offer the inheritance Jalen liked to deny. It documented an institution acting through seven people under pressure. Present dependents had not made that choice. Neither had Ada. Yet she had defended its concealment for twelve years, long after emergency judgment could explain anything.

Her wrist channel lit with Jalen's identity.

She accepted without closing the file.

"You entered a restricted vault after revocation," he said.

"The lock accepted my authority before your change reached it."

"Leave the bar in place and come out."

"A Court order requires records responsive to intent."

"The Court requires production through counsel. It does not authorize you to dismantle corridor security."

Ada looked at the second sealed object. "Why does a current route model share suppression custody with an Eiren minute?"

A pause traveled over the channel. Jalen never filled a silence he could make another person carry.

"Close the reader," he said.

“Answer the question.”

“The alternative schedule contains untested assumptions across six polities. Releasing it before validation could produce unilateral withdrawals from Crown coordination.”

“It completed validation fourteen months ago.”

“You have an index, not the working model.”

“I am looking at the working model.”

A softer tone entered his voice, which meant he had stopped treating her as staff. “Ada, the Court separated historic intent from remedy. Give them the minute through our filing process. We can stipulate to the choice and preserve control of the present schedule.”

“Your filing process has denied this minute exists.”

“It protected millions from a panic shutdown.”

“The current model prevents a shutdown.”

“It proposes a transfer of control. That differs from prevention.”

Twelve years earlier, Ada had accepted the seal after a Morcant refinery stoppage cut catalyst output by six percent. The outage had lasted nine days. Crown rerouted reserves without publishing whose scheduled freight lost priority, and no habitat crossed its emergency line. She had taken that success as proof that concentrated authority could move faster than public consent. Later shortages repeated the lesson because Crown’s ledgers omitted the families who waited, the clinics that diluted compounds, and the repair crews who borrowed parts from the next quarter. The corridor remained open. The accounting called every hidden transfer continuity.

“Your control has always distributed harm,” she said. “It merely kept the allocation out of view.”

“Visibility does not create catalyst.”

“No. It tells Morcant whether Near Orison’s fabrication run outranks its heat reserve.”

“And if six polities refuse the ranking?”

“Then the refusal belongs in the record before you impose it.”

Jalen’s reply arrived without heat. “You think procedure makes scarcity legitimate.”

“I think secrecy makes your preference look like physics.”

The vault reader showed a fresh denial against the court wafer. Someone outside had tried to close her session and discovered the disputed access state. Ada rested two fingers on the conductor cloth. Her own defense of Crown had depended on that same confusion. She had described private ranking decisions as corridor requirements, then warned that questioning them endangered the Mouth. Some warnings had been true. Their truth had protected the claims wrapped around them.

Ada released the second seal. The display opened into a twenty-six-month schedule with six habitat tracks and two Callis mass contributions. Red dependency lines crossed every page. Crown relinquished exclusive bell priority in month two. Near Orison rationed industrial catalyst from month one. Two Callis rings shifted from

ceremonial balance to active tuning. Patient transfers clustered around a narrow window in month seven.

The model contained hardship in every column. It also kept every habitat above failure margins.

“What did your reviewers reject?” she asked.

“They did not reject the physics.”

“Then what?”

“Close the reader.”

Ada enlarged the governance appendix. Crown’s exclusive schedule ended under the model. Each polity gained a witnessed allocation key. No operator could bury a delay or reserve a bell without publishing the effect on all six habitats.

“The reviewers rejected Crown’s position,” she said.

“They rejected an operating structure that has kept the Mouth open for forty-seven years.”

“After using Eiren to prove why nobody else should inspect it.”

Jalen’s breath touched the channel once. “You have defended the same structure.”

“Yes.”

“Do not pretend discovery gives you distance from your own work.”

“I have no such distance.”

That answer stopped him longer than accusation would have. Ada detached the custody wafer. It held only the two digests and her access record. The contents remained on the bar.

Jalen spoke with the precision he used when minutes might later be read aloud. “Destroy the recovery path. Remove the model index from your private store. Leave the historic object for authorized production.”

“And the current model?”

“Restore its suppression seal.”

“You are ordering destruction of responsive access evidence during an active proceeding.”

“I am ordering protection of an unadopted infrastructure model. Do not convert an internal draft into public instruction.”

“The instruction is witnessed.”

“By Crown systems.”

“And by this channel.”

He ended the call.

Ada did not move for two breaths. The vault fan pulled cold air through the reader and over the exposed conductor bar. On the schedule wall beyond the door, millions of people depended on a company whose chair

had just given her a useful order. The usefulness did not make her brave. She had spent twelve years arranging facts so that no one faced the choice Jalen had forced into a record.

She attached the court wafer again. Content extraction still failed under chair lock. A digest could authenticate existence but not prove substance. She needed either Jalen's seal or physical custody of the bar.

The storage rack had its own rule. Any object under disputed judicial claim could be moved to neutral containment if removal did not interrupt an active system. The rule protected customer records during insolvency. Crown had written it to keep executives from taking archives with them.

Ada marked the bar disputed.

The rack asked for a claim number. She entered C-418. It asked for evidence of court receipt. The receiving clerk had returned a timestamp against her digest twelve seconds earlier. She applied it. Mechanical clamps closed around the conductor cloth and released the bar into a neutral transit sleeve.

Only then did the vault alarm sound.

Ada held the sleeve against her ribs and opened the door. Two security officers waited outside with a route supervisor she had promoted eight years earlier. None carried a weapon. Crown protected its infrastructure through access, employment, and the fact that every corridor depended on someone choosing not to make a scene beside tuned mass.

"Director," the supervisor said, "the chair has ordered the object retained."

"The object now carries a judicial dispute mark." Ada turned the sleeve so he could see its white thread. "Interference requires a witnessed claim that removal threatens active operations."

His eyes moved to the schedule wall, then back. "Does it?"

"No. This bar has not served an active route system for forty-seven years."

One security officer checked the thread. "Your operations authority has been revoked."

"Judicial custody does not require it once the mark attaches."

The supervisor's jaw tightened. He knew she had drafted that clause after Crown absorbed a failing freight operator. "If you take it off this floor, you will not come back."

Ada placed her wrist key on the nearest desk. "Record the surrender time."

No one blocked her. The supervisor logged the surrender with a hand that paused once above the time field. Ada waited until the entry sealed. If Crown later disputed how authority left her, the record would show that she had not carried it through the door.

The Continuance Court reconvened before the vault chill had left Ada's hands.

She stood at the lower evidence rail with the sleeved bar secured between two physical seals. Cal Orsen sat with the advocates rather than the bench. His empty place beside the Callis delegation remained conspicuous only because he had occupied it through thirty-five days of argument. Sena Pell and four other justices watched the clerks test the white custody thread.

Crown's replacement counsel rose. "We object to acquisition through an employee acting outside authority."

"Former employee," Ada said.

The counsel looked at her wrist. The absence of a key answered him.

Sena leaned toward the timing lamp. "The Court will first determine preservation. Clerk?"

"The object's judicial dispute mark predates removal from Crown's vault by four minutes and seventeen seconds. Crown revocation predates the mark but follows accepted entry. No break appears in local custody."

"Seal it under court control."

The clerk closed a third band around the sleeve. Its indicator changed from white to amber.

Crown's counsel tried again. "Whatever the historic record contains, the second object described by Director Neme presents live corridor risk. Public technical disclosure could invite unsynchronized retuning."

Ada heard the argument she had made in different words for years. It retained force. A model could save lives and still become dangerous when detached from the tools, staff, and ration agreements required to carry it out.

"Seal the technical layers from general release," she said. "Give complete access to the Court's engineering panel and one representative from each affected polity. Publish assumptions and costs, not executable bell timing."

The counsel turned on her. "You cannot offer Crown material."

"I am not offering it. I am identifying a way to examine it without creating the risk you named."

Sena's gaze remained on Ada. "Why did Crown suppress a feasible schedule?"

"Because feasibility did not preserve Crown's exclusive control."

A small movement passed through the public gallery. Paper shifted. Someone touched a handrail. The Court's timing lamps continued without interruption.

"Does the model avoid immediate Mouth closure?" Sena asked.

"Yes, if all required parties accept costs the current schedule keeps unequal and mostly invisible."

"List them without operational timing."

Ada did. Crown would relinquish exclusive scheduling. Callis would give up two ceremonial mass rings. Near Orison and the other inner reserves would ration catalyst and freight. Nineteen hundred high-risk patients would need relocation during a transit gap. Trade would slow for years. Peripheral habitats would survive, but none would escape damage.

Cal rose after she finished. "Does any technical requirement depend on further access to C-9?"

"No."

"Does the old minute depend on testimony from its recorded witness?"

"No. The minute carries seven attributed assents, internal timing, and the AR-6 instruction. Pilot telemetry and

the physical bell record corroborate execution.”

Crown’s counsel said, “Director Neme is stating conclusions reserved for the Court.”

“I am stating how Crown authenticated its own executive records when I represented it.”

Cal approached the evidence rail but did not touch the sleeve. “Why did you defend delay after you learned the Eiren choice occurred?”

The question reached the part of her evidence no bar could supply.

Ada looked toward the habitat observers. Latchkey’s representative wore pump gray. Morcant had sent a refinery allocator whose left sleeve showed acid repairs. Near Orison’s counsel sat behind three sealed reserve ledgers. None of them had chosen Eiren’s death. Some had lived for decades inside the corridor that choice preserved.

“I believed disclosure without an alternative would force a false remedy,” she said. “A full shutdown could kill people whose dependence Crown helped create. I treated concealment as the price of preventing that response.”

“Did you disclose the existence of a slower alternative when you found its index?”

“No.”

“Why?”

“First, I did not have the model. Later, I had reason to believe it worked and still withheld the index while I tried to obtain it inside Crown.”

“How long?”

“Nineteen days.”

Cal let the number remain where she put it. “Do you ask the Court to excuse that?”

“No.”

Jalen entered through the Crown access door before the next question. He wore no operations key either. His counsel made room, but he remained standing behind the rail.

Sena addressed him. “Chair Orr, do you contest the authenticity of the executive minute?”

“I have not inspected the object since its removal.”

“Your system digest identifies it.”

“I contest unauthorized context, not the existence of a record.”

“Do you contest that Crown officers directed the convoy mass toward Mouth stabilization?”

Jalen’s attention rested on the sealed bar. “The company has already acknowledged that stabilization occurred.”

“That did not answer the question.”

“No,” he said. “I do not contest the direction.”

The answer offered no confession and no grief. It removed a factual dispute because the evidence made continued denial costlier than concession.

Sena ordered the old minute opened to all parties and the model confined to the engineering panel. Each polity would receive a complete non-executable account of burdens by the next civic morning. Crown's control claims would be heard after feasibility testing, not before.

The clerk broke the bar's outer cloth. Two record lights appeared through the sleeve, one aged amber and one recent blue.

Cal returned to his table. The chair beside him stayed empty. No channel opened toward the archive ring. No one asked a silent person to prove what Crown's own minute now established.

Ada watched the panel technicians carry the blue record toward the sealed engineering room. Historic intent had entered evidence behind them. Ahead waited pumps, patients, ration ledgers, and twenty-six months of work.

At the sealed engineering-room door, Ada surrendered her Crown access wafer to the clerk and followed the model inside.

Chapter 24 — Twenty-Six Months

<!-- POV: Nia Daro -->

<!-- Day 38; Callis engineering panel -->

Nia held the temporary mass key against the test bridge while Osei cut power to the second Callis ring.

Nothing moved. The bridge carried no tuned mass, only a reduced phase model built from the suppressed Crown schedule. Even so, the instrument resisted the change through its ceramic handle. A faint pressure gathered under Nia's fingers, traveled into her wrist, and stopped when the simulated ring dropped out of alignment.

"Loss at the outer dependency," Osei said.

Across the engineering room, six habitat tracks narrowed on the wall. Latchkey went amber first. Morcant followed. Vesper Fold's agricultural window held for another cycle before its line began to thin.

Ada stood beside the sealed Crown reader with her sleeves rolled to the elbow. Without her operations key, she looked less altered than Nia had expected. Authority had left only a pale strip around her wrist where the device had covered the skin.

"Restore ring two," Ada said.

Osei did. The habitat lines recovered.

"That confirms the objection," said Crown's senior scheduler from the observation rail. "Callis cannot convert both contributions without exposing three dependents during the transfer."

"Not both at once," Nia said.

"The filed plan shows two ceremonial mass rings."

"It shows two conversions. Your challenge assumes simultaneous release."

The scheduler tapped the public timing lamp. Every exchange entered the Court's engineering record as it occurred. Behind the acoustic baffles, representatives from six habitats watched with their own technical advisers. Sena Pell had given the panel one civic day to turn a hidden model into a plan any polity could inspect without receiving executable bell timing.

Nia shifted the key one notch clockwise. "Run the first conversion against Crown schedule relinquished in stages."

Ada entered the condition. Crown's exclusive priority line broke into six witnessed allocations. The test bridge changed pitch under Nia's hand.

Osei withdrew the second ring from the model again.

Latchkey stayed green. Morcant dipped toward amber, then recovered as Near Orison's industrial freight moved out of the first ration block. Vesper Fold held its heat-sink window. The simulated corridor narrowed but did not close.

The scheduler leaned forward. “You have transferred the failure to inner fabrication.”

“Yes,” Ada said.

Near Orison’s representative spoke from behind the baffle. “Transferred or shared?”

“No rhetorical answers,” the panel chair said. “State the material effect.”

Ada enlarged the inner-habitat track. “Near Orison loses priority freight and catalyst volume throughout the first stage. Medical supply holds. Nonessential fabrication does not.”

“Define nonessential,” the representative said.

“You define it under a published cap,” Ada replied. “Crown no longer decides in a private schedule.”

Nia watched the test bridge rather than the gallery. The suppressed model carried more than phase timing. It carried choices in fields labeled reserve protection, customer continuity, and operator discretion. Each neutral heading concealed a person who would wait. Making those choices public did not reduce their pressure on the instrument.

“Latchkey pump load is wrong,” Ema Orsen said over the remote engineering link.

Her image occupied a narrow panel beside the habitat tracks. Transmission delay from Latchkey clipped the first fraction of each reply, so the chair had instructed everyone to wait for her channel marker before speaking. Ema wore a pump hood pushed back from her forehead. Condensation had dried in a line across one cheek.

Ada checked the source table. “The model uses your filed maintenance reserve.”

“My filed reserve assumes normal heat-sink replacement. Your first stage moves that replacement by one window.”

“Crown’s table classifies the delay as tolerable.”

“Crown’s table does not operate our pumps.”

The scheduler began, “Latchkey certified those limits.”

Ema’s marker remained lit. He stopped because the record would have shown the interruption.

“We certified a maximum under ordinary redundancy,” she said. “Take one sink bank out for the longer window and the remaining pumps cannot carry the stated load. Reduce throughput before you delay the shipment, or you will force an emergency shutdown halfway through the stage.”

Nia felt Osei’s attention move from the wall to her hands. He had learned, during four months of disciplinary interviews and custody work, when she had found a fault but not its boundary.

“Can we reduce Latchkey throughput without losing Morcant catalyst?” he asked.

Ada brought the transport dependencies forward. “Not under Crown priority.”

“Under the public allocation?”

A different path opened when she removed the operator-discretion field. Morcant’s catalyst shipment shifted

earlier. Latchkey's heat-sink mass followed through the next narrow window. Near Orison lost another fabrication block.

Its representative pressed for recognition. "That brings us below our industrial reserve agreement."

"The agreement depends on Crown exclusivity," Cal said from the legal table. He had no engineering vote, but the Court had assigned him to identify obligations that disappeared with the judgment. "If exclusive control falls, the reserve preference falls with it."

"People work in those plants."

"No one has suggested otherwise."

"Then put their losses in the plan."

Nia looked toward the representative. "We will."

The clerk entered Near Orison's fabrication loss beside Latchkey's pump limit before Osei started the next run.

Osei added the throughput reduction and reran the stage. The test bridge pressed back more evenly. Latchkey's track remained above its pump floor. Morcant received catalyst before the deeper ration period. Near Orison's industrial line contracted into a band that would be politically difficult and physically survivable.

The panel chair said, "First transfer conditionally sustained. Proceed."

By the sixth hour, the model had covered every available surface.

Osei worked at the test bridge. Nia occupied a lower table with phase diagrams, custody copies, and two cups of glucose tea gone cold. Ada translated Crown schedule assumptions into statements the habitat engineers could challenge. Ema remained on the link from Latchkey, leaving twice to answer pump alarms and coming back with fresh stains on her hood.

The original schedule treated the Mouth as a sequence of protected openings. The phased retuning plan treated it as a system that would remain imperfect for twenty-six months. Every stage borrowed stability from the next and paid it back through rationing, converted mass, or slower transit.

Callis had called the two outer structures ceremonial because their daily work had become easy to ignore. Civic processions crossed them at accession years. Families fixed memorial tags to the sheltered rails. The rings also balanced the Court, carried archive shielding, and gave the station enough reserve mass to trim without suspending hearings. Conversion would close whole public sectors and force the Archive into a narrower thermal allowance. Nia traced the service routes on the model. C-9's cradle remained stable, but three conservation bays would lose simultaneous cooling.

"We need a preservation rotation," she said.

Osei pulled up the archive load. "One bay warm at a time."

"Not warm. Reduced cooling. Anything near stress limit moves before conversion begins."

The Callis representative asked, "How long will public access stay closed?"

Ada checked the stage sequence. “Most of the first year. Partial access after that, subject to mass recovery.”

A murmur passed behind the local baffle. Callis had offered rings in the abstract. The schedule now translated that offer into sealed memorial walks, delayed court sessions, and archive crews moving fragile glass by hand.

“Put every closure in the civic instrument,” Nia said. “If Callis claims credit for the mass, it records what residents lose with it.”

The clerk added a public-access appendix. Another hidden cost became a schedule someone could dispute.

Nia crossed out a proposed safeguard. “This requires active access to C-9.”

“It requires an Eiren-bell baseline,” Ada said.

“Then use the non-conscious geometry Osei authenticated. No destructive read. No activation channel.”

The Crown scheduler objected from the rail. “A fixed geometry cannot report drift.”

“It can set a boundary,” Osei said. “Current bells report their own drift. C-9 contributes a verified route relation and nothing else.”

“What happens if the relation falls outside tolerance?”

“We stop that stage and use the published fallback.”

“The fallback costs another trade window.”

Nia met his eyes. “Then write the cost beside it.”

He did not like the answer. He entered it anyway.

Ada moved the stage marker to the patient-transfer gap. A column of medical dependencies expanded across Arden Coil, Latchkey, and Near Orison. The total had survived every version of the model: 1,900 patients whose ventilation, thermal regulation, or drug production could not tolerate the narrowest corridor interval.

Arden Coil’s clinician appeared on a second remote link. “Your transfer field treats these people as one movement.”

“It is one protected window,” Ada said.

“It contains different tolerances. Some can travel before the ring conversion. Others cannot leave their current support until replacement beds come online.”

“How many groups?” the panel chair asked.

“Five clinical dependency classes. We can publish the classes without publishing individual records.”

Nia brought up the mass table. “Does splitting them change the required transit load?”

“Not total load. It changes preparation and receiving capacity.”

“Then the bell schedule can retain one protected window while the medical plan uses multiple departures around it.”

The clinician shook her head. “Not if Crown can cancel feeder transit to protect freight recovery.”

Ada’s fingers stopped above the reader.

Under the old schedule, Crown could downgrade a feeder line whenever corridor stability threatened contracted priority freight. The hidden model preserved that power in an appendix even while distributing the main bell schedule. A single retained clause could leave the patient plan technically present and operationally disposable.

“Delete operator downgrade,” Ada said.

The Crown scheduler stood. “You cannot remove emergency discretion.”

“We can identify who holds it.”

“During an unstable window, a committee cannot tune a corridor.”

“No one proposed tuning by committee. The active controller keeps safety authority. It cannot use that authority to replace a protected medical movement with commercial recovery unless the movement itself exceeds a published safety boundary.”

“You are asking operators to carry liability without judgment.”

“I am asking them to exercise technical judgment inside a visible rule.”

The scheduler looked toward the Court’s counsel. “And when the boundary proves incomplete?”

Cal answered. “Emergency action remains available. Its reasons become reviewable afterward.”

Nia remembered how many harms had entered the archive under the word emergency. Review after damage could not restore a phase state or a body. Yet hidden discretion had not prevented harm. It had only decided who could name it.

She took the patient field off the schedule and laid its load against the bridge. “Run all five dependency classes through a single protected designation. Stagger feeder departures. Lock commercial replacement behind the medical load.”

Osei built the test. The bridge’s response roughened at the transition into the narrow window.

“Too sharp,” Nia said.

He extended the feeder taper. The roughness moved rather than vanished.

Ema’s marker lit. “You are solving the transit edge. Latchkey’s receiving pumps will see the arrivals as a heat edge.”

“Can you absorb it?”

“Not without temporary sink mass.”

Morcant’s allocator spoke. “We have idle refinery sink during our ration block.”

Ada checked the geometry. “Moving that mass costs freight capacity.”

“Our freight capacity already falls under the plan.”

“Your catalyst reserve also falls.”

“It falls because everyone else needs what we refine. Use the idle sink before the next run or it helps no one.”

No one praised the offer. The clerk entered it as a mass contribution with an obligation to return or replace the equipment after the retuning. Shared sacrifice required better records than generosity.

With Morcant’s temporary sink mass, the patient edge flattened. Osei ran the stage three times under different delay assumptions. None crossed a safety floor.

The panel chair marked the medical window sustained.

Nia rubbed the ceramic key with her thumb. The material had warmed through hours of handling. In another room C-9 remained under a seal built from a refusal. Here, living people had supplied every correction the hidden model lacked. No absent voice had been made to solve their work.

The live technical challenge began at the ninth hour.

Court channels carried a public view of the dependency tracks, the test bridge, and every non-executable assumption. Crown’s scheduler received the challenger’s position because Jalen had withdrawn the company’s cooperation after the vault seizure. He did not repeat Jalen’s politics. He attacked the plan where a schedule could actually fail.

“Stage fourteen,” he said. “Second Callis conversion. Apply a delayed thermal recovery on the outer Crown bell and loss of the Near Orison contribution for one window.”

Ada entered both faults.

The bridge kicked against Nia’s palm. Morcant crossed amber. Latchkey’s pump line stayed above floor by less than the panel’s approved margin. The Mouth trace split into two unstable bands.

Observers spoke behind the baffles until the chair cut their channels.

“The filed schedule fails its live reserve test,” the scheduler said.

Nia kept the key in place. A bridge model could not injure her, but habit made her hold it as if a sudden movement might score glass. “Why did you combine those faults?”

“Because both remain plausible.”

“Plausible together?”

“The model does not prohibit coincidence.”

Ada opened Crown’s historic recovery table. “Your own standard applies coupled faults only when they share a cause or each exceeds the independent trigger.”

“I am challenging a public plan, not certifying Crown practice.”

“Then state a standard the plan can meet.”

He looked at the timing lamp. “No dependent habitat crosses its failure floor under one major bell delay plus one discretionary mass withdrawal.”

“Near Orison’s contribution cannot remain discretionary after adoption,” Cal said.

“The polity could breach.”

“Then the breach has consequences, not neutrality.”

Near Orison’s representative requested the channel. “We will bind the mass contribution if every other signatory binds its ration share.”

Morcant followed. Latchkey’s marker lit from the remote link. Vesper Fold, Arden Coil, and Sable entered the same condition. Their statements did not create mass. They changed a modeled withdrawal into a breach the schedule could treat as exceptional rather than ordinary operator choice.

The scheduler did not yield. “Run the bell delay alone.”

Osei cleared the discretionary withdrawal and retained the delayed thermal recovery. The Mouth trace continued split.

Nia felt the defect in the bridge before she saw its source. Pressure arrived from two simulated bells at nearly the same interval, then fell away together. The retuning stages had inherited Crown’s assumption that synchronized recovery minimized lost capacity. Under the slower schedule, synchronized recovery created a common edge.

“Separate the recovery intervals,” she said.

Ada examined the stage. “That extends the second conversion.”

“By taking time from where?” Osei asked.

“Freight recovery after the protected medical window.”

The Crown scheduler said, “You will deepen rationing.”

“Yes,” Nia replied.

Near Orison’s representative asked for the industrial effect. Ada displayed it. Morcant requested its catalyst curve. Ema asked for the revised Latchkey sink interval. Each cost appeared before anyone consented.

Osei separated the bell recoveries and extended the stage. The first unstable band narrowed. He shifted the outer bell by another increment. The second band joined it without crossing.

“Run delay,” Nia said.

The bridge pressed hard, then settled.

“Add one feeder loss,” the scheduler said.

Osei added it. Latchkey remained above floor. Morcant touched amber but did not enter failure. Sable lost a freight window. Vesper Fold’s agricultural buffer shortened.

“Reverse the order of bell recovery.”

The model survived.

“Move the patient preparation late.”

Arden Coil’s clinician objected. “That violates the clinical plan.”

“Test it,” Nia said.

They did. The medical field crossed its boundary, and the public display marked the schedule invalid before the corridor model could treat those people as available load.

For the first time, the Crown scheduler nodded. “The boundary reports correctly.”

The panel chair asked whether he had another coupled challenge under the stated standard.

He studied the tracks. “Not without adding a second major failure.”

“Then stage fourteen survives.”

The room did not celebrate. The surviving plan required two converted Callis rings, binding ration shares, public allocation, medical relocation, slower freight, and the end of Crown’s schedule monopoly. Success appeared as a set of losses no longer assigned in secret.

Near the end of the civic day, the panel compiled the public instrument.

Its title read PHASED RETUNING: TWENTY-SIX-MONTH MULTI-POLITY SCHEDULE. Below it, the obligations began with verbs. Crown relinquishes exclusive priority. Callis converts two ceremonial mass rings. Inner habitats ration. Six signatories publish reserve use. Medical authorities relocate 1,900 patients under protected transit. Operators retain immediate safety control and disclose every substitution.

Ada read the Crown clause twice before signing as a technical witness. Her signature did not bind the company. The Court’s order would do that if judgment adopted the plan.

Ema signed for Latchkey’s pump assumptions through the remote seal. “Do not use my name to call this painless,” she said.

“No one will,” Nia answered.

“You do not control what they call it.”

“No. Only what the record shows.”

Osei carried the test key to Nia for the archive witness mark, then stopped. Her license loss barred her from certifying activation work. This instrument contained no respeaking, yet its phase procedures still crossed a category the disciplinary order had reserved for licensed staff.

He looked at her rather than the form.

“You checked every run,” he said.

“You performed them.”

“The method came from you.”

“The mark belongs to the person who can lawfully answer for the instrument.”

Osei set his seal into the field. His hand remained steady through the acceptance pulse.

The panel doors opened. Court clerks took the public schedule toward the judgment chamber. Engineers began disassembling the test bridge because Callis needed the table for actual conversion work as soon as the order issued.

Nia removed the temporary key. A pale pressure line remained across her fingers, then faded while Osei locked the instrument under his own name.

Chapter 25 — Judgment in Silence

<!-- POV: Cal Orsen -->

<!-- Day 39; multi-polity Continuance Court -->

Sena Pell began reading while the engineers were still sealing the retuning schedule into the Court register.

The last clerk crossed behind the bench with an amber custody band in both hands. Cal heard its clasps meet through the paper-thin acoustic baffles. On the public wall, six habitat seals waited in a vertical column beside Callis and Aster Crown Transit. None had yet changed color. Agreement on engineering did not bind anyone until the judgment gave the plan an authority willing to survive appeal.

Sena set one palm on the printed opinion. She preferred paper for operative orders because a page could not revise itself after a vote.

“This Court addresses two questions argued together and decided separately,” she said. “First, whether a valid preference concerning destructive access retains force when the person who formed it no longer occupies an active embodiment. Second, whether Crown’s historic choice and present concealment create liability that can be remedied without imposing an immediate corridor closure.”

Crown’s counsel sat beside Jalen Orr at the lower rail. Ada occupied no Crown seat. She had taken a place among technical witnesses, three rows behind the advocates, where her bare wrist rested on the folded model summary.

Nia Daro sat beside Osei. Her license-loss order had removed every formal role she once held in activation work, but Iven’s valid selection of her as technical adviser had not been erased by discipline. Cal had insisted the seating clerk preserve that distinction. Institutions often turned a punishment into a deletion because deletion required less careful recordkeeping.

At the center of the witness rail stood an empty chair.

The Court had not moved it after argument. No device faced it. No channel waited beneath its arm. A clerk had sealed the floor socket. Cal had checked both before the chamber opened.

Sena continued. “The Continuance Articles do not make duration a measure of personhood. They make novel preference the threshold. Once a signal person passes that threshold, the state may not convert the limits of embodiment into permission to destroy the remaining state.”

She paused while the public transcript fixed the sentence.

Cal knew the next paragraph. He had written its first version at a narrow desk during the thirty-first night, crossed out half of it after Sena’s objections, and removed every claim broader than the case required. The wider Court had changed it again. That process mattered. A rule created to honor one person had to survive judges who did not share Cal’s attachment to the facts.

“We therefore recognize silent standing,” Sena said. “A preference formed during valid standing in continuance may retain legal force after deactivation when the preference concerns renewed embodiment, destructive measurement, or other access that would consume the person’s remaining substrate. Such force requires authentication independent of reconstruction, contemporaneous capacity, a defined protected interest, and review for fraud or material contradiction.”

The phrase entered the chamber without ceremony. No light changed above the empty chair.

Crown's counsel wrote something for appeal. Cal expected him to. A durable right needed an adversary precise enough to expose its weak boundaries.

Sena turned one page. "Silent standing does not grant remnants authority over public policy, property distribution, inheritance beyond existing law, or the choices of living persons. It protects bodily autonomy where the body exists as a nonrenewable state. It does not establish governance by the dead."

Jalen's head lifted slightly. The judgment had answered his strongest objection rather than dismissing it. That narrowing had cost Cal three days and much of his pride. He had wanted a principle that named every indignity the case revealed. Sena had required one the Court could enforce.

"Applied here," she said, "the refusal geometry authenticated by the Callis Archive confirms a novel preference formed by Iven Ko while he held standing in continuance. The record states his stopping decision. It also establishes his request against renewed activation. Crown may not compel another respeaking, and no custodian may authorize one absent evidence that the geometry itself resulted from fraud."

Osei did not look toward C-9's remote custody indicator. He kept his eyes on the opinion. Nia's hands lay open on the rail, motionless except when her right thumb crossed the place where an activation key once rested.

Cal felt relief arrive as a procedural fact. The request now bound everyone in the chamber, including those who had never heard its voice.

A justice elected by Sable lifted his copy. "Chief Justice, I join the result and request clarification on duration. Does the protected preference expire when technology changes?"

Sena turned to the remedies page. "Not automatically. Review attaches to the access request, not to age alone. A custodian must show why new methods no longer threaten the substrate or contradict the protected interest."

"And if a later method claims to read without destruction?"

"Then the applicant proves that claim through independent testing. The remnant does not bear the cost of demonstrating safety."

Crown's counsel requested the lamp. "May a custodian refuse testing forever by citing uncertain damage?"

"No. The order permits non-contact examination, external modeling, and comparison against unrelated archives. It forbids spending this person's state to establish whether spending it would be safe."

The Sable justice marked his page. "That satisfies my concern."

Cal had resisted that paragraph in conference. He feared any review language could become a tunnel back to compulsion. Osei's method had changed his position. A right did not require ignorance around it; it required placing the risk on whoever sought access. The distinction would demand competent custodians, funded laboratories, and judges willing to reject convenient certainty.

Sena named the custody chain. Callis would hold C-9 in its preservation field. Two external custodians would review every annual integrity report. Any fraud petition required particular evidence and could not rely on the remnant's refusal as proof of incapacity. Nia could advise on preservation but could not conduct licensed activation work during her five-year loss. Osei could certify non-conscious measurements once his license reached full standing.

Each limit gave the order somewhere to fail in practice. Each review rule also gave a future court a place to catch that failure before a silent preference became property again.

The evidence ruling came next.

Crown had argued that unfinished cross-examination barred the dispatcher allegation. Under ordinary hearing rules, a party could not present an accusation and then remove the witness before the opposing side tested the full account. The rule protected courts from crafted fragments. It had never contemplated a witness whose continued appearance consumed the witness.

Sena read the distinction without softening it.

“A person’s lawful exercise of bodily autonomy does not become evidentiary misconduct because it prevents further examination. The resulting record may carry less weight. It does not vanish. Courts must ask what portion reached completion, what opportunity for testing occurred, and what independent material confirms the claim.”

Cal watched the timing lamp beside Crown’s table. It marked each operative sentence with a narrow green pulse.

“The completed testimony identified dispatcher code AR-6, a three-bell rescue requirement, a nineteen-hour interval, and a commanded turn away from Eiren Reach. Crown tested memory sequence, personal knowledge, route competence, prior activation damage, and the distinction between modeled routes and witnessed operations before the witness stopped the examination.”

Crown’s counsel stood. “Chief Justice, the order understates our unasked causation questions.”

Sena looked over the printed page. “Your objection remains preserved. Sit down.”

He did.

“The unasked questions limit unsupported inference,” she continued. “They do not erase facts independently confirmed by pilot telemetry, physical scoring in bell C-9, Crown’s activation ledger, non-conscious preference geometry, and the executive minute authenticated from Crown’s own vault.”

The minute appeared on the public wall. Its operative AR-6 entry occupied one plain block. Preserve corridor continuity. Redirect available convoy mass to primary stabilization. Eiren recovery proceeds only if no further corridor degradation results.

No voice read it aloud.

“The Court admits the completed testimony for the purposes supported by that corroboration,” Sena said. “It finds that Crown officers knowingly reassigned the three bells required for rescue and used them to stabilize the Meridian Mouth before Eiren’s available rescue interval closed.”

A sound crossed the gallery, too dispersed to identify as grief or anger. The baffles caught it and reduced it to cloth movement.

“The Court does not find that preservation of the Mouth lacked legitimate public purpose. The corridor supported inhabited polities then and supports 2.3 million people across six dependent habitats now. Legitimate purpose does not convert concealment into accident. Crown chose between lives, preserved the profitable

system, then represented the choice as navigation loss.”

Jalen remained still. The opinion did not assign him his grandfather’s act. It assigned him what the records proved about his own tenure: obstruction, continued suppression, and defense of exclusive control after a feasible alternative existed.

Sena named those findings one by one. She did not call him cruel. Courts reached conduct more reliably than souls.

Cal looked at Ada. She listened without turning away. The judgment credited her production of the minute and model as cooperation after breach. It also found that twelve years of defending concealment caused continuing institutional harm. Her nineteen-day withholding of the model index remained in the findings. Assistance reduced no fact to absolution.

The registry clerk brought in two sealed volumes.

One carried Eiren’s historic resident register. The second contained the reconstruction completed from broken transit manifests, shift rolls, docking claims, and private duty lists. Cal had reviewed their count until the arithmetic entered his sleep: 18,204 registered residents plus 312 transient workers excluded from the original casualty field.

Sena waited until both volumes rested beneath the public timing lamp.

“The old record classified Eiren’s population loss through categories inherited from property, residence, and compensated cargo,” she said. “Those categories omitted people whose temporary work status did not reduce their capacity to die.”

The clerk opened the second volume to its certification page.

“The Court orders the Orison civic disaster register corrected to 18,516 persons lost at Eiren Reach. Each recovered name shall enter the register as a person. Where a name remains unrecovered, the corresponding verified occupational or transit identity shall retain a place pending correction. The 312 transients shall not remain an appendix to resident loss.”

On the public wall, the total changed.

No list began scrolling. The Court had rejected that display after registry clerks argued that a ceremonial cascade would turn damaged entries into spectacle and make broken records appear less human than complete ones. The wall showed only 18,516, the two source volumes, and a route to inspect each record with its uncertainty intact.

Nia bowed her head once toward the number. Osei touched two fingers to the rail and withdrew them.

Cal remembered ration hearings during the Pellin shortage, when people became units in a column because a magistrate could not distribute heat by learning every name. Counting had practical mercy in it. Counting also offered institutions a place to hide the difference between a person omitted and a unit never entered. The corrected registry did not recover anyone. It prevented the old omission from continuing as administrative truth.

Crown’s counsel rose when Sena reached liability. “We renew our objection to class restitution absent

individual estate claims.”

“Noted,” Sena said.

“The company cannot compensate unidentified estates.”

“The order does not require fiction. It requires a fund administered under verified claims, public memorial maintenance, surviving community institutions where lawful successors exist, and civic services connected to the corrected registry.”

“Forty-seven years of successor disputes will consume the award.”

“Then Crown will not control administration.”

The word restitution appeared beside the corrected count. Its details occupied pages rather than a single number. Crown owed payments into an independently governed Eiren claims fund. It owed the costs of registry reconstruction and C-9’s permanent preservation. It owed corridor credits to the six habitats whose dependence had been used to preserve concealment. Executives who inherited no personal guilt still faced corporate obligations carried through the same continuity that preserved Crown’s contracts.

A registry advocate requested the timing lamp. “The fund language still favors people who left complete records. Transient workers often have no lawful successors recognized by residence codes.”

Sena checked the operative schedule. “Unclaimed portions do not revert to Crown.”

“Where do they go?”

“To restoration of names, preservation of Eiren civic records, and services available to verified work communities connected to the lost transit crews. The administrator may not manufacture an heir to close an account.”

“Will occupational fragments qualify?”

“For identity restoration, yes. For private estate transfer, existing evidence rules remain.”

The advocate did not sit immediately. “Then some people receive a name in the public book and no private award.”

“Yes,” Sena said. “A court cannot repair missing kinship by inventing it. It can keep the institution that caused the loss from profiting by the missing evidence.”

Cal wrote the exchange into his copy beside the restitution clause. Courts often weakened honest orders by promising completeness. The fund could rebuild records, compensate successors, and support communities carrying identifiable loss. It could not create a family history where Crown’s own secrecy had allowed one to disappear.

The administrator’s first report would fall due during the retuning’s opening stage. That timing linked liability to current scarcity, which Crown had opposed. Sena retained it. A remedy postponed until abundance would never arrive because every institution could name a more urgent present use for the money.

Jalen requested standing.

Sena allowed it.

“You treat institutional continuity as liability when it burdens Crown,” he said, “and deny continuity when the same institution claims authority earned by keeping the corridor open.”

“The Court recognizes both,” Sena replied. “Crown’s operational service weighs against punitive closure. Its continuous benefit and control support restitution. Continuity does not permit selecting assets without obligations.”

“The award will reduce retuning capacity.”

“Operational payments follow the protected schedule. Registry and preservation costs do not.”

“You believe a distinction on paper will survive scarcity.”

“No,” Sena said. “The Court orders review because paper alone will not.”

Jalen sat. He had received an answer shaped like work rather than moral victory.

The corridor remedy required every habitat seal.

Sena adopted the twenty-six-month schedule under temporary multi-polity supervision. Crown lost exclusive control of choir-bell priority and retained a technical operating role subject to published allocations. Two Callis mass rings entered conversion. Inner-habitat rationing began with the first stage. Medical authorities received protected transit for all 1,900 high-risk patients. Independent engineers would publish stage failures and substitutions without releasing executable bell timing.

Then she reached Callis.

“A polity cannot demand visible sacrifice from an operator while treating its own contribution as symbolic,” she said. “Callis accepts the closure and conversion obligations stated in the public instrument. It also accepts catalyst rationing, reduced civic access, archive preservation rotations, and the consequent limits on Court scheduling.”

The Callis delegate rose and set her seal against the register.

Near Orison followed after its counsel reread the industrial cap. Morcant entered its catalyst obligation and temporary sink contribution. Latchkey’s remote seal arrived with Ema Orsen’s pump conditions attached. Vesper Fold, Arden Coil, and Sable bound their shares.

Crown’s seal remained dark.

“The Court cannot compel corporate agreement to every allocation,” Crown’s counsel said.

“It can condition continued operation of a public corridor under multi-polity law,” Cal replied from the advocate rail. “Crown may decline the operating role and surrender its bells to supervised tuning.”

Jalen turned toward him. “You know surrender would interrupt the first stages.”

“Yes.”

“You are using present dependence as leverage.”

“Crown has used it as immunity.”

Cal regretted the symmetry as soon as he heard it. A judgment chamber rewarded phrases that made opposing harms look equal. They were not equal. The six habitats needed Crown's technicians, and Crown had a right to resist uncompensated seizure. The order worked because it preserved payment and technical authority while ending secrecy, not because one side had acquired better leverage.

Sena corrected the record more precisely. "Continued operation remains compensated. Exclusive control does not. Chair Orr, the Court requires a choice between the supervised role and an orderly transfer under the emergency corridor charter."

Jalen requested a private conference with counsel. The timing lamp granted eight minutes.

During the recess, no one approached the empty chair. Clerks checked seals. Habitat engineers compared the effective date against reserve tables. Nia spoke quietly to Osei about cooling rotations on the archive ring. The law had not interrupted ordinary work long enough for anyone to mistake judgment for completion.

Jalen returned before the lamp expired.

"Aster Crown Transit accepts the supervised operator role under protest and preserves every appellate claim," he said.

Its seal changed from dark to amber.

The six habitat marks turned green in sequence after it. Callis followed last because its conversion obligation required two internal civic countersignatures.

Sena gathered the opinion pages. "The majority judgment takes effect upon filing. Separate views will follow. Preservation orders remain active. No access to C-9 may occur except under the authenticated preference and the narrow fraud review stated here."

She pressed the physical filing seal through the paper.

The chamber did not erupt. People read. Crown's counsel began marking appeal points. Engineers carried authorized copies toward the retuning rooms. Registry clerks closed the two Eiren volumes and placed them together on one cart.

Cal remained at the rail until the public wall cleared everything except the corrected count and the first scheduled obligation.

18,516 persons lost. Callis ring conversion begins at second shift.

Osei left with Nia for the Archive. No channel opened behind them. The empty chair stayed empty while the Court's order went to work.

Chapter 26 — The Voice Not Called

<!-- POV: Nia Daro -->

<!-- Four months later; Callis first retuning window -->

Nia found the stress line because Osei's torque stopped one mark before the ring clamp seated.

He held the long ceramic key with both hands. The converted ceremonial ring moved beneath them in a slow, massive rotation, carrying its new tuning blocks past the service gantry. Through the soles of Nia's boots, each block arrived as a low pressure rise and left as a fading pull. The clamp in front of Osei should have accepted the key's full turn between those rises. It had refused.

"Do not force it," she said.

"I am under limit."

"The tool is under limit. The collar is not moving."

Osei eased pressure without letting the key spring back. Four months ago, he would have asked her to take the handle. Now his license seal occupied the key socket, and her hands remained outside the work.

Callis had stripped the public walk from ring three and filled its sheltered curve with phase couplers, heat shunts, and service rails. Memorial tags once fixed to the inner rail had gone into temporary archive cases. Their empty fastener holes traveled past Nia every seventeen seconds. The station smelled of oil cloth and hot ceramic instead of procession incense.

The first retuning window would begin in forty-three minutes.

Osei locked the key at its current position. "Surface check?"

"Start with the witness strip."

He pressed a passive strip along the clamp edge. One end darkened where pressure exceeded the seating model. The mark lay two millimeters spinward of the latch, narrow enough to miss under ordinary inspection.

"Block distortion," he said.

"Or collar distortion."

"We measured both after thermal soak."

"Then measure what changed."

Osei released the key into its brace and photographed the collar from four fixed angles. He placed a scale strip beside the latch, then asked Nia to witness the service temperature without touching the phase meter. The distinction felt absurd at close range. She could read the instrument aloud but not certify what its phase field implied. It also prevented the old habit by which a senior worker performed every meaningful step and called the junior worker trained.

"Service temperature within expected range," she said.

"Visual scoring?"

“One bright contact line spinward. No glass exposure.”

“Prior condition?”

Nia opened the conversion record on a passive slate. The collar photograph from installation showed no bright line. Its measured diameter appeared within tolerance, but the record carried a note from Osei himself: coefficient accepted from Crown materials table pending installed confirmation.

“You left the dependency visible,” she said.

“I should have demanded confirmation before load.”

“Could the ring have waited?”

He considered the conversion sequence rather than answering from shame. “Not without losing the first protected medical preparation window.”

“Then your note preserved the risk for this inspection. That differs from pretending it was resolved.”

Osei looked at the refusing clamp. “A visible risk can still fail.”

“Yes.”

“That is not comforting.”

“It should not be.”

A ring worker approached with an emergency torque extension. “Control says the schedule can accept a field waiver if you seat within redundant capture.”

Osei did not take the extension. “Who assessed the collar distortion?”

“No one yet. The tool is for the time limit.”

“Put it back.”

The worker hesitated. Nia had seen that pause directed at her for years: the fraction of time in which a crew decided whether authority lived in the named license or the older person standing beside it.

Osei pointed to his seal in the key socket. “My hold. My decision.”

The extension went back into its case.

He set three pickups around the clamp and called the ring crew for a hold on local adjustments. Nia watched his order appear on the window ledger under his own name. She could advise, observe, and handle non-activation preservation. She could not authorize phase work for five years. The boundary had felt punitive on the first day. By the fourth month, it had become useful in ways she distrusted. Osei no longer borrowed certainty from her position.

The pickups reported stable block geometry and a collar ovality outside service tolerance. Osei repeated the measurement with a pickup from another kit, then rotated all three positions. The same oval followed the collar rather than the instruments. He saved both runs. A single surprising result invited caution; a repeated one demanded a decision.

“Heat?” Nia asked.

“Within the conversion model.”

“Whose model?”

He opened the source line. Crown’s old ring table had supplied the collar coefficient. Callis had verified it on three spare collars but not on this installed piece because removal would have delayed conversion.

Osei looked toward the central control room. “We can replace it before the second stage, not before the window.”

“Can you seat it safely?”

“Not to certified depth.”

“Then no.”

A window alarm sounded along the gantry. Thirty-eight minutes.

Osei sent the fault to control. Ada answered from the supervised operator desk before the ring engineer did.

“Effect?” she asked.

“One clamp uncertified on ring three,” Osei said. “No active instability. We need the stage recalculated without this tuning block.”

“How long?”

Nia watched him make the estimate. “Nine minutes for the first model. Longer if it fails.”

“The six-habitat release begins in thirty-seven.”

“I see it.”

“Give me the fault field.”

He did. Ada did not ask Nia to confirm.

The ring engineer came onto the channel from the opposite gantry. “I can authorize a reduced seating depth under emergency discretion.”

“Based on what installed-collar test?” Osei asked.

“Operating history. The ring carried civic balance for sixty-one years.”

“Not at retuning load.”

“The clamp has redundant capture.”

“The second capture shares the distorted collar.”

Silence held the channel for half a breath.

Ada said, “Model it absent. No waiver until we know the alternative.”

Nia unclipped a passive gauge from Osei's belt and set it beside the dark witness strip. Handling it crossed no license line. Her fingers still remembered the pressure of phase tools with an accuracy that sometimes woke her before shift. She used that memory for comparison, not authority.

Beyond the converted ring, the Archive's shielded section passed through view. Choir bell C-9 occupied its preservation cradle behind two pressure doors and a court seal. The seal accepted integrity checks from outside. Only the authenticated preference held inside the bell could authorize a change to the activation barrier, and the custody system contained no override for schedule convenience.

The doors stayed closed.

The absent-block model failed at minute twenty-nine.

On the control room wall, the Mouth trace narrowed into a broken fork. The slower schedule already used less synchronous mass than Crown's former windows. Removing one Callis block shifted the first edge beyond the published tolerance for Morcant's catalyst convoy.

Ada stood between Crown's surviving scheduler and the multi-polity allocation board. Every substitution appeared on the public operations channel with its effect by habitat. Jalen no longer occupied the room. Crown technicians still did, paid to operate bells they no longer scheduled alone.

Ema Orsen joined from Latchkey with pump noise crossing her link. "Can you move the window?"

"Later increases your heat-sink gap," Ada said.

"Earlier?"

"Ring three cannot recover."

Morcant's allocator said, "Our convoy can shed freight."

"Catalyst?"

"Not enough to recover the trace."

Osei expanded the tuning map. "We do not need mass alone. We need the missing block's phase relation."

The Crown scheduler turned toward the sealed archive indicator on the far board. "C-9 carries an Eiren relation in that band."

No one answered immediately.

The suggestion had technical sense. The non-conscious geometry authenticated during the hearing had contributed boundaries to the twenty-six-month model. A fresh destructive read could reveal drift at the exact band now failing. Before the judgment, someone could have called it emergency analysis and put the burden on whatever remained in the glass.

Osei closed the archive source on his display. "We have the fixed boundary. We do not have permission for another read."

"I said the bell carries the relation. I did not request activation."

“Any new interior measurement spends state.”

The scheduler looked to Ada. “Emergency safety control remains with the operator.”

“Inside the adopted schedule,” Ada said. “The archive seal lies outside it.”

“If the Mouth forks, safety authority reaches every contributing mass.”

“C-9 is not contributing mass to this window.”

“It could prevent failure.”

Nia watched the public ledger. The line identifying the proposal remained blank because no authorized person had entered a request. An emergency could become a story told afterward unless someone forced it into a field while refusal still mattered.

“State the request for the record,” she said.

The scheduler met her eyes. “I am not making one.”

“Then remove C-9 from the fault discussion.”

He cleared the archive indicator.

Osei restored the active mass map. “We can build the relation from two living sources if Sable changes its tuning work and Callis shifts the axial reserve.”

Callis control answered at once. “Axial reserve protects station balance during ring conversion.”

“How much can you release without crossing civic limit?”

“Not enough under full Archive cooling.”

Nia looked at the preservation load. Three bays had operated on rotation since conversion began. C-9’s field drew little compared with the conservation rooms holding freight recorders, damaged beacons, and family archives. Lowering cooling would not destroy them immediately. It would narrow their safe margin and require crews to move the most stressed glass by hand.

“We can suspend one conservation bay for the window,” she said.

Osei shook his head. “Bay two has the heat-fractured intake records.”

“Then move them to bay one.”

“In twenty minutes?”

“Eighteen now.”

The Archive chief entered the channel. “Nia, you do not authorize conservation load.”

“No. I am offering the effect. You authorize it or you do not.”

A beat passed while the chief read the risk table.

“Bay two suspends for one hour,” she said. “No extension without inspection. I want every case moved before

cooling drops.”

Ada entered the Callis contribution. “Still short.”

Sable’s tuning lead came onto the board. “We can shift our work bell to the missing relation.”

“What do you lose?” Ada asked.

“Two mining windows and the mass-casting run behind them.”

“Safety effect?”

“None if we stop the casting now. We scrap the current heat.”

The allocation board required a civic seal. Sable’s representative applied it after eleven seconds.

Morcant offered to reduce non-catalyst freight. Vesper Fold delayed a seed shipment whose temperature margin could tolerate the later window. Near Orison released the fabrication priority already reduced under the judgment. Each contribution changed a local plan. None erased the missing clamp.

Osei built the new relation from Sable’s bell and Callis’s axial reserve. The Mouth trace joined, narrowed, then developed a shallow oscillation at the release edge.

“Pump effect?” Ada asked.

Ema had already overlaid Latchkey’s line. “Manageable if you extend our reduced throughput.”

“For how long?”

“Until the second recovery stage.”

“Your public minimum?”

“We stay above it.”

The pump noise behind her grew sharper. “But we shut one fabrication deck and cancel local heat allotments for the same period. Put that on the board before anyone accepts.”

Ada did.

No one called the result efficient. The public ledger showed scrapped Sable heat, delayed freight, closed Near Orison fabrication, Archive cooling risk, and Latchkey reductions. The old schedule would have hidden most of those losses under operator recovery.

The combined trace remained inside tolerance.

“Technical challenge?” Ada asked the Crown scheduler.

He examined the recovery edge. “Run one Callis trim loss.”

Osei introduced the fault. Oscillation rose and settled below limit.

“One Sable timing delay.”

The trace held.

“Reverse both.”

It held again.

The scheduler nodded once. “Executable.”

Ada looked at the allocation seals. “Authorized if Archive transfer completes and every contributing polity confirms the listed burden.”

Green marks began appearing beside the losses.

One line remained amber: Callis civic consent for the Archive draw. The control board had accepted the chief’s technical authorization, but the retuning order also required a public custodian to acknowledge any preservation risk above the ordinary rotation.

A woman from the displaced memorial office joined by audio. Nia knew her only from the temporary case labels. “Bay two contains private deposits placed under continuous-cooling promises,” the custodian said. “Do families receive notice before suspension?”

“Not before this window,” the Archive chief replied. “They receive the fault record and individual condition reports after inspection.”

“That breaks the service promise.”

“Yes.”

“Can another public load supply the reserve?”

Callis control displayed hospitals, pressure safety, water recovery, and the axial court chambers. Court load had already fallen to minimum. No ceremonial lighting remained on either converted ring.

Nia requested the channel. “The cases can tolerate the hour under current estimates. The risk comes from hidden stress we have not measured. We will move every near-limit record first and inspect all cases when cooling returns.”

“You said estimates.”

“I did.”

“If a family record fractures, who answers?”

“The Archive does. Not the retuning panel and not the corridor emergency.”

The custodian stayed silent long enough for the window alarm to sound again. “Enter that responsibility with the draw.”

The chief placed the Archive’s institutional seal beside the risk. The memorial custodian countersigned as public witness, not as consent on behalf of every depositor.

Callis turned green.

On another channel, Vesper Fold withdrew its seed-delay offer and resubmitted it with a temperature inspection at arrival. Sable attached worker compensation to the scrapped casting run. Near Orison added a

restart priority for the fabrication deck it would close. Shared sacrifice acquired conditions because people had learned that an unqualified offer became someone else's permanent convenience.

Nia left before the last operational annotation arrived. Bay two had to move.

The conservation cases weighed little in Callis's ring gravity and carried enough inertia to break a wrist.

Nia guided the first case along a rail while two archive workers controlled its tail. Inside, five auric-glass records rested in pressure foam. Fine stress lines showed through their smoked amber layers. None contained a verified person. That did not make careless damage acceptable.

Osei joined them after transferring window control to the ring engineer.

"You should stay at the board," Nia said.

"My model is certified. Ada owns execution until the pre-window inspection." He took the tail strap from one worker. "You are short a licensed phase handler."

"For external preservation."

"For any case with responsive geometry."

Nia released her grip so he could inspect the first seal. Training had changed shape after her license loss. She could explain why a tool resisted, where heat accumulated, and which omission would survive an unfriendly question. Osei had to decide what those facts authorized.

He cleared the case.

They moved eight more along the narrow rail. Fan vibration traveled through the handles. At the bay-one threshold, each case received a new position tag and thermal witness strip. The Archive chief called time every three minutes without urging anyone to hurry. Haste could turn a shared sacrifice into damage assigned to whoever held the weakest record.

The final case carried transit beacons recovered from minor decompressions. Nia recognized one acquisition number from her first year at Callis. She had written the intake condition in a hand she no longer used.

Osei checked its foam pressure. "This corner needs another pad."

"The old seal will resist opening."

"Then we brace outside."

He cut a wedge from inert foam and secured it against the case shell. The correction took ninety seconds. Bay two's cooling alarm sounded before they crossed the threshold.

Nia felt heat begin as a change in air movement rather than temperature. Fans slowed. The axial reserve released from the Archive load and moved into Callis control.

"Last case clear," the chief reported.

Ada's voice came over the public channel. "All burden seals confirmed. Retuning window proceeds on revised relation."

Osei closed bay one. "I need to inspect ring three."

"I know."

"You are coming."

It sounded like an order because his role permitted one.

Nia clipped the passive gauge to her belt. "Yes."

At the control gantry, Osei performed the pre-window inspection while Nia read values back to him.

Ring three carried one absent block and no hidden waiver. A red mechanical tag covered the distorted clamp. Sable's bell entered the revised relation on the public map. Callis's axial reserve showed a temporary draw from Archive cooling. Every loss had an owner, a duration, and a review time.

"Phase edge?" Osei asked.

"Within published tolerance."

"Thermal recovery?"

"Separated intervals holding."

"Latchkey pump condition?"

Ema answered through the board. "Reduced and stable."

"Archive?"

The chief said, "Bay two suspended. Bay one below soft limit and rising slowly."

Osei set his seal into the window key.

The converted ring pressed against the gantry as its tuning blocks aligned. No spectacle marked the Meridian Mouth outside Callis. Freight crews saw timing fields. Habitat controllers saw pressure margins and arrival predictions. Nia felt the corridor form as a pattern of force through the rail, less abrupt than the old Crown openings and wider at the recovery edge.

"Window available," Ada said.

Morcant's catalyst convoy entered first. Its track advanced across the board without deviation. Medical feeder mass followed under protected designation. Sable held its altered relation while the scrapped casting heat cooled in a chamber no one here could see.

The Mouth opened on the slower schedule.

At the Archive indicator, the external integrity light for choir bell C-9 remained level. Its court seal showed no access request, no power change, and no destructive measurement.

Osei kept one hand on the key until the convoy cleared. Nia stood beside him without touching it.

C-9 remains silent under its seal.

Epilogue — A Law for the Unspoken

<!-- POV: Osei Marr -->

<!-- Twelve years later; Callis Continuance intake -->

Osei waited for the new signal person's breathing to settle before he placed the refusal form within reach.

The vocal body lay supported in warm saline mesh, one hand free above the restraint linen. A pressure timer counted the return in small amber increments. Across the room, an independent custodian watched the phase budget while a medical advocate held the channel open to the Court clerk.

No crowd waited outside. The discovery had entered Callis through an ordinary freight inspection: an emergency recorder sealed inside a damaged survey mass, identity incomplete, ownership suspended at intake. Twelve years earlier, such a find would have begun with arguments over salvage. Now the preservation order had preceded the transfer cradle.

The person called herself Teren Vale. That name appeared in the recorder, along with the end of a survey route and a request to warn the next crew about a magnetic fault. Her choice during the Novel Preference Test had not appeared anywhere in the source. She asked to hear the present Callis maintenance fans rather than a reconstruction of her vessel. Then she chose the blue cup over the identical gray one because blue reminded her of nothing she could name.

Temporary standing followed.

Teren read the form twice. "If I stop, you keep the recorder?"

"We preserve it under the access limits you choose," Osei said.

"And if better equipment exists later?"

"A reviewer may test that equipment on unrelated material. No one spends your state to prove a claim of safety."

"Can I change this after I am gone?"

"Only through a preference you form while you have capacity now."

Her fingers rested on the refusal field. "That sounds like no."

"It means I will not pretend there is another conversation available."

The advocate looked at him, then returned to the form. Osei had learned the answer from Nia, though she had never given it in those words. A careful custodian did not soften a limit until consent crossed it by mistake.

Teren selected preservation, external integrity checks, and no second embodiment. She excluded destructive measurement for research, testimony, family search, or public education. At the last category she hesitated.

“What if they find someone who knew me?”

“They may give that person your existing records. They may not open you to make a new one.”

“Even if they ask?”

“Your choice governs access to you. It does not govern what they feel.”

She pressed her thumb to the form.

The witness lamps recorded capacity, pressure budget, medical stability, and every spoken question. Osei ran the refusal geometry through a non-conscious comparison. It matched the preference event without reconstructing thought. The independent custodian repeated his test on another instrument. Their digests agreed.

One field did not. The survey recorder gave Teren’s employment identity a damaged checksum, while the vocal body had supplied a complete family name. The Court clerk marked the identity provisional.

“Does that stop the refusal?” Teren asked.

“No. Capacity and preference do not depend on whether the registry can yet prove every part of your name.”

“Then why mark it?”

“So no one uses this activation to close a different question.”

The advocate requested a separate identity review using the non-conscious route and payroll fragments. Osei approved external comparison and barred another embodiment for clarification. The distinction took less than a minute to record. Years of cases had taught the Court that uncertainty in one field tempted institutions to reopen all of them.

Teren touched the provisional mark. “Keep the name I gave you with the doubt.”

“We will keep both.”

The Court clerk entered silent standing on the recorder.

No opinion accompanied the entry. Strict review had become ordinary practice: two custodians, one advocate, an external test, annual integrity reports, and particular evidence before any fraud petition could reach a judge. Ordinary did not mean easy. It meant the difficult steps already had names.

Teren’s return had begun to thin. Her breathing grew shallower against the mesh.

“Will I feel the channel close?” she asked.

“The body will become tired. We can reduce the field slowly.”

“I do not want a speech.”

“All right.”

“Tell the next survey crew about the fault.”

“That record does not require another access. It has already entered the route warnings.”

She nodded. "Then stop."

Osei confirmed the request with the advocate and custodian. Teren pressed the physical stop field herself. The room's activation light changed from green to amber.

Outside intake, the rebuilt Eiren registry occupied one long wall of the axial passage.

It hung at reading height behind plain auric glass. Complete names appeared beside occupational fragments and unresolved identities. The 312 transient workers remained within the main count, not on a lower panel. Visitors could inspect a record, leave a correction claim, or pass without being instructed to grieve.

Freight crews passed it on their way to the public Mouth board. Trade still moved on the slower schedule established after Crown lost exclusivity. Windows took longer to recover. Allocation changes showed every habitat burden before release. Delays caused arguments instead of disappearing into operator discretion.

Osei crossed the passage to the sealed control station. Teren's recorder had already arrived in its preservation cradle. The annual-review field waited blank. No activation control appeared on the public side.

He entered the final procedure into the custody log: Osei Marr closes the activation channel at the person's request.

The independent custodian countersigned. Osei turned the ceramic key to zero, removed it from the socket, and sealed the empty channel.